

Interactions with the standard in early and late modern regional varieties of English

Edited by

Christine Elswailer

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Chapter 1

Introduction: Interactions with the standard

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1 Background to interactions between regional varieties and (perceived) standards

This volume presents current research into the interaction between Early and Late Modern regional varieties in the British Isles, including those transported overseas, and the incoming English standard that was subsequently codified and prescribed as the norm during the Modern period. Much has been written about the rise of the English standard, though it is worth briefly reiterating its trajectory in relation to the varying linguistic codes, textual models and prestige norms that interacted with it throughout its development. After all, this nascent standard variety did not emerge overnight out of the wellspring of industrialisation and increased social mobility, nor was it immediately and simultaneously adopted by language users across different regional, social and stylistic boundaries, as the contributions to this volume will make clear. Rather, it was a result of the increased textualisation of the English vernacular as well as supralocalisation processes during the late Middle English period (Lange 2012: 1001).

The late West Saxon dialect had displayed some characteristics of a standard variety during the Old English period, having assumed functions in domains such as history, legal, and religious writing and having evolved into a focussed “centripetal prestige norm” attracting “users of other varieties” (Kornexl 2012: 382). The Norman Conquest in 1066, however, cut the incipient standardisation short

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(Nevalainen & Tiekens-Boon van Ostade 2006: 271; Lange 2012: 1000) so that English lost the communicative functions it had previously fulfilled alongside Latin to both Anglo-French and Latin (Nevalainen 2003: 128). Due to the absence of a prestige norm, Middle English is characterised by considerable dialectal variation in writing and is known as “the standardless period of English” (Schaefer 2012: 520; see also Smet 2008). Nevertheless, from the 14th century onwards, an English standard gradually re-emerged. This incipient standardisation can be attributed to English gaining ground in written domains in which previously only French and Latin were employed. The vernacular was consequently structurally elaborated, drawing on the established discourse traditions in French and Latin, to be fit for these new functions (Schaefer 2006: 16–17; Lange 2012: 1001; Schaefer 2012: 528–531). As a result, the functional elaboration of English accelerated the spread of “colourless” supraregional forms, thus achieving “more broadly diatopic communicative efficiency (...) in the vernacular” (Smith 2012: 136). This reduction of variation in the 14th century, which intensified in the 15th and 16th centuries, happened both on an orthographic and on a morphosyntactic level (Nevalainen 2006) and the diffusion of supraregional forms can be ascribed to the mass urbanisation in the late medieval and Early Modern periods. London, in particular, attracted migrants from both the Midlands and the North of England, which led to dialect contact and subsequent levelling as well as the diffusion of these levelled forms from London to other parts of Britain (Nevalainen 2000; Nevalainen 2003: 129–130; Nevalainen & Tiekens-Boon van Ostade 2006: 292–299; Gordon et al. 2020). Although some of the forms that became part of Present-Day Standard English, for instance, 3rd person singular -s, had their origin in northern dialects, there is no single source for these levelled features (Hope 2000: 51; Nevalainen 2000: 358–359; Wright 2000: 5–6).

As a result of these processes, by the start of the Early Modern period the London-based English standard language was developing, which came to be viewed as a normative variety by contemporary writers, as is evident from metalinguistic comments (Mugglestone 2003: 9; Lange 2012: 1002). These comments provide insights into attitudes towards regional varieties. In the late 14th century, for example, Trevisa, translating Higden’s *Polychronicon*, describes the Northumbrian dialect as “scharp, slytting, and frotyng, and unsschape” (‘sharp, cutting, and grating, and unshapely’) (cited in Wales 2006: 61; see also Beal & Cooper 2015: 29). From the middle of the 16th century, such unfavourable perceptions of regional varieties moreover lead commentators to endorse the use of London English. George Puttenham, for instance, states in his *Arte of English Poesie* (1589) that his readers should emulate the “vsuall speech of the Court, and that of London and the shires lying about London within lx. myles, and not much aboue”, which

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is known to be “the most vsuall of all his countrey” (cited in [Nevalainen 2014](#): 108; see also [Wales 2006](#): 69; [Beal & Cooper 2015](#): 30–31). Puttenham not only links the newly developing standard variety to London but at the same time associates it with social rank, as do other writers such as the schoolmaster Alexander Gil ([Nevalainen 2014](#): 108). Comments such as these testify to an ‘emerging’ standard language ideology, which influenced speakers’ attitudes towards the standard as well as regional varieties and contributed to the dissemination of the standard ([Lange 2012](#): 995). We can thus gain insights into the emerging standard ideology from the perspective of grammarians, compilers of dictionaries and glossaries, orthoepists, schoolmasters as well as other public figures. However, in the 16th and 17th centuries, these writers did not in fact advocate one unified standard norm but rather promoted different emerging norms for specific target groups, including recommendations on an appropriate literary writing style or the use of technical vocabulary in monolingual English specialist dictionaries and glossaries ([Nevalainen 2003](#): 139–140; [Nevalainen 2014](#): 106–107; 112). These early examples of codification were therefore “often of a very local kind, both socially and generically” and should be considered as “*codifications*, in the plural” ([Rutten & Vosters 2021](#): 68–67). This propagation of target-group specific norms testifies to the existence of “multiple” standards that speaker-writers could orient to. Even for spelling, which reached a high degree of uniformity in printed texts by 1650, different norms applied for private writing ([Salmon 1999](#): 32, 42–43; [Nevalainen 2003](#): 138).

In contrast to the 16th and 17th century, where the diverse codification efforts do not reflect a “uniform march towards regulating the English language” ([Nevalainen 2014](#): 108), the 18th and 19th centuries increasingly witnessed the promotion of linguistic uniformity. While 17th-century grammar writers such as John Wallis included variants in their descriptions, e.g. of irregular preterite forms, later 18th-century grammars placed the focus on proscribing incorrect usage ([Nevalainen 2003](#): 142–143). These grammars, along with usage guides offering linguistic advice ([Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2014](#): 145–146), catered for the aspiring middle classes, who were driven by the idea that upward social mobility depended on the successful appropriation of the progressively uniform standard ([Rutten et al. 2014](#): 9; [Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2014](#): 135–136; 147). The considerable growth in the number of grammars and reprints in the later 18th century testifies to their popularity. Their places of publication, for instance, Newcastle, Dublin, and Edinburgh, moreover indicate an interest in the standard outside the South-East of England ([Beal 2004](#): 90; [Ostade 2008](#): 2).

These standardisation processes sketched out in the previous section – highlighting the spread and perpetuation of the standard from its London origins –

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represent a top-down, birds-eye perspective (see [Raumolin-Brunberg & Nevalainen 1994](#)). Such research has foregrounded in particular the focussing and codification stages of the nascent standard ([Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1998](#); [Nurmi 1999](#)), the selection of variants, their spread through various text types ([Nurmi & Palander-Collin 2008](#)) and down the social strata of society ([Raumolin-Brunberg & Nevalainen 1994](#); [Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003](#); [Burke 2004](#); [Hernández-Campoy & Conde-Silvestre 1999](#), [Conde-Silvestre & Hernández-Campoy 2004](#); [Nurmi & Pahta 2004](#); [Nevalainen 2006](#)), and their increasing adoption across geographical and temporal parameters ([Britain 2001](#); [Hernández-Campoy & Conde-Silvestre 2005](#); [Bergs 2006](#)). These findings remain invaluable to understanding the processes behind the development and growth of the standard, and the role of prestige and text-types in characterising its trajectory from London to greater Britain (see also [Hernández-Campoy & Conde-Silvestre 2015](#)). In recent years, however, there has been a shift within historical sociolinguistics towards incorporating a bottom-up, ‘worm’s eye’ ([Elspaß 2007](#): 4) view, looking at lesser-skilled writers and their language practices (see [Elspaß 2021](#)). The focus of this research has primarily been on the influence of prescriptive norms on language usage, specifically the perceived national standard ([Vandenbussche 2002](#); [Nordlund 2007](#); [Rutten & van der Wal 2011](#); [Tieken-Boon van Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2005, 2006, Ostade 2008](#)). A number of studies have suggested a lack of awareness, acceptance or adoption of these norms by such writers, given the high prevalence of non-standard, phonological and idiosyncratic spellings and language features in their writings (i.e. [Rutten et al. 2014](#); [Auer 2008, 2015](#); [Dossena 2019](#)). In fact, norms within their local communities of practice, though of lower authority than grammars and usage guides, may have exerted a greater influence on lesser-skilled writers (see [McLelland 2021](#): 283).

In this volume, and in line with developments in the field over the past two decades, we offer a change in perspective that considers the linguistic behaviour of underrepresented writers in relation to the *multiple* potential standards that may have existed within their practice at that time.¹ The following contributions explore whether these writers may have been adhering to various emergent social or regional norms that aligned with their regional or social origins or audience, or the text-type in which they were producing writing, rather than observing their behaviour through a simple, binary yes/no split between adoption or not of the incipient standard. The development of a standard variety is not necessarily a one-way process involving increasing convergence and the loss of variation.

¹[Elspaß et al. \(2025\)](#) discussion of double or multiple standards distinguishes, among others, between *language standards*, typically a product of standardisations ‘from below’ and *standard languages*, resulting from standardisation ‘from above’.

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As, for example, dialect writing in Late Modern English shows, non-standard dialectal forms may evince different functions, e.g., representing different linguistic and cultural identities. In addition, awareness of the standard and ability to adopt it could be moderated by various social and stylistic influences, that involve not just access to the prestige norms (for instance, education of female writers, see Elswailer, Gough and Gotthard's chapters) but also typological norms (as suggested by Elswailer's regarding prefabricated epistolary formulae in letters) and agentive or performative desires (as suggested by Dörnbrack, for example). Moreover, while research on regional varieties has expanded in recent years, in many cases such research is focused largely on the language variety itself, and how it was influenced by the incoming standard. In particular, previous studies have explored the historical events that encouraged the adoption of the standard (Hernández-Campoy & Schilling 2012), the role of power and prestige (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2000; Dossena 2012; Sairio & Palander-Collin 2012; Millar 2020), the entire, gradual or incomplete adoption of standard English variants across different textual arenas (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009; Rutkowska & Rössler 2012), and across different regional varieties such as Scots (e.g., Devitt 1989; Aitken 1985, Aitken 1997, 2015; Meurman-Solin 1993, 1997; Bugaj 2004; Maguire 2012; Corbett et al. 2003; Johnston 2007; Millar 2012). While there has been an increasing number of studies examining how speaker-writers experienced the standard and interacted with it as agents in their own right, particularly in more recent years (Raumolin-Brunberg & Nurmi 2011, Nurmi 2013; Pietsch 2015; Conde-Silvestre 2016; Hernández-Campoy 2016, Hernández-Campoy & García-Vidal 2018), these have not yet been compiled into a single volume. The lack of a comparative approach across different regional varieties and social layers within the British Isles makes it harder for us to discern whether there was, in fact, any universality of experience with the idea of "the standard", whatever shape that took for the various language communities that existed at any one time within these geographical boundaries.

Accordingly, this volume brings together current work that examines language-users' interactions with the standard. Of course, the standard itself was not a fixed entity during the Early to Late Modern period, but rather a standard with fuzzy boundaries (Ammon 2003: 8), and to enshrine it as such ignores the complexity of linguistic norms throughout this time period. Yet, in our view, the title of this volume, "Interactions with the Standard", in fact allows for more than one interpretation of "standard". This includes both the perspective of standard language ideology – which may have as its default assumption that there is a single model to be adhered to – and the perspective of various speaker-writers interacting with the standard who may have recognised and utilised multiple different

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“standards”, and social or textual norms. Compiling such research allows us to explore the effects of the standard language ideology and the varying socio- and geolinguistic practices present across time and space, and how this both intersected with and delineated groups of writers at different points in time. This enables a vantage point into the multifaceted nature of the standard, how it shaped, and was shaped by, various language communities in the British Isles. As will become clear throughout this volume, the “Standard” was not a static, timeless, one-dimensional variety in binary opposition to “regional” varieties but much more complex in its nature, as were the writers who interacted with it. Variation and variability, rather than manifesting an incomplete mastery of a fixed norm, reflects instead dynamic language users who were motivated and influenced by various factors and goals in their everyday linguistic behaviour.

2 Women’s interactions with the Standard

Three contributions focus on women’s awareness and adoption of the incipient English standard, from the perspective of specifically Scottish female writers adapting or changing certain Scots orthographic, morphosyntactic and pragmatic variants to the southern English equivalents. All three studies use the same resource – namely – the *Helsinki Corpus of Scottish Correspondence, 1540–1750* (*ScotsCorr*), exploring the influence of prestige norms and the Gender Paradox within the realm of correspondence. This gives us a two-fold perspective into social and regional differences in writing practices in relation to the standard, considering that women tended to acquire at best limited education and highly domain-specific letter-writing skills, and that Scottish writers faced the dualism of adhering to either the prestige, pan-regional standard or the covert prestige of local, Scottish norms.

Christine Elsweiler examines the letters of female Scottish writers between 1650 to 1750, and the presence of Standard English spelling variants within routine formulae – the prefabricated constructions frequently occurring during the opening and closing of a letter, which formed a necessary part of the epistolary norms surrounding letter-writing. Focussing on spellings reflecting various levels of ‘standardness’, she explores whether the epistolary standard and print standard norms, which were becoming increasingly salient in Scottish society, introduced standard English spelling features into Scottish women’s letters via the formulaic phrases commonly found in correspondence during the later 17th century and earlier 18th century. Correspondingly, she examines whether Scots and non-standard spellings persist for longer in the more creative and idiosyncratic parts of letters. The study finds, contrary to expectations, that there are

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high levels of variability, with some women using more standard-like features in the routine formulae, and others less so. This suggests that interactions with the standard were not uniform even within the community of female Scottish writers. Rather, this highlights the agentive and nuanced interaction that individuals could have within the incoming standard, and the active presence of multiple standards operating across the British isles, which female writers seem to have been aware of and adhered to.

Emily Gough's chapter takes a largely quantitative, statistical approach to spelling variation within ScotsCorr, examining specifically the presence of the sibilant interchange – a salient Scots feature that was disappearing during the eighteenth century – in the letters of men and women during the late Modern period. This study seeks to identify whether the Gender Paradox (cf. Labov 1990) holds for diachronic, written data in the context of female, Scottish correspondence, and what this indicates about women's awareness of the incoming standard. Confirming the Gender Paradox – i.e. that women lead change from above – would indicate a heightened awareness of prestige norms, despite their generally more-limited access to the public realm and the standard spelling features accompanying it, while the opposite would confirm previous research suggesting women were more conservative in preserving Scottish spelling norms. Gough finds that, contrary to previous research, Scottish women are ahead of men in their use of the sibilant interchange, though once change was underway the standard variant was rapidly adopted by both sexes, suggesting its saliency. This gives new perspective into Scottish women's awareness of, and ability to harness, southern English spelling norms, despite their reduced access to the public sphere and literacy.

Finally, Lisa Gotthard statistically explores gendered differences in the first Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence (PCSC; Gotthard 2024) from the perspective of under-researched morphosyntactic features; including the Northern Subject Rule, do-support, and verbal -ing. Similarly to Elswiler, she does not find a blanket pattern of female or male-dominated change across the board when it comes to these features. Rather than a consistent gender effect, morpho-syntactic change is feature-specific and socially situated, highlighting once again the intricacies of the time period and the individual relationships that writers had to multiple standards or written conventions. Moreover, the social norms and expectations surrounding letter-writing, coupled with the varying degrees of salience that different linguistic levels (morphological versus syntactic) might have, can add to the picture surrounding adoption of the standard. Gotthard notes the possibility of informal norm transmission within women's social networks, through

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the common practice of copying existing correspondence. This may have reinforced community-specific conventions, through which locally salient features may have been perpetuated as a stylistic norm. Consequently, within these circles such variants were not necessarily perceived as “nonstandard, leading to their continued use despite pan-regional developments in the direction of the incoming standard.

3 Pauper’s interactions with the standard

Two contributions consider how lower-class writers of different regional backgrounds interacted with standard norms. As paupers typically had limited access to education, it is of particular interest to see to which regional and local forms, and possibly norms, had an impact on their writing and to what extent these speaker-writers oriented towards the norms of the southern English standard. Yet, while the analysis of lower-class writing adds a much-needed perspective in historical linguistics, it also transpires that it remains challenging to determine to what extent paupers consciously interacted with standard norms.

Moragh Gordon’s chapter aims to shed light on the emergence of Scottish Standard English (SSE) and the role different social classes played in its development in the 19th century. Specifically, it explores how speaker-writers from the lower classes and the upper-(middle) classes interact with standard English features when writing in formal contexts. To this end, the study compares the use of the modal auxiliaries of necessity *must*, *ought (to)*, *need (to)* and *have to* in Scottish pauper letters represented in the ScotPP corpus with both Scottish and English upper-(middle)-class writing, drawing on the *Corpus of Modern Scottish Writing* (CMSW) and English letters from the corpus of *Late Modern English Prose* and *CL-MET*. The almost equal use in the pauper letters of deontic *must*, associated with formality, and *have to*, more commonly used in spoken contexts, suggests that different writers oriented towards different models. Some writers seem to have adhered to the standard prescribed in English letter-writing manuals, whereas other, more proficient, writers seem to have incorporated more local practices in their letter-writing. Moreover, the high rates of *have to* point to a potential change from below in SSE.

Anita Auer and Mark Iten’s contribution examines to what extent social and regional variation are interlinked in Northern English pauper letters of the late 18th and early 19th century in the *Pauper Letter Core Corpus* (PLCC). Drawing on metalinguistic comments on linguistic features of Northern English discussed in contemporary grammars, dictionaries and manuals, they investigate, from both

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a quantitative and a qualitative perspective, how adherence to standard norms and the use of non-standard (regional) features interact in their writing. Some of the metalinguistic comments point to an awareness of the link between social and regional variation, drawing interesting distinctions between, e.g., vulgar language, associated with the lower classes, and more acceptable dialectal forms. The quantitative case study of the reflection of the STRUT-FOOT merger/split in spelling suggests that Northern lower-class writers use spellings indicating a [ʊ] pronunciation more frequently than Southern writers in the *PLCC*. The two qualitative case studies show that while the writers consistently avoided dialect lexis in their letters, they do, e.g., evince non-standard spellings, some of which potentially reflect Northern pronunciations. Yet, as the authors discuss, it remains difficult to determine whether the (non-)use of ‘non-standard’/dialectal features mentioned in grammars and dictionaries is attributable to a conscious interaction with standard norms or whether particular Northern features were simply absent from their region.

4 Individual awareness of the standard

Moving away from broad, corpus-wide patterns of behaviour, two contributions explore awareness of the standard from the perspective of the individual. This provides a bottom-up, ‘worm’s eye’ view of variation and the intricacies of writing practices, social and stylistic influences and motives, and subtle developments that can be masked by aggregating linguistic data. They highlight the complexity of writers’ interactions with the standard, offering a qualitative and unique insight into the multitude of ways in which this could manifest.

Nora Dörnbrack’s longitudinal study of Mary Ann Wodrow Archbald (1762–1841) and her personal writings offers a glimpse into the changing language norms of an individual who underwent a dramatic change in her life circumstances – namely – immigrating to America. Combining a quantitative analysis of three different Scots variants and the adoption of their Standard English equivalent, with qualitative examples from the texts, and metalinguistic comments made by Archbald, Dörnbrack highlights the alternating motives influencing a writer’s linguistic choices. Her research suggests that Archbald both actively engaged with contemporary norms to project a polite writing style in line with contemporary practice, but also retained or even increased her use of certain Scots features to highlight certain parts of her identity post-immigration. This once again indicates the multiple standards that a writer could interact with, depending on their personal intentions and the codified expectations of the letter

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or text. Such nuance is only accessible to the researcher when a deep-dive into individual practice is undertaken, and reinforces the need to take a layered rather than blanket approach to language change. Moreover, Dörnbrack's study also provides a valuable new addition to our understanding of linguistic behaviour among female, regional and emigrant writers.

Carolina Amador-Moreno examines metalinguistic comments on the *Irish brogue* found in private letters from the Corpus of Irish English Correspondence (CORIECOR, 1700s–1900s), written by emigrants to their families and friends in Ireland. The term *brogue* refers to the English spoken in Ireland, with comments often emphasising a strong Irish English accent. Amador-Moreno's analysis highlights that the letter-writers demonstrated a high level of metalinguistic and dialectal awareness in their observations. Interestingly, they do not only associate it with a stigma but also attach positive connotations to the *brogue*, describing it as, e.g., “musical” and “good fun”. Additionally, the metalinguistic comments provide insight into the speaker-writers' interactions with what they possibly perceived as a standard pronunciation norm. The majority of writers indeed seem to have noticed the *brogue* in connection with an Irish accent. Pronunciation features would have been particularly salient to them as they were aiming for a levelled pronunciation in a dialect contact situation. By contrast, non-standard grammatical features of Irish English appear to have been less salient to these writers, who interact with grammatical norms in their letters to different extents.

5 Interactions with the standard in manuscript texts and literature

The final two contributions consider (a) how manuscript texts reflect interactions with the print standard and (b) how dialect is distributed in literature, specifically folklore, and which criteria shape the selection of dialect or the standard.

Samuli Kaislaniemi's contribution considers the role of print in the standardisation of spelling in Early Modern English, and how increasing literacy and ability to write may have led writers to be gradually influenced by developments and standards emerging in the printing houses. While the relationship between print and standardisation has generally been acknowledged, this study seeks to directly compare the diachronic developments of selected variables in both print and manuscript, providing a broad overview of writers' interactions with the printed and written standard. Kaislaniemi compares the development of three graphemic variables - word-initial <u/v>-variation, word-medial <u/v>-variation and epenthetic <aun> - in printed texts from the EEBO-TCP (part of the

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Early English Books Online Text Creation Partnership project), with their occurrence in two corpora of manuscript texts - the Corpora of Early English Correspondence (CEEC-400) and the Electronic Text Edition of Depositions 1560–1760 (ETED). Findings indicate that the developments of these variables were not uniform and systematic. While print does appear to have driven the change in manuscript practices for word-initial <u/v>-variation and word-medial <u/v>-variation, the decline of the etymologised graphemic cluster <aun> seems to have happened simultaneously in both print and writing. This highlights the complexity of investigating writers' interactions with the standard from a diachronic perspective, in which literacy and exposure to print differed across different time points and different social layers. It also speaks to the multiplicity of standards that can exist simultaneously, and non-linear relationship that these may hold with one another.

Oliver Currie investigates interactions between late modern regional varieties and Standard English in folklore, a hitherto underused source for historical sociolinguistic studies. He presents an exploratory corpus study of 19th to early 20th-century English folktale publications, investigating the factors impacting the choice between the standard and dialect as well as the association between dialect use and dialogue. As much of the material was collected orally from minimally schooled speakers, it captures both dialect use and its avoidance across a continuum from fully standardised retellings to tales wholly in dialect. Three narration types are distinguished: third-person without dialogue, third-person with dialogue, and dialogue-like/conversational narration. These correlate with particular usage patterns. While discursive prose is consistently in Standard English, third-person narrative is overwhelmingly standard with only occasional dialect items. By contrast, over half of the tales with dialogue include dialect in the dialogue, and narratives wholly or mostly in dialect are typically made dialogue-like via first-person framing or attribution to a dialect-speaking narrator. Within dialogue, dialect often marks local, lower-status characters, whereas non-locals typically use the standard. The corpus thus reveals considerable inter- and intra-writer variation in the extent and placement of dialect. Overall, dialect clusters in dialogue, reflecting an association with orality, and is used as a stylistic resource to index local identity.

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Chapter 2

Interactions with the standard in women's epistolary spelling (1650–1750)

Christine Elswailer

This study examines the spellings attested in Scottish women's letters written between 1650 and 1750 to see how women interacted with Standard English orthographic norms, comprising both the print standard and established epistolary norms. A focus is placed on routine formulae, which have been shown to act as scaffolding especially in the letters of less experienced letter-writers. It is hypothesised that these prefabricated patterns may have offered ready spelling models for female writers of different levels of letter-writing experience.

The findings reveal diverse patterns rather than a consistent diachronic trend. For many female-authored letters, the degree of standard spellings does not differ between formulaic and non-formulaic parts. However, some women exhibit a more standard orthography in formulae, while others demonstrate fewer standard spellings in formulaic parts. By retaining older spellings in formulae, such as <u> for the consonant /v/, they may thus have preserved a conservative epistolary standard.

1 Introduction

Over the course of the Early Modern period, English orthography changed from being largely inconsistent in both print and handwritten manuscripts to a system that is close to present-day standard English spelling – at least in printed texts. The move towards modern standard spellings in printed texts happened in the 16th and 17th centuries, probably due to the influence of dictionaries, grammars and spelling books, which had been published from the later 16th century onwards (Scragg 1974: 80; Salmon 1999: 30–32; Rutkowska 2012: 233–234;

Christine Elswailer. 2026. Interactions with the standard in women's epistolary spelling (1650–1750). In Christine Elswailer & Sarah van Eyndhoven (eds.), *Interactions with the standard in early and late modern regional varieties of English*, 19–48. Berlin: Language Science Press. DOI: ??

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Nevalainen 2014: 111–112; Condorelli 2022: 158–162; Hernández-Campoy 2023: 531–532).¹

The standardisation of English spelling coincides with the Anglicisation of Scots (Devitt 1989; Meurman-Solin 1997; Millar 2020: 86–91), during which Scottish printers as well as writers adapted their spellings to English orthographic practices (Meurman-Solin 1993: 196–203; Kniezsa 1997: 44–46). The features of the emerging London-based English Standard were adopted more quickly in printed public texts, most of which were fully anglicised by the beginning of the 18th century,² than in private writing (Meurman-Solin 1997: 15, 18).³ Evidence from the *Helsinki Corpus of Scottish Correspondence* indicates that, in personal letters, Scots spellings such as the abbreviated form *qch* ‘quhich’ for English *whch* ‘which’ could be found even after 1700 (see also Eyndhoven 2021: 256–258).⁴ Similarly, handwritten English texts, and, in particular, letter-writing continued to manifest spellings which did not adhere to the print standard, e.g., *easier*, *unworthyness* and *untill*, throughout the 17th century and into the 18th century (Görlach 2001: 78; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009: 42). Even highly educated writers evinced spellings that deviated from orthographic conventions in print since no systematic instruction was offered (Salmon 1999: 42–43; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009: 42–43). In fact, letter-writers developed their own spelling norms such that two standards existed side by side throughout the 18th century: a print standard and an epistolary standard (Osselton 1998; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009: 42–44). Nevertheless, during the 17th and 18th centuries, a trend towards modern standard spellings is discernible in letters, and idiosyncratic as well as non-standard writing practices were increasingly viewed negatively (Görlach 1991: 48; Salmon 1999: 51; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009: 44; Kaislaniemi et al. 2017: 204). This tendency towards modern orthographic norms is, however, mainly evidenced in

¹Condorelli (2022: 158–161) posits, based on study findings by Basu (2016), that the standardisation of English spelling proceeded in two waves, one from the middle to the end of the 16th century, and the second one in the middle of the 17th century.

²This was, however, not without exceptions. Scots continued to be used, for example, in Victorian newspapers and published popular literature during the Vernacular Revival (see Donaldson 1989; Millar 2020: 135–151).

³The high degree of anglicisation in public texts is corroborated by van Eyndhoven and Clark’s study of the <quh>-<wh> switch based on data from the *Helsinki Corpus of Older Scots (HCOS)* covering the period 1570–1708 (Eyndhoven & Clark 2020: 222–224). Nevertheless, they also found that in family letters, many of which were exchanged between members of the Scottish landed gentry in London and their family in Scotland, <quh> is more likely to be replaced by <wh> than in royal and official letters.

⁴See, for example, letters #1617 by John Campbell of Glenorchy, 2nd Earl of Breadalbane, #1826 by John Murray of Broughton and #1855 by Dougal Campbell.

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letters by male writers. By contrast, since women in the early modern period generally had more limited access to a classical education,⁵ which continued into the earlier part of the 18th century, even letters by women of higher social standing often manifested idiosyncratic and phonetic spellings⁶ (Meurman-Solin 1997: 18; Salmon 1999: 43; Meurman-Solin 2000; Daybell 2006: 96–99; Moore 2006: 114–116; Sairio 2018; Evans & Tagg 2020: 196).⁷ In the early 18th century, by which time Scots writing had been largely anglicised, Scottish women writers tended to retain Scots and non-standard spellings for longer than men (Millar 2020: 100).

Although women's letters thus seem to reflect a more limited knowledge of standard spelling conventions, female letter-writers actually had opportunities to familiarise themselves with epistolary and print standard orthographic norms in the Early and Late Modern periods. Apart from dictionaries (Osselton 1963: 274), spelling books specifically designed for women as a target audience appeared in the early 18th century, for instance, James Robertson's *The Ladies Help to Spelling* from 1722 (Jones 1997: 434–435). This particular manual combined guidance on spelling with advice on letter-writing conventions, thus demonstrating that spelling was perceived as a key skill for female letter-writers in early eighteenth-century Scotland. This combined guide was preceded by 17th-century letter-writing manuals especially catering to women, for example, Henry Care's *The Female Secretary* (1671) (Nevala 2004: 36; Mitchell 2007: 183–184; Taniskanen 2009: 127–128), which would have provided models for different types of letters as well as epistolary formulae. Beside such manuals, women had other opportunities to acquaint themselves with conventional formulae in the 17th century, for instance, through letters passed around family members and friends,

⁵Particularly in the later Middle Ages and during the early modern period, many women even from the higher social ranks were illiterate and therefore often dictated their letters to scribes. The spellings found in such letters therefore generally reflect the scribes' spelling practices, but do represent the women's grammatical practices (Hernández-Campoy 2016: 112–113; Hernández-Campoy 2013).

⁶It has, however, been pointed out by Sönmez (2000) that the differences between women's and men's spellings may have been exaggerated. Since women mostly wrote private letters in the Early Modern period, a spelling difference regarding text type rather than gender may be reflected (Sönmez 2000: 407–408). Moreover, perceived differences in spelling skills may also be based on the fact that women's private writings manifest more marked spellings such as phonetically obscure spellings, than men's private writings, although the overall frequency of non-standard spellings is similar (Sönmez 2000: 427–430).

⁷As Daybell points out, social status is another factor impacting literacy levels in the 16th century, such that women of a lower social status, for instance members of merchant families, evinced more idiosyncratic and phonetic spellings. Nevertheless, men of lower social status who had not attained the same level of education as gentlemen and noblemen similarly manifested poor spelling skills (Daybell 2006: 98–99).

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manuscript miscellanies and copybooks (Daybell 2014: 57–61; Palander-Collin 2010: 653; Whyman 2009: 26).

Previous research has shown that routine formulae acted as scaffolding especially in the letters of less experienced letter-writers, who relied on these prefabricated patterns to construct their epistolary discourse (Elspaß 2005: 192; Rutten & van der Wal 2012).⁸ This may, in fact, not only have applied on a lexical and syntactic level but also on an orthographic level. Indeed, some women manifest more standard spellings in formulaic parts of letters than in the body text, as is illustrated in (1), an excerpt from a letter by the Scottish letter-writer Mary Maule from the beginning of the 18th century.

- (1) I have (1a) *bein* prity well if I war quet of (1b) *alittill* cold I have gotten with in (1c) *thir* ('these') ten days Master Harie is very well he gives his humble serves to your La: (= Ladyship) ther is no more word (1d) *comt* yet from alloa about Goger my affectionat serves to good Lady Iean (1e) *which is all at present from*
Madam
 Your La (= Ladyship's) most affectionat daughter & obident humble servant Mary Maule
 (#1255, Mary Maule, 1700)

In the body text, the writer uses, on the one hand, Scots grammatical forms such as the demonstrative adjective *thir* 'these' (1c) and the weak past tense form *comt* (1d) and, on the other, Scots spellings such as *littill* (1b) and the digraph <ei> representing a long vowel in *bein* 'been' (1a).⁹ By contrast, in the letter-closing formula in (1e), the spelling of most words corresponds to the print standard norms or may reflect an epistolary standard. In view of the presence of more standard spellings in the closing formula in Example (1), this study aims to explore in more detail how Scottish women interacted with and acquired both epistolary and print standard spelling norms. It is hypothesised that the prefabricated patterns offered by epistolary formulae may have provided ready spelling models for female writers of different levels of letter-writing experience.

Specifically, this study will explore (a) if there is a tendency for Standard English spellings, reflecting the epistolary standard and the print standard norms,

⁸See also Wood (2007: 54–55) on the persistence of older routine formulae in personal letters in the 18th century.

⁹For typically Scots spelling variants of *little* see *DOST*, s.v. *litil(l)*, *lytil(l)*, *littil(l)*, *lil(t)le*, adj., n. and adv. and *OED*, s.v. *little*, adj, pron., n., adv.. For the use of the *ei*-digraph in the past participle form of *be* see *DOST*, s.v. *be*, v.¹, A. I. 6. and *OED*, s.v. *be*, v..

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to be introduced in Scottish women's letters through formulaic patterns during the later 17th century and earlier 18th century and (b) if, diachronically, Scots and non-standard spellings persist for longer in the more creative and idiosyncratic parts of letters. This study thus aims to shed light on how female Scottish letter-writers, who evinced different levels of letter-writing skills, incorporated the English epistolary and print standard norms in their own writing – on an individual level but also at the level of local communities of practice. By doing so, it moreover seeks to demonstrate that correspondence data, especially when based on transcripts of autograph letters, are particularly well suited to investigating how different genders interacted with various supraregional and local spelling norms.

The analysis is based on a selection of 50 female-authored autograph letters drawn from the *Helsinki Corpus of Scottish Correspondence, 1540–1750* (*ScotsCorr*): 25 letters from the second half of the 17th century and 25 letters from the first half of the 18th century. These reflect the later stages of the Anglicisation of Scots and encompass the time period at the beginning of the 18th century for which Scots features, including Scots spellings, have been found to persist, in particular, in women's private writings.

This paper falls into five parts. After this introduction, Section 2 will discuss in more detail which spelling norms were available to Scottish letter-writers. The correspondence data at the basis of my analysis are presented in Section 3.1 and the methodological approach taken in this study is detailed in Section 3.2. Section 4 discusses the study findings, which are placed in the larger context of female Scottish letter-writers' interactions with the different standards in Section 5.

2 Spelling norms for Scottish letter-writers

2.1 Print vs epistolary spelling standard

As Scragg notes, by the middle of the 17th century, English printers consistently applied a spelling system which resembled the one in use in present-day British Standard English in most respects¹⁰ (Scragg 1974: 67; see also Nevalainen 2003: 138; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009: 39). For instance, the addition of a final *-e* that was not necessary to indicate vowel length, e.g., in *confesse* or *finde*, was

¹⁰ A few spelling features of the 17th and 18th century printers' standard deviate from present-day conventions. Among these are the preference for *-ick* instead of *-ic* in words such as *publick* as well as the use of long <s> (f) (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1996: 329; Görlach 2001: 79–80).

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no longer commonly found in printed books and neither was its retention in inflected verb forms such as *comeing* (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2009: 41). Moreover, the modern distribution of the graphemes <u> for vowel sounds and <v> for the consonant /v/ had been established in printed texts by then (Salmon 1999: 38–39; Rutkowska 2016: 168–169).¹¹ Printers had also settled on the use of final -y in adjectives and nouns such as *merry*, *happy* and *beauty* instead of -ie as well as on -our instead of -or in nouns such as *favour* (Osselton 1998: 36).

To a large degree, this would also have applied to 17th century Scottish printers, who were increasingly under pressure to adopt English spelling norms so that their prints had a wider reach (Millar 2020: 91). After 1627, many texts printed in Scotland were fully anglicised (Bald 1926: 114–115), although Scots continued to be featured in the 18th and 19th centuries in specific print genres such as newspapers, chapbooks, popular literature, legal texts and certain religious tracts (Donaldson 1989: 19; Millar 2020: 135–151; Eyndhoven et al. 2025). A brief survey of prints from Scotland indicates that, in the earlier 17th century, this did not necessarily mean that the printed texts applied the modern spelling system outlined above. However, prints from the middle of the 17th century onwards increasingly adhered to the spelling system advocated by English printers.¹²

Nevertheless, as was pointed out in Section 1, 17th and 18th-century letter-writers did not adhere to this system but rather implemented a private, epistolary spelling system that allowed for some degree of variation. According to Osselton (Osselton 1998: 40–44) and Tieken-Boon van Ostade (1996, 1998); Tieken-Boon van Ostade (2009: 42–44), their epistolary spelling system included, for instance, the following features:

- The spelling of *your's* with an apostrophe
- Retention of final -y in plural forms of nouns (e.g., *beautys*) and comparative and superlative forms of adjectives (e.g., *easier* and *prettiest*)
- Dropping of final -e in formations like *immediatly*

¹¹From Middle English through to the early 17th century, <u> and <v> were distributed by position in the word. <v> was used initially to represent both vowel sounds and the consonant /v/ and <u> was employed in medial position (Salmon 1999: 38–39).

¹²*The Glorie of Man Consisting in the Excellencie and Perfection of Woman* printed by Edward Rabon in Aberdeen in 1638, for example, still applies final -ie instead of -y, as is evident in the title, as well as final -e in words such as *confesse*. By contrast, *The Laws and Acts of the First Parliament of our Most High and Dread Sovereign Charles the Second*, printed by Evan Tyler in Edinburgh in 1661, as well as later texts such as *The King's Majesties Letter to His Parliament* from 1670 apply the spelling system adopted by English printers relatively consistently.

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- Contractions such as *tho* for *although*
- Consonant simplification, as in *corespondence* or *leter*
- Consonant doubling, as in *cutt*, *fitt*, *allways* and *faithfull*¹³

This epistolary spelling system is mostly based on spelling features found in the personal correspondence of English writers.¹⁴ Interestingly, while largely corresponding to the print standard, some of the features of the epistolary standard can also occasionally be found in Henry Care's 17th-century manual *The Female Secretary*, one of the first English letter-writing manuals specifically targeted at women (Tanskanen 2009: 127–128 see §1). Spellings reflected in Care's model letters include, for example, the retention of final -y in superlative forms such as *heartyeft*, consonant simplification, e.g., in *aclamations*, and consonant doubling, e.g., in *merrits* (Care 1671: 26, 42, 59). The following sub-section will explore to what extent English epistolary spelling features also apply to 17th and 18th-century Scottish letters.

2.2 Epistolary spellings in Scottish letters

To establish whether the 17th- and 18th-century letters by female Scottish letter-writers follow the same spelling system as English letter-writers, these were checked for the features identified by Osselton (Osselton 1998) and Tieken-Boon van Ostade (1996, 1998); Tieken-Boon van Ostade (2009: 42–44). In addition, in cases where recurrent spelling features did not form part of Osselton and Tieken-Boon van Ostade's lists, I made use of a small control corpus of English letters in the *Parsed Corpus of Early English Correspondence* (PCEEC) written in the second half of the 17th century to see whether these were common features of contemporary English letters and would thus also represent the 17th- and 18th-century epistolary spelling system.

The close analysis of the spelling practices in the correspondence of the 17th- and 18th-century female Scottish letter-writers explored in this study shows that,

¹³Kaislaniemi et al. (2017: 191–195)) found for *always* that the double <ll> spelling remains in common use in letters throughout the 17th century and is still found in 18th-century letters but manifests a steady decrease in frequency. Adjectives ending in *-ful* show a preference for the double <ll> variant throughout the 17th century and then a sharp increase in the single <l> variant towards the end of the 18th century.

¹⁴Tieken-Boon van Ostade's research includes a study of James Boswell's spellings habits, a Scottish author, who is known for his linguistic insecurity due to his Scottish origin and his eagerness to conform to Standard English linguistic norms (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1996: 333–334; Millar 2020: 105).

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with few exceptions, they also evince the features that are characteristic of the English epistolary spelling system. While neither the retention of final -y in plural noun forms such as *beautys* and comparative and superlative forms of adjectives such as *easyer* or *prettyest* nor *your's* were found in the Scottish letters, other features are regularly represented. These include variation between -or and -our, e.g., *favor* vs. *favour*, as well as -ick and -ic, e.g., *critick*, which was advocated by the printers, vs. *critic* (see Osselton 1963; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1998: 460–462; Görlach 2001: 79–80). Moreover, they comprise contractions, e.g., *tho*, and consonant simplifications, e.g., *leter*, as is illustrated in (2).

- (2) Which *tho* I did intend to haue testified to you the sence I haue of it befor now by *leter*,
(#1233, Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth, 1701)

Consonant doubling is also frequently found, see (3), where both consonant doubling and simplification are combined in *Counttes*.

- (3) For the Right Honorable the *Counttes* of Leven at Bellgoanie
(#509, Christian Leslie, Marchioness of Montrose, 1695)

However, some cases of consonant doubling may not solely be a feature of the epistolary spelling standard but rather a continuation of Older Scots spelling practices. The doubling of <s> word-finally, for example, may have signified an unvoiced realisation (Bann & Corbett 2015: 37; Kniezsa 1997: 38), e.g., in *houss* in (4):

- (4) & make ye *houss* redimable by his Lops
(#525, Margaret Wemyss, Countess of Wemyss, 1696)

Apart from the features identified by Osselton (Osselton 1998) and Tieken-Boon van Ostade (1996, 1998); Tieken-Boon van Ostade (2009: 42–44), the Scottish letters exhibit further recurrent spelling patterns shared with English letters. These comprise of:

1. -y instead of -i, representing /ɪ/ and /e:i/ in words such as *tyme*, *chylde* and *fynd*, e.g., in (5),
- (5) And what I humblie Conceau wsfull to be tacken for your self or *Chyld* you will fynd in the receptes
(#703, Anne Hamilton, 3rd Duchess of Hamilton, 1659)

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2. the addition of final *-e* to the highly frequent verbs *doe* and *goe*, see (6),
- (6) But please know that I *d^{oe}* not incline to be baffled of that which is Justly my own
(#1271, Jean Campbell, 1708)
3. the retention of final *-e* with other verbs, nouns as well as adjectives and adverbs, as in (7), which also occurs with inflected forms, as in (8).
- (7) and how much I really am more then I can *expresse*,
(#1236, Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth, 1701)
- (8) *leaveing* it to yo*ur% co*n%sideration¹⁵
(#626, Elizabeth Forbes, 1661)

A further typical spelling feature found in Scottish letters, but not regularly in English letters, is the omission of final *-e* in words such as *not* 'note', *don* 'done' and *fals* 'false', as is illustrated in (9),

- (9) I hau sent yow a *not* of what most be *don*. that she doe not talk or pratll *fals* thing.
(#1254, Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth, 1711)

Since, apart from rare instances, the omission of final *-e* is not a regular feature of the letters in the English control corpus, in this study, these spellings are not considered representative of the English epistolary standard¹⁶ and, if the spelling of words without final *-e* otherwise follows the English orthographic practices, they are generally classified as 'transitional spellings', a concept which will be further elaborated on in Section 3.2.

3 Data and methodology

3.1 Data

This study is based on letters covering the second half of the 17th century - a period during which the Anglicisation of Scots writing was consolidated (Devitt

¹⁵* ... % indicates the contraction of the letters between these symbols in the manuscript (Meurman-Solin 2016c).

¹⁶Certain selected words in Henry Care's letter-writing manual *The Female Secretary* also evince omission of final *-e*, notably (*un*)*welcom* and adjectival compounds in *-som*, e.g., *fulsom*, *troublesom* and *loathsom*. In the Scottish letters, however, omission of final *-e* is spread across a wider range of words.

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1989: 56–60; Meurman-Solin 1993: 196–203; Meurman-Solin 1997: 8; Görlach 1991: 8) - and the first half of the 18th century; a time where Scots features were generally becoming rarer in private writing but were typically retained in more remote locations such as the North of Scotland and in women's letters (Millar 2020: 100). The letters are drawn from the 1650–1699 and 1700–1750 sub-sections of the *Helsinki Corpus of Scottish Correspondence, 1540–1750* (*ScotsCorr*) (Meurman-Solin 2016b). The correspondence data in *ScotsCorr* are particularly suitable for research into spelling since most of the letters are autograph, thus representing the writers' own spelling practices. The data are moreover relatively homogeneous regarding social background, as the majority of the writers are from a noble or gentry background (see Meurman-Solin 2016b,a).

For each sub-period, 25 autograph letters were selected. While it was possible to include letters from every decade between 1650 and 1700, the 18th-century letters in *ScotsCorr* are mainly clustered in the first two decades, with the last letter dating from 1731. Thus, the 17th-century data will be a better indicator of diachronic change. As regards geographical origin of the writers, the 50 letters are relatively evenly distributed across different regions within Scotland. The meta-data indicate that the letters are addressed to recipients in Scotland. However, for two 17th-century letters and for twelve 18th-century letters, the addressee is not known. The corpus includes both private letters and letters dealing with matters such as estate business.

A general goal in the selection of letters was to be able to chart the spelling practices of a range of different women. Therefore, letters of 19 different female letter-writers were included in each sub-period. The majority of writers are represented with just one letter, namely 15 writers in the period 1650–1699 and 13 writers in the period 1700–1750. In addition, in the 17th-century data, four writers are represented with two or three letters and, in the 18th-century material, six writers with two letters, see Tables 1 and 2.

For Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth, one letter forms part of the 17th-century data and two letters of the 18th-century data.¹⁷ The length of the letters included for the present analysis varies between 70 words (#1256 by C. Montrose) and 888 words (#1220 by Margaret Campbell), with the majority comprising between 100 and 300 words.

On the basis of these correspondence data, it will be gauged to which degree spellings in both the letter as a whole and the opening and closing formulae

¹⁷In the *ScotsCorr* metadata, the Countess of Seaforth is recorded as *Isobel* for her letter from 1688 (#811) and as *Isabel* for her letters from 1705 (#1252) and 1711 (#1254). Since all three letters are signed with *Isobell Seaforth* and consistent spelling features are manifested across them, in this analysis, they are considered to be produced by the same writer (Meurman-Solin 2016a).

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Table 1: Letters from the 1650–1699 sub-period in chronological order

No	Year	Writer	Letter
1	1650	Marie Campbell, Countess of Caithness	#969
2	1651	Anne Hamilton, 3rd Duchess of Hamilton	#700
3	1655	Anne Campbell	#967
4	1659	Margaret Farquar	#615
5	1659	Anne Hamilton, 3rd Duchess of Hamilton	#703
6	1660	Elizabeth Farquar	#602
7	1661	Barbara Forbes	#624
8	1661	Elizabeth Forbes	#626
9	1664	Christian Lindsay, Countess of Haddington	#746
10	1665	Anna Lindsay, Countess of Rothes	#733
11	1665	Anne Hamilton, 3rd Duchess of Hamilton	#707
12	1665	Christian Lindsay, Countess of Haddington	#747
13	1666	Margaret Forbes	#629
14	1666	Isobell Douglas of Kelhead	#576
15	1666	Christian Lindsay, Countess of Haddington	#748
16	1667	Margaret Montgomery, Countess of Loudoun	#558
17	1667	Marie Leslie, Countess of Eglinton	#502
18	1671	Elizabeth Fraser, wife of Walter Barclay of Towie	#632
19	1671	Sophia Erskine, wife of Alexander Fraser	#631
20	1688	Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth	#811
21	1692	Margaret Wemyss, Countess of Wemyss	#524
22	1693	Anna Melville	#529
23	1695	Christian Leslie, Marchioness of Montrose	#509
24	1696	Anna Melville	#530
25	1696	Margaret Wemyss, Countess of Wemyss	#525

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Table 2: 25 letters from the 1700–1750 sub-period in chronological order

No	Year	Writer	Letter
26	1700	Anna Scott, Duchess of Buccleuch Monmouth	#1258
27	1700	Margaret Campbell, Countess of Balcarres	#1220
28	1700	Mary Maule	#1255
29	1701	E Ruglen	#1257
30	1701	Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth	#1233
31	1701	Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth	#1236
32	1702	Anna Scott, Duchess of Buccleuch and Monmouth	#1262
33	1702	C Montrose	#1256
34	1702	Elizabeth Gordon	#1223
35	1702	Margaret Hamilton, Countess of Panmure	#1228
36	1705	Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth	#1252
37	1705	Lilias Campbell	#1221
38	1706	Anne Mackenzie	#1246
39	1707	Jean Campbell	#1270
40	1708	Susanna Campbell	#1272
41	1708	Jean Campbell	#1271
42	1709	Elizabeth Cunningham, Lady Kilmaurs	#1222
43	1711	Jean Sutherland, wife of James Lord Maitland	#1224
44	1711	Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth	#1254
45	1713	Anne Mackenzie	#1249
46	1714	Janet Brodie	#1269
47	1716	Anne Hay	#1230
48	1716	Anne Hay	#1231
49	1722	Christian Cameron, relict of John Cameron of Glen- dessary	#1268
50	1731	Frances Stirling, Lady Montgomery of Skelmorlie	#1267

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correspond to the epistolary spelling standard. It will, moreover, be possible to explore if non-standard and Scots spellings persist for longer in the body text of the letters than in the formulaic parts. Section 3.2 will introduce the categories underlying the classification of spellings in my analysis.

3.2 Methodology

To be able to measure to what degree 17th- and 18th-century female Scottish letter-writers follow standard (epistolary) spelling norms in their letters, all words, except for proper nouns, whose spelling tends to be more idiosyncratic (see [Evans & Tagg 2020](#): 214–215), were classified into one of the following three categories:

1. Standard spellings
2. Transitional spellings
3. Non-standard spellings

Standard spellings

The first category comprises both spellings corresponding to the 17th and 18th-century printers' standard spelling norms and the epistolary spellings introduced in Section 2.1. Thus, for instance, the spellings listed by Osselton ([Osselton 1998](#)) and [Tieken-Boon van Ostade \(1996, 1998\)](#); [Tieken-Boon van Ostade \(2009](#): 42–44), such as consonant simplification, e.g., *leter*, and consonant doubling, e.g., *faithfull*, were counted as standard spellings. Only if the relevant words displayed other spelling features that were, for instance, indicative of Scots, such as *cairfull* instead of *carefull*, were they classified in the third category 'non-standard spellings', as will be discussed in more detail below.

Additionally, to check whether recurrent spellings in the Scottish letters not listed by Osselton and Tieken-Boon van Ostade are, in fact, commonly found in English letters, a control corpus was used, consisting of nine 17th-century letter collections included in *PCEEC*, see Table 3.

Since *PCEEC* is based on editions of letter collections, where editors may have modernised certain spellings, e.g., towards the modern <u/v> distribution, in the past, letters contained in *PCEEC* were not deemed suitable data for research on spelling variation ([Nevala & Nurmi 2013](#): §2.3). However, in a recent study, Kaislaniemi and colleagues pointed out that an important compilation principle

Table 3: 17th-century English control corpus

Collection	Date range	Word count
Browne	1653–1681	20,778
Conway	1640–1680	57,946
Essex	1675–1677	25,206
Fleming	1650–1680	39,833
Haddock	1657–1673	5,657
Pepys	1663–1680	42,476
Petty	1676–1681	22,408
Prideaux	1674–1680	7,571
Tixall	1650?–1680?	11,544

for *PCEEC* was to use editions that reflect the original spellings as much as possible. Moreover, they have demonstrated with their study that “the overall orthographical reliability of *PCEEC* seems to be greater than expected” (Kaislaniemi et al. 2017: 188).

For the present study, the English control corpus helped determine which spellings in Scottish letters should be considered reflective of English epistolary spelling norms. If spelling patterns in the Scottish letters were also a feature of the English letters, as is the case with the retention and addition of non-functional final *-e* as in *doe*, *goe* and *again*, they were classified as standard spellings.

Transitional spellings

The second category encompasses spellings that are close to the print and/or the epistolary standard norms but are neither listed by Osselton and Tieken-Boon van Ostade nor regularly found in the 17th-century English control corpus. I classify these as transitional spellings since writers seem to have tried to adapt to spellings commonly found in printed texts and in letters. The biggest class within this category are words displaying omission of final *-e* such as *befor*, *tym* and *wellcom*, as is illustrated in (10).

- (10) yet I feare I must come to it *befor* I can be settled,
(#1233, Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth, 1701)

Other cases include instances where the Scottish writers attempt to adapt their spelling to English conventions, for example, when replacing the grapheme

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<ch>, representing the Scots velar fricative /x/, with the anglicised spelling variant <gh> (see [Bann & Corbett 2015: 23](#)). This is the case with *doghter* instead of Scots *dochter*, where the consonant grapheme is anglicised but the vowel is not changed to <au> (see [Aitken 1984, 2015: 5](#); [Aitken 1997, 2015: 30](#)), as exemplified in (11).

- (11) I am soe selff a fflaterer and reallie so much a serueant to your mothers
doghter
 (#703, Anne Hamilton, 3rd Duchess of Hamilton, 1659)

A further example of adaptation towards the emerging English standard are cases where the grapheme representing the stressed vowel is anglicised, for example, using <a> instead of the digraph <ai> in *carles* to represent long /e:/, see (12).

- (12) I find the advocat and president uas verie *carles* when thy dreu thos
 papers at London
 (#1258, Anna Scott, Duchess of Buccleuch and Monmouth, 1700)

The category 'transitional spellings' further comprises spellings preserving an older spelling norm, for instance, the use of medial <u> for the consonant /v/, e.g., in *haue*, or of initial <v> for vowel sounds, e.g., in *vpon* (see [Rutkowska 2016: 168–169](#)), as is displayed in (15).¹⁸

- (13) For *vpon* what you writ me word, I *haue* sent to *haue* the holle *aduiſe*
 sent to me by *Aduocat* put in excecusion
 (#1236, Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth, 1701)

The positional distribution of <u> and <v>, though abandoned in printed texts in favour of the modern orthographic-phonetic distribution in the first half of the 17th century (see Kaislaniemi [this volume]), is still in a transitional stage in handwritten texts at the of the 17th century ([Grund et al. 2021](#)). Although the use of <u> for /v/ is attested in the English control corpus, it only represents the spelling practices in the Fleming letter collection and is therefore not taken to be representative of an epistolary spelling standard. Since the English control corpus draws on PCEEC data, which are based on editions, it is, however, possible that <u/v> spellings were modernised by the editors, as Kaislaniemi et

¹⁸The conservative use of <i> for <j> (see [Rutkowska 2016: 169–170](#)), as in *ioy* and *iudge*, is classified as a standard spelling because it is frequently found with different writers in the English control corpus.

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al. (Kaislaniemi et al. 2017: 190) point out. Therefore, it cannot be ruled out that the old positional distribution of <u> and <v> was more widely applied in the English letters (see also Kaislaniemi forthcoming [this volume]).

Non-standard spellings

The final category contains both Scots spellings and idiosyncratic spellings. To determine whether a spelling should be classified as Scots or as idiosyncratic, the *Dictionary of the Older Scots Tongue* (DOST), the *Oxford English Dictionary* (OED) and Bann & Corbett's (2015: 16–58) description of the development of Scots vowel and consonant graphemes up to 1700 were consulted.

Examples of Scots spelling conventions include, among others,

- the vowel digraph <ai> representing the long vowel /e:/ instead of <a>, as in *cairfull*,
- the use of <a> in *sarvant* 'servant' and *sarvis* 'service',
- the use of final *-ie* instead of *-y* in nouns such as *beautie* and adjectives such as *happie*,
- the use of <u> instead of <o> in *sum* 'some',
- the use of <s> in *sall* 'shall' and *sould* 'should', indicating the Scots pronunciation with /s/ instead of /ʃ/, i.e., sibilant interchange (see Gough forthcoming [this volume]).
- The use of <w> to represent vowel sounds and the consonant /v/ (see Bann & Corbett 2015: 35), e.g., in *hows*, *swbcriwe* and *hawe* in (14).

- (14) He canot be ansarabell to allow me to *hawe* in the *hows* if I will not
swbcriwe the testement
 (#1268, Christian Cameron, 1722)

If unusual spellings could not be found in the *OED* or in *DOST*, these are considered idiosyncratic, as, for example, *diseres* and *Espislie* in (15).

- (15) I am mor *diseres* of *Espislie* to seae my {torn except for initial <s>}
 (#1268, Christian Cameron, 1722)

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After categorising the spelling of all words, excepting proper nouns, in the 50-letter dataset into one of the three categories, a) standard spellings, b) transitional spellings and c) non-standard spellings, as outlined above, percentages were calculated for each category both for the whole letter and for the address forms as well as the opening and closing formulae. In some letters only an address form and a short closing formula were used. In others, either the address form was followed by an opening formula, or they manifested a sequence of closing formulae (also in the post script), or both. Based on the percentages for the different letter parts, it was possible to investigate to what extent standard spellings were introduced into the letters through formulae, representing prefabricated units, as will be discussed in Section 4.

4 The distribution of standard spellings in 17th and 18th-century Scottish female-authored letters

This section explores both to what degree female Scottish letter-writers adhered to an epistolary standard, as established for English correspondence, and to what extent they deviated from this standard (Section 4.1). Moreover, it will be considered whether there is evidence for standard spellings being introduced via epistolary formulae (Section 4.2).

4.1 Standard spellings across the whole letter

Analysis of the fifty 17th- and 18th-century letters revealed considerable variation regarding the ratio of standard spellings they contain. To illustrate this variation, Figure 1 charts the percentages of a) standard spellings, b) transitional spellings and c) non-standard spellings in the letters in chronological order, ranging from the oldest letter written in 1650 on the left to the most recent letter from 1731 on the right. The numbers along the x-axis correspond to the numbers assigned to each letter in Tables 1 and 2 (see Section 3.1).

A slight diachronic trend towards an increase of standard spellings is discernible in letters written after letter No. 17 which was written in 1667, suggesting this increase takes place from the 1670s onward. With four exceptions, letters written before the 1670s do not exceed a level of 80 per cent of standard spellings. This is matched by a fairly consistent rate of well over 10 per cent of non-standard spellings, with one exception. Nevertheless, the letters written after the 1670s, rather than displaying a clear upwards trend, are characterised by marked individual variation regarding the ratio of standard spellings. This variation also applies to non-standard spellings. In the majority of letters, these drop

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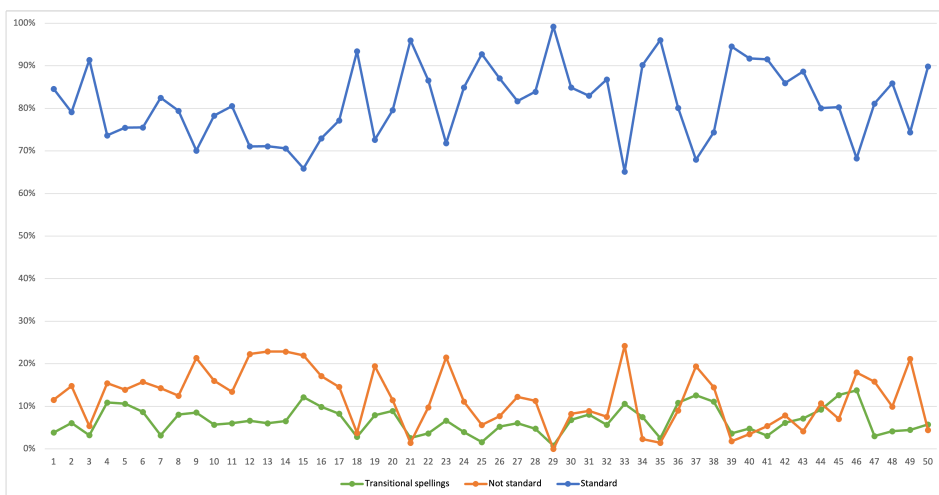


Figure 1: Relative distribution of standard spellings, transitional spellings and non-standard spellings in 50 letters (1650–1750)

to – in some cases clearly – below 10 per cent after the 1670s, but there are also 12 letters where the rate of non-standard spellings is above 10 per cent.

In 10 letters post-dating 1670, the rate of standard spellings reaches ca. 90 per cent or more. One of these letters dates from 1671 and the other eight were written in the 1690s or the first decade of the 18th century. The writer with the highest percentage of standard spellings is E. Ruglen (No. 29), attaining 99.22 per cent. Her spelling practices are illustrated in (16).

(16) Madam

Your La: has great reason to think me one of the rudest creatures in the world for not returning y^r La: (= Ladyship's) my humble thanks for the favour of y^r *oblidging* letter sooner; but I assure y^r La: till this day I did not know how to direct to you, or else I had not omitted doing what I was {ins} so {ins} much ty'd to, both by civility, & inclination;

(...)

Madam Your La:^{sp}s affect^t: Sister & Most humble Servant
(#1257, E. Ruglen, 1701)

Only *oblidging*¹⁹ is classified as a transitional spelling. All other spellings cor-

¹⁹Only two writers in the Fleming collection have *oblidge* rather than *oblige*, the common spelling across the other English letters. Moreover, the search string *oblig** by far outnumbers *oblidge** in the printed texts represented in the *Early English Books Online (EEBO-TCP)* collection, with 21,823 hits compared to 506 hits (<https://quod.lib.umich.edu/e/eebogroup/>).

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respond to the standard, in fact, overwhelmingly the print standard, and no non-standard forms are attested.

Conversely, letters with a percentage of standard spellings below 70 per cent, representing the other end of the spectrum, are found in both the 17th and the 18th century, with one letter dated to 1666 and three letters to 1702, 1705 and 1714, respectively. An excerpt from a letter by Isobell Douglas of Kelhead (No. 15) exemplifies how Scots spellings are intermingled with idiosyncratic spellings in such letters, see (17).

- (17) Dear madam *thes* is a tim when *pipell* canot *choues* Bot Be most *angsioues* for *noues*
(#748, Christian Lindsay, Countess of Haddington, 1666)

Typical Scots spellings include *thes* 'this', *pipell* 'people', *choues* 'choose' and *bot* 'but'. *Angsioues* and *noues* are idiosyncratic spellings not found in *DOST*.

In sum, while there is a slight trend towards a decrease of non-standard spellings after the 1670s, accompanied by a concomitant increase in standard spellings, spelling practices in the late 17th- and early 18th-century letters under analysis are characterised by marked individual variation.

4.2 Comparison of standard spellings in the whole letter and in the formulae

After discussing patterns regarding the general ratio of standard spellings to non-standard spellings in the letters under analysis, this section will compare the rate of standard spellings in the whole letter with the rate in the opening and closing formulae to see whether there is a trend towards introducing standard spellings through formulae.

Consistent spelling across all letter parts

In 28 letters (57%), which are spread across the whole time period under consideration, the rate of standard spellings remains relatively constant across all letter parts, i.e., it deviates by less than 5 percentage points, see Figure 2. This applies, for instance, to E. Ruglen's letter (No. 29), which manifests an overall percentage of standard spellings of 99.2 per cent, matched by a rate of 100 per cent in her formulae (see Example (16) above). While E. Ruglen's letter displays a consistent application of standard spellings in the whole letter, writers may also demonstrate a uniformly low percentage of standard spellings across all letter parts. C. Montrose (No. 33) from the North-East of Scotland, writing in 1702, is a case in point.

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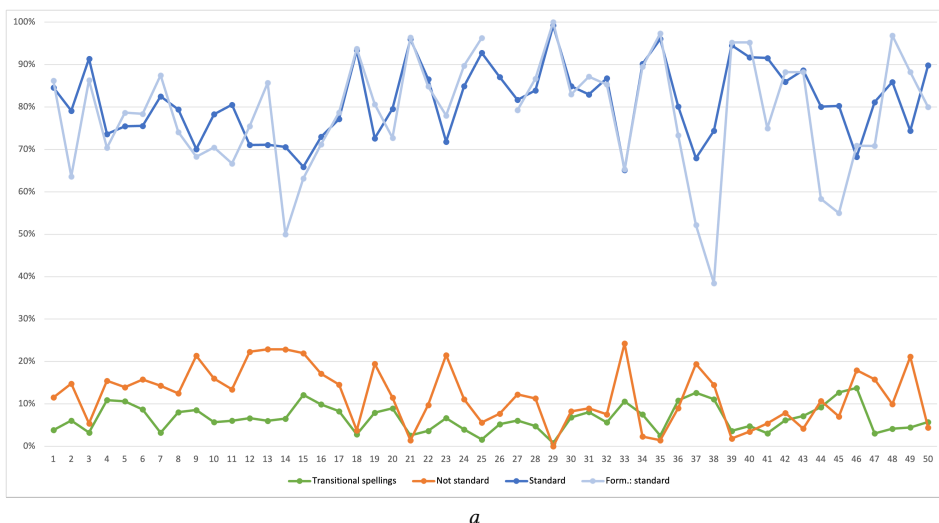


Figure 2: Comparison of percentage of standard spellings in the whole letter and in the opening and closing formulae

^aSince one letter by Anna Scott, Duchess of Buccleuch and Monmouth, neither includes an address nor opening and closing formulae, Figure 2 only displays percentages of standard spellings in the formulae of 49 letters.

More standard spellings in the formulae

More interestingly, however, in 21 letters the percentage of standard spellings in the whole letter does not agree with the percentage in the opening and closing formulae. Only six letters (12%), display a higher percentage of standard spellings in the formulaic parts than in the letter as a whole. For four of these, the rate of standard spellings in the letter as a whole is comparatively low, i.e., below 75 per cent. This pattern is, for instance, found in Christian Cameron's letter (No. 49), see (18).

- (18) I am mor diseres of Espislie to seae my {torn except for initial <s>} and
nixte peter Cambell for afortnighte tym I am sencbell that fisick will
hawe mor Emprisione their at other tym D: b: (= Dear brother) that
Archbld Cambell I neade write to *yow* was the Minister of the brease
{<blurred>} I being in heaste Cased him to *aqwite* *yow* god knows it if (= is?)
the leaste in my Minde
(...)
Which is all from D: b: (= Dear brother) *your Loving* sister Christian
Camerone

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(#1268, Christian Cameron, 1722)

The excerpt above illustrates that Christian Cameron regularly uses the Scots variants <w> for /v/ and <ow> for /u/ in the body text of her letter. However, in her closing formula, she avoids <ow> and <w> and uses <ou> and <v> instead in *your Loving sister*. Thus, it is possible that she memorised this formula as a prefab also in terms of spelling. Nevertheless, her opening formula *I receiwd yowr the 19 of this month*, which frequently recurs in slight variations in other letters in *ScotsCorr*, displays the use of <ow> and <w>. Anne Hay's two letters (No. 47 and 48) present a similar case, which, moreover, illustrates that writers' spelling habits were not stable. She also consistently applies <ow> for /u/ and <w> for /v/ and vowel sounds in the body part of her letters. While she applies the Scots variants <ow> and <w> to represent vowels in the closing formula of her letter dated 21 March 1716, see (19), she applies the standard variants <ou> and <v> in her letter dated 6 April 1716, see (20).

(19) I am Madam Yowr La: (= Ladyship's) most dutifull and most *Hwmbble servant* Anne Hay
(#1230, Anne Hay, 21 March 1716)

(20) I shall ask her commands till then I hope this may be acceptable from Madam your La: (= Ladyship's) most dutifull and most *Humble servant* Anne Hay
(#1231, Anne Hay, 6 April 1716)

Fewer standard spellings in the formulae

In 15 letters (31%), the formulae manifest the opposite trend, namely a lower percentage of standard spellings than in the letter as a whole. Among the most conspicuous cases are three letters by Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth, and Anne Mackenzie from the early 18th century. They manifest a particularly high percentage of transitional spellings in the formulae, see No. 38, 44 and 45 in Figure 3.

The excerpt from Anne Mackenzie's letter from 1713 in (21) illustrates that her address and closing formula are very dense in transitional spellings due to the omission of final *-e* in *affectionat* (2x), *troubll* (1x) and *humbll* (1x) and the spelling of *cousing* with <ng>. Moreover, *seruant* represents the conservative spelling with <u> for /v/.

(21) affecctionat Cousing

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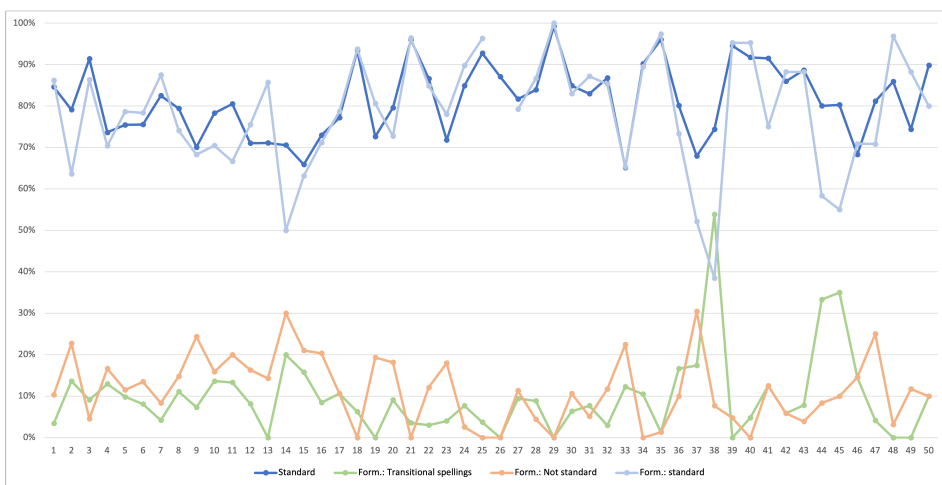


Figure 3: Comparison of percentage of standard spellings in the whole letters with standard spellings, transitional spellings and non-standard spellings in the opening and closing formulae

I find my Lady *very vexed*. soomtyms. That she cannot comply. With her
grandsons desyr. I heard soom of the Lords, and soom other lawers. say.
they thought it strang. That they wad. *Have* my Lady *give* a trust,
(...)

I shall ad no furdre troubl. But *beleieve* me to be Sir your *affecationat*
Cousing and *humbl* *seruant* Anne M^ckenzie
(#1249, Anne Mackenzie, 1713)

The use of <u> in *seruant* and also in *beleieve* in the closing formula is especially intriguing since Anne Mackenzie is otherwise relatively consistent in her application of the modern distribution of <u> and <v>, exemplified by *very vexed*, *have* and *give* in (21). This modern distribution had been applied in printed texts since ca. 1630 (Salmon 1999: 39). Recent research has demonstrated, though, that even handwritten texts from the end of the 17th century did not consistently apply this new system but instead evinced considerable variability, as is the case in the *Records of the Salem Witch-Hunt* (1692) (Grund et al. 2021). To check whether Anne Mackenzie applied the distinction between the body text and the formulae across all her letters, the analysis was extended to the eleven letters by Anne Mackenzie in *ScotsCorr* that had not been included in my 50-letter corpus, all dealing with estate business. This confirmed that she seems to have aimed for the standard spelling in the body text of her letters. The grapheme <u> is only occasionally used in function words, e.g., initially in *uith* and *uich*, but consistently

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for *servant*, once in the body text and otherwise in her closing formulae. Other women writers from the North of Scotland and the same family in my 50-letter corpus exclusively apply the spelling <u> for /v/, e.g., Isobel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth, and Frances Herbert, Countess Dowager of Seaforth. By contrast, male family members represented in *ScotsCorr*, such as Charles Mackenzie, generally favour <v>, with only isolated relics of <u> in letters from the late 17th century, as is illustrated in (22).

- (22) Who is *verie* much Sir yowr most oblidged *servant* Charles Mackenzie
Excuse me that I *giue* the truble {ins} of {ins} this inclosed to be *delivered*
to George Mackenzie
(#806, Charles Mackenzie, 1682)

In this example, Charles Mackenzie employs <v> for /v/ in the closing formula in *verie*, *servant* and *delivered*, and, in fact, throughout his whole letter. The only exception is *giue*.

The example of the Mackenzie family demonstrates that the male members had changed to the modern distributional system for <u> and <v> by the end of the 17th century, with only the occasional slip back into the old positional system. The female members, however, still held on to the conservative <u> for /v/ spelling to varying degrees. While Frances Herbert and Isobel Mackenzie consistently applied <u> in their letters,²⁰ Anne Mackenzie relatively consistently switched to the new <u/v> distribution in the body text of her letters. Her regular use of <u> for /v/ in her closing formulae suggests that she may have regarded <u> as the standard variant for epistolary formulae.

In summary, the comparison of the rate of standard spellings in the opening and closing formulae to the rate in the entire letter reveals a varied pattern. While most writers manifest a consistent percentage of standard spellings across all letter parts, only few writers in fact evince a higher rate of standard spellings in the formulaic parts. Interestingly, there are more letters in which writers include fewer standard spellings in their formulae, as is the case with Anne Mackenzie. Her spelling practices suggest that she may have learned from older models preserving conservative epistolary spellings in her closing formulae.

²⁰Findings from a separate study of <u/v> alternation in Isobel Mackenzie's letters in *ScotsCorr* (Elsweiler n.d.) indicate that she introduced the occasional medial <v> spelling alongside her usual <u> spellings in a letter from 1697 but returned to her old system in her early 18th-century letters.

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5 Conclusions

The goal of this study was not only to find out whether female Scottish letter-writers introduced Standard English spellings in their correspondence through prefabricated formulae, but it aimed more generally to shed some light on how these women interacted with standard spelling norms and which norms these were.

Rather than fully confirming my hypothesis that standard spellings would be introduced via formulae, the study findings revealed various patterns, indicating that women writers interacted with different standards in varied ways. Overall, the results testify to a general awareness of an epistolary standard norm, which was increasingly aimed for towards the latter part of the 17th and in the early 18th century, as is implied by the slight decrease of non-standard spellings after the 1670s. This is, however, not accompanied by a clear diachronic upward trend. Rather the letters exhibit considerable inter-writer variation.

Although few in number, the evidence from letters manifesting a higher rate of standard spellings in the opening and closing formulae suggests that women with limited spelling skills may have turned to established epistolary models as scaffolding for their letters also on an orthographic level. These established standard formulae may have been drawn from manuals or from correspondence circulating among family and friends.

By contrast, some women at the other end of the scale show a high degree of awareness of standard spelling norms. Among the eight writers achieving a rate of standard spellings of 90 per cent or higher, idiosyncratic spellings are hardly evidenced. The majority of these writers adhered to the established epistolary spelling standard. A few Scots spellings may be interspersed, which, in some cases might be instances of “an identity performance that involves the writer’s adherence to idiosyncratic, or perhaps local, forms, despite exposure to more widespread forms” (Evans & Tagg 2020: 208). This may well apply to Jean Campbell’s use of *cussane* and *cusine* (No. 39 and 41) when addressing her recipient Alexander Campbell of Barcaldine and referring to herself. However, women letter-writers do not only manifest exposure to epistolary spelling norms, but some seem to have aimed for the print standard, for instance, E. Ruglen (see Section 4.2), indicating that they had access to printed writing and interacted with it in their own letter-writing.

Lastly, “local network norms” (Evans & Tagg 2020: 213) seem to have influenced some writers’ spelling practices as well. Anne Mackenzie, for example, was, on the one hand, surrounded by women writers from the North of Scotland consistently using medial <u> for /v/. On the other, the men in her family had

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recently switched from medial <u> to medial <v>, thus implementing the new supraregional norm. While mainly drawing on the male spelling practice in the body text of her letters, in her closing formulae she seems to have applied a local conservative epistolary standard involving the regular use of medial <u> in *seruant* and in other words.

This study therefore indicates that Scottish women in the 17th and 18th century interacted not just with one standard but with multiple standards. These included both local standards, representative of a regional community of letter-writers, and supraregional epistolary and print spelling standards, thus testifying to a complex pattern of letter-writing practices.

With my analysis, I could thus demonstrate that the *ScotsCorr* correspondence data offer valuable insights into writers' spelling habits, how these change over time, and how these relate to various standard norms. The corpus data lend themselves to both focused qualitative studies and more extensive quantitative studies. While this study zoomed in on the spelling practices of 50 female letter-writers, in a follow-up study focusing on <u> / <v> variation in a selection of high-frequency words, I zoom out and account for larger-scale patterns across all writers in the 1650–1700 and 1700–1750 sub-corpora (Elsweiler n.d.).

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Chapter 3

Gender differences in the anglicization of spelling practices in Scottish correspondence (1540–1750)

Emily Gough

In the Early Modern period, both Scots and English were emerging standards. English would eventually complete the standardisation process. Scots, however, would not and instead undergo anglicisation. The 16th-18th centuries represent a unique time for Scots spelling practices during which, due to various events which increased Southern English influence, Scots underwent anglicisation. As a result, features which were characteristic of Scots spelling and pronunciation were replaced by English. This study is interested in one such feature: Sibilant Interchange—the presence of /s/ or /ʃ/ where the other is etymologically expected. In addition, this study investigates the possibility of a quantifiable gender difference in the adoption of the incoming spelling forms by incorporating statistical models in the analysis. Whereas previous studies have found women to retain Scots features longer than men (Meurman-Solin 2005), ultimately, I find that women were significantly ahead of men in this change.

1 Introduction

1.1 An emblematic feature

Before the end of the 16th century, Early Modern Scots [EModSc] (as conceptualized by Kopaczky 2013: 253) was on its way to becoming a national language standard. However, various events (e.g., the Reformation, the Union of Crowns, and the Union of Parliaments) led to increased contact with the emerging Southern English standard variety and ultimately anglicization - the increasing adoption

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of lexical, morphological, syntactic and spelling features of the Southern English standard by Scottish writers. These events interrupted the standardization process,¹ and by the 18th century, most features emblematic of Scots spelling, which were often indicative of Scots pronunciation, had been replaced by (Southern) English forms. This study explores this process for what Johnston (1997: 105) refers to as “one of the more salient features of Older Scots phonology”: Sibilant Interchange (SI). SI refers to the phenomena when /s/ or /ʃ/ occurs where the other is expected etymologically, e.g., Scots *sal* /s/ ‘shall’ < Old English (OE) <scV-> /ʃ/; *schir* /ʃ/ < French *sieur* /s/ ‘sir’. Specifically, I explore the SI pattern of /s/ for etymologically expected /ʃ/ by investigating the change from Scots <s> to English <sh> (henceforth S-SH) in variants of *sal/suld* ‘shall/should’. This will be done by analyzing how letter-writers used three graphemes: <s>, <sh>, and the tri-graph <sch>. <s> is seen as the typical Scots spelling while <sh> is the incoming English form which gained popularity during the Middle English period (Scragg 1974: 46). <sch> is of interest as it is the expected Scots spelling for /ʃ/ and therefore it is possible to consider a change in pronunciation as well as spelling. That is, if the letter-writers are incorporating <sch> prior to <sh>, perhaps this is a reaction to the change of pronunciation and the writers are implementing their Scots spelling system before they began using the English digraph. As the focus is on S-SH, the discussion of the other pattern of SI will be kept to a minimum.

This study uses correspondence data, which allows for the investigation of women’s spellings (see Section 3.1). As correspondence data enables the analysis of both male and female informants, it is possible to investigate the potential of a gender difference in the adoption of the incoming spelling. Based on previous studies of gender differences in the anglicization of EModSc spellings, it would be expected that women would be more conservative and retain Scots features longer (Meurman-Solin 2005). The guiding research question for this study is as follows: Is there a quantifiable gender difference in the incorporation of the incoming English <sh> in variants of *sal/suld*? The focus on these variants is due to the nature of the corpus used and the overwhelming prevalence of variants of *sal/suld* for the S-SH pattern of SI. In addition, this study considers what this may reveal about how men and women interacted with the spelling conventions of the emerging Scots and English standards.

¹For an overview of these events and the history of Scots in general, see e.g., Corbett et al. (2003), Görlach (2002), and Macafee & Aitken (2002).

3 Gender differences in the anglicization of spelling practices

1.2 Two emerging standards

Prior to anglicisation, Scots was well on its way to developing a standard form. As Aitken (1985: 4) puts it, “in the later fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries there were two national languages in use in Britain; metropolitan Tudor English in [...] England, and metropolitan Older Scots in [...] Scotland.” However, the increasing social pressure to adopt the emerging English prestige standard over the course of the 16th to 18th centuries, and the concurrent replacement of Scots features with their Southern English equivalents, ultimately resulted in Scots failing to reach full standardisation in the same way that (southern) English did.

Scots spelling practices have often been discussed as being characterised by variation (e.g., Aitken 1971). However, the same can be said for Early Modern English (EModE) spelling practices (e.g., Agutter 1988: 6; Moessner 2017: 170). That is, at the beginning of the period under investigation, neither variety had a fixed spelling system. English, however, reached a similar system to Present-day English by the mid-17th century (e.g., Moessner 2017: 172). By this time period, Scots spelling practices had largely adopted English forms following anglicisation.

One of the driving forces behind the standardisation of spelling was the influence of printing. Whereas printing in England was introduced in Westminster by William Caxton in 1476, in Scotland the first printing press was established in Edinburgh in 1507/8 by Walter Chepman and Andrew Myllar. At first, this does not appear to be noteworthy outwith the 32-year delay; both printing presses were set up in major centres of power for their respective countries and initially, Edinburgh printers printed materials in Scots. However, printing in Scots did not last, or as Bald (1926: 115) puts it, “the period of Scotticised printing had lasted for little over a century. It began in 1508; it ended as a deliberate process between 1603 and 1606; it entirely disappeared after 1627.” An escalation in anglicised printed materials from Scotland and English printed materials from the south resulted in increased contact and therefore familiarity with the English spellings forms—at least, for the literate.

In addition, one important resource that existed for English, and not Scots, was the English translation of the Bible. As there was no official Scots Bible at the time, it was the Geneva Bible (published in full in 1560) that was distributed in Scotland.² Thus, English became associated with the Church and the literate population was increasingly exposed to written English in their daily lives. Finally, the rise of anglicisation was cemented during the 18th Century, which saw

²Some did try making a Scots translation of the Bible, for example Murdoch Nisbet translated the New Testament in c.1520, though this was not published until the 20th century (Smith 2012: 9; Millar 2023: 52).

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a rise in prescriptivist views *against* Scots and guides to help individuals decrease their use of ‘Scotticisms’, e.g., David Hume’s *Political Discourses*.

Consequently, codification, i.e. the reduction in variation and increase of prescriptivist materials, was the stage of standardization (Haugen 1966) that Scots did not achieve. Rather than dictionaries and guides for people to align their Scots use to, there were instead guides and spelling books to decrease the use of ‘Scotticisms’, e.g., works by Walter Scott, David Hume, and James Beattie (though see Jones 1997: §8.1 for a more detailed discussion), and classes to promote English pronunciation and, crucially, spelling.

1.3 Women

Following previous historical sociolinguistics approaches (e.g., Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003) I use the term ‘gender’ throughout this study rather than ‘sex’. This is due to gender relating to the societal association rather than a biological connotation. That said, I also will be associating the informants’ gender by their biological sex for it is not known if any of them identified differently. Gender is frequently found to play a significant role in language change in modern sociolinguistic studies, with women using a higher proportion of prestige forms than their male counterparts. Labov (2001: 293) proposes that there is a ‘Gender Paradox’ regarding women as leaders of change in present-day sociolinguistic studies: women are more likely to conform than men if the “sociolinguistic norms...are overtly prescribed”, though the reverse is true if these norms are not. Following the Uniformitarian Principle which states that what is (linguistically) possible now, must also be the case in the past, i.e., ‘using the present to explain the past’, it is possible that women were leading changes in the past also. That said, gender is a societal factor, and it would not be accurate to say that gender and social roles today are identical to 16th–18th century Scotland. Therefore, it is necessary to contextualise not only the history of the Scots, but also the society and women at the time. Section 1.3.1 will therefore consider this history as it relates to women and literacy in Scotland.³

1.3.1 Women and literacy in 16th–18th century Scotland

Formal education was not a priority in Scotland in the Middle Ages, let alone for women/girls, with those who were literate in the minority, while the ability to write was even rarer. By the beginning of the 16th century, members of the

³This section draws heavily on Marshall (1983) and Houston (1985). I have cited where appropriate but see these works for more comprehensive discussions of women and literacy in Scotland.

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(male) gentry were beginning to view the ability to read and write as valuable (Marshall 1983: 57). Prior to the Reformation in 1560, the eldest sons of landowners were educated in Latin at grammar schools (per the Education Act of 1496). If girls learned to read and/or write, it was done at home either by a family member or “their brother’s tutor” (Marshall 1983: 57), but this was not the norm. Following the Reformation, the Reformers wished to create schools “in every parish” though this was an expensive task and therefore not accomplished in the way the Reformers had hoped (Marshall 1983: 125). The number of schools did increase, and therefore the opportunity for girls to go to school should have as well, but girls’ low school attendance persisted as it was more useful for families to have the girls at home than in school (Dennison 2007; Marshall 1983: 125). Once attendance increased, the curriculum of boys and girls remained different. Boys were to be educated so that they could succeed in business endeavours; girls were educated to be good wives and mothers – that is, they were taught “sewing, washing, and cookery” (Marshall 1983: 126–127). Some girls were taught to read, but with the intention that they could read the Bible. Marshall (1983: 129, 131) describes the differences in boys’ and girls’ education in Early Modern Scotland:

As the years went by, more and more girls of landed families did learn to write in childhood, though not at such an early age as boys did. The latter went to school at six, but, for girls, lessons at home did not usually begin until they were seven or eight. They were then taught an italic style of writing, imitating either the letters set out in a copybook or a sample of writing done by a friend or relative thought to be especially proficient. ... Once a girl could read competently, sew and play an instrument, her lessons ceased....

That is, as time went on, girls were becoming more educated. However, the opportunities for girls were not as plentiful as they were for boys (e.g., Dennison 2007), though more so within wealthier families (who form the majority of the individuals represented in this study). Due to such a difference in access to education between men and women, it is not surprising that women’s letters show a higher degree of ‘orality’ (i.e., features relating to speech) and evidence of ‘sounding it out’ than their male counterparts (e.g., <twischone> ‘tuition’, <daufar> ‘daughter’, see Section 3.2).

Unsurprisingly, literacy rates between men and women were rather different, though it is difficult to measure this in present-day terms. One method of determining literacy is to evaluate signatures: someone would be deemed literate if they could sign their name, and illiterate if they could only sign initials or a

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symbol (Houston 1985: 20). However, as Nurmi (2017: 15) points out, using signatures to determine literacy simply provides us with an estimation and is by no means exact. This is especially the case with ‘gentlewomen’ whose literacy rates are likely to be underestimated (Nurmi 2017: 15). Nonetheless, it seems Scottish men were much more literate in the mid-17th century than women, though both were becoming more literate throughout the period (Houston 1982: 90–91) and the same can be said for English men and women (Cressy 1980: 2–3, 177). By the mid-18thC, Scottish women (77% illiterate) had not yet caught up with men’s literacy rates (22% illiterate), though it seems that men and women were increasing at similar rates (Houston 1982: 90–91). It would certainly be easier for a woman to help with various business duties while her husband was away if she knew how to read and/or write, as such help was frequently required (Dennison 2007; Nurmi 2017: 15; Ewan 2012: 275; Spence 2008).

1.3.2 Previous studies

Regarding the gendered use of Scots features in the 16th–18th centuries, Meurman-Solin (1991, 1993) conducted various studies on the effect of gender on Scots language change. She investigated multiple Scots forms affected by anglicization: variants of i-digraphs, (e.g., <oi> indicating the long vowel /o:/ in *befoir* ‘before’), as well as the switch from *quh-* to *wh-* (though she grouped this with *thai* ‘they’) and the change in preterit and past participle endings from *-it* to *-ed* (Meurman-Solin 1993: 126). She found that overall women were more conservative than men in retaining Scots features longer (Meurman-Solin 1991: 44; Meurman-Solin 1993: 160–162). However, in later studies, she did find that some women were indeed early adopters of innovative forms when comparing letters from a few individuals (e.g., Meurman-Solin 2000). She concluded that this is dependent on what region they come from, i.e., the South, and their contacts (Meurman-Solin 2000: 165).

Thus far, neither SI nor S-SH has been the primary focus of any in-depth sociolinguistic analysis. When previous studies have investigated SI, it is most often alongside other features which are analyzed together (e.g., Kniezsa 1997; Meurman-Solin 1993, 1997). Indeed, SI is often confined to very brief discussions or not mentioned at all: Meurman-Solin (1993) and Kniezsa (1997) included it in their list of ‘diagnostic variants’ for Older Scots, and Eyndhoven (2023: 194, 203) also included SI combined with other features in researching 18th century Scots, finding that attestations representative of SI were some of the least frequently used. In one of her studies, Meurman-Solin (1993) included SI with other characteristic Scots features where she found that men and women followed a similar

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trajectory in adopting the incoming English forms. However, while she split her data into three sub-periods of roughly 60–70 years: 1500–1570, 1570–1640, 1640–1700, for the analysis the data was grouped together, leaving her unable to determine when the male and female writers changed or who may have changed first.

2 Orthographic representation

The three graphemes which are relevant for S-SH during the 16th–18th century are <s, sh, sch>. In OE, it was <sc> that was typically used for ‘shall’ and ‘should’. In early ME, <sh> starts to be implemented for representing the palatalized /ʃ/ with the *Ormulum* having the first attestations of <(s)sh> for OE <sc> (e.g., [Knieszsa 1997](#): 31). Later in ME, <h> began to be used in other digraphs as well to represent frication, e.g., <gh, wh>. As such, throughout the ME period, the orthographic situation becomes increasingly complicated: “[a]s a rough approximation, we can say that ME *sc* spellings are ambiguous, *sk* indicates non-palatalisation, and *s, ss, sh, sch*, indicate palatalisation” ([Lass et al. 2013](#): SKP).⁴ [Scragg \(1974](#): 46) states that the use of <sh> as the reflex of OE <sc> “gradually found favour in London English at the end of the fourteenth century” and by the mid-15th century was almost always used to represent /ʃ/. This is evidenced by spellings like <oblygashons> (‘obligations’) which arise in the 15th century showing the palatalization of /sj/ > /ʃ/ ([Lass 2000](#): 121).

In EModSc, in initial position, <s> typically represented /s/, while /ʃ/ was instead represented by the trigraph <sch> ([Knieszsa 1997](#); [Bann & Corbett 2015](#)). The trigraph <sch> was also used to represent /ʃ/ in English – that is, it is not the case that <sch> is a grapheme exclusive to Scots at this time, nor is it specifically a Scots innovation. Rather what is significant is that Scots *overwhelmingly* used the trigraph for representing /ʃ/, allowing for the comparison between <sh> and <sch> to provide an insight to the letter-writers’ anglicising orthographic practices. Possible exceptions to this rule include some French borrowings such as *sure* and *sugar*; for which [Bann & Corbett \(2015](#): 32) note spelling variants like “*shugar, schugger* and *shoor, shower*” in addition to those with only initial <s>, suggest Scots would have /ʃ/ in these loans. There are no attestations of <sh> initial variants for ‘shall’ or ‘should’ in the southern Scottish localities in the *Linguistic Atlas of Late Mediaeval English* (eLALME c. 1325–1450, [Benskin et al. 2013](#)).

⁴They assumed that <s> was representative of /ʃ/ when the text had a majority <s> for OE <sc> in addition to some <sh> or <sch> ([Lass et al. 2013](#): ORPSC). For a more detailed discussion of <sk> and palatalisation, see, e.g., [Lass et al. \(2013](#): SKP), [Jordan \(1974](#): §181, 183).

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In the corpus *From Inglis to Scots* (FITS 1380–1500, [Alcorn et al. n.d.](#)), only five of the 2,275 tokens of *sal/suld* are not <s> (3 <ch>, 1 <sch>, and 1 <sh>).

In sum, OE initial <sc-> /sk/ underwent various sound changes which by early ME would have been /ʃ/. In Scots, *sal* and *suld* are examples of an exception to this rule; they instead came to be pronounced with /s/, which, orthographically, was represented by <s>, as <sch> indicated /ʃ/. This differs from English, which broadly had the digraph <sh> for /ʃ/ by the mid-15th century. However, in Scots <s> was eventually replaced by <sh> during the anglicisation process due to increasing contact and influence from the emerging English standard. This study investigates these three graphemes to better understand how Scottish letter-writers adapted their spelling to the growing influence from English. By including the Scots trigraph <sch> and comparing its use to the Scots variant <s> and the Southern standard English variant <sh>, it may be possible to determine if the writers were simply substituting the orthographic forms, or if they indeed were representing a change in pronunciation.

3 Methods and data collection

3.1 Correspondence data

The present analysis draws on data collected from the *Helsinki Corpus of Scottish Correspondence* (ScotsCorr, [Meurman-Solin 2017](#)) which contains diplomatic transcriptions of letters written by individuals from Scotland from the period 1540–1750 (specifically, the data spans 1542–1747),⁵ with data being organised into roughly 50-year periods. The letter-writers included are primarily members of the gentry, nobility, and a few of the royal family. As Scots corpora compiled before ScotsCorr have neither focused solely on correspondence, nor included such a large proportion of female-authored works, ScotsCorr provides a unique set of data. The currently-available version of ScotsCorr is not lemmatized and therefore I have relied on the alphabetised wordlist feature on the Korp concordance search tool website ([Borin et al. 2012](#)).

In total, ScotsCorr has 466 informants (letter-writers) and 1,362 letters containing over 400,000 words across nine sub-corpora; eight of the sub-corpora are divided by gender and period, and one sub-corpus contains ‘royal letters’. There are four time periods: 1540–1599, 1600–1649, 1650–1699, and 1700–1750. The 1600–1649 period contains the most data overall; however, the 1650–1699 period contains the most data overall from female informants.

⁵The earliest letter’s date is doubtful and may be from 1543 rather than 1542. ScotsCorr provides its *year* as 1542, but the *year* in the *date* is listed as 1542/3.

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Figure 1 presents the distribution of tokens for the male, female, and royal writers.⁶ Female informants and letters total 118 (25%) and 335 (25%), respectively, contributing about 86,000 words (21%). This disparity is to be expected as the combination of lower literacy and the preference to preserve men’s letters means that the data from women is likely to remain smaller (Marshall 1983: 57). It is, however, still possible to investigate the potential for a gender difference despite the difference in proportions from men and women.

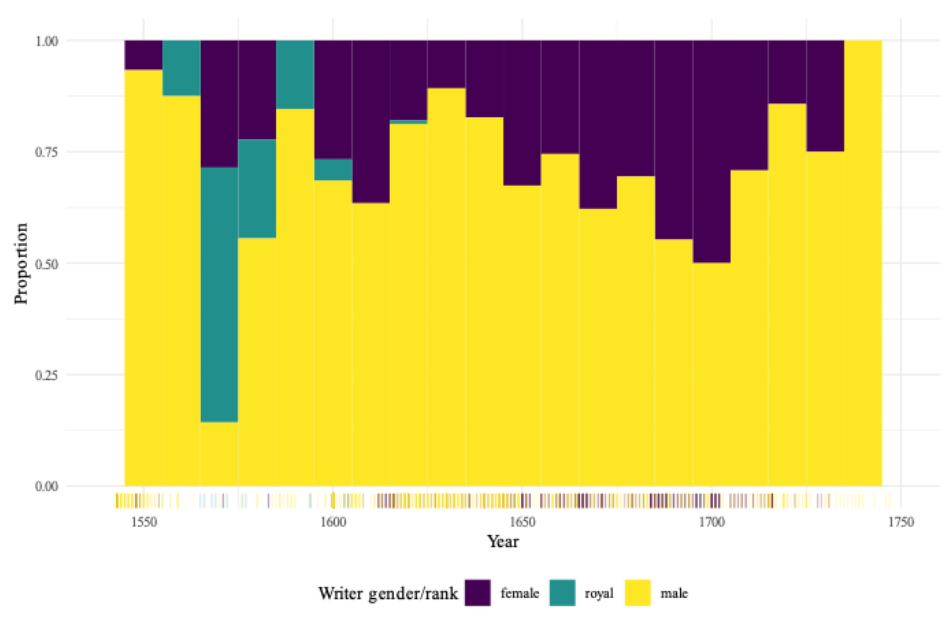


Figure 1: ScotsCorr proportion of writer gender/rank tokens - 10-year periods

One major benefit to using letters as a data source is that correspondence, specifically private correspondence, has been described as ‘speech-like’ and therefore represents a sense of orality that other genres do not display (Culpeper & Kytö 2010: 17). Another benefit to studying correspondence is that the biographical information of the writers and addressees, and their relationship, is often (though not always) known (Culpeper & Kytö 2010: 16). While this is certainly

⁶As will be addressed in Section 4.1, the *royal* data is minimal and concentrated in a small time frame and therefore is coded *male* and *female* for the purposes of the models. There are only five people with the ‘rank’ of *royal*: Mary, Queen of Scots, Mary of Lorraine, James VI, Charles I, and James Stewart, 1st Earl of Moray.

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true for some of the informants in this study, it by no means holds for all, especially regarding the women. Nonetheless, letters make it more possible to study the writings of underrepresented individuals such as women compared to other genres (e.g., Nurmi 2017: 9, 17).

While the data may be scarce, there are benefits to investigating women's letters and spelling. Women's letters have been found to contain higher proportions of 'phonetic spellings' (e.g., Meurman-Solin 1993, 1999). These 'phonetic spellings' are variants which are closer to representing speech, i.e., where the writer may have been 'sounding it out' (e.g., <spangzarttis> 'Spaniards'). This is particularly of interest for the present study as it may facilitate determining if women were ahead in the anglicisation of spellings representing speech. This is not always the case - Sönmez's (2000) comparison of spellings between two 17th century English letter-writers—Lady Brilliana Harley and William Cavendish, 1st Duke of Newcastle—found that there was not an increased number of phonetic spellings in Harley's letters. That said, previous studies have found women's correspondence to be insightful (e.g., Meurman-Solin 1991, 1993, 2001).

In sum, letters are the best data source for this study for two reasons: first, because they allow access to women's writing and including data from women is necessary in order to better account for the history of Scots, and second because letters are especially informative for 'speech-like' variants which may prove insightful for investigating anglicisation as well as sound changes under way. Furthermore, the letter-writer's gender is one of the few sociolinguistic variables available from historical correspondence (though certainly not the only variable).

3.2 Variant selection

The process for this study began with scanning through the wordlist feature in Korp and selecting any variants expected to be representative of *shall* or *should*. I focussed on *shall/should* for this study as these variants represent the overwhelming majority for word-initial position and facilitated data selection. For this study, I was able to focus my search on the *s* section of the wordlist. The OED and DOST were necessary for determining potential spellings. <sal(l)> and <suld> were by far the most frequent variants, and there are some examples of variants that required more scrutiny for determining their validity in representing one of the desired words. For example, (1) and (2) exemplify why it is a necessity to check the context for each variant. Consulting DOST, <salt> is listed as a potential variant for *should* (DOST, s.v. *sal* v.), but it is clear from the context that it is not representative of *should* in this case, instead representing *salt*. Similarly, DOST

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also provides <sel(l)> as a potential spelling for *shall*, but it can instead also be representative of *sell* as seen in example (2).

- (1) <salt>⁷
alex*ander% watonse will haue ane crear with salt of myne in londoun“
“Alexander Watson will have a career with salt of mine in London”
(#300, John Gordon, 12th Earl of Sutherland, 1615)
- (2) <sel>
I haue so often desyrit zou to sel al and let vs liue lyk man and vyf
“I have so often desired you to sell all and let us live like man and wife”
(#640, Agnes Keith, Countess of Morton, 1600)

The variant selection yielded a total of 2,949 tokens. The distribution of these variants is presented in Table 1. Most of them are either <s-> or <sh-> initial. This is as expected as these are the graphemes that align with the traditional Scots and English spellings (see Section 2). During the earlier and the latest periods, the letter-writers appear to be the most categorical as a group in their usage, preferring almost exclusively <s> in the earliest period and almost exclusively <sh> in the latest. This is expected as FITS (1380–1500) only has two attestations of <sh> or <sch> for *shall/should* out of 2,275 tokens and Eyndhoven (2023) reports minimal <s> or <sch> usage in the 18th century. Table 1 also shows that there is most variation between the spellings in the first half of the 17th century, when 62% of the variants are <s-> initial (see Figure 2). This period is also when the trigraph is used. It is interesting that this spelling would have been used while the writers were the least categorical, perhaps demonstrating that these writers who used <sch> were reacting to a change in pronunciation, whether or not it was their own, as <sch> was the typical Scots representation of /ʃ/.

While this study focuses on the change from <s> to <sh>, as has been shown, <sch> was used in the first half of the 17th century when the data is the most variable. I will thus now briefly discuss <sch>. In total, there are 42 attestations of <sch> spellings of *sal/suld* from seven writers. Three of these writers are women: Elizabeth Ker of Cessford, Lady Bellenden, Jean Drummond, Countess of Sutherland, and Isabella Seton, Countess of Perth. The four men are Patrick Murray, 3rd Earl of Tullibardine, John Seton, Archibald Campbell, 7th Earl of Argyll, and

⁷This example contains some of the transcription symbols found in ScotsCorr. *...% indicates that these letters were contracted in the original manuscript and have therefore been expanded. The <”> at the end of <londoun> indicates that the writer ended this word with some form of flourish (Meurman-Solin 2016: 44–45).

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Table 1: Variant totals by period and initial graph

	<i>s</i>	<i>sch</i>	<i>sh</i>	<i>n</i>	% <i>s</i>
1540–1599	475		9	484	98
1600–1649	916	42	520	1,478	62
1650–1699	71		649	720	10
1700–1750	1		266	267	<1
<i>n</i>	1,463	42	1,444	2,949	50

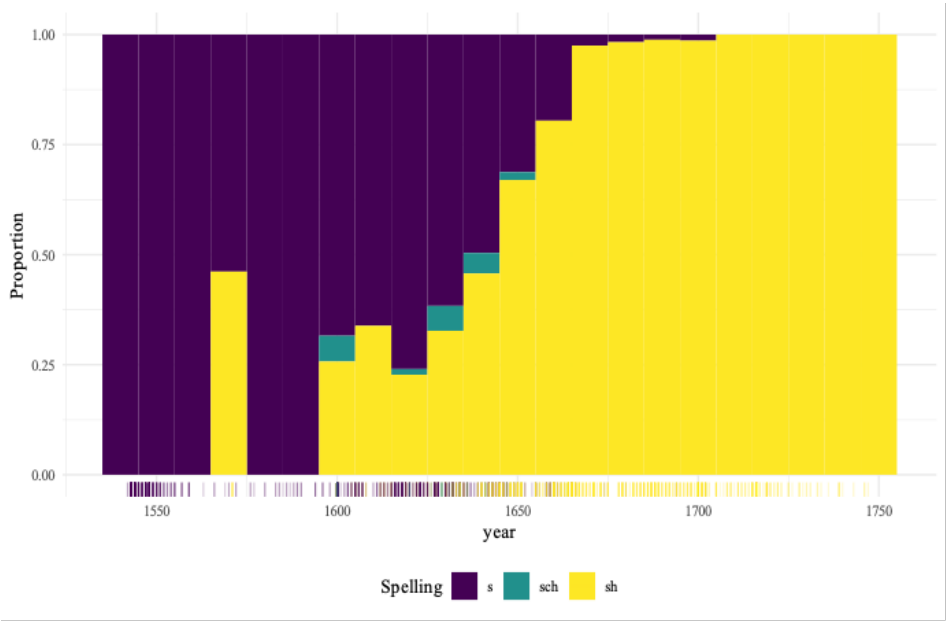


Figure 2: Proportion of spellings for shall/should

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George Hay of Kinfauns, 2nd Earl of Kinnoull. Of these letter-writers, only two were categorical in their use of <sch>: George Hay and Jean Drummond. The remaining writers had some level of variation between <s> and <sch>. Elizabeth Ker and Isabella Seton both favoured <s>. Patrick Murray and Archibald Campbell both preferred <sch>. The last individual, John Seton, is an interesting case as he is the only letter-writer to contribute all three graphemes (7 <s>, 4 <sh>, and 1 <sch>). Those who were not completely categorical did not vary in many of their letters. That is, apart from John Seton, they were consistent with one of the spellings throughout most of their letters.

Furthermore, regarding intra-writer spelling variation of *sal/suld*; 43 writers (roughly 1 in 7) have attested variation demonstrating that the writers were largely consistent in their spelling practices. Table 2 presents the number of variants from non-categorical letter-writers for men and women by time period (Section 4.1 presents the overall data distribution of the study by gender). Unsurprisingly, the highest proportion of intra-writer variation is found in the first half of the 17th century, i.e., the period with the most variation. Of the intra-writer variation, most writers varied between <s> and <sh>. As mentioned with regards to the trigraph, there was no variation from writers between <sch> and <sh> with the exception of John Seton who also varied with <s>. That is, only John Seton showed variation in his spellings that would indicate palatalisation of *sal/suld*.

Table 2: Number of variants from letter-writers with more than one spelling form attested

	Male	% of total	Female	% of total
1540–1599	2	<1	0	0
1600–1649	573	46	90	43
1650–1699	109	21	27	13
1700–1750	3	2	2	3
n	687	29	119	23

3.3 Statistical methods

Following this, a statistical analysis of the spelling variants was carried out on the data. The models implemented were generalised linear mixed-effects models (GLMM); specifically, logistic regressions. Logistic regression is particularly suitable for categorical data and useful for studying (historical) changes, as the

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S-curve pattern of change (e.g., Devitt 1989; Kroch 1989) is a logistic function (Labov 2001: 450). Recent studies have incorporated GLMMs when investigating variation and change (e.g., Denis et al. 2019; Simonenko et al. 2019; De Smet & Van De Velde 2020), and historical sociolinguistics studies have also found GLMMs to be insightful (e.g., Sinnemäki 2020, Mazzola et al. 2022).

These mixed-effects models take the data and, based on the variables included, describe how well the variables explain variation in the data. Each of the models include independent (fixed effects) and dependent variables (the outcome variable). Fixed effects are independent predictor variables and are assumed to be constant. As I am using ‘mixed effects’ (also known as multivariate) models, I have also included a random effect. For these models, the random effect is in the form of random intercepts which are different to fixed effects as they are assumed to have a different baseline (intercept). A common random effect in linguistics is *individual*. By including *individual* as a random effect/intercept, the model will be able to allow a different intercept of each informant that is not based on the fixed effects. The random effect in my models each *letter-writer*, apart from those who only contributed a single variant in a single letter. These individuals were classified as ‘other’ as “when only a single observation is available per individual, it is not possible to include the individual as a random-effect factor” (Tagliamonte & Baayen 2012: 158). For each model, *year* was included as a fixed effect. This is the only continuous variable included. In addition, I have centred *year*. Centring is a form of linear transformation (i.e., each level for *year* is transformed in the same way) which results in the mean of a continuous variable being the new ‘0’. By centring *year*, the intercept is no longer at year 0. Clearly, the data does not contain a year 0 and therefore by centring *year*, the mean year is now ‘0’. This ends up being roughly 1642 and facilitates model interpretation.

4 Analysis

4.1 Logistic regression

ScotsCorr has three levels encoded in *writer gender/rank*: *female*, *male*, and *royal*. Tables 3 and 4 provide a distribution of the data for S-SH. For both the male and female writers, there is a drastic change in the second half of the 17th century where both have almost completely switched to the English digraph <sh>. However, there is a difference in the proportion of <sh> in the four periods between the men and women. First, in the 16th century, women are the only ones to have attestations of the incoming spelling variant with 35% of their spellings being <sh>. In the first half of the 17th century, men and women have similar

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proportions of <sh>; roughly 36% and 30% respectively. The second half of the 17th century, however, again shows a difference. Whereas the men progress from 35% in the first half to 73% in the second, the women made a larger advancement with 98% of their variants being <sh>. By the first half of the 18th century, men and women have similar proportions again with 100% and 99%, respectively.

Table 3: Total tokens by writer gender/rank

Writer gender/rank	n
Female	513
Male	2,407
Royal	29
n	2,949

Table 4: Variant totals by graph, writer gender/rank and period

Female			Male			Royal		n	
Graph	<i>s</i>	<i>sch</i>	<i>sh</i>	<i>s</i>	<i>sch</i>	<i>sh</i>	<i>s</i>	<i>sch</i>	<i>sh</i>
1540–	17		9	443			15		484
1599									
1600–	139	8	62	764	34	457	13		1,478
1649								1	
1650–	5		202	66		447			720
1699									
1700–	1		70			196			267
1750									
n	162	8	343	1,273	34	1,100	28		2,949

Figure 3, a smoothed proportion of <sh> by writer gender/rank, visually exemplifies the minimal royal data – especially evident with the span of the confidence interval. Because of the sparsity of the royal writers, I have coded them as male or female for the models. Based on this plot, it appears women may indeed be changing their spelling before men; women reach 50% <sh> roughly twenty years before men. This supports the preliminary observations from Table 4, but it is surprising considering previous studies on gender and EModSc spelling have found women to be more conservative. Fitting a statistical model may prove insightful.

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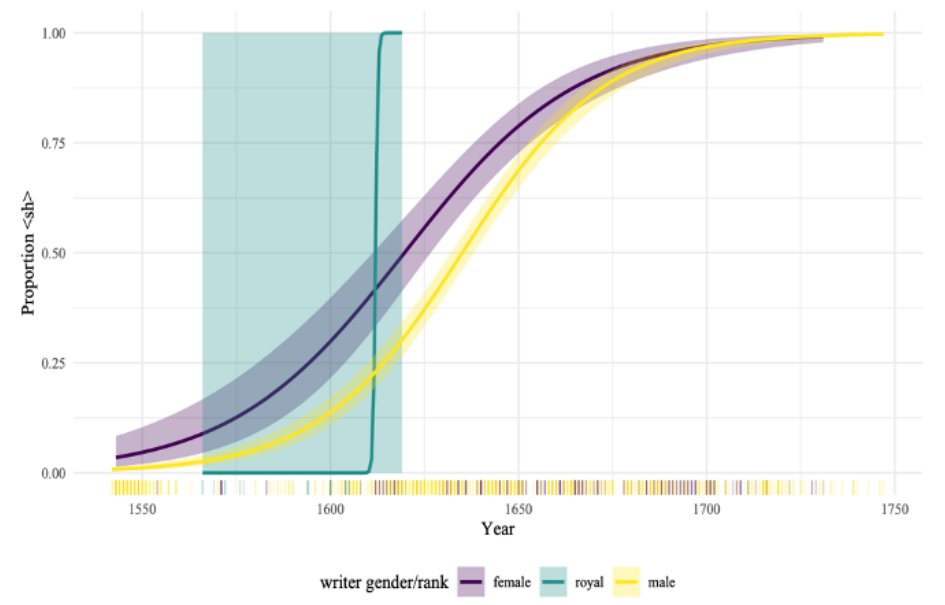


Figure 3: Smoothed proportion of <sh> by writer gender – including royal

Table 5 presents the coefficient table from a GLMM predicting the use of <sh> with *year* and *writer gender* as predictor variables, including the interaction of *year* and *writer gender*. The reference level for the GLMM is *female writers*. In this model, *writer gender* is a significant predictor for variant selection ($p=0.04$). The interaction of *year* and *male* is not significant ($p=0.68$), therefore the hypothesis that the rate of change is different between men and women cannot be disproved. Be that as it may, the combination of gender being significant and the estimates for intercept and *male* can be interpreted as indicating statistical significance for women adopting the incoming form earlier than men.

Table 5: GLMM predicting <sh> with year and writer gender

	Estimate	SE	z	p
Intercept	1.0456	0.4671	2.238	0.0252
year	3.8085	0.7358	5.176	<0.001
male	-0.9802	0.4712	-2.080	0.0375
year:male	0.3519	0.8462	0.416	0.6775

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Figure 4 is a visualisation of the model from Table 4. This plot aligns with the interpretations thus far. That is, women adopted <sh> in *shall/should* earlier than men. In addition, the non-significant finding for the interaction of year and male writers is clear, i.e., the slopes for the male and female writers are similar thus demonstrating that the rate of change is not overly different. Throughout 1600–1650, it appears that women are roughly 15 to 20 years ahead of men. By the middle of the 17th century, men and women are using similar proportions of the incoming spelling.

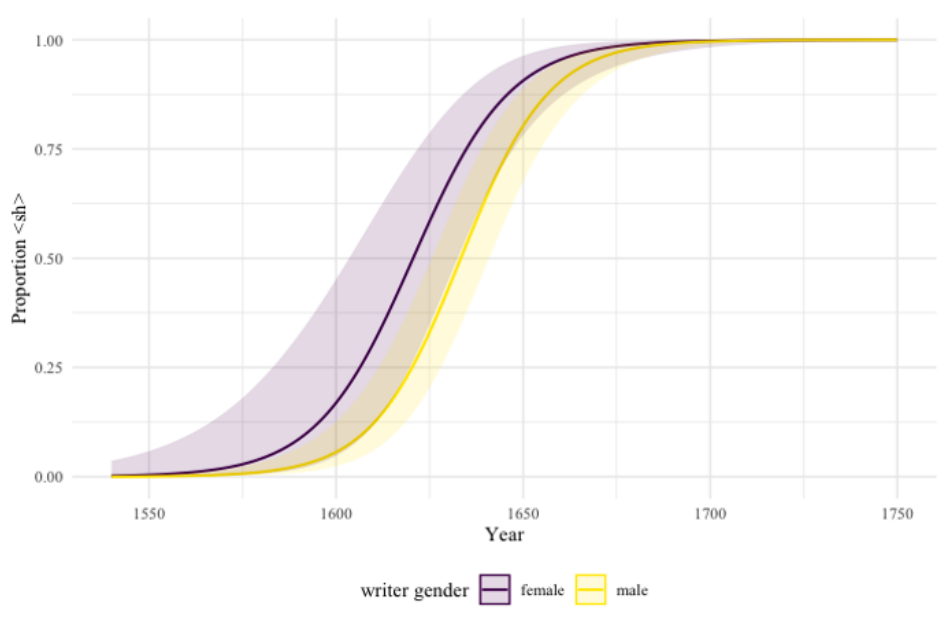


Figure 4: Visualization of GLMM for writer gender

The findings thus far have differed from previous accounts of gender difference in Scots spelling changes. Specifically, the model describes women as changing to <sh> earlier than men. This is different as the previous studies have found the opposite, i.e., that women were more conservative and retained Scots spellings longer than men. However, Section 5 explores if the findings here are influenced by a single individual outlier.

4.2 Margaret Douglas, Countess of Lennox

Margaret Douglas, Countess of Lennox’s spellings appear to be ahead of the rest of the informants for S-SH and therefore she is a potential outlier. Her nine tokens

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are the only attested <sh> spellings in the 16th century data for all of the writers, not just the women. Furthermore, she is categorical in her use of <sh> across her two letters found in ScotsCorr. Therefore, this section investigates whether her variants are skewing the results in the female letter-writers' favour.

A challenge of investigating women's writing is that it is not always possible to find information about the women in the corpus beyond their names and some sparse and basic information. However, Margaret Douglas, Countess of Lennox is one of the exceptions to this rule. Margaret, whose mother was Margaret Tudor and whose father was Archibald Douglas, 6th Earl of Angus, spent time in both Scotland and England. In her younger years she was brought up and educated at the English court, and indeed was a favourite, even serving as a lady-in-waiting to Anne Boleyn, and first lady of honour to Anne of Cleves and Katherine Howard (Marshall 2006). Eventually her son, Lord Darnley, married Mary, Queen of Scots. Her grandson would later become James VI/I. Therefore, it is clear that Margaret had ties to both the English and the Scottish court and therefore it is not surprising that her writing shows anglicised orthography.⁸ As her spellings are the earliest attested <sh>, is it the case that her data is resulting in an overestimation?

The model for Table 6 is the same as for Table 5, however Douglas' variants have been removed. It appears that, for S-SH, gender is no longer a significant predictor for variant selection without Margaret Douglas's letters (p=0.08). Instead, only *year* is described as significant. Figure 5 is a visual representation of the model from Table 6.

Table 6: GLMM predicting <sh> with gender and year as predictor variables – excluding Margaret Douglas, Countess of Lennox

	Estimate	SE	z	p
Intercept	0.8807	0.4681	1.882	0.0599
year	4.0956	0.7950	5.152	<0.001
male	-0.8395	0.4746	-1.769	0.0769
year:male	0.0189	0.8946	0.021	0.9832

When comparing Figures 4 and 5, the slope of the regression lines for female writers is different. Looking at the year 1600, Figure 5 shows the proportion of <sh> for women at 12%, whereas in Figure 4 women are at roughly 18%. Around

⁸She also has categorical <wh> for reflexes of OE *hw*- whereas Scots pre-anglicization would be expected to have <quh>.

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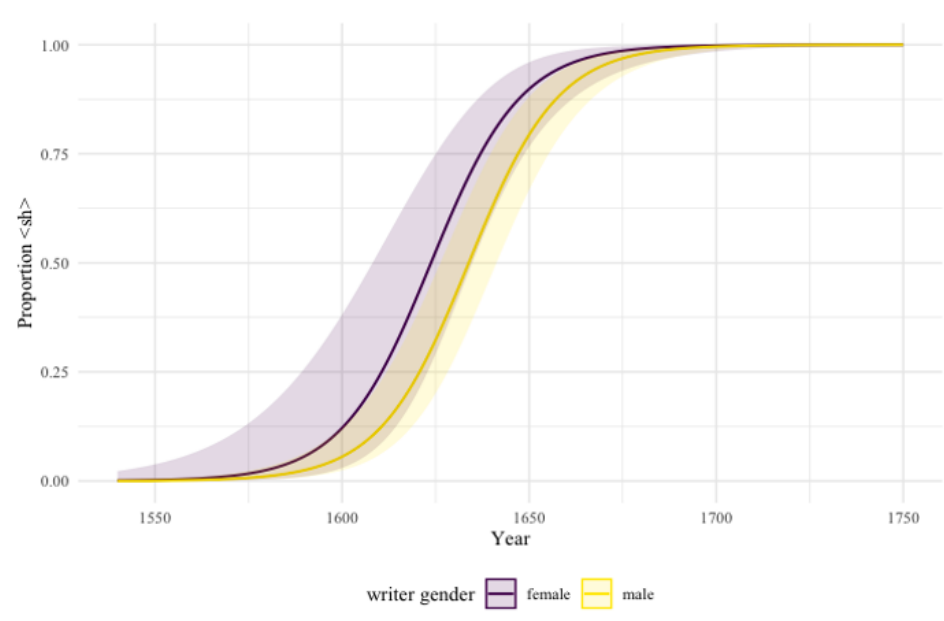


Figure 5: Visualization of model from Table 2

25 years later, the difference is greater at ~50% and over 60%. However, by 1650, the regression lines are almost identical, showing that the variants from Margaret Douglas had a stronger influence in the earlier period. As her data is from before 1600, this is not unexpected.

Margaret Douglas, Countess of Lennox is not the only woman with early frequent <sh> usage. In the early 17th century, there are a few women who also favoured <sh>. Three of these women are Marie Stewart, Countess of Mar (11 <sh> tokens), Jean Drummond, Countess of Roxburgh (10 <sh> tokens), and Anna Livingston, Countess of Eglinton (1 <s> and 9 <sh>). Interestingly, like Margaret Douglas, these three women all were involved to some extent with the Scottish and English court of James VI/I and Anne of Denmark, and therefore had a higher chance to be exposed to the English spelling convention.⁹ It is fair to say, based on the data for *sal/suld* in ScotsCorr, that Margaret Douglas is an outlier that resulted in the first model describing gender as statistically significant. However, given that Margaret Douglas is not the only individual with ties to the English

⁹Of course, it is not only women who had some sort of tie to the English court and therefore had an increased likelihood to have access to the incoming spelling form. One example is Henry Stewart, 1st Lord Ruthven. He was the third and final husband of Margaret Tudor (Margaret Douglas' mother), however he only ever used the etymologically expected <s> spelling.

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Court, there is insufficient evidence to remove her, and we can therefore treat the earlier model as valid.

5 Conclusion

Spelling practices in Scotland during the 16th–18th centuries went from moving towards a Scots standard to undergoing anglicisation resulting in the adoption of (Southern) English spelling practices. By investigating the S-SH pattern of SI, I have shown that there is a quantifiable gender difference regarding the anglicisation of spelling practices of EModSc during the 16th–18th centuries. Furthermore, I found that this gender difference is in favour of women who were roughly a generation ahead of men during the height of the change in the first half of the 17th century. However, I also found that when removing the data of the earliest adopter who spent a large amount of time at the English court, gender was no longer described as a significant predictor. It is possible that this change in findings is a result of the scarcity of data from the 16th century. However, as the second model still described women as ahead (it just was not statistically significant), further research is needed.

As Johnston (1997: 105) states, SI is “one of the more salient features of Older Scots phonology” and both women and men seemed to be aware of this. Prior to 1600, there was minimal use of <sh> with only one writer contributing the incoming form (Section 5). During the first half of the 17th century, both men and women rapidly changed from the expected Scots <s> to the incoming English <sh>. Therefore, it seems that once the writers were aware of SI and S-SH, they quickly changed their spelling practices. Early adopters in this study were found to be involved at the English court and therefore, future research should further investigate the writers in the 1600–1649 period to determine when writers who were not associated with the English court began to use <sh>, and whether it still the case that women changed earlier than men.

Previous studies investigating gender differences in the anglicisation of EModSc have either found women to retain Scots features longer or they have not found a (quantifiable) gender difference (e.g., Meurman-Solin 2005). However, given enough data, it is indeed possible to find that women were ahead of men in the use of the anglicised spelling forms. This study has merely scratched the surface in the investigation of gender and its influence on EModSc spelling practices during the 16th–18th centuries. Future studies might fruitfully investigate other distinctive Scots features which would provide a large enough dataset, e.g., the change from <quh> to <wh> as the reflex of OE <hw>.

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Chapter 4

Shifting standards? Insights from women's writing in the *Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence*

Lisa Gotthard

This chapter presents results from three case studies on morpho-syntactic change in correspondence data produced during the anglicisation of Scots during the sixteenth to eighteenth centuries. It explores the written behaviour of female writers with respect to these changes; whether they are leaders of change, per Labov, Labov's (1990, 2001) gender principles, or conservative in their use of Scots over English, as predicted by results in Romaine (1982) and Meurman-Solin (1993). The investigation uses data from a new resource, the Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence (Gotthard 2024b), which is the first of its kind and can thus present novel results regarding morpho-syntactic change in Scots and the role of women in these changes. The results reveal different trends depending on the feature under investigation, with only one of the changes showing a significant gender difference: the move from a Northern Subject Rule system of subject-verb agreement to a Standard English one. These findings indicate the complexity of the role of women in language change, and highlight the need to consider more factors in future studies on the mechanisms of anglicisation.

1 Introduction

This paper investigates gender differences in morpho-syntactic changes taking place during the rapid *anglicisation* of Scots between the sixteenth to eighteenth centuries; the process by which Scottish writers shifted to using English forms. Such quantitative diachronic study has recently become possible through the creation of the *Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence* (PCSC; Gotthard 2024b).

Lisa Gotthard. 2026. Shifting standards? Insights from women's writing in the *Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence*. In Christine Elswailer & Sarah van Eyndhoven (eds.), *Interactions with the standard in early and late modern regional varieties of English*, 75–108. Berlin: Language Science Press. DOI: ??

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This resource has already facilitated observations of dramatic morpho-syntactic changes in the anglicisation period (Gotthard 2022, 2024a, 2026), including the decline of the Northern Subject Rule (NSR), the rise of *do*-support, and the emergence of verbal *-ing*. These features, selected in Gotthard (2022) for their relevance to shifts in the period, all represent changes towards emerging Standard English norms. Three features are syntactic – *do*-support, the NSR (see fn3), and the verbalisation of gerunds – whereas one change, the replacement of *-and* with *-ing*, straddles morphology and orthography.

This study asks whether women’s usage patterns offer insight into the mechanism of these changes, and whether they reflect conscious shifts toward new standardising pressures or Scots-internal developments. If Scottish women historically had less access to incoming Southern English written norms (per Romaine 1982; Meurman-Solin 1993), then their adoption of a new feature may point to local diffusion rather than standardising pressures. In this way, the paper builds on previous research on gender as a macro-social factor in morpho-syntactic change in English (e.g., Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 1996, 2003; Nurmi 1999, 2011), while testing the sociolinguistic utility of the PCSC.

The development of new historical corpora since the 1990s has allowed researchers to assess the role of gender in English and Scots variation and change. These investigations often draw on Labov’s (1990); Labov’s (2001: 261–293) gender principles: Women lead change both in cases of change from above (adopting prestigious norms) and below (innovating new linguistic norms). This is formulated in the Gender Paradox: “Women conform more closely than men to sociolinguistic norms that are overtly prescribed, but conform less than men when they are not” (Labov 2001: 293). These principles are upheld in Early Modern English data, including for verbal gerunds and *do*-support (Nurmi 1999, 2011; Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003). Yet, in Scots data from the same period, women have been observed to favour Scots forms over incoming ones (Romaine 1982; Meurman-Solin 1993). However, this apparent conservatism has not been systematically tested with quantitative data – partly due to the gender imbalance in historical corpora and lack of parsed Scots data until recently. Scots morpho-syntactic features, in particular, have received little attention in this area.

Considering that the effect of gender on language change may be closely linked with the impact of the perceived prestige of certain forms, it is important to note that the prestige attached to linguistic forms in this period was not limited to incoming English: Scots users navigated local Scots prestige (e.g., in legal or literary registers), Scots innovations, and incoming Southern English prestigious norms. How female writers manage these competing pressures may, then, reveal how

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these changes were perceived, especially if women's greater use of Scots forms reflects restricted access to English-dominant models (cf. [Millar 2012: 28](#)).

Hence, while women are often cast as leaders of language change, the historical Scots context complicates this generalisation: What happens when prestige, education, and genre conventions exert conflicting pressures on different linguistic variables, and explicit prescriptive advice is not available? This study aims to probe that complexity. Rather than assuming a binary of leadership versus conservatism, it tests whether gender-based generalisations hold across different types of morpho-syntactic change. Thus, this paper offers new insights into how Scottish writers responded to Southern English norms in the Early Modern period and considers whether women's use of morpho-syntactic features reflects linguistic awareness or social alignment. In doing so, it adds a further dimension to the picture of gendered interactions with the incoming English standard that other contributions in this volume (cf. [Elsweiler 2026 \[this volume\]](#), [Dörnbrack 2026 \[this volume\]](#), [Gough 2026 \[this volume\]](#)) provide, enabling the first comparison between orthographic and morphosyntactic variation, from the perspective of female Scottish writers.

Accordingly, the following Research Questions (RQs) are asked:

- RQ1: What is the effect of gender on morpho-syntactic change in sixteenth to eighteenth century Scots correspondence? Do women use higher frequencies of incoming, potentially prestigious, Southern English features, or are they more conservative in their use of Scots forms?
- RQ2: What insight does this offer into women's interaction with ongoing standardisation through anglicisation?

While this study adopts a first-wave sociolinguistic approach ([Eckert 2012](#)), focusing on gender as a macro-social variable and using quantitative methods to track change over time, it also engages with broader developments in the field. First-wave studies correlate linguistic features with broad social categories, while later waves emphasise social meaning, agency, and style. Labov's gender principles provide a starting point, but applying them to historical correspondence requires caution due to the distinct social and communicative contexts of the genre. Moreover, due to the nature of the data – 16th-18th century correspondence – micro-level, context-sensitive approaches are not always fully feasible, especially given the lack of information on social network and biographical detail for many women writers compared to their male relatives. Nonetheless, the variable uptake of morpho-syntactic innovations among women found here, suggests possible stylistic flexibility and social indexing of linguistic forms - themes

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explored in third-wave research. As such, while the framework here is first-wave, the findings open avenues for third-wave research which explores writer identity, genre, and audience effects, as more contextual metadata becomes available.

The paper is organized as follows: Sections 2.1–2.2 provide background on Scots standardisation and the anglicisation process as a restandardisation toward Southern English (Agutter 1990). Section 2.3 introduces the three features under investigation: the NSR (Section 2.3.1), *do*-support (Section 2.3.2), and verbal *-ing* (Section 2.3.3). Section 3 outlines the methodology, beginning with the role of women’s letters in historical change (Section 3.1.1) and introducing the PCSC (Section 3.1.2). Section 3.2 describes how data was retrieved, and Section 3.3 outlines how this was analysed. Section 4 presents the results, followed by a discussion of their implications in Section 5, which also concludes the paper.

2 Background

2.1 Standardisation in Early Modern Scots

Scots and Southern English both descend from dialects of Old English (OE) and had been diverging for centuries by the time prose records in Scots first appear in the late fourteenth century. From the Middle Scots period¹ onward (fourteenth–fifteenth century), Scottish writing – literary, parliamentary, legal, and personal – exhibits a distinct identity, combining uniquely Scots features with those shared with Northern English dialects (Meurman-Solin 1997).

Meurman-Solin (1997) labels this as a period of “differentiation” from English. However, as argued in Gotthard (2026), this divergence appears to have occurred earlier: features highlighted by Meurman-Solin already appear at 100% frequency in texts from 1400, suggesting that “differentiation” predates the Middle Scots period. Rather than increasing divergence, this period sees reduced internal variation in Scots, indicative of its own standardisation process.

Haugen’s (1966) influential model of standardisation involves *selection* of forms, *elaboration* to serve a “maximal elaboration of function”, *codification* to “achieve minimal variation in form”, and community *acceptance*. Scots appears to have met the first three criteria during the Early Modern period: it was functionally *elaborated* to be used in a range of genres (Görlach 2002: 26; Millar 2005: 89–91), and had achieved *selection* and *acceptance* (King 1997: 157); Agutter (1988, 1990)

¹A more traditional periodisation (e.g. Aitken 1985: xii) would label this period Early Scots, but this paper will apply the periodisation from Kopaczyk (2013b,a) for the time periods discussed: Middle Scots 1375–c.1450, Early Modern Scots c1450–c.1560, Late/Transition Scots c1560–1700. The period up to 1700 is referred to as Older Scots.

demonstrates that official Scots documents lacked the regional features found in personal letters or burgh records, implying a supra-local standard (see also [Meurman-Solin 2000](#); [Bugaj 2004](#); [Kopaczyk 2013b](#): 249–251). This standard included morphological forms such as preterite *-it/-yt* for English *-ed*, and participial *-and* for *-ing* (the morpho-orthographic change studied here, see Section 2.3.3; also [Agutter 1988](#); [Meurman-Solin 2000](#)), though uniformity of syntactic features have not been reported.

[Millar \(2005: 89–91\)](#); [Millar \(2023: 48–50\)](#) describes Early Modern Scots as an “emerging” or “developing” standard that, unlike English, never became a “mature standard” (cf. [Joseph 1987](#)). Crucially, Scots did not undergo *codification*, and the standardisation trajectory was interrupted by growing pressure to conform to Southern English norms during anglicisation. Although no codified standard emerged, some written norms were established, and the syntactic features investigated here are found to be highly consistent before the onset of anglicisation; Middle Scots lacked *do*-support ([Meurman-Solin 1993](#); [Gotthard 2024a, 2026](#)), used the NSR consistently ([Montgomery 1994](#); [Ledesma 2013, 2017](#); [Gotthard 2024a](#)), and had not yet verbalised gerunds ([Zehentner 2014](#); [Gotthard 2022](#)).

2.2 Anglicisation as restandardisation

From the late sixteenth century, Scots features increasingly began to be replaced in writing by their Southern English equivalents. This process, commonly termed the *anglicisation* of Scots, has been quantitatively investigated in seminal studies by [Devitt \(1989\)](#) and [Meurman-Solin \(1993, 1997\)](#), whose findings show a marked acceleration of anglicisation during the seventeenth century. As described in works by, among others, [Murison \(1979\)](#), [Aitken \(1984, 2015\)](#), [McClure \(1994\)](#), [Kopaczyk \(2013b,a\)](#), and [Millar \(2020, 2023\)](#), this shift was catalysed by socio-political changes, including the 1560 Protestant Reformation, the Unions of Crowns (1603) and Parliaments (1707), and the growing dominance of English in print, even among Scottish printers, after the invention of the printing press (see [Bald 1926](#); [Aitken 1971](#); [Corbett et al. 2003: 11](#); [Eyndhoven et al. 2025](#)). These developments associated Southern English norms with formal writing, and written Scots consequently declined until its revival in literary and popular media in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries.

[Agutter \(1990\)](#) frames anglicisation as a “re-standardisation” process, which suggests a shift in written conventions rather than speech. This is evident in genre-based differences: high-register genres such as religious treatises show more English influence than personal correspondence, which appears to retain

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Scots features longer (e.g., [Devitt 1989](#)). Even into the eighteenth century, individual writers adjusted their use of Scots according to audience ([Cruickshank 2012, 2017](#)). Anglicisation also varied by linguistic feature: some, like *quh-* to *wh-* in Wh-words, shifted rapidly, while others, like preterite *-it* to *-ed*, declined more gradually ([Meurman-Solin 1997](#)). These patterns may suggest conscious stylistic shifts for more salient features, indicated by their rapid adoption ([Eyndhoven & Clark 2020](#)).

The features examined in this study (see Section 2.3) – NSR, *do*-support, and verbal *-ing* – all show movement toward Southern English norms during this anglicisation/re-standardisation period ([Gotthard 2022, 2024a, 2026](#)). Whether these changes reflect change in Scots itself (as outcomes of internal mechanisms or local norms), or an adherence to new Southern written norms is difficult to assess without considering social factors. Given the potential role of women in leading or resisting linguistic change (see Section 3.1.1), female writers may provide valuable insight into how these changes were perceived and enacted by contemporary users, and thereby shed light on the mechanics of anglicisation.

2.3 The features

2.3.1 The Northern Subject Rule

The Northern Subject Rule (NSR) is historically a distinctively Scots and Northern English morpho-syntactic feature. It is a subject-verb (S-V) agreement system operating near-categorically in fifteenth to sixteenth century Scots data ([Montgomery 1994; Ledesma 2013, 2017](#)), but declining in favour of Standard English (StE) agreement during the sixteenth to eighteenth century ([Gotthard 2024a](#)). Today, the pattern persists variably in some Scots, Irish, and American English dialects ([Pietsch 2005a,b; Adger & Smith 2010; Haas 2011: 108–116; Buchstaller et al. 2013](#)).

The ideal NSR states all agreeing present tense verbs carry some variant of *-s* as inflection – *-(i)s* in Older Scots – regardless of the subject’s person and number, unless the subject is *I, we, you, they* ($\emptyset$ -subjects) and immediately adjacent to the agreeing verb (S-V adjacent). Thus, either an NSR or StE system can be determined by two diagnostic environments indicating one system unambiguously. As shown in Table 1 (adapted from [Gotthard 2022: 53](#)), these are (i) when the subject is plural and non-pronominal (plural DP) regardless of clause position, or (ii) when the subject is a $\emptyset$ -subject in a non-adjacent clause – if the agreeing verb has *s*-inflection in these contexts (bold in Table 1), it indicates an NSR system, not StE.

Table 1: The Northern Subject Rule compared to StE agreement

<i>S-V adjacent clauses</i>		<i>StE</i>		<i>NSR</i>
He/she/it/the girl	sing-is	yes		yes
I/we/they/you	sing- $\emptyset$	yes		yes
The girls	sing-is	no		yes
<i>Non-adjacent clauses</i>				
He/she/it/the girl	while danc- ing furiously	sing-is	yes	yes
He/she/it/the girl		sing- $\emptyset$ and dance-s	yes	yes
I/we/they/you	while danc- ing furiously	sing-is	no	yes
I/we/they/you		sing- $\emptyset$ and dance-s	no	yes
The girls	while danc- ing furiously	sing-is	no	yes
The girls		sing- $\emptyset$ and dance-s	no	yes

The examples in (1)–(2) below illustrate the operation of the NSR in PCSC data. In (1), the plural DP subject (in bold), regardless of adjacency, triggers *s*-inflection on the agreeing verbs (underlined). This is also the case when a $\emptyset$ -subject is non-adjacent to the agreeing verbs in (2). There is no *s*-inflection on the first verb in (??), *se* (= ‘see’), because it is S-V-adjacent.

- (1) a. for all his **freyndis** thynkis it suld be sa
(Hew Campbell, 1548)
- b. zour **frendis** yat ar heyr’ consellis yow all ...
(Richard Kincaid, 1543)
- (2) a. I being young and hauing little experience knows little ...
(John Murray, 1700)
- b. I se na help bot be zowr grace & hoppis na vdyr ...
(Alexander Gordon, 1549)

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2.3.2 *Do-support*

The history of *do*-support in English is extensively documented (e.g., Ellegård 1953; Denison 1985, 1993; Kroch 1989; Poussa 1990; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1990; Garrett 1998; Auwera & Genée 2002; Warner 2002, 2005; Ecay 2015), but besides Meurman-Solin (1993), has only recently gained attention in Scots research (Gotthard 2019, 2024a, 2026). The rise of *do*-support involved grammaticalisation of the OE causative *do* auxiliary, eventually replacing verb-raising to express tense and agreement. Today, *do*-support is mandatory in negative declarative and imperative clauses (I **don't** eat cake/Don't eat cake!), Questions (Do/Don't you eat cake?/What **do** you eat?), verbal ellipsis and tag questions ('I eat cake, and Alex **does** too'/'You eat cake **don't** you?'), and for emphasis (I **do** eat cake!). Historically, *do*-support was possible in affirmative declaratives without emphasis, deemed a "failed change" in English (Kroch 1989; Postma 2010). Scots affirmative declarative *do* also follows this trajectory (Gotthard 2024a, 2026).

Scots *do*-support emerges in the anglicisation period, about 200 years later than English, suggesting that it is a transfer from Southern English (Meurman-Solin 1993; Gotthard 2019, 2024a). However, Gotthard (2026) argues for caution in calling Scots *do*-support anglicisation-induced, suggesting the lag could reflect northward diffusion. So far, only negative and affirmative declarative *do* have been quantitatively studied in Scots, due to low numbers of imperative and interrogative *do* in available corpora.

Nurmi's (1999, 2011) investigations of social factors conditioning the rise of English *do*-support, using the *Corpus of Early English Correspondence* (CEEC; Nevalainen et al. 1998), find the change initially led by men, but after *do*'s re-analysis around the turn of the sixteenth-seventeenth century (Kroch 1989; Warner 2005; Ecay 2015), women spearheaded its regularisation. Early male adopters of negative declarative *do* had low levels of education, but the later rise mostly involved highly educated men, and this rise coincides with women using more affirmative declarative *do*-support than men (Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003: 125–126, reproducing Nurmi's (1999) results). These findings suggest women lead the change overall, an apparent change-from-above scenario as per Labov, Labov's (1990, 2001) principles. This may predict a similar pattern in Scots if *do*-support is a prestigious incoming feature from Southern English or locally.

2.3.3 The rise of verbal *-ing*

Another widely researched change in English (e.g., Dal 1952; Tajima 1985; Jack 1988; Houston 1989; Fanego 1996, 2004; Smet 2008, 2013; Fonteyn 2019) is the rise

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of verbal *-ing*, involving two possibly connected developments: the change from participial *-and* to *-ing*, shown in (3) with the verb *pray* (from the PCSC), and the verbalisation of gerunds, illustrated in (4) for modern English and (5) from the PCSC with the verbal/nominal gerund *coming*.

- (3) a. **preyand** god to haif zour g[=grace] in his keippin
(Gilbert Kennedy, 1551)
- b. **praying** yow remember my seruic to my lord your husband
(Jean Drummond, 1613)
- (4) a. *Nominal*: [The closing of the door] muted the noise
- b. *Verbal*: [Closing the door], Alex muted the noise
- (5) a. *Nominal*: ye **cumyng** of zour g[=grace] letter
(John Hamilton, 1551)
- b. *Verbal*: **cumming** out of setone on tusday Last
(Hugh Montgomery, 1667)

Both changes led to verb forms inflected with *-ing* in English (and Scots), but at different times and via distinct processes. The change from *-and* to *-ing* occurred in early thirteenth-century English (Lass 1992). The verbalisation of nominal gerunds happened later, starting in the Middle English period and accelerating between the fifteenth and eighteenth centuries (Fanego 1996; Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003; Fischer & van der Wurff 2006: 178–179; Fonteyn 2019). As with do-support, Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003: 121–122 find this to be a women-led change in CEEC data.

In Scots, the *-and* to *-ing* change took place in the sixteenth century, when gerund verbalisation was already beginning – thus, the changes are nearly simultaneous, unlike in English. The expansion of *-ing* replacing *-and* may be initiated by anglicisation pressures (Devitt 1989), or such pressures reinforced a change already initiated by a phonological collapse of /nd/ and /ng/ into /n/ (Agutter 1990; King 1997; Macafee & Aitken 2002); the change from *-and* to *-ing* would then reflect a shift in spelling practices rather than morphology.

Quantitative research on Scots verbalisation of gerunds is limited to Zehentner (2014) and Gotthard (2022). Zehentner (2014) finds that verbal gerunds increase as *-and* is lost in the late sixteenth century, suggesting they are connected changes, largely corroborated by Gotthard (2022: 126–152). If *-and* to *-ing* influenced gerund verbalisation by enabling bare *-ing* forms followed by direct objects (Fanego 1996), both developments may ultimately stem from Southern English

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influence. Hence, gender differences in *-and* usage could indicate different possibilities: women could use more *-ing*, adopting an incoming feature, or more *-and*, retaining a feature. Either way, we would expect any gender difference in *-and* to *-ing* to be matched in the verbalisation of gerunds if the first change feeds into the latter.

3 Method

3.1 Data

3.1.1 Women and language change

One research agenda in historical sociolinguistics since the 1990s has been testing Labov's gender principles using historical data, notably through quantitative studies of Early Modern English by Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg (1996, 2003) in their work on the CEEC. A central question is how applicable contemporary hypotheses about women's role in language change are in periods where women occupied different social roles; for instance, Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg (1996: 77) highlights mobility as a particularly salient contrast with the present day. Moreover, as shown in past scholarship (e.g., Milroy & Milroy 1985, Cheshire 2002, Eckert 2012), linguistic change is rarely uniform across variables or speaker groups. While gender remains a key macro-social category, its interaction with style, networks, and genre often produces contradictory patterns.

While women's lower social status in historical society might be expected to influence their language use, Elswailer (2022) cautions against overly deterministic assumptions; expecting Early Modern women to use more indirect request strategies, given their legal and economic dependence, she instead finds little gender-based difference. Elswailer's (2022) findings reveal that women often took on authoritative roles in matters like land ownership, business, and family, which were reflected in their requestive styles. Men, despite broader structural power, could occupy subordinate positions relative to their addressees, prompting use of indirect request strategies. Similarly, Kielkiewicz-Janowiak (2002, 2012) warns that gender effects can be masked by inter- and intra-individual variation. Her work suggests that gender in historical contexts is best viewed as one of several interacting factors, shaped by local social and stylistic conditions. Still, in some morphosyntactic changes, like the verbalisation of the gerund (Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 2003) and the rise of *do*-support (Nurmi 1999, 2011), women have been found to adopt incoming norms more quickly than men.

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The current paper's research questions arose from observations in studies which investigate gender as a macro-social variable: Romaine (1982) and Meurman-Solin (1993) found women to be more conservative in using Scots features. Romaine (1982), studying relativisation strategies in sixteenth-century Scots, shows that women adhered more closely to conservative spelling conventions. Meurman-Solin (1993) tests a range of Scots diagnostic features in the *Helsinki Corpus of Older Scots* (1570–1640; Meurman-Solin 1995), including phonological spellings (e.g., OSc. /a:/ for Eng. /o:/ in *knew/know*), morphological features (e.g., OSc. *-it* for Eng. *-ed*), and orthographic distinctions (e.g., OSc. <ch> for Eng. <gh> representing /x/). Both at the group and individual levels, women show less convergence toward English than men. These gender differences in Scots are often attributed to unequal educational access (e.g., Millar 2012: 28); boys were more likely to attend school – often in England – while girls, if educated at all, were tutored at home. This likely limited women's exposure to Southern English standardising norms compared to men, which led them to adhere more closely to local Scots norms.

The relative conservativeness of Scottish women is surprising if we adopt Labov's principle of women as early adopters of incoming norms. However, as later work has elaborated (Cheshire 2002; Eckert 2012), macro-social trends are shaped by local practice, interactional stance, and social meaning. In historical correspondence, the interplay of genre, audience, and formality may blur gendered patterns, as demonstrated by Elswiler (2022) and Kielkiewicz-Janowiak (2002).

Labov (1990) also posited that women's linguistic behavior is linked to overt prescriptive norms. However, before the eighteenth century, explicit prescription was minimal in Scotland (Meurman-Solin 2000; Bugaj 2004). Instead, women likely learned by imitating models from existing correspondence, which meant absorbing local conventions rather than formal rules. The rise of English in print during the seventeenth century increased exposure to standardising forms, though explicit prescriptive advice was lacking. This further complicates assumptions about gender and norm adherence in historical Scots data.

3.1.2 Letters as a language source

Letters are a frequently favoured resource for historical sociolinguistic study, as correspondence, falling under the broader genre of ego-documents, is argued to bring us as close to the spoken variety as possible for historical texts (e.g., Wal & Rutten 2013; Dossena 2013; see also Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg 1996:

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39–40). Letters exhibit a striking amount of variation compared to more circumscribed genres, as they can be “both conventional and unconventional, formal and informal, public and private, and they can have mixed purposes” (Palander-Collin 2010: 652, citing Görlach 1999: 141). Importantly, correspondence is also one of the few genres in which we find a significant representation of women’s writing, as letter writing was a practice in which women actively engaged and were explicitly taught.

Although many historical letters were produced by the literate upper classes, individuals from lower social strata also contributed to this genre. In such cases, letters were often dictated to scribes due to widespread illiteracy, introducing another layer of mediation in authorship. Consequently, these texts reflect a range of sociolinguistic variation, offering insights into the writer’s social background, their relationship with the recipient, and their communicative goals. Despite the often “oral” and variable nature of letters, it is essential to recognise that letter writing was also shaped by established conventions and formulae, codified in epistolary manuals prescribing structure, tone, and expression (see, e.g., Palander-Collin 2010: 652–655; Eyndhoven 2023: 87–88, and works cited therein). Thus, historical letters occupy a complex space between spontaneous personal expression and socially constrained written practice.

The data for the present study is drawn from a corpus of personal correspondence (see Section 3.1.2), meaning that the letters are produced by identifiable individuals, in line with the definition by Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg (1996: 54). The contents range from personal affairs to official matters, including exchanges between family members as well as communication between lords, royals, and their subjects. As previously noted, the scope of this study is limited to the analysis of gender as a variable; while factors such as social class, relationship between correspondents, and communicative setting are undoubtedly relevant, fully accounting for these would require extensive further annotation and stratification. Nonetheless, their potential influence on linguistic choices should be acknowledged.

3.1.3 The *Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence*

The *Parsed Corpus of Scottish Correspondence* (PCSC; Gotthard 2024b) comprises approximately 270,000 words of correspondence data sourced from the *Helsinki Corpus of Scottish Correspondence* (ScotsCorr; Meurman-Solin 2017). It is annotated (parsed) using the *Penn Parsed Corpora of Historical English* (PPCHE; Kroch 2020) format for morpho-syntactic annotation. Parsed corpora enable efficient retrieval of relevant clause types, vastly reducing the time required compared

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to lexical searches with manual analysis. As such, they are essential tools for the quantitative study of morpho-syntactic change (Taylor 2020; Gotthard 2022: 36–38). The PCSC is the first, and currently only, parsed corpus of Scots.

The PCSC spans the crucial period from 1540 to 1750, during which Scottish writing increasingly shifts towards Southern English norms. It includes texts authored by both men and women; as shown in Table 2, the seventeenth-century data is relatively gender-balanced, with 42.5% representing women’s writing, compared to the parsed CEEC (Taylor et al. 2006), where women’s writing constitutes around 20%. The dataset is less balanced pre-1600 and post-1700. ScotsCorr compilers prioritised autograph letters and single-hand manuscripts² (Meurman-Solin 2016: §4.1). This increases confidence that the women’s writings reflect their own usage rather than scribal intervention.

Table 2: Word counts by gender and time period in the PCSC

Time period	Female writers (individuals)	Female writers (words)	Male writers (individuals)	Male writers (words)	tot. words
1540–1599	8	3,603	70	48,048	51,651
1600–1649	44	32,113	35	46,190	78,303
1650–1699	49	37,041	56	47,385	84,426
1700–1749	19	14,699	34	41,474	56,173
<i>Total:</i>	120	87,456	195	183,097	270,553

While many writers belonged to the literate elite, including a few linked to royal or courtly circles, the corpus also includes individuals from professional backgrounds such as clergy, lawyers, and military officers (Meurman-Solin 2016). Among the women, many appear to be from noble or landowning families, though detailed metadata on class, education, or occupation is sparse – this reflects broader gaps in Early Modern women’s history and complicates stratification beyond gender.

Before 1600, most female-authored texts are from noblewomen writing to Mary of Lorraine, with a small contribution (273 words) from Mary Queen of Scots. In the seventeenth century, the top five female contributors account for 37% (1600–

²The ScotsCorr manual states that there is more variation in hands in the sixteenth century letters, but does not make clear how much more.

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1649) and 39% (1650–1699) of women’s writing; these include Agnes Keith, Countess of Moray (sister-in-law to Mary Queen of Scots), Anne Leslie, Duchess of Rothes, and lesser-known figures such as Marie Douglas. Some women writers span generations, such as Elizabeth Keith, her daughter Lady Jean Gordon, and possibly granddaughter Jane Gordon. Eighteenth-century contributors include Isabel Mackenzie, Countess of Seaforth, her daughter Anne Mackenzie, and the prolific Jacobite Margaret Hamilton, Lady Nairn (see [Cowmeadow 2014](#)).

The annotation, time span, data selection, and gender balance make the PCSC the ideal available corpus for investigating these research questions. At the same time, the case studies here also test the corpus’s potential for sociolinguistic analysis, helping to identify data gaps and limitations.

3.2 Retrieval and analysis

In accordance with the PPCHE format, the base annotation of the PCSC does not include lemmatisation, nor tags for certain morphological forms such as type of suffix or pronoun. Therefore, additional annotation was required to extract relevant tokens for the case studies, which will be briefly outlined in the following subsections where the diagnostic traits of the investigated features are given in turn.³ This additional annotation, as well as querying, was carried out using CorpusSearch2 (CS; [Randall 2010](#)) revision and coding queries, which is a custom-built tool for PPCHE-style corpora.

3.2.1 The NSR

To identify *s*-inflected verbs – present tense forms ending in *-s*, *-is*, *-es*, *-eth*, *-th*, and spelling variants – tokens were extracted and manually checked to exclude non-inflected verbs with similar endings (e.g., *confess*). Remaining *s*-inflected verbs were tagged accordingly and targeted in the search query. The query extracted clauses based on:

- *Presence of s-inflection*
 - Whether the present tense verb is tagged for *s*-inflection
- *Adjacency*
 - A clause is S-V adjacent if the head of the subject noun phrase immediately precedes the finite verb and is not an empty element (e.g., **con**, marking elided subjects under clausal conjunction).

³Full details of the data preparation for each case study are given in [Gotthard \(2022\)](#).

- A clause is non-adjacent if an intervening element (other than an AdvP or Q(uantifier)P) appears between the subject and verb⁴, or if the head of the subject noun phrase is an empty element.
- *Subject type*
- $\emptyset$ -subjects:
 Variants of *I*, *you*, *we*, *they*, and any subject phrase dominating an empty element *con* which co-refers to a $\emptyset$ -subject.⁵
 - plural DP:
 Plural non-pronominal subjects, and any subject phrase dominating an empty element *con* which co-refers to a plural DP.

3.2.2 Do-support

To extract frequencies of *do*-support, no further annotation was needed; all relevant clause features are already in the base annotation (see also [Gotthard 2024a, 2026](#)). A clause was counted as *do*-support if a finite *do* auxiliary appeared with an infinitival lexical verb sister (6a), ensuring the exclusion of lexical *do* (6b). Negative declaratives were identified by the presence of a NEG tag (6c):

- (6) a. for I **did** giwe him my tickit to Restore them ...
(John Gordon, 1650)
- b. his father will at the sight of your freinds **do** all satisfacioun
yairanent
(Margaret Montgomery, 1615)
- c. but my nephew Elho **did not** wrett to me ever in his life,
(Anna Scott, 1700)

The query returned affirmative and negative declarative clauses with and without *do*-support for proportional comparison.

⁴This is because these elements are argued to be “invisible” for the adjacency constraint (see e.g., [Henry 1995](#): 25–26; [Pietsch 2005b](#): 9–10). Clauses with single adverbs and quantifiers as intervening elements are too infrequent to reliably measure over time (see [Gotthard 2022](#): 72; [Gotthard 2024b](#): 31). For the purpose of this study, these clauses are excluded entirely from the count.

⁵Any *con* subject counts as a non-adjacent subject, in terms of the adjacency constraint. That is, if a subject phrase dominates a *con* with a $\emptyset$ -subject referent immediately preceding the finite verb, this clause is counted as a non-adjacent clause

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3.2.3 The rise of verbal *-ing*

In order to identify and categorise suffixes *-and* and *-ing*, all present participles and verbal gerunds (i.e., forms tagged as VAG, BAG, HAG or DAG) were extracted, and the resulting list was manually sorted to identify all possible spelling variants of the *-ing* and *-and* suffixes for query targeting. For the first part of the change, *-and* to *-ing*, participial verbs were tagged for these suffixes, so that proportions of verbs with each suffix could be measured.

To investigate the verbalisation of gerunds, nouns were extracted if they ended in an *-ing* suffix as specified on the list, manually excluding base forms ending in *<-ing>* (e.g., *king*)⁶. The list of nouns with *-ing* could then be used to identify nominal gerunds for query targeting, which the proportion of verbal gerunds were measured against. Only verbal gerunds functioning as prepositional complements were included, to make the results more comparable to the findings by [Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg \(2003\)](#). Thus, for this case study the resulting query targeted:

- *Type of suffix*: Whether *-and* or *-ing*
- *Word class*: Whether verbal or nominal
- *Function*: Whether the form is a prepositional complement

3.3 Data analysis

The output from each case study query was exported as a .csv data frame and merged with the PCSC metadata via clause ID, linking linguistic features to author metadata – specifically, *year* of writing and author *gender*. The combined dataset was uploaded to R ([R Core Team 2021](#)) for visualisation and statistical analysis.

For each case study, proportions of the relevant linguistic variables were stratified by *gender* and circumscribed thus:

- NSR: The dependent variable is the presence of *s*-inflection on the finite verb in present tense clauses. Frequencies were calculated over time in two diagnostic NSR environments (see Section 2.3.1):
 - *ø*-subjects in non-adjacent clauses
 - plural DP subjects (regardless of adjacency)

⁶There were no nouns with *-and* in the corpus

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- *do*-support: The dependent variable is the presence of *do*-support. Proportions over time were calculated separately for affirmative and negative declarative clauses.
- The rise of verbal *-ing*: The two changes were investigated in turn:
 - Participial *-and* to *-ing*
Proportions of *-and* verbs out of all *-and* and *-ing* participles were measured over time.
- Verbalisation of gerunds
Proportions of *-ing* verbs out of all *-ing* verbs and *-ing* nouns were measured over time.

LOESS curves were fitted to each set of proportions, with *year* as a continuous variable; LOESS offers flexible, smooth trendlines useful for visualising change, but this method does not allow for significance testing. To assess significance, a parametric model was also fitted. Since language change is often modelled as S-shaped (Kroch 1989), a logistic regression model was used with *year* as a continuous variable. Therefore, to allow for significance testing of the cases where the LOESS plots suggest a gender difference, a mixed effects logistic regression model was fitted. The dependent variables (as specified above) were regressed on fixed effects for *gender*, *year*, and a *gender*year* interaction. Random effects were added for *author/filename*, where *filename* refers to individual letters and is nested within *author* to account for multiple letters by the same writer. *Year* was normalised to span from -1 to 1 so that the *gender* fixed effects measure the curves' intercepts at the middle point.

4 Results

4.1 The NSR

The change from an NSR to a StE system was investigated by measuring the proportion of *s*-inflection in the two diagnostic environments in turn: $\emptyset$ -subjects in non-adjacent clauses, and plural DP subject in clauses of any adjacency. In both contexts, *s*-inflection on the verb unambiguously signals an NSR grammar (see Section 2.3.1 and Table 2). Figure 1 shows the result for non-adjacent $\emptyset$ -subjects.

The mixed effects model shows a significant gender effect ($p = 0.0026$), with men using less *s*-inflection overall, indicating greater alignment with StE norms by men. The interaction *year*gender* was not statistically significant, suggesting

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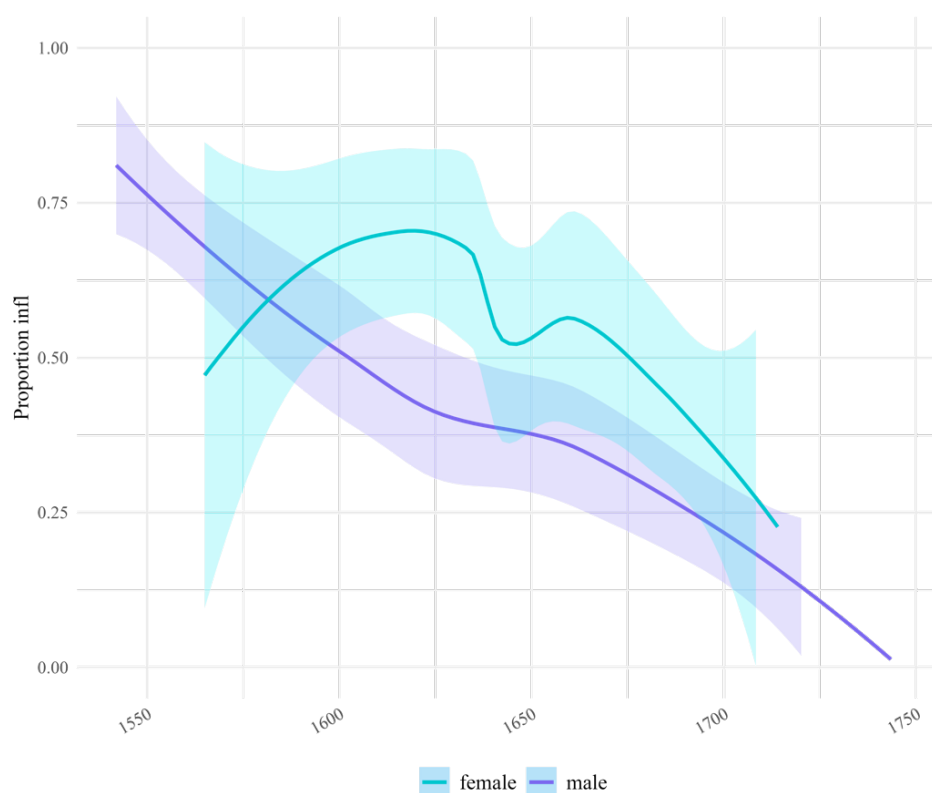


Figure 1: Proportion of -s inflection with non-adjacent $\emptyset$ -subjects (“I, we, you, they, while dancing furiously, sing-is”), by gender (LOESS curves)

this gender difference is stable over time. This aligns with the prediction that women would be more conservative in their use of Scots features.

A similar pattern might be expected with plural DP subjects – that is, that female writers would use more *s*-inflection than men in this diagnostic context too. Figure 2 confirms this, but suggests a different time trend.

The model again shows a significant gender effect ($p < 0.0004$), with women consistently using more *s*-inflection. However, women’s use of *s*-inflection increases toward the end of the period, while men’s usage declines – a move from initially similar usage, towards divergence at the end. That is, the women increasingly favour an NSR pattern, while the men shift toward StE.

Thus, plural DP and non-adjacent $\emptyset$ -subjects do not show the same trajectory over time between female and male writers in the PCSC, despite being part of the

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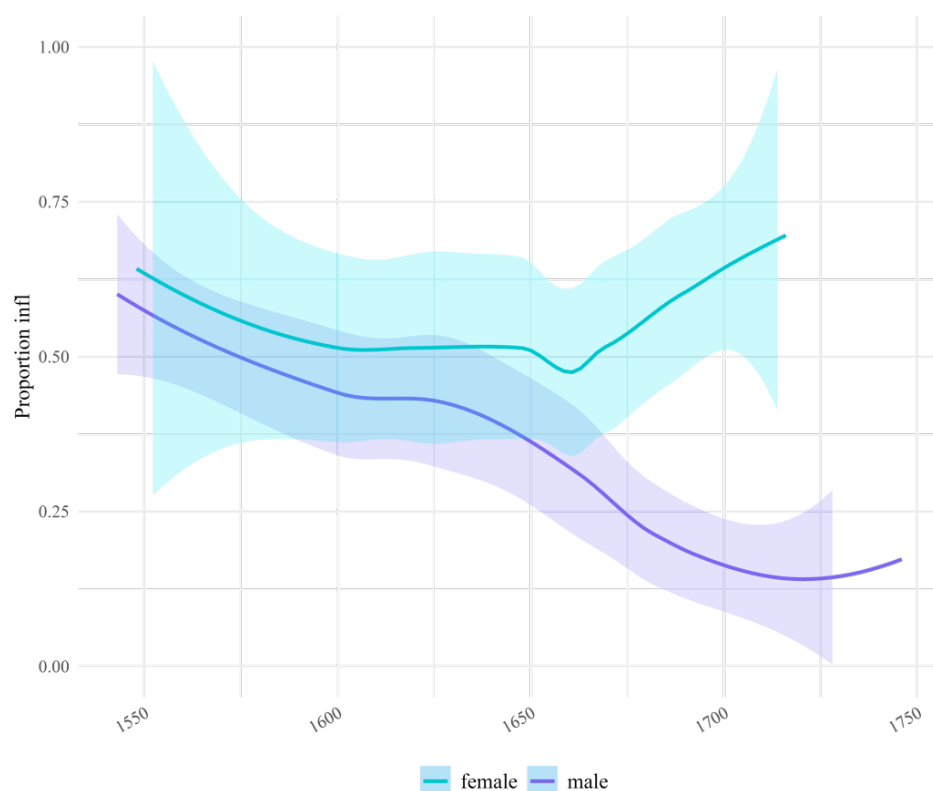


Figure 2: Proportion of -s inflection with plural DP subjects (“The girls dance-s”), by gender (LOESS curves)

same overall change (see [Gotthard & Wallenberg 2023](#)). The cause of the divergent trends between the different NSR contexts remains slightly mysterious. It may relate to data imbalance; plural DP clauses are relatively rare ($n = 454$) compared to non-adjacent $\emptyset$ -subjects ($n = 6,711$). However, mixed effects models help control for this. Perhaps more likely, the results reflect internal variation, rather than a uniform gender effect. Still, both results tentatively support the conclusion that women retain NSR features longer, thus engaging less with incoming Southern English standard norms.

4.2 Do-support

For the second case study, proportions of *do*-support were measured over time in affirmative and negative declarative clauses, stratified by gender. As *do*-support

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does not emerge in Scots in relevant frequencies until after 1600 (see [Gotthard 2024a, 2026](#)), Figure 3 shows data starting from 1600.

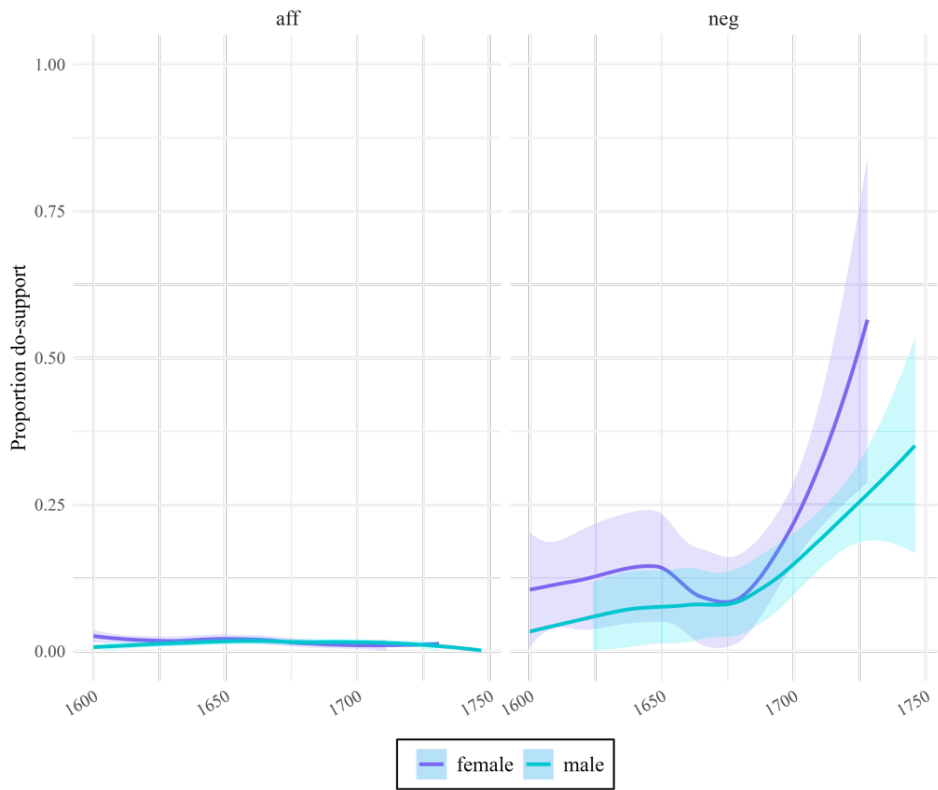


Figure 3: Frequencies of negative and affirmative declarative do-support, by gender (LOESS curves)

In negative declaratives, women appear to lead the change after 1675, paralleling [Nurmi’s](#) (2011) findings for English *do*. However, the mixed effects model does not confirm a significant gender effect ($p = 0.0545$), nor a *year*gender* interaction.

No model was fitted to the affirmative declarative data, as this feature did not undergo a completed change and so does not follow an S-curve trajectory. Aggregated over the whole period, male and female usage is similar: 3.5% (73/2104) for men and 3% (81/2678) for women.⁷ This small difference is not statistically

⁷The low proportion is not surprising, given that the overall proportions of affirmative declarative *do*-support in this data do not reach higher levels even at its peak (see [Gotthard 2019, 2024a, 2026](#)).

significant (t-test: $p = 0.387$).

Overall, there is no strong evidence that men and women differ in their uptake of *do*-support. Consequently, we cannot confidently conclude that *do*-support was interpreted as part of the incoming standard, or that gender played a major role in its spread.

4.3 The rise of verbal *-ing*

The two changes forming the overall rise of verbal *-ing* were examined separately, starting with the shift from participial *-and* to *-ing*, shown in Figure 4.

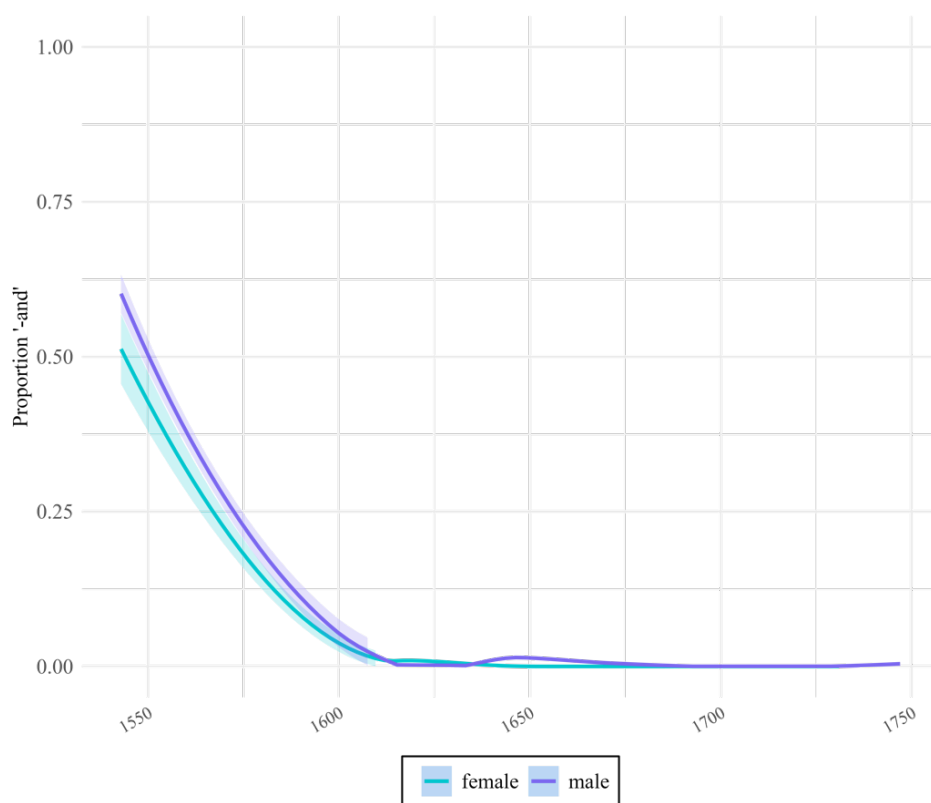


Figure 4: Proportions of verbs in *-and* and *-ing*, by gender (LOESS curves)

Figure 4 suggests women writers used *-and* less (8/182) than men (158/574). The change appears largely complete by 1625, after which only three instances of *-and* occur (7). These uses are likely formulaic; all refer to debts owed, using

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the phrase *restand awand* ('remain owed'; DSL 2024), with (7c) simply having *restand* while still referencing owed debts (*deweties*; DSL 2024). This formulaic usage may be due to the preservation of Scots phrases in legal discourse (e.g., Kopaczyk 2013a).

- (7) a. I am no to blame to seik yis deweteis **restand** yis fourteen zeiris.
(William Douglas, 1642)
- b. all sowmes thatt ver **restand awand** to my Father the tyme of his
disceass
(John Erskine, 1643)
- c. Conserving thes Muneyis ... **Restand awnd** owt off his landis within
the parochine off Kirkaldie ...
(Charles Seton, 1650)

A mixed effects model on 1542–1625 data found no significant *gender* effect ($p=0.456$), nor a *year*gender* interaction.

Next, the effect of gender on the verbalisation of gerunds was tested by measuring verbal gerunds' proportion out of total *-ing* forms as prepositional complements, such as in (8) from the PCSC verbal/nominal gerund *writing*.

- (8) a. *Nominal*: at ye **writing** of yis bil
(Adam Otterburn, 1543)
- b. *Verbal*: vse diligence In **wryting** the missiues
(Thomas Hamilton, 1600)

Figure 5 shows verbal gerunds increasing around the time of the loss of *-and*, with similar trends for men and women until 1700, after which women's usage rises faster – though, smaller female samples post-1725 may cause overfitting (cf. Table 2).

Aggregated data show women using slightly more verbal gerunds (32%, 93/290) than men (29%, 190/659), but no significant gender effect was indicated by the mixed effects model ($p=0.859$).

In sum, unlike findings for English, Scots women do not show a leading role in the rise of *-ing* forms; no gender differences emerged in either change, offering little insight into anglicisation's influence or the relationship between these developments.

4.4 Summary

There is no single conclusion capturing the role of women across all changes:

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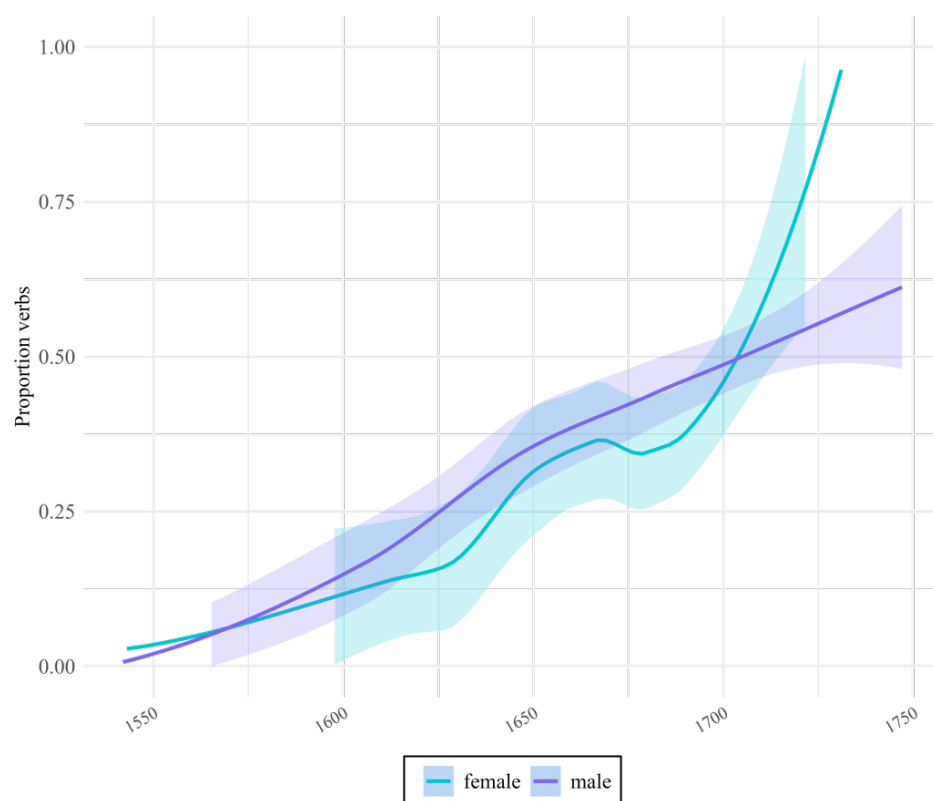


Figure 5: Proportions of verbs in *-ing*, out of total *-ing* forms, as prepositional complements, by gender (LOESS curves)

1. NSR:
Women use less of the incoming feature, StE S-V agreement.
2. *Do*-support:
Similar usage between men and women, with no significant difference.
- Verbal *-ing*:
No significant gender difference between men and women in the decline of *-and* nor the rise of verbal gerunds.

Hence, the answer to RQ1, *What is the effect of gender on morpho-syntactic change in 16–18th century Scots correspondence?*, must necessarily be that the effect of gender is variable, depending on the change under investigation.

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Only the NSR shows a significant gender difference, with women retaining Scots agreement longer than men. These findings might suggest that women's interaction with the emerging standard was selective, influenced by the salience or prescriptiveness of features. The lack of a consistent gender effect may imply that awareness and adherence to Standard English norms differed across linguistic domains, rather than following a uniform sociolinguistic pattern. This will be discussed further in the next section.

5 Discussion and conclusion

This study tests the sociolinguistic capabilities of the PCSC, demonstrating its use for robust quantitative investigation of gender effects on morpho-syntactic change during Scots anglicisation. Bearing in mind the data gaps at the beginning and end of the period under investigation, as shown in Table 2, conclusions on gender differences are not equally robust for all changes, and particular caution is warranted in analysing trends before 1600 and after 1700, where over-fitting may be an issue.

Importantly, the findings highlight that neither women's relative conservatism, reported in past Scots scholarship, nor their purported leadership in linguistic change, as per Labov's (1990) gender paradox, can be generalised across features, underscoring the value of a corpus-based, data-driven approach. Rather than a consistent gender effect, morpho-syntactic change is feature-specific and socially situated.

A key question is what causes this variable effect, and whether perception of features drives variation. This related to RQ2: *What insight does this offer into women's interaction with ongoing standardisation through anglicisation?*

Grammatical type may offer one explanation. The morphological/orthographic shift from *-and* to *-ing* follows a steady, uniform trajectory, while syntactic changes (NSR, *do*-support, verbalisation of gerunds) show greater fluctuation. Morpho-orthographic changes, being visually salient and less semantically complex, may spread more evenly across social groups in shared genres like correspondence. The lack of a gender difference suggests men and women faced similar orthographic pressures, perhaps from print norms or genre conventions. In contrast, syntactic variables, involving more semantic and pragmatic complexity (see Auer & Voeste 2012), may exhibit more nuanced variation. NSR may have held social or stylistic significance for some female writers, serving as resistance to anglicisation or a group identity marker – though this remains speculative.

This interpretation finds support in the educational and social positioning of many women represented in the corpus. Although explicit metadata on class

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and education is limited, the corpus primarily includes elite female writers, often members of ducal or noble families. These women likely received higher levels of education than most of their contemporaries, and their correspondence would have reflected not only their literacy but their embeddedness in elite social networks. The possibility that women learned to write by copying existing correspondence implies a form of informal norm transmission, reinforcing community-specific conventions, particularly if these women were writing to others of similar social standing. If the NSR was locally salient within these circles, its use may have been perpetuated as a stylistic norm, not necessarily perceived as “nonstandard.”

In this context, the presence or absence of prescriptive advice becomes crucial. As explicit grammatical prescription did not emerge until after 1700, instead, linguistic behaviour would have been shaped by imitation, exposure, and local norms. The rise of print culture may have introduced writers to more standardised English forms, but syntactic features like the NSR were unlikely to be explicitly addressed. Even in later prescriptive works such as those by Beattie and Hume⁸ (see for example [Dossena 2005](#)), such morpho-syntactic Scots features are notably absent, and we can therefore only speculate about the salience of these features⁹. Hence, the persistence of NSR among women may reflect indirect norm acquisition and local prestige, rather than disregard for explicit standards. This aligns with Labov’s gender paradox, which posits that in the absence of overt prescription, women may innovate or preserve locally meaningful forms.

Meanwhile, the lack of gender differentiation in *do*-support and verbal *-ing* suggests that these features may have held less social or stylistic salience, or were not strongly associated with either local or non-local prestige. If women’s higher usage of such features in English signalled top-down norm adherence (which is argued for *do*-support by [Nurmi 1999, 2011](#)), then the absence of gender differences in Scots suggests that they may not have held the same status, or at least not uniformly so across communities.

While it may be that these results reflect greater access to written norms among women than previously assumed, these findings also resonate with critiques of over-reliance on gender as a singular explanatory factor (e.g., by [Cheshire 2002](#)). As was discussed in Section 3.1.1 and demonstrated by [Kielkiewicz-Janowiak](#)

⁸It should be noted that, while informative of metalinguistic awareness, such advice is notoriously unreliable for linguistic evidence, as authors remarked on more widespread non-standard features which weren’t necessarily Scots.

⁹For example, [Nurmi \(2000\)](#) speculates that the decline of affirmative declarative *do* in the South was influenced by the language of James I/VI, who would have used less of this feature in line with Scots norms.

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(2002, 2012) and Elswailer (2022), among others, inter- and intra-individual variation, shaped by communicative roles and pragmatic contexts, often outweighs macro-social variables like gender in historical data. In personal letters, audience design, genre constraints, and individual rhetorical goals may blur expected patterns. It is possible, and even likely, that women's apparent conservatism in NSR usage was shaped more by genre and social networks than by resistance to change *per se*.

Although this study takes a first-wave sociolinguistic approach, its findings open space for further research using later-wave models. The variability observed – particularly the possibility of the NSR as a socially salient form – suggests that writer identity, stance, and community may be productive avenues for future investigation. With richer metadata, it may become possible to examine how gender intersects with audience, social networks, and genre, offering deeper insight into the mechanisms of anglicisation and women's role in this process. For instance, as Nurmi (2011) showed for English *do*-support, exploring men's linguistic behaviour across social strata could further illuminate how change was perceived and transmitted. Overall, the findings here suggest that women's engagement with the emerging Standard was not a binary of resistance or compliance, but rather a negotiation of locally meaningful practices shaped by audience, identity, and elite social networks. While grounded in first-wave principles, this study hopefully paves the way for third-wave analyses of identity, genre, and writer networks – research avenues which, through the PCSC, may yet enrich our understanding of how women navigated the rising Southern English standard alongside their local written norms.

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Chapter 5

The emergence of Scottish Standard English: A case study of modals of necessity in 19th-century Scottish pauper letters

Moragh Gordon

This paper seeks to shed light on the historical sociolinguistic development of Scottish Standard English in the 19th century by studying modals of necessity as used by highly educated Scottish and English authors, as well as Scottish paupers representing the lower ranks in Scotland. In doing so, this paper also aims to explore the prospects and benefits afforded by pauper letters for the study of language change from below. Modals of necessity show diverging patterns in present-day Scottish Standard English, a development that potentially started among the lower classes in the 19th century. The findings of the case study reveal that the pauper letters more closely follow present-day modal patterns than the higher ranks in some respects, particularly concerning features associated with spoken language.

1 Introduction

To this day, the exact historical roots and distinct characteristics of Scottish Standard English (SSE) remain relatively under-researched (McClure 1994: 85; Schüt-zler et al. 2017). On the one hand, the prolonged interaction between Scots and its sister language English, and the resulting anglicisation pressures that started affecting written Scots more intensely from around the 16th century, has been well-documented (e.g., Romaine 1982, Devitt 1989, Meurman-Solin 1993, Aitken 1997, 2015, Bugaj 2004, Kopaczyk 2012). On the other, the 18th and 19th centuries

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- when written Scots had largely been supplanted by a variety based on a Southern English prestige variety - have received comparatively less attention. While there has been some scholarly focus on orthographic and syntactic variation in early 18th-century written Scots (cf. [Gotthard 2024](#), [Eyndhoven 2021, 2024](#)), as well as the effects of prescriptivism on the usage of Scots in opposition to English (cf. [Dossena 2005, 2010](#)) in the 19th century, the distinct (written) Scottish prestige variety of English that emerged as a result of anglicisation has only marginally been studied and rarely systematically across different social layers of society (see [Jones 1993, 1995](#) for spoken SSE, [Dossena 2002, 2007](#) for historic code-switching between written Scots and English; [Cruickshank 2011](#) on 18th-century upper-class correspondence).

Even though a growing body of studies on present-day SSE has begun to uncover some patterns that go beyond the impressionistic (e.g., [Miller & Brown 1982](#), [Miller 1989, 2004](#), [Scobbie & Stuart-Smith 2008](#), [Schützler et al. 2017](#), [Schützler & Herzky 2021](#)), the social and historical roots of these patterns still need to be scrutinised more extensively, particularly when it comes to syntactic variation. The origin of some of the present-day syntactic features making SSE distinct from Southern British Standard English (SBSE) can likely be traced to at least the 19th century (cf. [Tagliamonte & Smith 2006](#)). What is more, due to increasing social mobility, the 19th century marks a pivotal period for the development of SSE from a sociolinguistic perspective.

Though not directly relating to the emergence of SSE, [Dossena, Dossena's](#) (2007, 2012) case studies on some Scots morpho-syntactic features resistant to anglicisation pressures in 19th-century Scottish emigrant letters provide valuable insights. She finds that especially personal letters written in an informal context by those with a lower literacy proficiency show more “unselfconscious” Scots vernacular features ([Dossena 2012: 33](#)). Relating to the overarching themes of this volume, this paper aims to shift the focus to contexts that require the most formal standardised language, in order to shed light on interactions with the standard among different layers of society. How did speaker-writers of different social groups and with varying levels of literacy negotiate English prestige features and non-standard (vernacular Scots) features in a standard context? In exploring these questions, this paper will also examine the suitability of a newly compiled corpus of 19th-century pauper letters to shed light on lower-class language in a standard context. Furthermore, rather than considering formal contexts as battlegrounds of competition between vernacular Scots and overt English prestige forms, this paper aims to study the development of a Scottish English prestige variety in its own right. Since Scots and Standard English are relatively closely related, they historically share many syntactic structures that may gradually have

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developed different usages in SBSE and SSE respectively.

Particularly interesting in this respect are the modal verbs of necessity, which took different grammaticalisation paths and display different usage patterns in SBSE and SSE (Miller 1989, Tagliamonte & Smith 2006, Schützler & Herzky 2021), e.g., *must*, *should*, *ought to*, which are more typically found in formal SBSE and *have to*, *have got to*, *need (to)*, which are found to be relatively more common in SSE.¹ However, the historical sociolinguistic evolution of these patterns remains relatively unexplored. Using modals of necessity as a case study, this paper aims to address this gap, and in doing so, aims to address the above questions relating to the overarching themes of this volume.

In what follows, I will briefly outline the anglicisation of Scots and the subsequent emergence of SSE in Section 2. Part of this is also a discussion of how SSE is best defined, which is not a codified variety and as such not a standard variety in the strictest sense. Section 3 delves a bit deeper into the prospects and challenges afforded by the newly compiled corpus of Scottish pauper letters (*ScotPP*) (Gordon et al. n.d.). Section 4 presents the case study and examines previous research on the development of modals of necessity in both Scots and SSE. It also considers the broader implications of the case-study findings for the emergence of SSE and the central themes of this volume. Section 5 offers concluding remarks and outlines the study's limitations.

2 Scots and SSE

2.1 The anglicisation of Scots: A brief history

Scots has its roots in the Northumbrian dialect of Old English and gradually emerged as a distinct variety in the 13th and 14th centuries, ultimately leading to Scots achieving status as the language of government and official writing in Scotland around the 15th century. (Aitken 1981, McClure 1994).

In this period, 'Scottis' became increasingly perceived as distinct from the developing Southern English standard variety and gained prestige; Acts of parliament started appearing in Scots in favour of Latin and literary works such as *The Brus* by John Barbour (1375) marked the start of a rich literary tradition in Scots (McClure 1995, Macafee & Aitken 2002). However, before written Scots could fully develop as a written standard, the cultural, political, and economic

¹Dossena's (2010) study briefly mentions the occurrence of deontic and epistemic modal verbs that seem to follow typically Scottish patterns but does not specifically go into modals of necessity.

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dominance of England led to convergence on the emergent Southern English standard variety, i.e. anglicisation (Devitt 1989, Meurman-Solin 1997a, Macafee & Aitken 2002, Bugaj 2004).

Though a clear trend of anglicised spelling can be observed between about 1580 and 1640 (Devitt 1989, Meurman-Solin 1993), Scots morphological, syntactic and lexical features persisted well into the 18th century (Dossena 2010, Millar 2020). What is more, convergence on the Southern English prestige variety happened at different rates and to different degrees across regions, text genres, contexts and social groups. For instance, texts typically associated with independent Scots legal traditions still retain many features of Scots today, whereas other national and printed texts relatively rapidly anglicised (MacQueen 1957, Macafee & Aitken 2002). In terms of regional variation, texts from the North East of Scotland showed a considerable lag in convergence on English, still using Scots features until the 18th century, whereas writers in the metropolis of Edinburgh more quickly aligned with the Southern English prestige model (Meurman-Solin 1993, 1997a,b, Macafee & Aitken 2002). As concerns contextual and social factors, personal letters allowed room for vernacular Scots features far beyond the 17th century and well into the 19th century, especially among semi-literates (Dossena 2010). In fact, van Eyndhoven (2024) still finds remnants of Scots <quh> for English <wh> spellings in the letters of early 18th-century Scottish politicians, suggesting that anglicisation of spelling took longer. Furthermore, Elswailer's (2019) work on pragmatic conventions in Older Scots correspondence shows that even though English patterns of *will* and *shall* occurred during the anglicisation period, they developed distinct pragmatic usages in a Scottish context. All in all, anglicisation did not lead to a wholesale adoption of English but is better described as a complex and continuous process of contact between two closely related varieties, ultimately giving rise to a unique Scottish variety of English.

2.2 The 19th century: The emergence of a Scots SSE continuum

From the 18th century, the English prestige model also started influencing upper-class spoken language (Millar 2020: 102), which resulted in a (spoken) Scottish prestige model that was nevertheless quite distinct from the English it was modelled on (Jones 1993). As industrialisation intensified, middle-class members climbed the social ladder and many became well-to-do factory owners. Millar (2020: 126) speculates that

“Many - probably most - of these magnates were Scots speakers (as would be their companies’ boards of directors and the men at higher levels of man-

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agement); their children, normally educated at local, but exclusive, schools, would have been far more likely to use Scottish Standard English alone”.

This would have given rise to a Scots versus (Scottish) Standard English diglossia, where Scots had nearly vanished from the written domain, surviving primarily as a spoken L-variety and only marginally in literature and personal writing (McClure 1994; Dossena 2002). As part of this, Millar (2020: 109) hypothesises that especially the Scots speaking-lower middle classes acquired the standard model “[...] second-hand through the specifically Scottish elite varieties developed through regular contact [with native speakers of the emergent Southern English standard variety].” This raises interesting questions about the role of non-elites in the shaping of SSE, since they were not directly exposed to native speaker models of the Southern English standard.

Furthermore, literacy education likely played a part in the emergence of a Scottish version of Standard English; notwithstanding large differences between the Highlands and Lowlands, literacy was steadily increasing across all layers of society. Estimates show that by 1750 about 65 percent of the Lowland men could at least sign their name, and about 15 to 30 percent of the women. By 1850, an estimated 89 percent of the men and about 77 percent of the women could sign their names. For the Highlands, these percentages were considerably lower (Anderson 1995: 15). Moreover, literacy among the working classes was still relatively low throughout the period, yet only a small minority was totally illiterate (Anderson 1995: 129–140). The introduction of compulsory mass education through the Education Act of 1872 undoubtedly further boosted literacy rates among lower classes.

Of particular interest are the language models used in literacy education among different classes. It is well known that the 18th and 19th-century grammars proscribing Scotticisms were largely aimed at the upper-(middle) classes. Yet, lower-class writers also avoided many of these proscribed forms in their letters, albeit to a lesser extent (Groot 2024, Dossena 2005, 2012). In addition, Millar (2020: 134) suggests that Scots probably still strongly featured in spoken settings, at least in rural schools, whereas urban schools may have tended to Standard English more in both written and spoken form. Williamson (1982: 65) states that Standard English was generally “firmly established as the language of literacy” partly due to the wide availability of materials in English, but probably even more so due to the high prestige English had and the ever-further declining status of Scots, which was increasingly seen as a lower-class language, as “vulgar” and “provincial” (cf. Williamson 1982: 48). The implementation of compulsory education only further marginalised Scots as educational policies specifically aimed “to promote

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Standard English as a literary and spoken language” and to supplant spoken vernacular Scots (Williamson 1982: 71).

In sum, the 19th century marked a pivotal decline of Scots that set the stage for the development of a complex sociolinguistic continuum that placed Scots at one end of the continuum and the emergent Southern English standard at the other end, permeating both written and spoken communication. We can only speculate to what extent this affected 19th-century speaker-writers. Given the educational policies and contemporary comments referring to Scots as an “imperfect” and “corrupt” dialect of English, we can at least assume they aimed for something resembling English in formal contexts, but whether there was a conscious notion of there being a distinct written Scottish prestige variety of English is questionable. Nevertheless, present-day conceptions of SSE might provide some useful insights into how Scots and (Scottish) Standard English interacted at the time.

Schützler et al. (2017) propose a useful model that captures the complex (socio)linguistic contacts between different varieties in Scotland today. Figure 1 below visualises how SBSE, SSE, as well as other varieties of English continuously interact. The arrows represent the multi-directionality as well as the continuity of these interactions. The dashed lines represent SSE’s flexibility to converge or diverge into different directions depending on the context, e.g., style, mode of communication, communicative setting, text type, the social status of speakers involved, etc. Very importantly, in this model, SSE and Scots can share features, so the use of Scots features does not necessarily reflect code-shifting towards the Scots end of the continuum, but it reflects a rather more complex situation where Scots, Standard English and uniquely Scottish English features can share the same space, giving rise to a “fully-fledged variety in its own right” (Schützler et al. 2017: 282).

The question remains how this model relates to the 19th century and to what extent different social layers of society had a part to play in the shaping of SSE. It is tempting to speculate at this point that change from both below the level of consciousness (Labov 1972) and below in terms of a change being pushed from the lower classes (Elspaß et al. 2007) were pivotal in the emergence of SSE, especially considering these classes had limited access to a native-speaker model of the emergent Southern English standard. That said, extensive empirical studies to confirm this are scant, primarily due to a lack of data by lower classes and a heavy focus on the Scots element in a Standard English context.² Groot’s (2024)

²Schützler & Herzky (2021: 135) refer to this as the ‘Scots bias’, i.e. “a focus on more obvious features directly motivated from Scots” as opposed to features that are not categorically different from SBSE, but that nonetheless show different usage frequency patterns in SSE.

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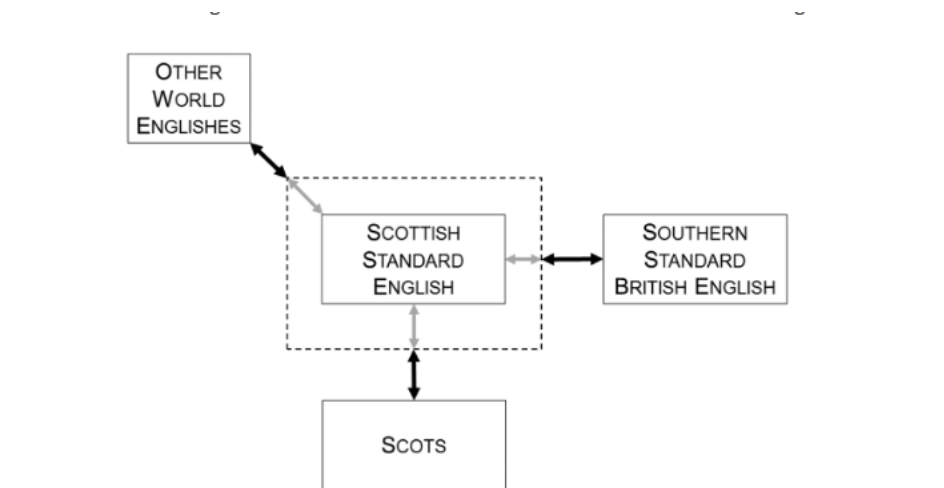


Figure 1: Model of present-day SSE (Schützler et al. 2017: 282)

study, though only looking at a small set of 19th-century pauper letters of the *ScotPP* and (upper) middle-class letters from the *Corpus of Modern Scottish Writing* (CMSW), offers some interesting insights. Scrutinising Aitken’s (1979) list of “overt Scotticisms”, i.e. linguistic features consciously perceived as Scottish, and “covert Scotticisms”, i.e. distinct Scottish features that are not consciously marked as such, Groot found that overt Scotticisms occurred at higher rates in the pauper letters, whereas covert Scotticisms were used in the pauper and upper-class letters alike, pointing to a change from below the level of consciousness for covert Scotticisms but a push from below by the lower social classes when it comes to both overt and covert Scotticisms. Arguably, modals of necessity do not fit neatly into Aitken’s overt/covert Scotticism distinction, as they do not represent clear-cut Scots versus Standard English features, but a different usage pattern that need not have rooted from Scots patterns. The aim of this paper is thus to study the use of modals of necessity across different social layers to provide evidence for SSE as a variety with its own developmental trajectory that may include both elements inherited from Scots and innovations that are not directly rooted in Scots.

3 ScotPP: Prospects and challenges

As mentioned in Section 2 above, literacy rates among the lower classes were still relatively low in the 19th century, but high enough to warrant some lower-class

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writing, such as emigrant letters (e.g., [Dossena 2012](#)). Pauper petitions and letters written in the context of the Poor Laws, provide us with another unique opportunity to catch a glimpse of this underrepresented group. In brief, the Poor Laws made local parishes and burghs responsible for the provision of the poor that legally belonged to their parish or burgh.³ As urbanisation and industrialisation expanded over the 18th and 19th centuries, and poverty grew, the ad hoc nature of the old Poor Laws that were mostly based on voluntary contributions to the poor funds was no longer tenable, ultimately leading to a major reform in 1845 ([Jones & King 2016](#), [Harris 2019](#)). The most significant changes were the establishment of a centralised body that levied compulsory taxes for poor funds and the appointment of local poor inspectors to oversee the administration of poor relief ([Cage 1974](#), [Jones & King 2016](#)). These reforms gave the poor more agency to apply for funds or appeal to decisions concerning their relief. Moreover, the increased geographical mobility that came with the Highland Clearances, urbanisation, and industrialisation displaced many from their legal home parish and generated a large number of letters from paupers who had to make their case for relief or assistance from a distance. The provision of relief was only intended for “the crippled, sick, impotent, and weak folk and those under fourteen years of age and over seventy” ([Cage 1974](#): 5), but the content of many letters that are part of *ScotPP* seems to suggest that in practice exceptions were made for widows and (temporarily) unemployed workers. Applying for relief almost inevitably meant a large distance between the writer and the addressee in terms of power, but usually also social hierarchy. This was especially true for the rural highlands, where strict social boundaries and hierarchy between heritors and crofters were strongly valued throughout most of the 19th century ([Jones & King 2016](#)). Pauper letters either took the form of highly formalised petitions, for which many templates existed in letter-writing manuals, letters resembling familial style, or letters that defied any epistolary conventions and usually contained many features of spoken language ([Sokoll 2006](#), [Jones & King 2016](#)).

Considering the lower literacy rates among lower classes, we may question how many of these letters were written by the paupers themselves. Apart from obvious cases where it is explicitly mentioned in the letter who wrote it or the letter is signed with a cross or in a different hand, it is not always possible to tell. [Sokoll \(2001: 65\)](#), who studied English pauper letters from the 18th and 19th centuries, claims that paupers rarely made use of professional scribes and the

³The notion of home parish was quite loosely applied at the time. Usually, the parish of birth was considered the home parish, working and living in another parish for a number of years could change this ([Paterson 1976](#): 171)

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creation of their letters was “for the most part performed within the social and cultural milieu of the labouring poor themselves”. After all, literacy rates were high enough for at least someone close to be able to write. It could be dangerous to trust this at face value. A more reliable method is to check marriage registers to see if the applicant in question signed with a cross or their name. However, this is extremely labour-intensive and only those who got married are traceable. Nevertheless, following [Auer et al. \(2023\)](#) and [Gardner \(2023\)](#), some text-internal clues can help make a more informed decision regarding the authenticity of a letter. First of all, the handwriting and layout of the letter can give some indication of the level of writing fluency and thus literacy a person had, e.g., deferential spacing, phonetic spellings, ink-flow, how graphs are linked, line spacing, etc. Caution is needed though, as it is possible for someone from the lower classes to have a relatively high level of literacy and fluency in writing. Also, it is difficult to find truly objective means to quantify the level of fluency in writing. Nonetheless, it is worth exploring if writing skills in some way correlate with overall fluency in the written standard.

Secondly, in some cases, there might be several letters by the same hand over a longer period, which makes it less likely that a person could fall back on the same person to write their letters for them. In other cases, a relative living within the household consistently writes on behalf of the applicant, making it likely that the letter was indeed written by the person in question and within the same social circle ([Gardner 2023: 9–10](#)). Using these cues the *ScotPP* letters have been encoded for authenticity and literacy levels. Arguably, writing proficiency levels are difficult to establish objectively, but it is worth investigating if they reveal any variation in the use of modals of necessity.

4 Modals of necessity: A case study

Following [Palmer \(1986\)](#), modality can be expressed through various means such as grammatical mood (e.g., the subjunctive), different clause types, adjectives, and - the verbs under study here - modals and semi-modals. Modality prototypically conveys the speaker’s perceived degree of factuality, truthfulness, or attitude concerning the proposition described. This involves expressions that indicate a degree of possibility, necessity, or volition ([Quirk et al. 1985: 221](#)). There are several ways to describe and classify the different meanings and uses of modality. For this case study, the commonly accepted binary distinction between epistemic and deontic modality largely suffices to describe cross-varietal usage of modals of obligation ([Lyons 1977](#)). Simply put, *epistemic* modality involves the speaker’s

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assessment of the truth or certainty of a given situation based on their knowledge or beliefs and includes expressions to do with logical necessity and possibility. *Deontic* modality, on the other hand, refers to the expression of granting permission, prohibition, or necessity placed on the speaker or the addressee for future actions (Hoye 1997: 42–43; Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 179).

A further way to categorise deontic modality is *subjective* versus *objective* (Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 183). This relates to the “[t]he person, authority, convention, or whatever from whom the obligation, etc., is understood to emanate” (Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 178). In the case of *subjective* deontic modality, the sense of obligation emanates from the speaker (1), whereas the *objective* type describes some external, more abstract source of obligation (2):

- (1) I must do something about this leak. (Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 183)
- (2) We must make an appointment if we want to see the Dean. (Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 183)

Lastly, some frameworks identify *dynamic* modality (cf. Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 185). In this case, obligation emerges from internal conditions, attributes, or situational contexts of the subject, as opposed to external obligations, authority, or conventions. This includes statements that express the subject’s ability (3), willingness or propensity to do something (4). Example (5) illustrates how some expressions can be ambiguous and can be interpreted as both deontic (granting the subject permission) or dynamic (the subject’s ability to speak French).

- (3) She can easily beat everyone else in the club. (*dynamic*)
(Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 185)
- (4) Ed’s a guy who must always be poking his nose into other people’s business. (*dynamic*)
(Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 185)
- (5) She can speak French. (ambiguous)
(Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 185)

It is not always easy to distinguish *dynamic* from truly *deontic* types. As Schütler & Herzky (2021: 137–138) point out, *deontic* expressions, as found in (6) below, may be also interpreted as *dynamic*, albeit less prototypically so, due to the lack of an identifiable animate subject from which obligation arises:

- (6) Now that she has lost her job she must live extremely frugally.
(Huddleston & Pullum 2002: 185)

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Following Schützler and Herzky, I argue that this can readily be categorised as *objective* deontic modality because there is some external deontic force being imposed on the speaker. Prototypically *dynamic* and ambiguous types will be ignored for this case study because they represent expressions of obligation to a lesser extent.

4.1 Modals expressing necessity in present-day SSE

Present-day SSE and SBSE share the same modals expressing deontic and epistemic necessity, but their usage patterns tend to differ. The present case study will primarily centre on *must*, *ought (to)*, *need (to)*, and *have to*,⁴ as these have been studied most extensively (e.g., Miller 1989, Tagliamonte & Smith 2006, Schützler & Herzky 2021) and were also in use in the 19th century and as such allow for diachronic comparison. Even though deontic *must*, *have to*, and *need (to)* are used in both SBSE and SSE, in contrast to SBSE, SSE seems to favour deontic *need (to)* over *must* in formal (written) contexts and *have to* over *must* in informal spoken contexts (Schützler & Herzky 2021: 151–153, based on ICE-Scotland data). The latter is also confirmed by Tagliamonte & Smith (2006) who studied spoken data and found an overwhelming preference for *have to*. Particularly the almost categorical absence of *must* in conservative dialects of northern Scotland and Northern Ireland led them to speculate that “deontic *must* may never have been present in these northern dialects in the first place” (Tagliamonte & Smith 2006: 355). However, it is difficult to say what the historical roots are of these patterns, as earlier stages of Scots have hardly been studied in this respect. Elswailer (p.c.) has identified deontic uses of *must*, *mon/maun* (the Scots equivalents of *must*) in the *ScotsCorr* corpus in Early Modern Scots letters from Northern Scotland, which suggests that the lack of deontic *maun/mon* was not universal at the time. Interestingly, epistemic *must* is frequently used in SSE, so that examples like (7) are common, but examples like (8) are relatively rare (Miller 1989: 16–17):

(7) the lights are on so he *must* be home (*epistemic*)

(8) you *must* be home by 10 or else there will be consequences (*deontic*)

It needs to be pointed out that there is a general decline of core modals such as *must* in favour of semi-modals such as *have to* across varieties of English (cf. Leech 2013, Daugs 2017). Variability in usage patterns across varieties can in this

⁴Studies on present-day Scottish English and SSE also include *got to* and *have got to*. However, these forms had only begun to develop in the late 19th century and there are no instances of them in the corpora studied for this paper, so they will not be discussed here.

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light be attributed to the layering of grammatical forms that signal a lasting grammatical change, i.e. a general drift to semi-modals (Tagliamonte & Smith 2006: 344, following Hopper 1991). Nevertheless, the grammaticalisation routes taken may differ across varieties, as well as the rate at which this modal decline takes place. For instance, as demonstrated above, *must* is more strongly associated with epistemic necessity than with deontic necessity in SSE. What is more, the fact that deontic *need to* is comparatively more frequent in SSE than in SBSE suggests that it is preferred for the expression of deontic necessity in formal SSE. As such it may mark a unique grammaticalisation route in SSE (Schützler & Herzky 2021: 153).

One thorny issue is whether or not deontic *must*, *need (to)*, *ought (to)*, and *have to* are truly all semantically equivalent (Tagliamonte & Smith 2006: 345; Schützler & Herzky 2021: 138). Huddleston & Pullum (2002: 175) argue for different strengths of obligation, ranging from weak to strong. In practice, this distinction is very difficult to make objectively. It can at least be said that the modals considered for this case study all have a sense of imposing a (near-)compulsory action (Schützler & Herzky 2021: 138). Morpho-syntactically, there are some important differences in that *must*, *ought to*, and *have got to* cannot be used in the past tense or occur in non-finite form. *Have to* and *need to* are more obvious choices in these contexts (Quirk et al. 1985: 145).

Other factors that may condition the choice between the modals of necessity are *subjective* and *objective* modality, where *subjective* modality favours *must* and *need to*, while *have (got) to* tends to be preferred with objective modality (Schützler & Herzky 2021: 138). The grammatical person may also play a role in that second-person subjects tend to trigger the use of *have to*, while third-person subjects seem to attract *must*. This possibly correlates with a negative politeness strategy; the objective modality associated with *have to* might be perceived as less imposing when addressing a person directly (Schützler & Herzky 2021: 153).

A final issue needing consideration is the historical development of the (semi)-modals in question. For English, most forms were commonly used to express deontic and epistemic modality by the Early Modern English period. Northern English/Scots *mon* and *maun* were also firmly established as modals in the Middle English period (Tagliamonte & Smith 2006: 246–351, based on Biber et al. 1999: 487; Brinton 1991, Jespersen 1914, Plank 1984, van der Gaaf 1931, Visser 1973, Warner 1993). Unfortunately, little is known about the diachronic development of the usage patterns of the modals under discussion in Scots and SSE. As mentioned earlier, deontic *mon/maun* have been attested in Older Scots. This is also borne out by the *Dictionary of Older Scots (DOST)*, which lists deontic uses of

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must and *maun* and variants before the 1700s, and the *Scottish National Dictionary* (SND) lists deontic examples of *maun* and variants but not *must* after the 1700s. The latter is probably due to compilation principles and not necessarily evidence for the absence of deontic *must*.⁵ As for *need (to)*, the SND marks the use of *need* as an equivalent of *must* as rare, showing only one example from 1872. Even less is known about the usage patterns of *have to* and *ought to*. From a grammaticalisation perspective, it could be argued that semi-modals like *need to*, *have to*, and *ought to* have not reached full modal status in present-day SSE yet because they do not have the same syntactic restrictions as core modals.

Based on these findings we can surmise that *must* and *ought to* are relatively rare in SSE deontic contexts, with *must* being favoured for the expression of epistemic necessity, whereas *need to* and *have to* are preferred for the expression of deontic necessity. Given the evidence from the SND, *need (to)* is probably still rare. The question remains how and when *must* was disfavoured in deontic contexts. Furthermore, when did the other constructions start competing with *must*? It would be interesting to see what the ScotPP data can reveal about this. *Have to* is less likely to occur in written language, but from a 19th-century perspective, this could mean that less literate speaker-writers used the spoken form less self-consciously. This leads us to the following research questions for our case study:

1. How do the 19th-century modal patterns compare to the ones that have been reported for Present-day SSE?
2. How do the 19th-century modal patterns compare to 19th-century SBSE patterns?
3. What insights do the ScotPP data reveal about the usages of these modals among different social layers and thus varying levels of literacy in the prestige variety? And what does this say about their alignment with SBSE and/or SSE patterns?

Again, by addressing these research questions, this paper also aims to address some of the overarching questions posed by this volume. First of all, the pauper letters under scrutiny come with their unique challenges and the hopes are that this case study can shed light on one of the thematic questions: “Which data are suitable for the exploration of the interaction of regional and social varieties with

⁵That is, *must* will most likely have been seen as distinct from Scots and part of English as used in Scotland.

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the standard and what more is needed for future research?” Can pauper letters provide insights into how lower social classes negotiated regional spoken Scots forms and written Southern English prestige forms in a context that required standard language? Tying in with this, pauper letters are written within a specific communicative setting, i.e. requesting relief from a superior. So, as regards the thematic question “In which text types and communicative situations do writers use regional features in a standard English context?” we can speculate about the role of the communicative setting in the choice of modal verbs.

4.2 Data and methods

Though potentially more modals deserve further study, this case study focuses on the occurrences of deontic *have to*, *need to*, *ought to*, and *must* in Scottish and English letters of the 19th century. These modals have been studied most extensively for present-day SSE, providing us with some empirical basis to build on.

As mentioned in Section 4.1, contexts requiring past-tense reference or non-finite forms naturally give rise to the morphologically richer *have to* and *need to* over *ought to* and *must*. Negated forms present another issue; in SBSE, for instance, *must* is avoided for the negation of epistemic necessity. This case study will therefore focus exclusively on non-negated deontic modals in contexts that do not require past-time reference or non-finite forms.

Very importantly, to gain as full a picture as possible of the sociolinguistic development of the modal verbs in question, I will also study usage patterns in middle/upper-class Scottish authors as found in the *Corpus of Modern Scottish Writing* (CMSW). Moreover, to gain an impression of how English in Scotland related to the Southern English prestige model it had long been based on, I also consider the occurrence of the same modals in highly educated English writers. For the latter a selection of letters from the *Corpus of late Modern English Prose* and CLMET (henceforth *English corpus*) was used. This amounts to circa 13,500 words, more or less equally divided over 17 different authors, covering the period 1830–1900, which overlaps with the period covered by *ScotPP*. It should be noted that the level of formality and topics vary across the letters, but they generally tend to be personal correspondence.

To represent the Scottish educated upper classes and upper middle classes, I selected 19th-century letters by Scottish authors from CMSW. This totals 16,901 words more or less equally distributed across 12 authors, again covering the period 1830–1900. From a sociolinguistic perspective, it can be assumed that they

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used prestige forms the most, allowing us to gauge to what extent the prestige variety in Scotland followed that of England. Here, too, the letters cover a range of different formal and informal, more intimate contexts. Due to limited availability, no strict divisions were made between formal and informal contexts. However, most letters involve personal communication.

None of the texts that I used are POS-tagged nor is the spelling normalised. To extract all relevant forms of *have to*, *need to*, *ought to*, and *must* Regex strings were used to account for as many spelling variants as possible.⁶ Next, examples were manually sorted to exclude non-modal uses of *have* and *need*. In the final step, the modals were classified as deontic or epistemic. Dynamic modal constructions were discarded. Furthermore, as grammatical person and subjectivity appear to be robust factors conditioning modal choice, each modal was encoded for these features.

Finally, it is expected that the *ScotPP* letters can shed some light on the lower classes and their interactions with the standard. So far, about 1500–2000 pauper letters have been located in the archives and photographed, of which about 509 have now been fully encoded for relevant meta-data concerning authorship and conjectured literacy levels, ranging from low to medium and high. A proportion of the letters have been written by poor overseers, leaving 427 letters classified as pauper letters (53,975 words), which I used for this case study. Also, owing to challenges regarding authorship, it is not easy to say how words are distributed across authors and it cannot be ruled out that some authors are overrepresented in the corpus. The analysis will therefore have to take into account scribal influences.

In contrast to the *CMSW* and the English letters, pauper letters all have to do with poor relief and are written in highly formal contexts, usually involving a considerable hierarchical and social distance between the speakers and addressees. Especially petitions tend to contain highly formulaic structures and standardised phrases, which may result in a more limited range of linguistic variation than in the other corpora. It can therefore be expected that modals of necessity are relatively less frequent in the pauper letters. Additionally, given the hierarchical difference between the writer and addressee, modals expressing obligation, i.e. deontic modals, might be avoided for politeness reasons.

A final caveat presented by the study of historical data is the definition of social class. For this study, when possible, occupation and level of education served as indicators of class (cf. [Groot 2024](#)).

⁶Based on spelling variants as listed in the *Oxford English Dictionary*, *A Dictionary of the Older Scottish Tongue* and the *Scottish National Dictionary*. Additionally, Regex wildcard symbols accounted for potential vowel variations.

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4.3 Results

Table 1 shows the normalised modal frequencies as found in the English letters and the CMSW (raw frequencies in brackets).

Table 1: Modals of necessity in English letters and CMSW per 10,000 words

Modal	English letters		CMSW	
	deontic	epistemic	deontic	epistemic
<i>must</i>	13,3 (18)	2,2(3)	6,8 (11)	2,5 (4)
<i>have to</i>	2,2 (3)	0	0,6 (1)	0
<i>need to</i>	0	0	0	0
<i>ought to</i>	1,5 (2)	0	1,2 (2)	0
Total	17 (23)	2,2 (3)	8,6 (14)	2,5 (4)

Overall, modals of necessity are relatively rare. Based on the frequencies presented here, it appears that highly educated English and Scottish authors were pretty much in alignment with each other. Both Scottish and English members of the higher ranks of society prefer *must* to express deontic modality. *Need to* and *ought to* are not used, or only rarely. The English authors seem to use *have to* a bit more freely than the Scottish authors, but a larger corpus is needed to say anything conclusive at this point. What is perhaps more striking, is that deontic modal constructions are comparatively rare in the CMSW. Possibly, different strategies or modals were used to express obligation.

As regards types of deontic modality and the grammatical person that may condition modal choice, the large majority (15 for the English letters and 8 for the CMSW) of deontic *must* instances is of the subjective type, which is in line with previous studies. As regards deontic *have to*, 2 are objective and 2 are subjective, so not much can be said about a preference for objective uses here. None of the instances of *have to* occur with a second-person subject, but at the same time the only four instances of second-person subjects appear with *must* ((9) and (10)).

- (9) *you must* excuse my brevity, for though I have a great many things to talk of when I see you, I have no particulars to write. (1842, CMSW, letter 300)
- (10) *You must* certainly come to Folitsocxs with me
(1899, *Corpus of Late Modern English Prose*, letter 8)

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How do these patterns compare to the ones found for *ScotPP*? Table 2 below provides the normalised and raw frequencies in the pauper letters. Note that this combines autograph, non-autograph letters, and letters of which the authenticity could not be established, as well as letters that were marked as highly literate and semi-literate.

Table 2: Modals of necessity in the ScotPP Corpus per 10,000 words

Modal	Pauper letters	
	deontic	epistemic
<i>must</i>	2,9 (16)	1,3 (7)
<i>have to</i>	2,8 (15)	0
<i>need to</i>	0,18 (1)	0
<i>ought to</i>	0	0
Total	5,8 (32)	1,3 (7)

Again, all modals under scrutiny are rare, even rarer than in the *CMSW* letters. As mentioned earlier, part of this can probably be attributed to genre conventions as well as the social distance between the speaker and addressee. First of all, particularly the formal petitions often closely follow a specific format that allows little room for linguistic creativity. Yet, at the same time, one would expect that obligation and necessity are typically associated with a person in need; circumstances oblige them to ask for relief and, usually, there is a strong sense of urgency attached to it. Indeed, the large majority of both deontic *must* and *have to* are of the *objective* type, emphasising how circumstances enforce a sense of necessity, see (11) and (12):

- (11)

I cannot do no longer without help let me know soon for I *must* try some other way
(1879, Ewart library, RI4/66)
- (12)

I am indeed Sorrow that I *have to* apply to you after so much kindness shown to me already by you
(1880, Ewart library, R14/70)

Secondly, due to the distance in hierarchy and power between the writer and addressee, the letters are highly deferential. Possibly, deontic modals are avoided because they are perceived as being too direct when performing face-threatening acts. Structures like (13) below are common throughout the corpus and convey

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strong necessity but are at the same time highly deferential and formal. In line with more formal petitions, which were traditionally perceived as a highly deferential form of writing in Scotland (Houston 2014), some letters are written in the third person, even when the letter in question is signed by the applicant and the letter does not appear to have been written by an amanuensis on the applicant's behalf. Despite being written in the third person, the use of modals of necessity is avoided in this letter and the sense of necessity is expressed in less direct terms. What is more, a high emphasis is placed on circumstances beyond the applicant's control:

- (13) having nobody to give her any aid, makes your humble petitioners situation to be very distressing - and being gone some time in Pregnancy makes her situation to be still worse, and having no work for herself renders her under the necessity of solicitating your honours for a little weekly to mitigate her distress hoping your honours will consider her case and as in duty Bound shall ever pray
(1830, National Records of Scotland, HR719/13/2)

Only two instances, (14) and (15), involve a second-person subject, which seems to further support the role of politeness.

- (14) be good enough to let me know when I am to come and *you must* send money to take me for I have nothing
(1878, Ewart Library, RI4/68)
- (15) *you must* wrrite to and let me know
(1854, Scottish Borders Archive Centre, SC/B/33/4)

Both authors have been labelled as having low writing proficiency. It could be that they were less aware of written politeness conventions in these contexts than more literate writers. A similar pattern is found in the *CMSW* data, but this concerns personal letters, where directness would be more permissible (see also (10) above).

Finally, Table 3, which compares the proportions of deontic *must* and *have to* in all letter sets, reveals that deontic *have to* is more on a par with *must* in the pauper letters. Using Fisher's exact test on the raw frequencies ($p < .05$), these differences test significant at $P = 0.0017$ for the *CMSW* and pauper letters, as well as the English letters and the pauper letters. The differences between *CMSW* and the English letters are not significant, supporting their alignment with each other. The difference between the pauper letters and the other letter sets is interesting, considering that deontic *must* is associated with more formal contexts

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today, whereas *have to* is more reflective of spoken language. Higher rates of *must* would therefore be expected in a highly formal contexts such as that of the pauper letters. Possibly, the on average lower literacy levels among the paupers allowed for the use of more unselfconscious spoken forms.

Table 3: Proportions of deontic *must* versus *have to* in all letter sets

	<i>must</i>	<i>have to</i>
English letters	0.86	0.14
<i>CMSW</i>	0.91	0.08
<i>ScotPP</i>	0.51	0.48

When taking into account the literacy labels the *ScotPP* letters have been encoded with, the highest proportions of *have to* occur among the letters that have been marked as high in terms of writing fluency (0.44 versus 0.33 in letters marked as lower writing fluency), but this difference is not marked as significant by Fisher’s exact test ($P<.005$). The question arises of how reliable writing skill is as a measure of fluency in written English altogether. Puzzlingly, a closer look at the individual letter writers who used *have to* and/or *must* does not reveal any clear patterns; letters that otherwise appear fairly standard English in terms of formality, syntax, and vocabulary include instances of deontic *have to*. Vice versa, letters that seem less standard and more reflective of spoken language in terms of spelling, vocabulary, and syntax show instances of *must*. A potential explanation could be that less experienced writers used English letter-writing manuals, following English patterns, whereas more confident writers would improvise more, but again, the results are far from conclusive. Overall, the instances of the modals are too scattered among the different authors to say anything about the potential categorical use of one modal over the other, or any potential regional differences. What can be said is that 6 of the 15 instances of *have to* that occur in the pauper corpus are produced by two authors, whose authenticity cannot be confirmed with certainty, but whose letters contain features reminiscent of spoken language. Interestingly, one of them has been labelled as having high and the other as having low writing fluency. For instance, parataxis is quite prominent in both letter writers, see (16) to (18):

- (16) and he does not agree to it and I will write to the Sherrif and he will give me advice
(1887, Ewart library, RI4/75)

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- (17) “Sir”, what is your reason that I can’t get out, and what have I done
(1887, Ewart library, RI4/75)
- (18) I have to get down to Thornhill Cattle Show in the cart and I will come
over and see you.
(1890s, Ewart Library, RI4/79)

Furthermore, neither use *must* in their letters, which further confirms the avoidance of this form in less formal registers closer to spoken modes of communication.

4.4 Discussion

This paper set out to address several questions. Using modals of necessity as a case study, the main goal was to gain insight into the development of written Standard English in Scotland across different layers of society in the 19th century and ultimately the development of SSE. The 19th century is a particularly interesting period due to the increasing social and geographical mobility, as well as increasing literacy, and the subsequent increase in pauper letters allowing us a glimpse of potential changes from below. As noted before, present-day SSE modals expressing deontic necessity show a stronger preference for *need to* over *must*, particularly in formal written language. Furthermore, in informal, spoken contexts, deontic *have to* is preferred and deontic *must* may have disappeared or never been present in some non-standard varieties in Scotland. Also, *have to* is generally preferred in *objective* deontic contexts, while *must* tends to be avoided when addressing a second-person subject. *Ought to* is generally avoided in SSE.

These observations led to the following question concerning the 19th century: How do the 19th-century modal patterns compare to the ones that have been reported for present-day SSE? Based on the data presented above, the almost complete absence of *need (to)* confirms that it had not emerged yet as a potential contender for *must*, which was commonly used as a modal of obligation in the Scottish 19th-century letters studied for this paper. The data sets are too small to say anything about the reported categorical avoidance of deontic *must* in present-day non-standard Scottish varieties in favour of *have to*; few authors used the relevant deontic modals more than once. However, two authors of the *ScotPP* corpus who contributed almost half of the instances of deontic *have to* avoided *must*. At the same time, it was noted that these authors generally leaned closer to oral registers, a context which *have to* is also associated with today.

As concerns *objective* and *subjective* deontic contexts, no clear pattern emerges due to the relatively low count of *have to*. If anything, the *ScotPP* data suggest no

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preference, as both deontic *have to* and *must* primarily occur in *objective* contexts. The latter might be reflective of the start of what Tagliamonte & Smith (2006) refer to as layering, i.e. competing structures emerge, eventually resulting in the persistence of both structures that develop subtly differentiated usages. However, it could also have to do with the orientation to different standards among pauper-letter writers; given the highly formal context, some pauper-letter writers may have relied on the most formal writing model, which was modelled on SBSE. This must certainly have been the case for the more formal stylised petitions, which clearly seem to follow the standard as prescribed by English letter-writing manuals that were commonly used in Scotland (Houston 2014). Other pauper-letter writers who did not have access to such models or perhaps felt less need to rely on letter-writing manuals because they were proficient enough to improvise, may have turned to more local practices formed within their own community, be it in spoken or written form.⁷ Another possibility is that the level of familiarity between the letter-writer and the poor inspector played a role, inviting more informal and local language usage. Some letters show evidence of longstanding contact between the letter-writer and the addressee.

To fully understand the role of the continuous contact between SBSE and SSE, we also need to consider what the English prestige pattern may have looked like at the time. A further question was therefore: how do the 19th-century Scottish modal patterns compare to 19th-century SBSE patterns? Related to this, can we observe any socially stratified patterns? First of all, it is striking to note that the modals in question are comparatively rare in the Scottish letters, particularly in the pauper letters. This could either be because a different set of modals was used altogether, or, as noted for the pauper letters, due to different politeness conventions that avoid deontic modals expressing obligation. Future research on other potential deontic modals such as *should* (see also Miller 1989) and politeness conventions could provide further clarity on these questions.

Furthermore, it is interesting to note that the highly educated Scottish authors of the CMSW very closely follow the modal pattern of their English counterparts. Both groups preferred *must* over any other modal verb. Notably, instances of *need to* and *ought to* are rare in all letter sets and the latter is completely absent in the pauper letters set. Possibly, both SBSE and SSE diverged away in different directions at a later point in time, which could then explain how *need to* has become more strongly associated with formal context in SSE. However, more likely, the forms are generally rare and larger data sets are needed to spot any reliable trends. Schützler & Herzky (2021) found that *ought to* is also rare in SBSE, suggesting that the standard varieties might not differ all that much in that respect.

⁷I kindly thank one of the reviewers of this chapter for this insightful suggestion.

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Regarding social stratification and the suitability of the current data for finding patterns of variation, it is promising to note that there is a significant difference between the *CMSW* letters and those of the *ScotPP*. Despite the highly formal nature of the pauper letters, as well as the caveats concerning the authenticity of the letters, there are comparatively high rates of *have to*, pointing to a potential change from below in both senses. Given the general increase of *have to* at the expense of *must* as observed among various varieties of English today, the question is whether the observed pattern in the *ScotPP* letters concerns a uniquely Scottish development, at least in terms of timing, or whether this is a more general “angloversal” development or possibly a “vernacular universal” (cf. [Szmrecsanyi & Kortmann 2008](#)) being pushed from below among various varieties of English. A cross-comparison with other lower-class material in different varieties of English might aid in addressing this question. Corpora being created by projects such as the *Language of the Labouring Poor in Late Modern England* ([Auer et al. 2023](#)) could in the future provide some very valuable insights into this question. Furthermore, a diatopic study of earlier periods of Scots and Scottish English could provide further evidence for the potential lack of deontic *must* in some varieties in Scotland.

Returning to the questions relating to the overarching themes of this volume, it can be stated that the pauper letters, despite their challenges, reveal unique interactions with the standard. The communicative setting requires highly formal language, yet compared to the *CMSW* and the English letter writers, higher rates of vernacular features can be observed. As suggested earlier, this could be a sign that some pauper-letter writers relied more on local writing practices allowing for higher rates of *have to*, whereas others may have turned to a writing model based on SBSE, which, going by the usage of the upper-class English and Scottish writers, most likely favoured *must*. The pauper-letter writers who did use the more prestigious *must* may have had access to the SBSE model through English letter-writing manuals. A future study examining contemporary English letter-writing manuals for the use of deontic *must* and *have to* in formal petitions and letters could provide further insight into this topic.⁸ Moreover, the overall relatively low frequency of deontic modals expressing obligation in *ScotPP* is potentially reflective of the unique communicative setting in which pauper letters

⁸A quick survey of contemporary English letter-writing manuals that provide examples of petitions requesting relief revealed that deontic modals are avoided, and that *have to* is non-existent throughout the manuals. As far as I know, there are very few letter-writing manuals by Scottish authors. If there are any, it can be assumed they were strongly influenced by the English manuals, given the prestige these manuals had.

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were written; a highly deferential setting calling for the avoidance of verbal expression of obligation, in a sense calling for a genre-specific standard.

5 Concluding remarks

This study examined the use of modals of necessity among highly educated Scottish and English writers, as well as pauper letters to better understand the development of written Standard English in Scotland and the potential role of the lower classes in the shaping of this variety. The findings suggest that *must* was the predominant form among both Scottish and English highly educated writers, while *have to* competed significantly more strongly with *must* in the in *ScotPP* letters. The near absence of *need to* indicates that its later association with formal written SSE had not yet developed. Additionally, the overall low frequency of the deontic modals under scrutiny in pauper letters suggests that politeness and the highly deferential nature of the communicative setting influenced modal usage. At the same time, the highly educated writers of *CMSW* also show relatively low frequencies for the modals under study when compared to the English prestige model, which could point to different conventions in Scottish English or a preference for deontic modals that have not been included in this study, such as *should*.

The contrast between the *CMSW* and the *ScotPP* letters, tentatively points to social stratification in modal choice, with *have to* potentially emerging as a change from below. However, whether this reflects a uniquely Scottish development giving rise to a unique SSE feature, a specific pauper letter writing practice, or a broader cross-varietal shift remains unclear. Future comparative studies of lower-class writing, the interplay between prescriptive works such as letter writing manuals and local practices, and diachronic analyses of Scots could shed further light on this.

Finally, this paper comes with its obvious limitations that should be acknowledged here. First of all, the modals under study are generally low-frequency features, making more fine-grained statistical analyses difficult. Larger data sets might reveal clearer trends regarding the role of the grammatical person and the type of deontic modality. Hopefully, more suitable corpus data will become available in the future. An issue less readily addressed is the fact that pauper letters are a unique genre of their own, that cannot easily be compared to other types of correspondence across social layers. Moreover, the writing fluency of authors is arguably difficult to quantify objectively and consistently. Perhaps better measures concerning literacy levels have to be designed. Nonetheless, when in-

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terpreted with care, the data presented here reveal some patterns that at least warrant future lines of research.

Acknowledgement

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Chapter 6

Northern English pauper letters: Exploring social and regional variation in Late Modern England

Anita Auer & Mark Iten

The North of England, perceived as culturally and linguistically different from the South since the Middle Ages, has received much attention from English (historical) linguists since the early 2000s. This paper contributes to these regionally focused studies by investigating the interplay between social and regional variation in Northern England during the Late Modern English period. As the period is marked by standardisation processes of written and spoken English, grammatical works and pronunciation dictionaries determined norms based on the language of well-educated gentlemen from the South of England, which necessarily led to the stigmatisation of other linguistic variants. While the upper layers of society were often aware of the linguistic norms and therefore could have adhered to them, texts produced by the lower strata of society like letters written by the labouring poor reflect reduced levels of literacy training and often contain ‘non-standard’ and stigmatised linguistic features.

This article aims at investigating Northern English poor relief letters within the context of language standardisation processes. First, linguistic features associated with the North and/or specific social groups, as indicated in contemporary grammars, dictionaries, and manuals, are discussed. Then, based on samples of pauper letters written in the North during the period c. 1795–1834, the study systematically investigates linguistic variation from two perspectives, notably (a) a case study of a possible FOOT-STRUT split or non-split in letters by the labouring poor and (b) selected case studies of individual writers in which the relationship between linguistic norms and non-standard features is investigated from a qualitative perspective. All in all, the study shows that pauper letters are a useful resource for investigating regional (and social) variation in the Late Modern English period, but that it is difficult to determine whether the adherence to linguistic norms and/or the lack of ‘non-standard’/dialectal features is due to higher literacy levels and an awareness

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of the linguistic norms or due to the fact that certain linguistic features were not used in the region.

1 Introduction

The North of England has already received much attention from English (historical) linguists since the early 2000s (see e.g., [Wales 2006](#); [Hickey 2015](#); [Beal & Hancil 2017](#); [García 2020b](#)), particularly the perception of the North as culturally and linguistically different from the South. This paper contributes to these regionally focused linguistic studies by investigating the interplay between social and regional variation in Northern England during the Late Modern English period (c. 1700–1900), i.e. a period marked by standardisation processes of written and spoken English, notably the codification and prescriptivism stages (see [Milroy & Milroy 1991](#)). At the time, grammatical works and pronunciation dictionaries determined norms based on the language of well-educated gentlemen from the South of England, which inevitably led to the stigmatisation of other linguistic variants, often non-Southern ones (see [Beal 2004](#): Ch. 8).

Another aspect to consider when investigating social and regional linguistic variation has to do with the fact that literacy was socially stratified, which makes it difficult to gain access to data created by the lower layers of society. With compulsory elementary schooling only being introduced in 1880, the literacy levels varied greatly until then. In addition to social differences linked to literacy, there were also regional differences, as [Reay \(1998: 40\)](#) shows for the Early Modern period, notably 1580–1700. More precisely, the gentry and professions were almost fully literate in different areas, while yeomen, traders, and craftsmen had somewhat higher literacy levels in London and Middlesex (c. 70%) in contrast to East Anglia (c. 60%) and the North (c. 54%). The lowest level, ranging from 15 to 25%, is found amongst husbandmen and labourers. While the literacy rates were increasing throughout the Late Modern English period, the social and regional differences in literacy levels pertained until the introduction of elementary compulsory schooling. Changes in society and education in the North of England were also a result of the Industrial Revolution, during which Northern cities grew in size and importance ([Beal 2004](#): 5–6). Within this context, while the upper layers of society were often aware of the linguistic norms and therefore could have adhered to them, texts produced by the lower strata of society reflect reduced levels of literacy training and may contain ‘non-standard’ and stigmatised linguistic features. As the rise of a standard language brings with

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it variation reduction, which means that dialectal forms are marginalised, the focus on written language produced in the North can reveal whether Northerners, whose ‘provincial’ speech and grammar was commented on in eighteenth-century grammatical works (see for instance [Johnson 1755](#): Preface), were aware of the established grammar rules and whether they adhered to them. [Wales \(2002: 54\)](#) notes the following:

There is plenty of well-documented evidence, in this period so crucial for linguistic ideologies which persist through the nineteenth century and into the late twentieth century, of a felt need and desire for a standardised writing and grammar based on London English (which was perceived as rational and logical), and this ‘ideal’ was propounded by schoolteachers even of Northern extraction (e.g. [Fisher 1750](#)), undoubtedly extra-sensitive to their sociolinguistic ‘marginalisation’. Indeed, aside from London, Newcastle published more grammars during this century than anywhere else ([Beal 1996](#): 364).

As the quotation above indicates, some Northerners tried to prevent sociolinguistic ‘marginalisation’ by teaching and learning ‘polite’ grammar and pronunciation. Social climbers during the Industrial Revolution also appeared to be aware of the importance of education as “wealthy *nouveau riche* businessmen and colliery owners certainly sent their sons south to acquire fashionable tastes and education” ([Wales 2002](#): 55). Grammar books and thus the ‘polite’ education reached the north in the second half of the eighteenth century. In the late eighteenth century, the Romantic movement was started, which in turn promoted genuine, i.e. colloquial and non-standard, language (see [Adamson 1999](#): 598–599; [Wales 2002](#): 55–57).

While insight into regional language use in the Late Modern English period is commonly gained through dialect literature, literary dialects, glossaries of ‘provincialisms’, as well as pronunciation and dialect descriptions (see for instance [Hodson & Broadhead 2013](#); [Hodson 2017](#); [García 2020a, 2021, 2023](#) and [Currie 2026 \[this volume\]](#)), lower-class writing can also serve as an interesting source for regional writing. An important contrast between the former text types and lower-class writing lies in the author of the text and the education they had received, to which the knowledge and awareness of linguistic norms can be linked (see [Fairman 2007c](#): 192). For instance, Hodson in her article “Literary uses of dialect” lists well-known novelists and poets as having used “dialect in new and innovative ways” in their writings ([Hodson 2018](#): 513). Similarly, [García \(2023: 561\)](#) describes the author Joseph Arthur Gibbs (1867–1899) of *A Cotswold*

Village (1898), i.e. a second-hand dialect description of Gloucestershire, as “an educated Londoner”. All of the previously listed text types, i.e. from dialect literature to dialect descriptions, were, to our knowledge, written by literate authors whose impressions of dialect and non-standard language use were reflected in their texts. In contrast, lower-class writing, as we will show, was produced by members of the lower social stratum whose access to schooling varied greatly. What can be observed is therefore an interesting interplay between the written standard and reflections of authentic lower-class (spoken) language (see for instance Auer et al. 2023). More precisely, the text type serving as the basis for investigation in this study are letters written by the labouring poor within the context of the Old Poor Law, which provided a system for poor relief distribution in England and Wales. The chronological focus is on the period 1795 to 1834, during which the payment and receipt of so-called outrelief from parish funds was legalised. More precisely, by sending an application letter/petition to their parish of legal settlement, impoverished people who were ‘in distress’ had the right to apply for out-relief. Relief could be offered in the form of money sent or by bringing the poor person back to their parish of legal settlement, where they were often placed in a workhouse (see Whyte 2004: 280; Auer & Fairman 2013). This roughly 40-year time span at the beginning of the nineteenth century predates the introduction of compulsory elementary schooling in England. The labouring poor applying for out-relief had thus often only received limited and varied schooling.

Couched within the context of language standardisation processes in Late Modern England, the article focuses on linguistic variation associated with the North, as indicated in a selection of contemporary grammars, dictionaries, and manuals. Then, based on samples of pauper letters written in the North during the period c. 1795–1834, the study systematically investigates linguistic variation from two perspectives, notably (a) a case study of the a possible FOOT-STRUT split or non-split in letters by the labouring poor (quantitative angle) and (b) a couple of qualitative case studies of individual writers in which the relationship between linguistic norms and non-standard features is investigated (see, e.g., Auer et al. 2023). The first case study aims to shed light on a specific linguistic feature associated with the North of England, including a critical discussion about the extent to which we can interpret spelling deviating from standard norms as being a reflection of contemporary speech variants. The second case study aims to illustrate the intricate relationship between written norms and non-standard language use by taking intra- and inter-writer variation into consideration. More generally, the contribution approaches standard language use by focusing on a specific group of writers in the North of England who lack a certain degree of

grammatical schooling and therefore employ different strategies in order to communicate in a highly formal (legal) context, i.e. the texts combine grammatical norms and their forms with variants influenced by spoken language (and at times dialect forms) (see also [Gordon 2026 \[this volume\]](#)).

This article is structured as follows: In Section 2, we discuss language standardisation processes with a particular focus on the North of England, i.e. meta-linguistic comments on language use in the North of England. Section 3 is concerned with the concept of language history ‘from below’ and provides an overview of existing studies on the language of the labouring poor within the field of historical sociolinguistics, followed by a focus on the English lower-class data and particularly the labouring poor. Section 4 presents the previously mentioned case studies. Finally, the conclusion (Section 5) will present the main findings, discuss limitations of the data, and provide an outlook.

2 Language standardisation processes and the North of England – Meta-linguistic comments in eighteenth-century English normative works and other relevant sources

The study of language standardisation processes in the North can be approached in different ways, e.g., (1) the role of Northern grammarians, orthoepists, and others in the codification and prescriptivism of the English language, (2) meta-linguistic comments on Northern language use as reflected in Late Modern English printed works, and (??) the effect of normative linguistic rules on actual language usage in the North of England (see also [Lismont et al. 2023](#)). While a focus on school curricula in the North of England, particularly with regard to English language teaching, would be of great interest, it is very challenging to find this kind of information for the great range of schools that existed during the period (see case studies in educational history, e.g., [Stephens 1973](#); [Purvis 1984](#); [Rule 2014](#)). In what follows, we first focus on contemporary descriptions of language use in the North of England as found in normative grammars and other relevant works.

In order to determine comments regarding linguistic features associated with the North of England, the *Eighteenth-Century English Grammars database* (ECEG) and the *Eighteenth-Century English Phonology Database* (ECEP) ([Beal et al. 2015](#)) served as lists of potentially relevant works (see [Yáñez-Bouza 2011](#) and [Beal et al. 2020](#) respectively). Thereafter, these works were consulted on ECCO, archive.org

and google books in order to determine whether the authors made reference to the North; more precisely, a keyword search of *North** was carried out. Due to the great amount of works identified through the *ECEG*, a manual search of the individual grammars in other databases was not possible. This approach may have missed information linked to specific counties or places, but within the scope of this study, it was not possible to close-read the databases.

Out of the 11 works listed in the *ECEP*, only two works, by William Kenrick (1773) and John Walker (1791), mention specific features that can be attributed to Northern English speech. Out of the 323 grammars listed in the *ECEG*, relevant comments concerning linguistic features in the North of England were found in 7 grammars (included in Table 1 below).¹ Given the approach taken to identify comments, there is a likelihood that relevant comments in other works were missed. Table 1 contains Northern features including examples that are discussed in eighteenth-century grammars and dictionaries.

In what follows, we discuss some of the features listed above in more detail. The majority of Northern linguistic features discussed in the identified eighteenth-century grammars and dictionaries concern vowels that are said to be pronounced differently by northern English speakers in comparison to speakers from the South. Here, the grammarians tend to remain in parts descriptive, for instance Walker (1791: 28) notes with regard to *ay* that when it “comes immediately after the accent in a final syllable, like *ai*, it drops the former vowel, in the colloquial pronunciation of the days of the week. Thus as we pronounce *captain*, *curtain*, & c. as if written *captin*, *curtin*, & c. so we hear *Sunday*, *Monday*, & c. as if written *Sundy*, *Mondy*, & c. A more distinct pronunciation of *day*, in these words, is a mark of the northern dialect”. Then again, Walker’s discussion of the STRUT vowel clearly indicates that he considers “provincials” to “mispronounce” the letter (Walker 1791: xiii):

Nay, harsh as the sentence may seem, those at a considerable distance from the capital do not only mispronounce many words taken separately, but they scarcely pronounce with purity a single word, syllable, or letter. Thus,

¹While it would, of course, be relevant to know which of these grammars were particularly important and popular in the late 18th and early 19th century, the popularity of individual grammars and, in turn, their effect on language users - both from a geographical and social perspective, is challenging to determine. While research has already been carried out on individual grammars’ popularities, also concerning print runs, references in book sale catalogues, and mentions in individual writings such as letters (see for instance the volume *Grammars, Grammars and Grammar-Writing in Eighteenth-Century England* (2008), edited by Tieken-Boon van Ostade), information about teaching the grammar rules are difficult to find with regard to a large part of society.

Table 1: Northern linguistic features discussed in eighteenth-century grammars and dictionaries

Linguistic Feature	Source(s)	Specific Region(s)
<i>ea</i> (<i>steal, seat, read</i>)	Charles Gildon & John Brightland (1711); James Greenwood (1711); Rudiments of English grammar (Anonymous 1788)	North in general
<i>gh</i> (<i>knight, might, through</i>)	James Greenwood (1711); Peter Walkden Fogg (1792)	North in general
<i>bairn/barn</i>	James Greenwood (1711)	North in general
short <i>u</i> (<i>skull, gun, supper</i>)	John Kirkby (1746)	North in general
Broad <i>a</i> (<i>fall, wall, water</i>)	Samuel Johnson (1755); John Walker (1791)	North in general
<i>r</i> (<i>round, rude, rock</i>)	William Kenrick (1773)	Northumberland
<i>strut</i>	John Walker (1791)	North in general
<i>good</i>	John Walker (1791)	North in general
<i>ay</i>	John Walker (1791)	North in general
<i>shall/will</i>	Peter Walkden Fogg (1792)	North in general
<i>ou</i> (<i>house, out</i>)	Peter Walkden Fogg (1792)	Yorkshire and other Northern parts
<i>yea/nay</i>	Alexander Barrie (1800)	North in general

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if the short sound of the letter *u* in *trunk*, *sunk*, & *c.* differ from the sound of that letter in the northern parts of England, where they found it like the *u* in *bull*, and nearly as if the words were written *troonk*, *foonk*, & *c.* it necessarily follows that every word where that letter occurs must by those provincials be mispronounced.

Beal (2012) provides further evidence of the identification of the FOOT-STRUT split, as well as an awareness of a non-split in certain regions, in a range of eighteenth-century sources. In addition to Walker (1791) and Kenrick (1773), the split was also recognised by Fisher (1762), Tucker (1773), Nares (1784), while Ward (1765), Carter (1773), Spence (1775), and Fogg (1792) did not seem to recognise the split (Beal 2012: 9). Fogg (1792), who did not recognise the FOOT-STRUT split, comments particularly on the county of Yorkshire with regard to variation in pronunciation of the diphthong *ou*, and he argues that “[e]ducation itself seems incapable of removing this defect, unless [the Yorkshire people] will themselves see the necessity of harmonising with the rest of the nation, and studying these minutiae of sound” (Fogg 1792: 89). More descriptive is Alexander Barrie’s (1800: 137) account of the disappearing distinction between *yea* and *yes*, as well as *nay* and *no*, which he describes as follows: “There is no trace of this distinction in the later Elizabethan English or onward; and *Yea* and *Nay* are now almost confined to poetry, the speech of Quakers, and the Northern dialects.”

Only few authors discuss non-phonological features, such as the distinction of *shall* and *will*. Peter Walkden Fogg (1792: 225) briefly discusses it by mentioning that “[t]he distinction between *shall* and the auxiliary *will* is extremely delicate. Foreigners and even our brethren of North Britain² and the sister island are frequently embarrassed by it”. In his Dictionary of 1755, Samuel Johnson is mostly concerned with lexicon and its geographical distribution, e.g., words like *ambry*, *bannock*, or *houlet* being used in the northern counties and Scotland. In addition, Johnson (1755: 62) makes a general comment about Northern speech and lexicon, describing it as outdated:

The language of the northern counties retains many words now out of use, but which are commonly of the genuine Teutonick race, and is uttered with a pronunciation which now seems harsh and rough, but was probably used by our ancestors. The northern speech is therefore not barbarous but obsolete.

²We assume that “North Britain” here not only refers to Scotland, but also to Northern England, as Fogg often groups the regions together, e.g., he discusses the pronunciation of *gh* in “the northern counties and in Scotland” (Fogg 1792: 89).

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Meta-linguistic comments cannot only be found in grammatical works but also in other types of books like histories, guides and manuals. One of these books is William Marshall's work on *The Rural Economy of Yorkshire* (1788),³ which dedicates a section to provincialisms. This section is particularly concerned with pronunciation and dialect lexicon in Yorkshire, i.e. it contains an alphabetical glossary including the lexeme and a definition but also contains some comments on morphology. The language-dedicated section starts with the statement that "[t]he Dialects of Yorkshire are strikingly various" (Marshall 1788: 303), observing great differences between the pronunciation of geographically close places and hypothesising about the reasons for these differences. As regards provincial words, Marshall (1788: 305–306) states the following:

Provincial words are either *corruptions* of the established language, or *native words* descended from the ANCIENT LANGUAGE of the province they are spoken in. Hence in RECLUSE DISTRICTS we must expect to find the greatest number of *genuine provincialisms*; – of ANCIENT VOCAL SOUNDS.

The VALE OF PICKERING is singularly circumstanced in this respect. The peculiar recluseness of its *situation* has been described; and being in a manner wholly agricultural, its *connexions* are inconsiderable. Had it not been for the influx of words and fashion which *Scarborough* has annually drawn into it, the secluded Vale must inevitably have been, in language and manners, a century at least behind every other District of *this* kingdom situated equally near its center.

The MORELAND DALES, which are in reality appendages of the Vale, have been still more effectually cut off from all *converse with strangers*. Their situation is so reclude, their soil in general so infertile, and their aspect so uninviting, that it is probable neither Roman, Dane, nor Saxon ever set foot in them. No wonder, then, the language of these Dales, which differs little from that of the Vale,-- except in its greater *purity*,-- should abound in *native words*; or that it should vary so widely in *pronunciation* from the established language of this day, as to be in a manner wholly unintelligible to strangers; not however, so much through *original words*, as through a regular SYSTEMATIC DEVIATION from the established *pronunciation of English words*⁴

³See also Ihalainen's (1994) discussion of Marshall's glossaries of provincialisms.

⁴It might be a difficult task, now, to ascertain with precision, whether these DEVIATIONS are in reality *corruptions* or *purities* of the ENGLISH LANGUAGE. They are probably a mixture of the two; I mean, they may contain some slight admixture of depravity. But it would be equally

Generally, Marshall's (1788) comments on language as well as his observations and associated interpretations are of great interest and deserve closer investigation. Following larger claims, he also gives very detailed examples of linguistic features. As regards morphology, for instance, Marshall (1788: 307) notes with regard to the "provincial language" of East Yorkshire that it has no genitive case except for possessive pronouns or whenever the nominative case is understood, e.g., "When this is expressed, the preceding substantive becomes in effect an adjective; as, *John Hat*,-- *George House*; analogous with *London porter*, --*Yorkshire butter*." The example is then followed by Marshall's opinion on the matter, i.e. "[t]his excision of the genitive termination gives great additional beauty and simplicity to the language, *doing away almost entirely the declension of nouns*, and *lessening that hissing* which is so disagreeable to the ears of foreigners, and which is indisputably one of the greatest blemishes of the English language." (Marshall 1788: 307). To illustrate pronunciation, Marshall (1788: 309) notes the following about "o long":

In the pronunciation of VOWELS, that of *o long*, as in *stone*, *yoke*, *bole*, *more*, is first noticeable. A mere provincialist of East Yorkshire knows no such sound; nor can he, without much practice, pronounce it. In the provincial dialect it takes four distinct vocal sounds; namely, *eea*, *au*, *ooa*, *a*,-- according to the consonants it is joined with in composition. Thus *stone* is pronounced *steaan*; *yoke*, *yauk*; *bole*, *booa*; *more*, *mare*.

When discussing words ending in *ault* or *alt*, Marshall (1788: 311) notes that the *l* is mute and the termination is *aut* in both cases, notably *fault*, *faut*; *salt*, *saut*; *malt*, *maut*. Linked to this example, Marshall provides a footnote that provides some insight into language use according to social factors, notably social class and age, as well as a comment about the development of the provincial languages (Marshall 1788: 311–312):

This brings to my mind a circumstance which deserves notice; as it serves to shew the *process of corruption*, or as others perhaps will have it, *refinement* of languages. There are, in many cases, *two distinct provincial languages* in this District: one of them spoken by the lower class,-- more especially of old people; the other by the superior class of *provincialists*. The first I shall call

reasonable to suppose that a disturbed steam should be less adulterate than its fountain, as that the language at present established should be less *corrupt*, or (to change the word without altering the argument) less *refined* than that of a District secluded in a singular manner from all intercourse with other languages.

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the *vulgar tongue* (though in all probability the purer language); the other the *middle dialect*. Thus the English word *malt* is in the vulgar tongue *maut*; in the middle dialect, *molt*: *Malton*, in like manner, becomes *Mauton* and *Molton*. All syllables formed with *o long* have three distinct pronunciations: thus *boool* in the vulgar tongue, *ball* in the middle dialect, and *bole* in the English language, convey the same idea. *Creeac*, *crake*, *crow*; *father* (the *a short*), *faither*, *father*, are other instances. In a few generations, it is probable, the present vulgar tongue will be lost, and the present middle dialect will then of course become the vulgar tongue.

This sociolinguistic distinction is unfortunately not given for more examples, but the comment does indicate that more linguistic variation can be found in different places. Moreover, it clearly illustrates attitudes towards different dialects that deviate from the linguistic norm established in the South of England (see Section 1). The distinction between “the vulgar tongue” (spoken by the lower classes, and especially old people), “the middle dialect” (“the superior class of provincialists”), and “the English language” (associated with Southern norms) provides an interesting insight into the perceived social differences and their language use in Yorkshire.

While we have only been able to discuss a selection of linguistic characteristics of Northern English here and cannot focus on more works in detail that discuss language use in different Northern counties (for relevant studies, also see Giner & Montgomery 2001; García 2008), Ihalainen (1994) has provided lists of dialect features from the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. The Northern features he determined are listed in Table 2 (Ihalainen 1994: 213–214).

It is noteworthy that Table 2 and Table 1 above only overlap with regard to 2 features, notably the STRUT vowel (*soom* ‘some’) and the pronunciation of *hoose* ‘house’.

All of the discussed sources will be taken into consideration when investigating actual language use in the Northern English pauper letters. The first quantitative case study will focus on the FOOT-STRUT split (see Marshall 1788; Walker 1791; Ihalainen 1994), while the two case studies of individual petitioners will be concerned with all determined features.

3 Language history ‘from below’: the labouring poor

For a long time, language histories were largely focused on the language of the social elite and the middling sort, which was mainly due to the availability of

Table 2: Linguistic features in the North of England in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century

Northern lack of rounding	<i>ste'an</i> [strən], <i>wark</i> 'work'
Northern oo-fronting	<i>me'an</i> [mɪən] 'moon', <i>se'an</i> [sɪən] 'soon'
Northern long <i>a</i>	<i>ne'am</i> [nɪəm] 'name'
/ai/-monophthongisation	<i>Ah</i> [a:] 'I', <i>faan</i> 'fine', <i>insard</i> 'inside'
yod-formation	<i>yan</i> 'one', <i>yak</i> 'oak'
<i>l</i> -vocalisation/dropping	<i>au'd</i> 'old'
linking <i>v</i>	<i>tiv another</i> 'to another'
<i>soom</i> 'some'	<i>some</i> pronounced [sʊm]
<i>hoose</i> 'house'	<i>house</i> pronounced [hʊ:s]
second person singular verb	<i>Tha knows</i> 'You know'
<i>y</i> -laxing	<i>Jerra</i> 'Jerry', <i>verra</i> 'very'
<i>at</i> 'that'	<i>a chap at knaws hauf as mich as me</i> 'a chap that knows half as much as me'
<i>t'</i> for <i>the</i> (i.e. the realisation of the definite article as a stop)	<i>Nea doot thoo knaws t' oad riddle</i> 'No doubt you know the old riddle'
<i>sal</i> , 's 'shall'	<i>Ah'se be forced te gang yam</i> 'I shall be forced to go home'
<i>I is</i> 'I am'	<i>Ah's seer</i> 'I'm sure'
universal -s, subject to the Northern Subject Rule	<i>They peel them and boils them, Birds sings</i>

data produced by that circle of society (manuscript and print) in comparison to the data produced by members of the lower social order (see Auer et al. 2015). Building on the work of German historical linguists with a strong focus on social history, notably the *non-elite* and *Arbeitersprache* (e.g., Mattheier 1986, 1990; see Vandenbussche 2006 for an overview), Elspaß introduced the concept of language history 'from below' in 2005, which he also discusses in some detail in the edited volume *Germanic Language Histories 'from Below' (1700–2000)* (Elspaß 2007; see also Elspaß 2021). The concept led to a change of focus in the study of language history, notably shifting from the traditional, elite-centred approach to one that is concerned with the linguistic practices of non-elite groups, including those who may not have received much formal education, if any at all. In order to apply this new framework, different types of less formal written materials, such as ego-documents or trial records, are considered in hopes of them

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reflecting how people actually spoke and wrote in their daily lives (see Auer et al. 2023). The first chapter of the previously mentioned edited volume (2007) in particular was concerned with text sources ‘from below’, such as correspondence or personal diaries (see Dossena 2007 for nineteenth-century Scottish emigrants’ letters; Fairman 2007a for lower-class English letters; McLelland 2007 for nineteenth-century German private emigrants’ letters; Reershemius 2007 for Western Yiddish in East Frisia; van der Wal 2007 for eighteenth-century Dutch ego-documents). In the same year, the journal *Multilingua* published a special issue on “lower class language use in the 19th century”, edited by Vandenbussche and Elspaß (2007). The special issue contains studies on a variety of languages, ranging from Canadian French (Martineau 2007), via Finnish (Nordlund 2007), to Danish (Sandersen 2007) and Flemish (Vandenbussche 2007).

Another important concept that has been applied to text sources like ego-documents concerns the distinction between ‘language of immediacy’ (*Sprache der Nähe*; orality, informality, unplannedness) and ‘language of distance’ (*Sprache der Distanz*; literateness, formality, plannedness), introduced by Koch & Oesterreicher (1985, 1994). The concept suggests that there is a strict dichotomy between the phonic and the graphic medium but they are both aligned on a continuum ranging from immediacy to distance. Prototypical texts like an intimate conversation are then charted on the side of immediacy, while a legal contract is found close to the opposing pole distance (Elspaß 2012: 157). Additional parameters that determine where a text type is charted are “formality, spatial or temporal distance, private or public setting of the communication, familiarity of the communication partner, spontaneity, and free or fixed topics” (Elspaß 2012: 157). The concept therefore clarifies the difference between the medium, i.e. spoken and written language, and the linguistic conception, i.e. oral and literary language, of different text types (see Elspaß 2015: 38). The language of ego-documents, particularly letters of a more formal nature like pauper petitions, which contain formulaic elements as well as oral features, can therefore be well explained with this concept.

When it comes to an English perspective on language history ‘from below’, researchers have been aiming to “give a voice to traditionally unheard social groups such as women and the lower classes” (Auer 2023: 437) by using a range of different data sources, such as witness depositions, pronouncing dictionaries, grammars, dialect writing, literary dialect, or pauper letters (see Beal 2023; Cooper 2023; Gardner 2023c; Grund 2023; Hodson 2023; García 2023; Wiemann 2023). Regarding the latter, Fairman (2007b) has previously worked on the language of several applications for poor relief written between 1795 and 1834. Fairman’s work was the basis for the SNSF-funded project *The Language of the Labouring*

Poor in Late Modern England (LALP). As part of the *LALP*-project, a corpus of pauper letters and related correspondence was compiled, which mainly includes letters sent by members of the labouring poor to parish officials from all historical counties in England. In order to focus solely on the language of the labouring poor, a sub-corpus named the *Pauper Letter Core Corpus* or *PLCC* was created that only includes letters relating to the poor relief system that were sent by paupers to parish officials or to family members and friends. At present, the *PLCC* contains roughly 820 letters or 147,248 orthographical units and includes letters sent to 39 different English counties. Due to opportunistic sampling, there is a discrepancy in letter and word count among the different counties as the collection of the relevant data depended on the survival and availability of pauper letters in each county. Similarly, the number of letters sent per pauper varies largely; most commonly, only a single letter by each pauper was available to the project team, while there were only a handful of paupers that sent more than five letters each. For each case study that follows, individuals from one of the northern English counties with six or more letters were selected in order to investigate the relationship between linguistic norms and non-standard features.

4 Case studies of Northern English pauper letters

As many of the labouring poor did not have access to regular and systematic schooling, their writing abilities varied greatly and many needed support to compose the petitions for out-relief. While some letters contain indications of whether they were penned by the applicant and can be considered authographical, e.g., including details on the writing process or education, other letters do not contain any clues at all. Based on this kind of evidence (or lack thereof) and the level of handwriting (evenness of lines and ink flow linked to writing experience and training), we aimed at classifying the letters as authentic, non-authentic, or ambiguous/unclear, which is the biggest category (see [Gardner 2023b,a](#); [Gardner et al. 2023](#); [Auer et al. 2024](#) for more detailed discussions regarding the categorisation of authenticity in the *LALP* corpus).⁵ As the historians [Sokoll \(2001: 64–65\)](#) and [King \(2019: 36–37\)](#) assume that many “of the letters were written by the applicants themselves or someone from their social circle with limited schooling”

⁵Other projects in the field of historical sociolinguistics that are focused on letters have similarly had to find solutions regarding the categorisation of letters linked to authenticity (see for instance [Nobels & Wal 2009](#) for Dutch, notably the Leiden Identification Procedure). In doing so, the specific sociohistorical context in which the letters were produced is of particular importance.

(Auer et al. 2024: 129), the letters can be described as representative of lower-class writing. In the following case studies linked to individual applicants (Section 4.2), we provide the authenticity details we have determined.

4.1 FOOT-STRUT split in Northern English pauper letters - A quantitative approach

The FOOT-STRUT split is the focus of the first case study, which takes a quantitative approach. As previously indicated, this is a feature that some eighteenth-century sources commented on, e.g. Fisher (1762), Kenrick (1773), Tucker (1773), Nares (1784), Walker (1791), while others did not recognise the FOOT-STRUT split, e.g. Ward (1765), Carter (1773), Spence (1775), Fogg (1792) (see Beal 2012: 9 for an overview of eighteenth-century sources). As said above, Walker (1791) associated the lack of a FOOT-STRUT split with mispronunciation (Walker 1791: xiii). In contrast, Spence (1775) did not directly comment on the feature. However, he categorically used the vowel [ʊ]⁶ in words from the lexical set STRUT. Given that Spence grew up in Newcastle and his pronunciation dictionary was published there, the pronunciation found in his work can be an indicator for a non-split of FOOT-STRUT in the Newcastle area. In line with this, Beal (2012: 12) notes that Ward (1765), Carter (1773), and Fogg (1792), grammar-school masters in the North of England, did not recognise the FOOT-STRUT split, which can be interpreted as them not being “aware of any stigma attaching to the northern pronunciation of these words” and them likely not teaching this split to their students. Given that not all grammar-school students would have been aware of a stigma related to a lack of the FOOT-STRUT split, this would likely also be the case for the labouring poor who often only received little education (cf. Auer et al. 2024: 129; Gardner 2023b). As education, writing practices, and linguistic repertoires of letter writers of poor relief applications could vary greatly, some authors therefore adhered to standard-like spelling while others resorted to phonetic spelling, thus reflecting spoken forms. In order to investigate this potential variation, the following case study investigates whether the FOOT-STRUT split or lack thereof, as generally associated with the North of England, can be found in the letters by the labouring poor. For this case study, all pauper letters within the LALP corpus that were sent to parishes within the Northern counties - Cheshire, Cumberland, Durham, Lancashire, Lincolnshire, Northumberland, Westmorland, and Yorkshire - were analysed according to the authors’ spelling of words typically attributed to the lexical set STRUT. In the first instance, we wanted to determine how a possible

⁶In his pronouncing dictionary, Spence (1775) uses a different symbol in order to represent modern-day [ʊ].

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FOOT realisation of the STRUT vowel was represented in terms of spelling, while being aware that spellings are ambiguous evidence in that they are not direct reflections of pronunciation (cf. see Dobson 1957: 588 in Beal 2012: 16). After all, spelling variation can arise from phonological representation, analogy with frequent graphemic patterns, e.g. *but*, *us*, *much*, and limited orthographic competence.

Table 3: FOOT-STRUT split in pauper letters from the Northern counties

County	Number of letters	Orthographic units	COMPATIBLE with strut-type vowel (variable context)	COMPATIBLE with foot-type vowel
Cheshire	5	526	23	0 (0.00%)
Cumberland	12	1,474	55	7 (12.73%)
Durham	19	3,117	89	3 (3.37%)
Lancashire	26	3,987	156	17 (10.90%)
Lincolnshire	0	0	0	0
Northumberland	2	539	11	1 (9.09%)
Westmorland	44	10,495	386	59 (15.28%)
Yorkshire	77	11,620	407	41 (10.07%)
TOTAL	185	31,758	1,127	128 (11.36%)

As seen in Table 3 above, we found a variable context of 1,127 tokens. Within this variable context, 128 tokens (11.36%) showed spelling variations that may be compatible with the FOOT-type vowel. In the majority of cases, the standard spelling of the variables in question made it impossible to deduce whether the paupers used a STRUT- or FOOT-type vowel when speaking, e.g. *us*, *much*, *must*. As noted in Section 2, Walker (1791: xiii) pointed out that Northern people pronounced words “as if [they] were written *troonk*, *foonk*, & c.” whereby ⟨oo⟩ seems to be a widely used convention for the representation of the STRUT vowel in Northern dialects by Southern authors (Beal 2012: 6). In contrast, the spelling variation found in letters written by the labouring poor contained instances of ⟨u⟩ in place of ⟨ou⟩ - as in *trubel* for *trouble* -, ⟨u⟩ in place of ⟨o⟩ - as in *sume-thing* for *something* - or ⟨ou⟩ in place of ⟨u⟩ - as in *ous* for *us*. The most frequent spellings compatible with the FOOT-type vowel were found in the lexical items *trouble* and *some*.

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As for *trouble*, which appears at a higher frequency in the poor relief letters than other lexical items, out of the 128 tokens, *trub** occurred 34 times within a variable context of 79 tokens, whereas *troub** was found 34 times and *trob** 11 times. As the variant *troub** follows the standard spelling, it is not possible to deduce what pronunciation the author had in mind. Regarding the *trub**-spelling, the question may be raised if the spelling reflects a FOOT-type vowel, whether the choice of spelling can be interpreted as analogy to the spelling of words like *but*, *us*, *much*, or whether it is the result of limited orthographic competence. A rough comparison of the data from the Northern counties to the data from the rest of England reveals that spellings compatible with a FOOT-type vowel are more frequent in the North. While letter writers from the South of England sometimes do use the *trub** variants as well, they do so at a much lower frequency than the writers from the North. In comparison, the *trob** variants are more frequently found in letters written in the South. This may be taken as a cautious indication that the *trub**-spelling may reflect regional pronunciation.

Regarding the lexical item *some*, the FOOT-type-vowel-compatible spelling *sum** was found in 54 instances within a variable context of 139 tokens. Given that the pauper letters often touch upon the topic of money, the lexical item *sum* - in reference to an amount of money - was also found in the corpus (nine times). In this case, orthographic analogy is likely the reason for its homophone *some* being spelled in a similar fashion, while phonetic spelling is similarly a possible interpretation.

Like *trouble*, other frequently used words, such as *double* or *enough*, showed a similar pattern, i.e. spellings compatible with a FOOT-type vowel were found in the letters, i.e. *duble* or *enuf*.

The dataset contains inter- as well as intra-writer variation. Regarding the latter for example, in Lancashire, all 17 instances of the non-standard spelling variants were found in letters authored by Moses Tyson, whereas all the other writers in this county consistently used standard spelling.

Overall, the poor relief letters contain some spelling variation linked to the STRUT- or FOOT-type vowels, but it remains challenging to interpret certain spelling choices as evidence for a particular vowel quality. While individual spellings are ambiguous, their distributional patterns such as higher frequencies in Northern data or clustering within individual writers are less likely to be explained by orthographic analogy and may in fact be interpreted as reflections of actual pronunciation. The reflection of the ‘mispronunciation’ on the page is likely not a result of prescriptive norms and thus an awareness of any stigma linked to the FOOT-STRUT non-split in Northern England, but the lack of education and writing training of the lower classes.

4.2 Intra-individual variation in Northern English pauper letters - Two qualitative case studies

The following two case studies, which take a qualitative approach, are concerned with the letters of individual petitioners from different Northern counties. The focus is thus on the intricate relationship between written norms and ‘non-standard’ language by taking intra- and inter-writer variation into consideration.

4.2.1 Linguistic variation in the pauper letters of a Yorkshire woman

The first case study focuses on the language used in Dorothy Styran’s 11 letters that were sent from Leeds to the parish overseers in Beverley during the period 1832 to 1834. Based on information provided in the letters, Dorothy Styran was a widow in April 1832, she had at the time a son aged 6, a child aged 8, and a married daughter in Leeds. The applications for out-relief, including reminders and type of payment, mainly concerned ill health of the applicant and her children. Table 4 provides an overview of some meta-data, notably the file names, the dates of the sent letters, information on authenticity / hand, and the word count. As regards authenticity, the abbreviation N 1 stands for non-authenticity, i.e. the applicant Dorothy Styran did not pen the letters herself. Indication for N 1 could be the following: No writing skills mentioned, writing assistance mentioned, reference made to the person signing the letter with the third-person pronoun, or the signature and the main text being written in different hands. In the case of Dorothy Styran, she mentioned writing assistance in one of her letters, notably in YKS_1832_003, referring to YKS_1832_002:

- (1) the perfon I got to Write for me laft I was Affraid Afterwards that they Did not Write to you in a proper Manner Which I thought it Waf on Account of you not Sending it. but if it af been the cafe I am Sorrey I see the Miffortune of Not being a Scholar.
(YKS_1832_003, Dorothy Styran, 23 April 1832)

In fact, we were able to determine that her letters were penned by 3 different hands, i.e. H1, H2, and H3. L? stands for lower/limited handwriting/layout skills, i.e. second on the continuum of L - L? - LH - H? - H, whereby H refers to higher/more professional handwriting/layout skills. As mentioned above, even though the applicant Dorothy Styran was not able to write, it seems that the three people who wrote her letters have not had much writing training / experience either; this may be taken as an indication that they were also from the same layer of society.

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Table 4: Letters written on behalf of the applicant Dorothy Styran

File name	Date	Authenticity Hand	/ Word count (excl. address and additions in different hands)
YKS_1832_002	1832 04 19	N 1 / L? (H1)	101
YKS_1832_003	1832 04 23	N 1 / L? (H2)	211
YKS_1832_008	1832 07 11	N 1 / L? (H1)	118
YKS_1832_009	1832 08 02	N 1 / L? (H2)	213
YKS_1832_011	1832 08 29	N 1 / L? (H2)	163
YKS_1832_012	1832 09 11	N 1 / L? (H2)	150
YKS_1832_018	1832 11 14	N 1 / L? (H1)	148
YKS_1832_019	1832 11 28	N 1 / L? (H1)	106
YKS_1832_021	1832 12 11	N 1 / L? (H3)	136
YKS_1832_023	1832 12 28	N 1 / L? (H1)	152
YKS_1833_007	1833 06 11	N 1 / L? (H1)	118
			1616 TOTAL

In terms of William Marshall’s (Marshall 1788: 311–312) categorisation, Dorothy Styran would have likely spoken in the “vulgar tongue”, i.e. the one “spoken by the lower class” where *bole* is said to be pronounced as *booa*, *crow* as *creeac*, and *father* with a *short a* (see §2.1). As for the writers of her letters, they would have likely belonged to the same social group and they would have therefore also spoken in the vulgar tongue.

To illustrate one of the letters, here is a plain text transcription:

- (2) Leeds the July, 11 1832
[^Mr Boys RUBBED OUT^] Sir i have Sent to you to See if you Would
Bee So kind as to Send Me the Chil[^il OVERWRITES d^]dren Money
for it Will Bee of great Service to Me at Present
for i have Been very Bad in the Collera for it
=is=[^INSERTION^] very fatal in the Nighbourhood Where I Reside
for it has taker four and five in ahouse But th[^{*...} HOLE^]od i am
Reco[^o OVERWRITES {*]^]vered But i am very
W[^OVERWRITES B^]eak i Shall Bee very thankfull if y[^OVERWRITES
{*]^]ou

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Will Bee So kind as to advance and Make
the Money into 2 guineas so i remain your humble
Servant Dorothy Stiran
(YKS_1832_008, Dorothy Styran, 11 July 1832)

As can be seen here, and as we have shown in other *LALP*-related publications, the lack of punctuation (which prevents the reader from parsing the text) and variant spelling, e.g., *Service* vs. *Servant*, indicates that the writer had not received any grammatical schooling. As regards specific linguistic features in Styran's letters, there is not a single example that could be immediately classified as a Northern feature (as listed above), but there are single examples that may indicate a specific pronunciation, e.g., *Naghbourhood* for *Neighbourhood* or *Cheldrin* for *children*. It is worth mentioning that Hand 2 (four letters) consistently writes *father* as *farther* (4 tokens in total), which may be interpreted as either a pronunciation of medial /r/ or a more open vowel quality, in contrast to Hand 1 (five letters) who uses the word *father* once in all letters. Hand 2 and Hand 3 (one letter) use long S, though not consistently, and the letters by Hand 1 and 2 contain few examples of *h*-dropping and *h*-insertion (but not consistently). As for linguistic norms such as the use of *shall* and *will* (see Fogg's 1792 comment above), it is noteworthy that *shall* is only found in the first person singular in letters by Hand 1 (six tokens) and Hand 2 (one token), more precisely five tokens of *I shall be thankful*, one token of *I shall be glad*, and one of *I shall be obliged to get an order*. According to Lowth's (1762: 59) description of the feature, *shall* used in the first person simply foretells, but this does not apply to the seven examples. While the phrases *I shall be glad* and *I shall be thankful* are fixed deferential expressions with a strong sense of obligation and commitment, the fixed phrase of *I shall be obliged* in this particular case can be interpreted as showing a strong sense of obligation and commitment. *Will* is used by all three hands and mostly occurs in the second and third person (14 in the second person and 10 in the third person), which is associated with foretelling and appropriate in the specific examples. There are four examples of *I will* that are associated with a promise/threat of which *I will assure you* (2 tokens) is in line with the rule, while *I will leave you to judge* (one token) and *I will be obliged to* (one token) are more ambiguous. All in all, when excluding fixed expressions, it may be observed that the writers of Styran's letters seem to have largely adhered to the rule (see Iten 2024). Finally, there is no dialect lexicon to be found in the letters, which is likely linked to the text type. More generally, the findings in this case study show both inter-writer (three hands) and a good amount of intra-writer variation on different linguistic levels. The latter raises the question of the writers' awareness

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of different linguistic norms and/or conventions. As regards the use of long S, i.e. a spelling convention that had gradually started disappearing in print after 1800 (see Auer et al. 2023 for a dedicated study), two of the three hands still used long S (but not consistently). Reflections of spoken language - in the form of H-dropping and H-insertion - can partly be found in the letters written by Hands 1 and 2. H-insertion, which can be interpreted as hypercorrection, may then suggest that two of the writers were aware of rules regarding the pronunciation and spelling of words with initial H (see Auer et al. 2023). Similarly, the application of *will/shall* may be interpreted as an adherence to the rule but then not consistently, particularly when using fixed expressions. The examples show that it is difficult to generalise as every linguistic feature (on different linguistic levels) seems to be used in different ways. The only linguistic level that stands out here is the lexicon, i.e. standard formal lexicon is used but the orthography may still vary.

4.2.2 Linguistic variation in the pauper letters of a Cumbrian couple

The second case study is based on six pauper letters sent by Ann and/or John Thistlethwaite from Ireby to Kirkby Lonsdale (historically in Westmoreland) in Cumbria over the period 1822 to 1825. John Thistlethwaite, a weaver, seems to have written all six letters that were sent to the parish overseers (A 2, i.e. at least two letters by the same applicant and all letters are written by the same authentic hand; LH suggests uncertainty in terms of handwriting, i.e. between low and high handwriting skills). There is mention of a large family including at least one son, one daughter and a brother. The reasons for the applications for out-relief are the need for money and rent due to underemployment, ill health, and an accident.

Late Modern English sources commenting on the language use in Cumberland more specifically are for instance Robert Ferguson's *Dialect of Cumberland* (1873) and William Dickinson's *Glossary of Words and Phrases Pertaining to the Dialect of Cumberland* (1878), as well as Joseph Wright's *English Dialect Dictionary* (1898–1905) (see Gardner et al. 2023: 62–63 for a discussion of Cumbrian dialect features). In fact, one linguistic feature in Thistlethwaite's letters that is also mentioned in Dickinson's (1878: vi) work is the absence of terminative *-ing* in words of more than one syllable and its substitution by *-in* or *-an* (*-ing* is retained in monosyllabic words), notably *ronen* for *running*, *farden* for *farthing*, *doen* for *doing*, *meten(s)* for *meeting(s)*, *Clothen* for *clothing*, *akorden* for *according*, *geten* for *getting*, *nothen* for *nothing*, *hopen* for *hoping*, *poten* for *putting*, *maken* for *making*, *leaven* for *leaving*, *boilen* for *boiling*. The only exception in the letters

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Table 5: Letters written by the applicants Ann and/or John Thistlethwaite

File name	Date	Applicant	Authenticity / Hand	Word count (excl. address and additions in different hands)
WES_1822_- 003	1822 07 XX	Ann Thistlethwaite	A 2 / LH	295
WES_1824_- 004	1824 03 25	Ann and John Thistlethwaite	A 2 / LH	641
WES_1824_- 005	1824 05 06	John Thistlethwaite	A 2 / LH	254
WES_1824_- 006	1824 05 31	John Thistlethwaite	A 2 / LH	196
WES_1825_- 002	1825 02 20	John Thistlethwaite	A 2 / LH	915
WES_1825_- 006	1825 XX 03	John Thistlethwaite	A 2 / LH	157
				2458 TOTAL

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is the single use of the word *sendeing* for *sending*, as the only other examples are monosyllabic *thing*. Other examples of phonetic spelling concern the conjunction *but*, which is consistently spelled as *bot* (38 tokens in total), as well as *trust* as *trost* as is in *trostad* ‘trusted’, the past participle use of *put* as *pot* (five tokens in total, of which two as phrasal verb *put off*), and the reflection of the FOOT-type vowel in *sum* for *some* (11 tokens in total as opposed to two tokens of *som*; see Section 4.1. for the larger case study). The consistent use of *pad* for *paid* (three tokens in total) suggests monophthongisation. Interestingly, the only other context in these letters where monophthongal realisations were an option was in the family name *Thistlethwaite*. In all cases, the *ai* was retained. It remains unclear whether the Thistlethwaites would have kept the diphthong in the pronunciation of their last name or whether they monophthongised it in their pronunciation but retained the diphthong in the spelling. Final *y* in words ending in a monophthong is mostly written as *e*, e.g., *famle* for *family* (15 tokens in total) and *ane* for *any* (22 tokens in total, also in combination with *thing* or *where* but written separately). The only exceptions for this were in the token *Badley*, where an *e* had been inserted but the *y* had not been dropped, as well as in six tokens of the variant *vrey* (for *very*). In two other cases, the token *vre* was used instead. While selected features identified as being found in specific Northern counties are contained in the Thistlethwaite letters, many Northern features cannot be found at all while some features are more general speech reflections. The letters do not contain dialect lexicon. The close investigation of the letters leads to the conclusion that the writer was not concerned with linguistic norms and/or stigmatised linguistic features and that he instead tried to get the message across with whatever means of writing skills he had. The limited training in writing received, i.e. according to orthographic and grammatical norms, allows us to gain insight into John Thistlethwaite’s spoken language use. As with the Styran letters, the lexical level appears to adhere to standard norms, i.e. which may have to do with the content and formality of the letters (they may not have invited local or regional lexical uses). Phonetic spelling that reflects regional pronunciation is given in Thistlethwaite’s letters, but not always consistently so. On an orthographic level, there is thus deviation from the standard norms. As for the syntactic level, the lack of punctuation in the pauper letters prevents us from carrying out systematic syntactic analyses.

All case studies in this paper show a deviation from standard norms at some linguistic level, which is not surprising given the limited grammatical schooling that the labouring poor received before the introduction of elementary compulsory education in 1880 (see also Auer et al. 2024). While syntax is difficult to study (see above), most variation can be found on the orthographic level, at times

revealing an influence of spoken language. While some examples can be interpreted as Northern features, that was not the case for all letters investigated. The question then arises how a lack of regional variants in writing, i.e. in terms of phonetic spelling, lexicon, or morphology, can be interpreted, i.e. was the writer aware of normative rules and therefore adhered to them (which may be taken as a reflection of more input in terms of education). Also, did a certain level of awareness of standard-regional differences lead the writer to choose the standard lexicon over a regional one? While we can only guess about the exact reflection processes of the writers of pauper letters, the systematic investigation of the language in the pauper letters and comparisons within letters as well as across letters (across the country) do allow us to gain a better understanding of the interaction with the standard, e.g., through incidental self-corrections and hyper-corrections. But also systematic spelling choices (that differ from choices made in other counties) can help us understand better what standard-related models the writers may have been aware of. As education before 1880 varied greatly and every writer had received somewhat different training and had a different writing experience, systematic investigations of autograph letters (if known) in our corpus are the most fruitful ones. They allow us to determine certain writing patterns (with regard to different linguistic features) and therefore also allow for a better reconstruction of the relationship to the written norm.

5 Concluding discussion

It was the aim of this study to investigate Northern English pauper letters within the context of language standardisation processes. To do so, first, selected contemporary grammars, dictionaries, and manuals, were discussed with regard to linguistic strictures and possible associations with geographical and/or social variation. Even though not all too many contemporary works contain comments about Northern English language use, some of them do contain clear attitudes towards social and regional variation. Then, linguistic investigations were carried out based on samples of pauper letters written in the North of England during the period c. 1795–1834. The first case study of the FOOT-STRUT split in all Northern English pauper letters shows that c. 11% of the variable context of the STRUT lexical set were realised with spellings that are compatible with the FOOT-type vowel. Interestingly, some of these realisations can be attributed to specific paupers and/or they tend to occur in specific words, e.g., *trouble* and *some*. While spellings such as <trub-> or <sum> are compatible with FOOT-like realisations, this cannot be taken as direct evidence for such a pronunciation; they could be a result of analogical spelling or generalised orthographic simplification. Having said

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that, while individual tokens are ambiguous, their distributional patterning, e.g. higher frequency in Northern data or clustering within individual writers, can be taken as an indication that spelling variation could also reflect actual pronunciation. The case studies linked to individual paupers, notably one from Yorkshire and the other from Cumberland, revealed that the non-authentic Yorkshire data, i.e. letters written by three hands, contained fewer Northern features than the authentic Cumberland data. Generally, it is striking that many of the features are not contained in the pauper letters at all. In these cases it would be tempting to attribute the lack of Northern features to a conscious interaction with Southern Standard English norms. However, it remains difficult to determine if the adherence to linguistic norms, e.g., *will/shall* in the Styran letters, and/or the lack of ‘non-standard’ and dialectal features, e.g., the reflection of the FOOT-STRUT split in the Styran letters, is due to an awareness of linguistic norms or the stigmatisation of linguistic features, higher literacy levels and writing training and experience, or the fact that certain linguistic features were not used in the region by the respective speakers. Despite this challenge in terms of findings and interpretation, the pauper letter data is valuable in that it complements other Late Modern English text types by providing a perspective ‘from below’ and it can validate contemporary meta-linguistic comments by way of empirical evidence.

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Chapter 7

Tracing the influence of prescriptive advice in the writings of Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald (1762–1841)

Nora Dörnbrack

This chapter discusses the Scottish emigrant Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald's (1762–1841) interactions with the standard of written English. An investigation of metalinguistic comments, irregular preterite forms, the use of -'d for -ED verb forms and her use of first person singular *shall* reveals that Archbald actively engaged with contemporary norms to highlight certain parts of her identity and to project a polite writing style in line with contemporary practice.

1 Introduction

In his study on the epistolary practices of nineteenth-century British migrants to Canada, Dollinger (2019: 62) notes that “[w]e should not be disappointed that the bulk of the data is considerably influenced by standard language ideology and writing conventions that harness that ideology”. The present chapter aims to show that, far from being a disappointment, an investigation into an individual's interactions with the standard presents a fruitful research endeavour.

The present chapter sheds light on the question of how codified norm(s) of written English were adopted on the individual level during the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, more precisely how this process can be observed in the private writings of Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald (1762–1841, henceforth ‘Archbald’). The received literature so far focuses for the most part on either the origins of the standard of written English (see, for example, Nevalainen 2000,

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Wright 2000, 2020, 2021, Stenroos 2021), or its distribution in the form of grammar books, usage guides and dictionaries (see, for example, Ostade 2008, Anderwald 2016). Even though studies exist which focus on the use of those grammars and usage guides, they usually follow a quantitative approach which determines whether a given rule was adhered to or not by larger swaths of the English-writing population (for example Anderwald 2016). The works of Ostade (1994), Kielkiewicz-Janowiak (2003) and Navest (2010) offer examples of studies which focus on individual writers and women in particular, but this has not been done for female Scottish writers. In contrast, the present chapter examines how one individual writer on the micro-level relates to the norms that were codified in contemporary grammars and usage guides on the macro-level. In conducting such a qualitative analysis which explores the links between the micro- and the macro-level, the present study contributes to what Moreton (2016: 322) phrases as follows:

[T]he overarching question is not so much about whether to focus on the individual or the collective (since both approaches offer valuable new insights), it is more to do with how to reconcile the individual with the general; the fragments with the whole (Lyons 2010: 14). In other words, how can the voices of individual migrants be understood within their broader historical context, thereby giving ‘a human dimension to significant historical issues’? (Lyons 2010: 18).

The present chapter thereby contributes to three of this volume’s overarching thematic objectives. First, the case of Archbald adds to the present volume’s aim to investigate how intra-individual variation with regard to the use of regional and variant forms can manifest on the micro-level. Second, by investigating the use of variant forms in Archbald’s journals and letter books - two less commonly studied text types - the present chapter adds further depth to the volume’s objective to explore different types of text that are suitable to shed light on interactions with the standard. Third, the present study includes a discussion of metalinguistic comments in the material, thereby highlighting the volume’s emphasis on the importance of taking metalinguistic comments into account when researching interactions with the standard.

The chapter is structured as follows: Section 2 provides background information on contemporary linguistic debates with a special focus on Scotland and an overview of the most important events in Archbald’s life. In Section 3 the corpus which was employed for the current study as well as the methodological approach are introduced. Section 4 outlines the metalinguistic commentary

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that can be found in the corpus as it relates to Archbald's viewpoint on issues of standardisation. In Section 5, I analyse three features of Archbald's writing more closely, namely irregular preterite forms, first person singular *shall*, and -'d as an ending for -ED verb forms. Section 6 provides a discussion and Section 7 concludes the chapter.

2 Background

2.1 Contemporary linguistic debates

During the latter half of the eighteenth century, linguistic debates in Scotland took on a new “intensity almost unequalled in any other part of the United Kingdom” (Jones 1994: 71). Grammars and usage guides were distributed all over the country in record numbers (Beal 2004: 90), and lists of Scotticisms appeared in print (Dossena 2019: 29). Standardisation efforts in Scotland were the result of the ongoing anglicization of Scots – a movement which started to gain traction after the Union of the Crowns in 1603 when Scots was deemed insufficient in formal and public contexts and which intensified with full force during the eighteenth century (Dossena 2003: 389).¹

The following excerpt from contemporary debates exemplifies the tone often encountered in those debates. In 1761, the *Select Society for Promoting the Reading and Speaking of the English Language in Scotland*, a debating club based in Edinburgh, issued a statement in the *Scots Magazine* outlining their effort to ‘improve’ the current language use in Scotland:

AS the intercourse between this part of Great Britain and the capital daily increases, both on account of business and amusement, and must still go on increasing, gentlemen educated in Scotland have long been sensible of the disadvantages under which they labour, from their imperfect knowledge of the ENGLISH TOUNGE, and the impropriety with which they speak it. (Regulations of the Select Society, 1761, p. 440)

In this opening paragraph, the *Select Society* labels an education in Scotland as “a disadvantage” and equates it with “imperfect knowledge” of English and a certain “impropriety” in speaking it compared to southern usage. Statements such as those outlined above are couched within the ideology of standardisation,

¹I direct the reader to Jones (1993, 2010), McClure (1994) and Millar (2020) in particular for a selection of excellent works on the development of Scots, Scottish English and efforts to anglicise varieties spoken in Scotland.

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i.e. that there is a norm which shall apply to every speaker and writer alike, and that this norm, in the case of written English, can be found south of the Scottish border. Despite the idea that one norm should apply to everyone, there was not one norm-giving language academy which would issue an authoritative version of written English. As a result, individual grammarians stood for the bulk of linguistic advice which was available. Examples of grammars and usage guides which were directed at a Scottish audience in particular include Beattie (1779), Sinclair (1782) and Mitchell (1799). Once Archbald had crossed the Atlantic, she might even have had access to American grammars, such as Bingham (1791), Humphreys (1792) or Webster (1828, 1831).

The above quote further highlights the notion of polite language use. Initially, polite language use was associated with the ways in which people of higher social standing, especially in urban areas, conducted their conversations (Stein 1994: 8). As such, polite language use was something to *look up to*. However, this perception began to change, and soon people *looked down upon* those who did not follow the rules of ‘correct’ language use (Stein 1994: 8). Accordingly, adherence to the norm became increasingly important for the socially aspiring who sought to better their social standing. In particular, terms like “elegant, polite, refined, [and] cultivated” (Hickey 2010: 17) were used to describe forms that were considered appropriate, while expressions like *affected*, *ignorant*, *inelegant*, *uneducated*, and *vulgar* (Hickey 2010: 17; Nevalainen 2003: 144) were employed to advise against the use of variant forms.

2.2 Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald’s life

Mary Ann Wodrow was born in 1762 to Reverend Robert Wodrow and his second wife Ann Wodrow, née Ruthven (Scott 1995: 29). Though her exact birthplace is difficult to establish, according to her own accounts Archbald spent her childhood and early adulthood on the island of Little Cumbrae, located in the Firth of Clyde on Scotland’s west coast. Judging by two letter book entries, Archbald was in all likelihood educated at home and did not receive any kind of formal schooling. She later described her upbringing in the following terms:

- (1) my youth, indeed my whole life, has been spent in almost intir[e] solitude on a small rocky Island off the west coast of scotland, unslaved by the forms of the world & having the command of my time I was early taught indus[try] & independance, the scenes of natur[e] were a perpetual source of enjoymen[t]

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(SSC-MS-00006: letter book 2, Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald to Robert R. Livingston, 1810. Letters in square brackets were added by the author in places where the microfilm was cut off.)

This self-reported isolation from much of the outside world necessitated a considerable letter-exchange with friends and relatives who resided on the mainland. In 1784, Archbald started to copy excerpts of outgoing letters into a letter book. A year later, in 1785, she started to keep a journal from which it becomes clear that she was engaged to the seafaring Mr McKay. This first engagement, however, was broken in favour of another suitor, the sheep farmer and tacksman James Archbald, whom she married on 4 August 1789. Together, James and Mary Ann Archbald had ten children of whom only four survived infancy. Shortly before the birth of their last child, the rent of their farm was increased to such a degree that the family began to look for farms on the adjoining islands and the mainland. In the end, emigration to America appeared the best option to ensure their children's future prosperity, and the family embarked for New York in the spring of 1807. After moving once, the family permanently settled on a farm which they called 'Riverbank', probably close to Auriesville, in New York State.

Throughout her life, Archbald was an ardent reader with a broad range of subjects eliciting her interest. In combination with the fact that she belonged to a prominent family of church historians and kept regular letter exchanges with her friends and family on the mainland, it might be expected that Archbald was exposed to a fair amount of writing in both print and private handwriting that adhered to both prescriptive and epistolary norms.

In both her letter exchanges and journals, Archbald stated a profound longing to see her homeland once more. However, she never set foot on Scottish soil again and died on her farm in New York in 1807.

3 **Material and method**

The data for the present study consist of Archbald's private ego-documents which are currently available for research.² More precisely, the present corpus includes eight journals, two letter books and six original letters. Especially her journals

²The overwhelming majority of the material, i.e. Archbald's two letter books and eight journals, can be found in the Sophia Smith Collection, Smith College. Two additional original letters are stored in the Coolidge Collection of Thomas Jefferson Manuscripts, Massachusetts Historical Society, and four additional original letters are part of the James Archbald Papers, Lackawanna Historical Society Library.

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and letter books – the latter of which were used to make copies of outgoing letters – are noteworthy since they represent two text types that are less commonly found in corpora exploring historical linguistic practices.

Taken together, the material amounts to more than 440,000 words and spans 41 consecutive years in addition to five years towards the end of Archbald's lifetime. The journals and letter books were first transcribed by [Scott \(1995\)](#), who generously shared the resulting transcriptions with the author of the present chapter. A representative selection of Scott's transcriptions has subsequently been checked against digital images of the original manuscripts to ensure linguistic accuracy. The remaining six original letters were transcribed by the author.

As is the case with all naturally occurring data, the material is unevenly distributed both with regard to time and genre. While Archbald in many cases noted the date of her journal entries, she largely omitted this piece of information for her letter book entries, though [Scott \(1995\)](#) offers the conjectured year in her transcriptions. In contrast, Archbald was meticulous in mentioning the recipient of the letters which she copied into her letter book. Approximately half of the excerpts which she copied were sent to family members. Of particular importance in this regard is her cousin Margaret Wodrow, who received roughly two-thirds of all letters sent to family members prior to migration. Even though this proportion drops to a third in Archbald's second letter book, higher postage and fewer opportunities to send letters across the Atlantic might account for this change. Another important group of addressees consists of friends and close acquaintances to whom Archbald sent a great number of letters while residing in Scotland, but only few following her migration. Interestingly, her second letter book contains a handful of letters in which she petitioned her social superiors, among others President Thomas Jefferson, the governor of New York State DeWitt Clinton, and the first Chancellor of New York Robert R. Livingston, with varying degrees of success. While she never received an answer from the president, governor Clinton even passed a law in which the Archbald children are mentioned by name ([Scott 1995: 56](#)).

The time prior to the birth of Archbald's first child in 1790 amounts to her most productive period. During those initial years, Archbald made very comprehensive entries into her journal, while the excerpts that she copied into her letter book are shorter in comparison. As Archbald's children arrived over the years, the time she spent making entries in her journal and letter books decreased, though she continued to keep both until the year of her migration. Upon leaving Scotland in 1807, Archbald discontinued her journal, though her letter books remained in use and run continuously until 1825. From 1826 onwards, a thirteen-year long gap exists in the material, which is only bridged by four original let-

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ters to her son James Archbald. The final part of the present corpus consists of Archbald’s eighth journal which she started in 1839. This captures her declining health and the ways in which she spent the few remaining years of her life. Figure 1 shows the number of words per text type over time.

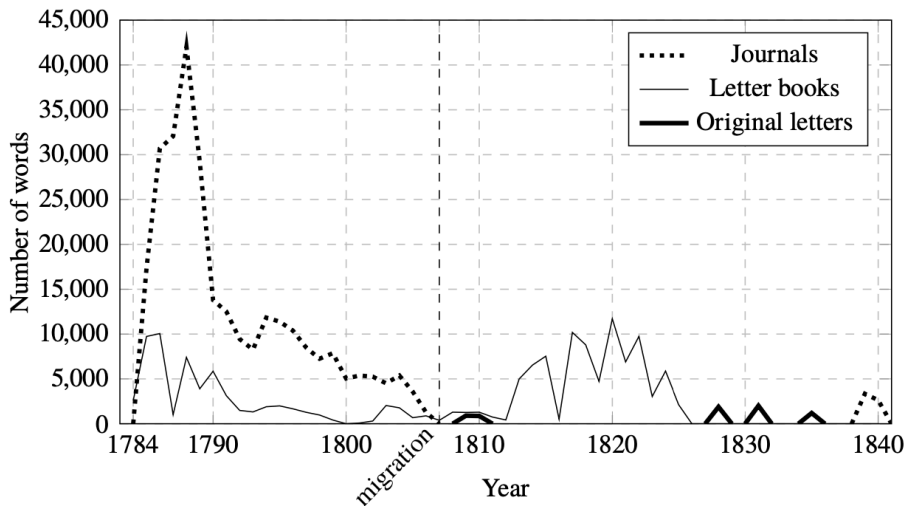


Figure 1: Number of words per text type per year

The fact that the data is distributed unevenly across time and genre is unsurprising given this is naturally occurring data. In the case of Archbald, she may have had a preference for keeping a journal at one point in her life, but preferred her letter books as time progressed. Furthermore, important life events, such as the birth and death of her children, impacted the energy she was able and willing to dedicate to her private journal keeping. In consequence, the quantitative results were analysed qualitatively and interpretatively, using absolute frequencies when possible.

It is furthermore important to note that I read the entirety of Archbald’s journals and letter books in order to gain insights into important life events, her reading and writing habits as well as her social network on both sides of the Atlantic. In addition, I discovered a number of metalinguistic comments in the material which will be further discussed in Section 4, as they exemplify how Archbald related to ongoing, contemporary discussions of polite language use.

For the quantitative analysis, the corpus analysis tool AntConc (Anthony n.d.) was employed to retrieve occurrences of individual verb forms. Using the concordance function, those results were sorted alphabetically or according to the

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surrounding linguistic context. Afterwards, I completed a manual assessment of the results and sorted out any occurrences which did not match the specific feature I was investigating, e.g. I would discard all past participle forms of a verb when investigating the preterite form. The subsequent results were transferred to an Excel sheet where they were organised and processed according to the feature under investigation, time of occurrence, and text type. The patterns of variation were then visualised using LaTeX.

The focus on morphological and morphosyntactic variation was chosen for three reasons. First, the frequency with which contemporary grammarians commented on variation in verb inflection increased the likelihood that Archbald became aware of the norms that grammars and usage guides promoted. Second, morphological variation could be retrieved from a corpus which exists presently without linguistic annotation. Third, variant forms concerning verb inflection appeared more frequently in the material than other types of variation (including lexical and syntactic variation), making a longitudinal analysis of Archbald's interaction with the standard more informative. Finally, I examine Archbald's use of the modal verb *shall* in order to complete the picture of her interaction with the standard.

4 Metalinguistic comments

Metalinguistic comments can shed important light on an individual's interaction with the standard (see [Amador-Moreno 2026 \[this volume\]](#)), and Archbald's metalinguistic comments offer fruitful insights, despite the fact that she seldom comments directly on linguistic matters. Compared to her lengthy discussions on literary and religious subjects, Archbald's lack of enthusiasm when it comes to language norms and usage might be best summed up by a comment from 1819 in which she reported that her daughter had to finish "a dry task in English grammar".³ Despite this apparent disinterest in English grammar, Archbald made entries on the topic of linguistic norms in her journal, concerning her receiving letters from a number of potential suitors. With regard to one such letter, she wrote:

- (2) but the stile was simple if not vulgar & the spelling not good so that for all my partiality I was a little disgusted at the first reading of it & may say that it almost desolved the charm which for some Weeks had pleased my imagination for a man to Write well is an accomplishment which I could

³SSC-MS-00006: letter book 2, February 1819.

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not dispense with - I made no allowances for the disadvantages of Education or for want of Practice - every one cannot Write so freely as they can converse but what is his Writing to me
(SSC-MS-00006: journal 1, 27 November 1785.)

This quote shows that Archbald was aware that some spelling variants were deemed acceptable, while others were not. In judging this particular suitor's spelling as "not good", she must have had a norm in mind which applied to every writer alike. In comparing the suitor's writing with the norm that she envisioned, she found that those two deviated. The mismatch between the suitor's spelling and the norm Archbald had in mind then prompted her to formulate a value judgement. Following her unfavourable assessment of the suitor's spelling practices, Archbald declared that she viewed writing skills as a necessity in any man that she would consider as a future husband, thus appearing to place a strong emphasis on the ability to write according to the codified norm. It is furthermore noteworthy that Archbald described the style of the letter as "vulgar", a common descriptor used in eighteenth-century discussions on polite writing practices (cf. Hickey 2010: 17), indicating that she was aware of contemporary discussions surrounding language use.

Another metalinguistic comment concerns a passage found in Archbald's journal on the receipt of a packet from her cousin Margaret Wodrow.

- (3) this evening I recd the Box from PW with a long letter Mr Buchanans Writing made easy (in which I a[m] a little disapointed it being a very thi[n] quarto consisting of some printed direc[tions] & a few elegant specimins & c -)
(SSC-MS-00006: journal 6, 30 September 1797.)

unclear
example
numbers

The publication *Writing Made Easy* (1797), which Archbald referenced above, concerns the practical side of letter writing, including directions for how to sharpen a pen and how to produce your own ink, as well as a select number of example letters. The fact that Archbald acquired a publication on the subject of letter writing is in itself revealing. In the absence of a language academy, writers had to purchase publications by individual grammarians in order to receive guidance on the written norm. Against this background, Archbald's acquisition of *Writing Made Easy* is significant, as it points to the possibility that Archbald sought out other publications as well in order to retain and improve a polite writing style.

Further, Archbald's disappointment with the work in question becomes tangible when she uses the intensifier *very* in "a very thi[n] quarto" as well as the

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quantifiers *some* and *few* in “some printed direc[tions] & a few elegant specimens”, all of which would suggest that she expected a more comprehensive guide which contained a greater number of directions and examples. This passage likewise reveals that Archbald had indeed a preformed idea about the comprehensiveness and content of a publication entitled *Writing Made Easy*. Unfortunately, the material offers no further clues what other publications Archbald might have consulted in either Scotland or America.

The emphasis which Archbald placed on the writing skills of a prospective husband in combination with the acquisition of a guide on writing indicates that Archbald was aware of contemporary polite epistolary practices. The following sections will explore how Archbald’s own writing practices related to the codified norms of her time.

5 Variation in verbal inflection over time

5.1 Irregular preterite forms

Irregular preterite forms in Archbald’s writings have been discussed previously in Dörnbrack (2023). However, recent findings offer a more nuanced picture of her use of irregular preterite forms and they are therefore included in the present analysis. Language guides such as those of Beattie (1779), Sinclair (1782) and Mitchell (1799), all three of which were aimed at a Scottish audience in particular, list individual preterite forms either alphabetically throughout the entire work or in no discernible order. Typically, the proscribed form is given alongside the prescribed one with no additional rule or elaboration on the forms concerned. The piecemeal way in which individual grammars and usage guides deal with irregular preterite forms makes it more difficult for potential readers like Archbald to use the prescribed irregular preterite forms systematically.

Examples of irregular preterite forms which can be found in Archbald’s writings include instances of *kept* and *slept* instead of the prescribed forms *kept* and *slept*, as well as instances of *catched* and *cought* for the prescribed form *caught* (cf. Dörnbrack 2023: 305–307). Especially the preterite forms of *keep* are numerous enough to warrant a closer analysis, and since the results have first been discussed in Dörnbrack (2023: 306), new forms have been detected in the material. Figure 2 illustrates these findings.

As can be seen in Figure 2, Archbald used a total of three variant forms in addition to the prescribed form. The three variant forms *kept*, *keapt* and *keipt* appear during the first four years of her writing, before Archbald discontinued

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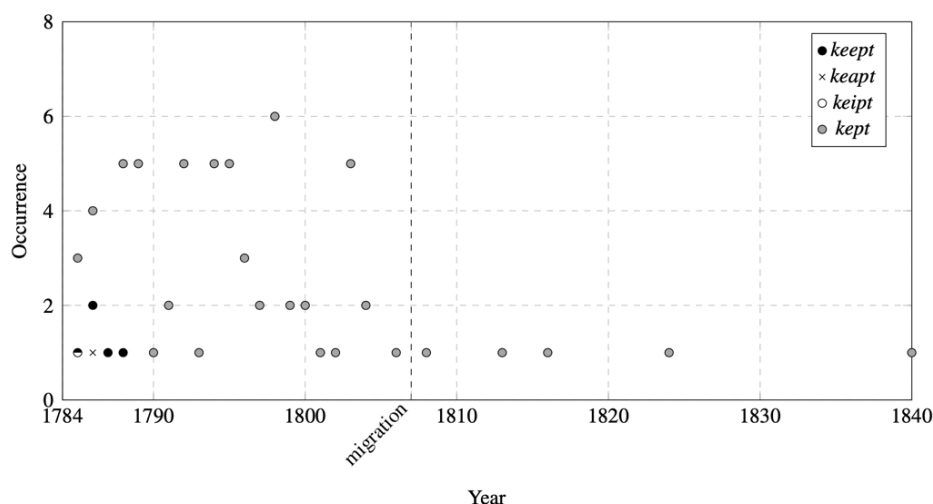


Figure 2: Preterite forms of KEEP (N=71)

to use all three variant forms. Throughout the time period under investigation, the prescribed form *kept* was Archbald's preferred form.

The pattern mentioned above, where Archbald used variant forms alongside prescribed forms during the early years of writing before abandoning the variant forms eventually, can likewise be observed in the preterite forms of *bid* (Figure 3). Today, the OED (2024, sv. *bid*, v1.) lists *bade*, *bad* and *bid* as possible preterite forms, though different forms might be preferred for different senses of the verb. Mitchell (1799: 22), the only grammarian to notice this particular preterite form among the selection of grammars and usage guides investigated for this study, advised readers to employ the form *bade* on a general basis.

Figure 3 shows that Archbald used both the variant form *bid* as well as *bad* and *bade* as preterite forms. In accordance with the pattern observed in the case of *keep*, Archbald made use of the variant forms only during the first few years of her writing, that is until 1790, before the prescribed form takes over completely. However, it is not the form *bade*, spelled according to prescriptive advice, which occurs most prominently in Archbald's writing, but instead a variant form spelled *bad*. Interestingly, Elswiler (2026 [this volume]) found that Scottish women would regularly omit final *-e* in words like *not* 'note' and *don* 'done' as part of their epistolary practice during the time period 1650–1750. Archbald's use of both *bad* and *bade* in favour of the variant form *bid* might thus indicate conflicting norms - reflecting awareness of the codified norm, but also signaling her

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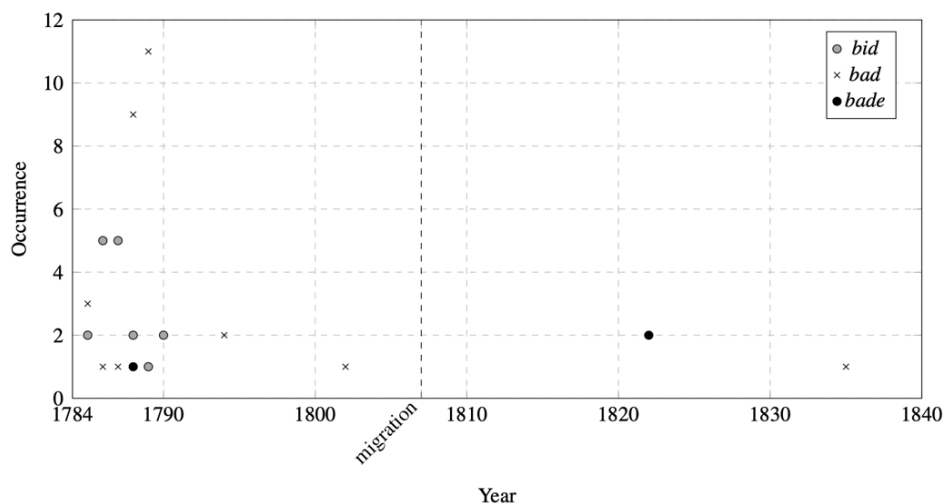


Figure 3: Preterite forms of BID (N=50)

alignment with the epistolary practice of omitting final *-e* in eighteenth-century Scotland.

The present case exemplifies one of the main difficulties in researching morphological variation in this data, namely the fact that the material becomes sparse towards the later years of Archbald's writings. The likelihood to detect any irregular preterite form decreases significantly as a result. In the case of *bid*, only six individual forms could be detected for the forty-nine year period between 1791 and 1840.

Nonetheless, this indicates a possible way Archbald interacted with the standard with regard to irregular preterite forms, where she initially used several competing forms alongside each other, before eventually settling on the prescribed form.

5.2 -ED verb forms: the case of *-'d*

Archbald's relationship to the emerging norm of written English can be further illuminated by looking at her use of -ED verb forms, in particular *-'d* in both preterite and past participle forms. Following Gustafsson (2002: 18), the term -ED, spelled with capitals, is henceforth used to refer to the whole group of spelling variants, namely *-ed*, *-'d*, *-d*, *-t*, and *-'t*, whereas the italicised *-ed* refers to the fully spelled variant.

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Gustafsson (2002) investigated the use of -ED verb forms in English private writing from 1760 to 1790, and concluded that *-ed* was the preferred variant in 76% of all cases, with *-’d* (18%) and *-d* (5%) still being in use, while *-t* and *-’t* were effectively absent from the preterite and past participle forms in her material (Gustafsson 2002: 94). Further, she noted that writers born between 1733 and 1752, which comprise the younger generation in her corpus, employed close to no variant forms, while older writers spelled -ED verb forms according to idiolectal patterns (Gustafsson 2002: 116–117). Some of the variation found in her dataset could be explained with “daily exposure to certain varieties of printing and spelling styles” (Gustafsson 2002: 123), while the writer’s gender did not seem to influence the results.

There is one set of verbs of particular interest which receives *-’d* as an ending in Archbald’s writings, namely *comply*, *enjoy* and *envy*. The spelling of the -ED form of verbs ending in *-y* depends on the preceding segment: in a case like *comply*, where *-y* is preceded by a consonant, *-y* is changed to *-i* which results in the form *complied*. However, in cases where *-y* is preceded by a vowel, it remains in place unchanged, so that the resulting form is *enjoyed*. In Archbald’s writings, we find the forms *complied*, *complied* and *comply’d* as well as *enjoyed*, *enjoied* and *enjoy’d*. Of those, the form ending in *-’d* occurs only once for each form, while forms ending in *-ed* appear more frequently, as can be seen in Figures 4 and 5.

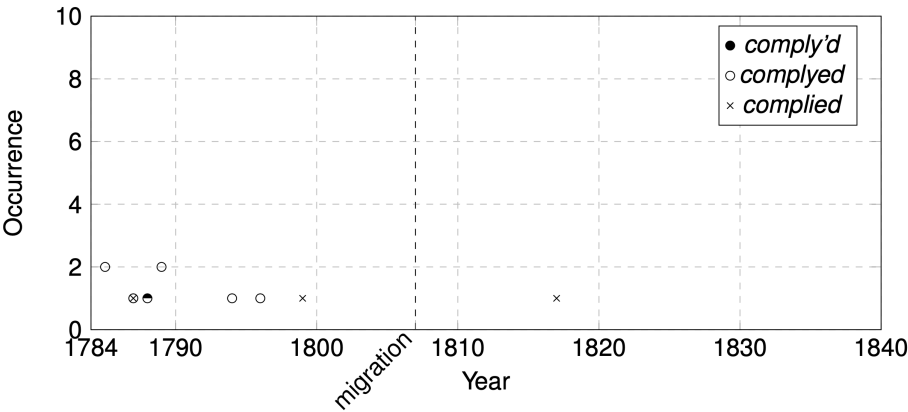


Figure 4: -ED verb forms of COMPLY (N=12)

Judging from the presence of three different forms in those cases, it seems reasonable to assume that Archbald was aware of the fact that *-y* had to be changed

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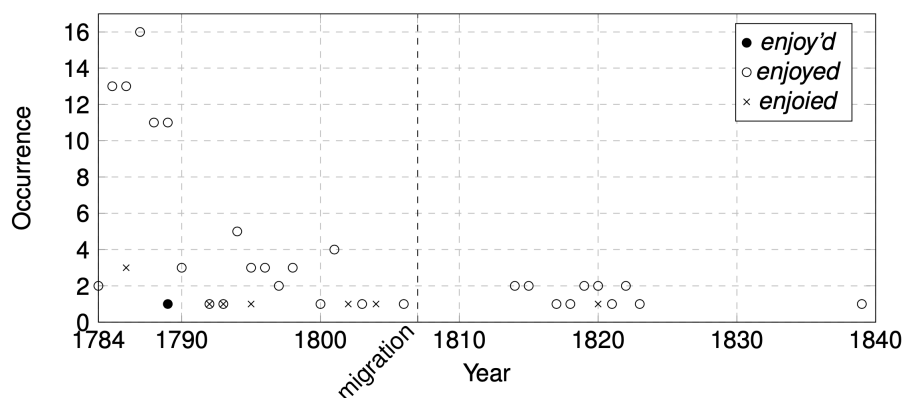


Figure 5: -ED verb forms of ENJOY (N=119)

to -i in some cases, though she might have been unsure when a change should take place. Using -'d instead seemed to have unburdened Archbald of the necessity to decide whether -y had to be replaced with -i or not. Her use of a form which was common in contemporary private writing practices and not explicitly proscribed by contemporary grammarians thus again suggests interaction with the standard, in which Archbald seems to have been aware of the prescribed form but unsure how to use it. In the case of *enjoyed*, however, she seems to have settled on the dominant variant later in life.

5.3 First person singular *shall*

Another way of engaging with the emerging norm can be found in Archbald's use of first person singular *shall*. According to contemporary grammars (see, for example, Beattie 1779: 29–30; Sinclair 1782: 72–75; Mitchell 1799: 71–72), first person *shall* was to be used to express prediction, while first person *will* denoted volition, and not, as was common in Scotland, the other way around. Sinclair (1782: 73–74) included an illustrative story to emphasise the importance of this distinction:

[A] story is told of a Scotsman, who having fallen into a river in England, had almost perished in it, in consequence of his calling out I will, for I shall be drowned; the spectators having for some time hesitated, whether they should venture their own lives for the safety of one, who, as they were led to imagine, was determined to make away with himself. (Italics in the original)

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Sinclair (1782: 72, italics in the original) adds that “[t]he principle error of the Scots [. . .] originates from supposing shall more emphatical and expressive in the first persons singular and plural, than will”. Most of the contemporary grammars surveyed for this study focus on the use of *shall* and *will* along the lines of futurity, in particular with regard to volition and prediction, while other factors influencing the use of those two modal verbs, for example extra-linguistic features such as the social rank of the writer and the recipient, were not mentioned.

In order to investigate Archbald’s use of first person singular *shall*, I first calculated the relative frequency of *I shall* per 1,000 words according to text type throughout the entire corpus. The result is visualised in Figure 6 below.

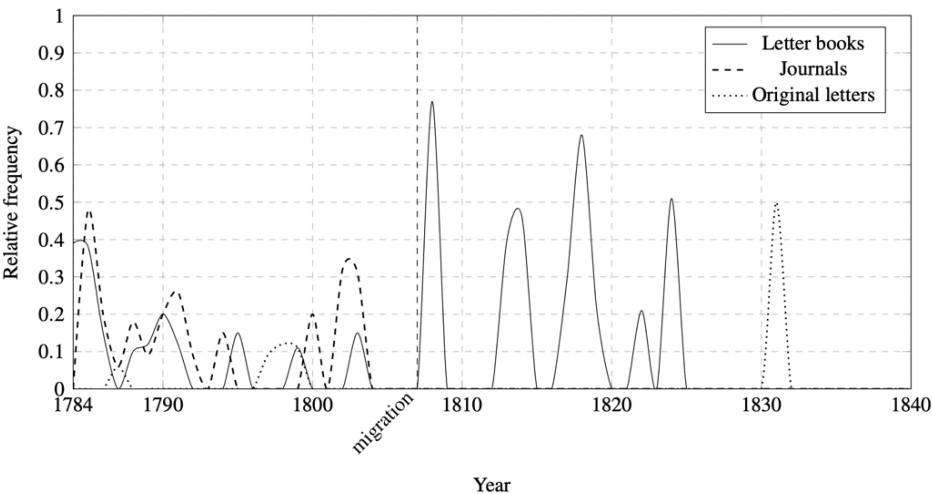


Figure 6: Relative frequency of *I shall* per 1,000 words

As can be seen from Figure 6, Archbald used *I shall* evenly across all three text types prior to her migration in 1807. However, the use of *I shall* markedly increased following her migration, especially during the time period 1808 to 1824, in her letter books.

A closer look at Archbald’s use of *I shall* in her letter books from 1807 onwards reveals that *I shall* is used in 10 out of 21 instances (48%) with reference to her ties to Scotland. In contrast, only 12 out of 67 occurrences (18%) of *I will* are used with reference to Scotland, highlighting Archbald’s preference for *I shall* rather than *I will* in those circumstances.

- (4) I cannot bear to let my self think even for a moment that *I shall* never again behold my native country –

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(SSC-MS-00006: letter book 2, Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald to Margaret Wodrow, June, presumably 12 June 1818.)

- (5) hey ho! *I shall* never forget the chearful hogmeney evenings I have spent at Stivenston.

(SSC-MS-00006: letter book 2, Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald to Margaret Wodrow, 31 December 1818.)

- (6) “I write this from Miss Bryces back room” O how these words struck me. *shall I* ever again see that good kind friend. it would of itself be worth recrossing the Atlantic for. I am glad that she is not much altered in her appearance her heart can never alter. I hope *I shall* not find you so altered neither as you seem to suppose.

(SSC-MS-00006: letter book 2, Mary Ann (Wodrow) Archbald presumably to Margaret Wodrow, without date, presumably spring 1817.)

In all three examples above, a locale in Scotland is invoked: First, the country itself as her “native country” (4), then the town of Stevenston where her cousin lived (5), and finally, even more specific, the back room of a friend who resided in Scotland (6). Viewed in the light of Sinclair’s comment that *shall* conveyed a greater emphasis in the minds of Scottish writers, Archbald might have used *I shall* rather than *I will* when invoking her ties to Scotland in order to underscore her continued reverence of her Scottish roots. Further, it explains why the increase happens in her letter books following her migration, as the need to express a continued loyalty to Scotland would be most urgent in correspondence with relatives and friends whom she left behind upon migration. As a result, the loyalty to her homeland overrides Archbald’s desire to follow the codified norms of her time. In deviating from the norm, she prefers a personal stylistic choice over the prescribed variant, thus highlighting a different side of her identity.

6 Discussion

The metalinguistic comments discussed in Section 4 show that Archbald did place emphasis on both her own writing practices by acquiring a usage guide by Buchanan (1797) and on the subpar writing skills of her suitors. It thus seems that Archbald was aware of the contemporary norm(s) of written English, and that she placed emphasis on the adherence to that norm both in herself and others.

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Subsequently, the investigation of irregular preterite forms, -'d in -ED verb forms and first person singular *shall* shows three distinct interactions with the standard.

First, Archbald's use of irregular preterite forms shows that she sought to align her writing with contemporary norms of written English. New results show that Archbald used the standard preterite form *kept* in addition to a total of three variant forms during the earlier years of her writing, all of which were eventually abandoned in favour of the prescribed form. The same trajectory has been found in the case of *bid*, as well as with regard to levelled past participle forms, especially the past participle form of the lexical verb *write* which has been discussed in Dörnbrack (2023: 302–305). The first trend thus shows greater alignment with the codified norm over time. Interestingly, in those cases where Archbald aligned her writing to the norms of her time, the switch to prescribed variants happened prior to her migration to America. This suggests that her emigration in itself did not contribute as the deciding factor. Rather, it seems likely that she made an effort to educate herself on the written norms, as was the case when she ordered *Writing made easy* by Buchanan (1797). Since there was no overarching academy that issued authoritative norms, Archbald would have to make an effort to receive such guidance from individual grammarians. The fact that she sought out *Writing made easy* and that this particular work did not live up to her expectations, suggests that she might have acquired similar works. Furthermore, her continued interest in contemporary literature presented her with a standardised body of text, as Gustafsson (2002: 259) found that «[n]ormally, this period [1760–1790] was characterised by the absence of variation in prose works”. Being exposed to a large number of texts which were largely uniform in spelling, might have contributed to her own writing practices in this regard.

Second, another way Archbald interacted with the codified norm emerged in the analysis of -'d as an ending for -ED verb forms ending in -y. Archbald seems to have been aware of the fact that final -y had to be changed to -i in some instances when adding the -ed ending to the stem, but she seems to have been unsure when exactly this was supposed to be the case. The ending -'d, which was in contemporary use in epistolary writing (c.f. Gustafsson 2002: 94), seems to have been a way to circumvent this decision. Archbald thus made use of a form which was present in contemporary polite epistolary practice, while at the same time not actively violating the codified norms. A similar example of such a practice is the omission of final -e in the preterite form *bad*. Archbald might have been uncertain which preterite form was prescribed by contemporary grammarians since only a single grammar of those investigated stated a preference, which

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in turn made it less likely that Archbald received direct guidance on this particular form. In contrast, *bad* is in alignment with contemporary epistolary practices in Scotland and might thus have been a reasonable alternative in the absence of any other advice. This second pattern, then, represents a rather creative solution on Archbald's part, in which she makes use of contemporary epistolary patterns in order to navigate uncertainty regarding the standard. As such, it presents us with yet another way in which writers were able to interact with the standard.

Thirdly, the investigation of Archbald's use of first person singular *shall* has shown the reverse pattern, that is a greater deviance from the norm. More specifically, Archbald's use of *I shall* increases only following her migration, and a closer analysis of those occurrences revealed that *I shall* is closely tied to references to Scotland. Following Sinclair (1782: 72), who postulates that first person singular *shall* carries a greater forcefulness than *will* in the minds of Scottish speakers and writers, it might be presumed that Archbald wished to highlight her continued loyalty to her homeland as well as her strong reverence for her friends and family members back home. Further, it might be argued that her use of *I shall* served as a bridge in the struggle to unite two opposing sides of her identity – on the one hand, the young woman who grew up on a small island in Scotland surrounded by close friends and immediate family, and on the other hand, the grown woman who had traded those roots for a farm in rural America, permanently separated from her homeland. Employing a form that was tied to the Scottish part of her identity at a time when she was unable to cross the Atlantic once more to return in person, might have helped her to reconcile those two conflicting sides of her identity. It was precisely because the standard postulated a different usage that she was able to highlight her loyalty to Scotland in opposition to the English norm. As part of the larger discussion around interactions with the standard addressed in this volume, it is worth contemplating whether Archbald perceived a difference between contemporary epistolary practice on the one hand and codified norms on the other, or whether the lines between them were blurred. Archbald never commented on the difference directly. However, A. Scott (1995: 17) found that Archbald and her cousins “set themselves topics for discussion with the explicit intention of improving their epistolary and social skills.” In addition, Archbald's heightened awareness of the lack of writing skills in potential suitors suggests that she was indeed aware of the fact that not all writing practices were equally desirable, and that both one's own writing style and that of others could be improved upon through practice as well as with the help of printed usage guides. In instances in which she was unsure which variant form was expected, either because prescriptive advice was lacking in general or because it was unavailable to her specifically, it seems that she took her lead

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from contemporary practices as the second best source for a polite writing style. Her use of -'d as well as the preterite form *bad* in line with contemporary norms testify to this preference. Presumably, Archbald sought out printed advice on the prescribed norms of her time, while she incorporated contemporary epistolary practices in her own writing at the same time, thus positioning herself as a polite letter writer within her community.

7 Conclusion

The present analysis of Archbald's interaction with the codified norm of written English revealed that the process surpasses the simple dichotomy of adopting or rejecting standard forms.

The trajectory most commonly found in the material can be summarised as a preference for prescribed forms over time. However, this picture is more nuanced, as the adoption of a prescribed form is usually preceded by a period in which both variant forms and the prescribed form are used alongside each other. This was the case for the preterite forms of *keep*, and it has likewise been documented for the past participle form of *write* in Dörnbrack (2023: 303–305). A different trajectory regards Archbald's use of first person singular *shall*, as it shows greater deviation from the norm over time. The change in this regard may be explained with the emphasis which first person *shall* conveyed in Scottish English and which enabled Archbald to highlight her continued loyalty to relatives and friends who were left behind upon migration. As such, the distance to the written norm enables Archbald to express a distinct side of her identity in writing. A final pattern was observed with regard to Archbald's use of -'d for -ED verb forms of verbs which end in -y such as *comply* and *enjoy*. Uncertain when to change final -y to -i upon adding -ed to the stem of the verb, Archbald employed -'d as a means to circumvent this decision. In doing so, she created a form which was at once aligned with contemporary practice and not in outright opposition to the standard, thus preserving a polite writing style.

The present chapter adds new insight into the standardisation of written English – a process which has hitherto been explored with regard to its origins and distribution in a wide range of studies, but where the actual adaptation on the individual level has received less attention. In this regard, this study represents one piece in the larger jigsaw puzzle that is the process of standardisation. This chapter has sought to exemplify that examining an individual's interaction with the standard, far from being a disappointment, as Dollinger (2019: 62) hinted, adds new insights into language use on the micro- and macro-level, and an individ-

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ual’s linguistic means to express their identity and changes across the lifespan. In doing so, this proves to be a fruitful research endeavour indeed.

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Chapter 8

“The brogue is common everywhere in Ireland, but you are taught to avoid it in reading”: Notions of correctness and speakers’ attitudes in 19th-century Ireland

Carolina Amador-Moreno

This chapter discusses the notions of language correctness in the voices of 19th-century Irish English letter writers. By turning to CORIECOR (The Corpus of Irish English Correspondence), the chapter analyses the occurrence of the term brogue, which provides an insight into the perceptions that Irish emigrants had of their own language use. The concept of the ‘Irish brogue’ is a sign of the stigma that was associated with this particular variety of English throughout the historical period covered in the corpus (1700s-1900s). As the chapter discusses, speakers echoed attitudes and perceptions of their own dialect that may have been raised in other texts where this variety was recorded. Along with literary texts, grammars, dictionaries, and treatises also contributed to the spread of language attitudes, ideologies, and myths.

The chapter starts by discussing the recording of the term brogue in some of these texts, and it then proceeds to the analysis of this term in the context of private correspondence. The letters can be accessed through the CORIECOR Visualized project: <https://corviz.h.uib.no/index.php>. The example in the title is one of the occurrences of brogue that can be found in the corpus.

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1 Introduction

While we know a good bit about how standardisation and codification took place in English in general (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2020), and how prescriptivism influenced 19th-century English (Calle-Martín forthcoming), we know less about the social factors that contributed to such codification (Conde-Silvestre & Hernández-Campoy 2014: 3), and still less about how those factors operated in varieties of English such as Irish English, which were taking shape at the time.

In their seminal work on Historical Sociolinguistics, Nevalainen & Raumolin-Brunberg (2017: 6) point out that the analysis of metacommentary from within the period can be a valuable contribution to the field. Contemporary comments on earlier usage of dialect forms and dialect awareness provide us with first-hand information on how linguistic variation was perceived by speakers living in the same period of time (Auer et al. 2015). Such analysis can be conducted by observing the views of grammarians and dictionary makers; however, as argued by Calle-Martín (forthcoming: 2), grammars and dictionaries by themselves “can hardly be responsible for the spread of linguistic forms in a language”. In that sense, expanding our observation to the comments provided by general language observers, as well as to the work of contemporary writers can be one step forward. Equally useful is the analysis of the voices of ordinary speakers whose views on language correctness and dialect use may be found in private correspondence. In this context, Anderwald’s (2014: 1) proposal to resort to historical corpora in order to confirm language attitudes in the past encourages us to zoom into individual speakers. This approach provides valuable external support for historical linguistic analysis, helping researchers piece together a more comprehensive understanding of language attitudes in the past. By focusing on individual speakers in historical corpora, researchers can better understand how language attitudes intersect with other key issues in historical sociolinguistics, such as language standardisation, linguistic attitudes, and prescriptivism.

The focus on individual speakers and their language attitudes, as evidenced in historical corpora and private correspondence, becomes particularly relevant when examining periods of significant social change and mobility, such as the Late Modern English era. The possibility of social mobility during the Late Modern English period brought about new attitudes towards language characterised by a sense of linguistic insecurity (Beal 2004: 94; Hickey 2009). These attitudes emerged on both sides of the Atlantic, even among emigrants who experienced dialect contact in the areas where they settled. Some of the linguistic observations and beliefs caused by such linguistic insecurities are sometimes found in the epistolary tradition of Ireland in the past few centuries, which was affected

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by massive emigration to America and other English-speaking territories where language awareness became more marked.

This paper investigates the notions of language correctness in the voices of 19th-century Irish English letter writers. The letters were penned during the period when Irish emigration had become more intensive. With the aid of the *Corpus of Irish English Correspondence* (CORIECOR) (McCafferty & Amador-Moreno 2012; Amador-Moreno 2022, 2024), the paper analyses the occurrence of the term *brogue*, which provides an insight into the perceptions that Irish emigrants had of their own language use. The concept of 'the brogue' as associated with the Irish is a sign of the stigma that was associated with this particular variety of English (although not exclusively) throughout the historical period covered in the corpus (1700s–1900s). This association shows the stigmatisation that this variety has undergone and it reflects interactions with the standard in the LModE period. Speakers echoed attitudes and perceptions of their own dialect that may have been raised in literary renderings of this variety. Grammars, dictionaries, and works on education and elocution also contributed to the spread of language attitudes, ideologies, and myths.

The paper discusses the term *brogue* in the wider context of 19th-century perceptions and then moves on to the analysis of this term in the context of the letters that form part of CORIECOR, by using the tools created through the CORVIZ (CORIECOR Visualized) project (Amador-Moreno et al. 2025): <https://corviz.h.uib.no/index.php>. The example incorporated into the title of the present chapter (i.e. 'The brogue is common everywhere in Ireland, but you are taught to avoid it in reading') is one of the occurrences of the term *brogue* that can be found in the corpus, and is also discussed, from a different angle, in Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García (2023). By building on previous research, the aim of the present chapter is to explore how prescriptivist views influenced 19th-century Irish English. The analysis of the metacommentary reported here provides valuable insights into the mechanisms that steered standardisation. We focus on individual speakers and their language attitudes. While the present study pays attention to the term *brogue* only, it also considers classical sociolinguistic questions regarding the consequences of dialect contact as a result of migration, dialect enregisterment, and perceptions.

2 Irish English in the Late Modern English period

The Late Modern English period in Ireland – here roughly understood as stretching from 1700 to 1950 (Beal 2004) – encompasses a number of key events that

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affected the development of the English language in Ireland. These include some interrelated factors, particularly in the north, that developed as a result of the plantation of Ulster. The plantation brought Scottish and English settlers to the Ulster province, which changed the linguistic landscape of this area. Considerable Scots input to this province in the early 17th century gave rise to Ulster Scots (see [Hickey 2010a](#); [Corrigan 2010](#), [Corrigan 2020](#): 28–63; [Maguire 2020](#): 13–39, [Maguire 2024](#)), which was one of the varieties transported across the Atlantic by the many 18th-century Ulster immigrants to America. High emigration rates from Ireland continued well into the 19th century, with a notable increase of emigrants from all parts of Ireland after the Great Famine of the late 1840s. The Late Modern English period encompasses the time when the National School system was introduced in Ireland 1831, which promoted the use of English to the detriment of Irish and thus inadvertently increased linguistic awareness. The changes in society that took place during this period allowed for the possibility of social mobility for native Irish Catholics, who had been excluded from political contexts until then. Thanks to the Roman Catholic Relief Act 1829, Catholics were integrated into political and social contexts and obtained access to education. However, social and geographical mobility among all sectors of Irish society brought about linguistic prejudice towards vernacular varieties (see [van Hattum 2024](#): 69) and new attitudes towards language, at a time when the variety of English spoken in Ireland was taking shape, as this section briefly discusses.

As [Hickey \(2007](#): 41) points out, this is also “the age of the writer Jonathan Swift (1667–1745), [...] the elocutionist and grammarian Thomas Sheridan (1719–1788) and of his more famous son, the dramatist Richard Brinsley Sheridan (1751–1816)” (see also [Hickey 2010a](#): 236; [Hickey 2024](#): 47–50). Irish-born Jonathan Swift, of Protestant origin, epitomises what James Milroy and Lesley Milroy (1999: 30) refer to as the ‘Complaint Tradition’, which they define as one of the mechanisms promoting linguistic prejudice. Thomas Sheridan, another Irishman of Catholic background, was central to the concept of ‘elocution’ and exerted significant influence on John Walker ([Hickey 2010a](#)), famously known for his publication *A critical pronouncing dictionary of the English language* in 1791 (and followed by several editions throughout the entire 19th century). Both Swift and Sheridan were key figures in the rise of prescriptivism, and their views contributed to the perpetuation of derisive and contemptuous attitudes towards the dialect, often referred to as *brogue-speak* (see [Kallen 2013](#): 39; [Hickey 2024](#); [Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García 2023](#)). Such attitudes were circulated widely, as will be discussed below.

At the beginning of the 19th century, the language shift from Irish to English was set in motion. The use of the Irish language underwent a rapid and irre-

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versible decline (although situations of bilingualism still survived, especially in rural areas). The figures of the 1851 census show a drop in the number of Irish speakers (only 23 per cent of the total Irish population are reported as speakers of Irish). However, although this is the first official census in which linguistic issues are documented, many authors have drawn attention to the fact that it understated the number of Irish speakers (see, for instance, [Fitzgerald 1984](#): 120–121). This underrepresentation was, according to [Kallen \(1994](#): 162), probably due to the low prestige which the Irish language had acquired and to the way the language questions were formulated. What is evident, nevertheless, is that English henceforth began to be perceived as the language of prestige and power. The year 1823 saw the rise of the Catholic community, led by Daniel O'Connell, who believed that it was necessary to use the English language in order to allow Ireland to develop into a quickly modernising Western world. In 1829 his political efforts led to the aforementioned Catholic emancipation act. O'Connell's encouragement to the Irish population to acquire English was undoubtedly influential in a sociolinguistic context where the language shift was gathering momentum, motivated by other factors as well.

As mentioned above, the influence of the National Schools, where instruction was in English, had direct linguistic consequences for the decline of Irish and the rise of English. In general, the spread of literacy was linked to the acquisition of English “in part because both literacy and English were seen as synonymous with modernisation, and also because no facilities developed to provide mass literacy through Irish” ([Daly 1990](#): 154). As the levels of illiteracy decreased, the number of English speakers increased. Closely related to the issue of education and the decline of Irish, the control exerted through the training of Catholic priests is also often mentioned as a key factor that contributed to the rise of English during this period.

Two other major reasons for the decline of Irish and the subsequent shift from Irish to English were the deaths and the emigration rate caused by the Great Famine (see [Barry 1982](#): 92), as mentioned above. The combination of both factors translated into the loss of about two million native speakers of Irish. More than one million died in the period between 1845 and 1851, and about one million and a quarter were forced into emigration. Intensive potato cultivation had meant that by the mid-1840s this was the sole food of one third of the population and essential to many more. The first crop blight occurred in the autumn of 1840 and subsequent poor crops in the late 1840s caused the death of approximately one million people as well as the emigration, mostly to America, of many hundreds of thousands more, as recorded in the letters contained in CORIECOR, which we turn to in Section 5.

3 Evidence of dialect awareness in written sources

Late modern descriptions of Irish English and commentary on it are recorded in grammars and dictionaries (see [Hickey 2009](#)), as well as in fictional representations (i.e. drama and novels mostly) of the Irish character, while ego-documents such as diaries and letters allow us to further complete the picture, as we will see below.

Written documents recording Irish English in fact go back to the EModE period; such recordings come mostly from drama. The Irish figures who appear in Restoration drama, as [Hickey \(2010a: 238\)](#) points out, “are nearly always objects of ridicule used as a foil to the English characters with whom they contrasted”. There was a tendency, especially during the Elizabethan era and up to the 18th century, to construct character types in similar fashions, thus replicating a number of traits and features which the audience could easily identify as Irish. Such construction on stage tended to make up in costume what it lacked in scenery ([Bartley 1954](#)), and nationalised Irish characters (i.e. Irish servants, Irish priests, Irish captains, Irish footmen, Irish costermongers etc.) were easily identified by their outfits. In this context, the selection of representative linguistic features that audiences identified as Irish English contributed to the depiction of the Irish character, too. The combination of all these traits derived into stereotypical representations that were perpetuated, giving rise to the establishment of the long-standing stock character of the Stage Irishman (see [Amador-Moreno 2010: 90](#); [Hickey 2010b](#)). The figure of the ‘Stage Irishman’ is prevalent in late 16th- and early 17th-century English drama, where a set of spoken features were beginning to constitute what later would commonly be known as the *Irish brogue*, in a rather vague manner that still persists through the 18th century to the present.¹

The term *brogue*, as well as other terms such as *bulls* and *blunders*, are all used in general observations and metacommentary to describe (often in a critical tone) the English spoken in Ireland in historical texts from this period. While the term *brogue* is often employed to refer to strongly marked Irish English accents, *blunders* and *bulls* are also used extensively in various publications over time to comment on “errors” or “deviations from the norm” ascribed to speakers of Irish English ([Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García 2023](#)). Along those lines are [Walker’s](#) (1791: xii) descriptions of the asperity of the dialect and the harshness of the accent, which followed [Sheridan 1780: 59](#) treatment of these features as “chief mistakes” that needed correction.

¹Further discussions of the concept are offered in [Hickey \(2007: 7\)](#); [Hickey \(2024: 476–478\)](#), [Amador-Moreno \(2010: 6–10, 89–101\)](#), and [Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García \(2023\)](#).

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As mentioned in Section 2 above, Thomas Sheridan, together with his fellow countryman Jonathan Swift, were key figures in the rise of prescriptivism in English in general. However, as Hickey (2010a: 243) points out, while Swift's *A Dialogue in Hybernian Stile* (c1735) ridicules the speech of two Irish individuals, his main concerns were with the codification of Standard English more broadly, as stated in his *Proposal for Correcting, Improving and Ascertaining the English Language* (1712). By contrast, Sheridan's concern with Irish pronunciation was more acute: the section on pronunciation contained in *A Rhetorical Grammar of the English Language* (1871) is entitled "Rules to be observed by the natives of Ireland in order to attain a just pronunciation of English" (Sheridan 1781: 137–155). Such rules are also accompanied by a number of remarks on the "mistakes" which the Irish make when speaking English. At one point, Sheridan goes as far as to offer a list consisting of two columns with Irish and English pronunciations respectively (as noted below). A detailed description and analysis of these features can be found in Hickey (2008).

This Irish repertoire of *brogue-speak* documented in all these historical documents comprises salient phonetic realisations such as short /e/ raising (in cases like *rint* 'rent', see Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García 2023), TH-fortition, e.g. *not-ing* for *nothing*, as well as consonant devoicing suggested by respellings like *wid* 'with' and "the rough jarring pronunciation of the letter R" (Walker 1791: x), which Walker identifies as one of "the strongest characteristics of the pronunciation of Ireland" (Walker 1791: x). Similarly, Sheridan (1780) remarks on consonant lenition, which he exemplified with the "vicious pronunciation" (Sheridan 1780: 16) of /d/ in comparative forms such as *louder* and *broadder*; the Irish, he wrote, "thicken it by an aspiration; and sound it as if it were written loudher, broadher" (Sheridan 1780: 15) (see also Hickey 2024: 473–481).

Accounts of Irish English during the Late Modern English period also included grammatical features, which were equally evaluated in the form of metalinguistic commentary (see e.g., Hickey 2008, Hickey 2010a: 263–267). Abraham Hume, for example, writing in 1877, notes that grammatical features such as the BE + *after* + V-ing construction in sentences like "I am after seeing him" (Hume 1878: 113) was "rudely constructed [...] [i]n imitation of the Irish [language]" (Hume 1878: 113), whereas "[i]n the uneducated circles" (Hume 1878: 114) non-standard verbal -s was the norm "with nouns, whether one plural or several of the same or different numbers form the subject of the verb" (Hume 1878: 114). Unlike Hume's remarks, which were driven by his antiquarian pursuit to record "the Hibernic dialect" (Hume 1858: 53) before it was lost, other language observers like Stoney in an interesting publication from 1885, for example, treat some of the dialectalisms of their time as "errors" and "defects"; while in the context of the northern region

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that had been affected by the plantations, Biggar (1897) uses the term *blunders* and declares that “Ulster people need correction” (Biggar 1897: 48).

The commentary found in relation to the use of the BE + *after* + V-ing construction and other “defects” is just an example of the type of perception of Irish English that was recorded in writing. Other linguistic traits associated with Irish English were also commented on or fictionalised, following similar prescriptivism/stereotyping. Observations stretching back to this period, for example, note – and overwhelmingly condemn – the Irish “inability” to use *shall* and *will* correctly (Beal 2004: 96–97; Hickey 2007: 179). By these accounts, the Irish difficulty “in [the use of] these auxiliaries [...] putting will for shall with the first person” (Fogg 1796, vol. II: 129; cited in Sundby et al. 1991: 191) seems to have emerged by the mid-18th century at the earliest (see McCafferty & Amador-Moreno 2014). This view of Irish English usage is also reflected in the title of Molloy’s *The Irish difficulty, shall and will* (1897). And later commentaries on Irish English appear to confirm the persistence of this situation through the 19th century (e.g., Biggar 1897: 46–47).

Evidence from private correspondence from this period shows similar attitudes to dialect. Some of the letter writers make open remarks about language, revealing a certain degree of contempt towards the use of Irish English. That such derisive attitudes were expressed in the letters of Irish emigrants is telling. The letters serve as a rich source of information, revealing how individuals managed their linguistic identities and the societal expectations surrounding language use.

4 Evidence of dialect awareness in CORIECOR

With the aim of determining to what extent, if any, language commentators influenced actual language use in the past, studies by Yáñez-Bouza (2008), Bax (2008), and others have paid attention to the speakers’ usage. These efforts, as pointed out by Pacheco-Franco (2023: 101) “are crucial in the historical process of standardisation since prescriptivists have often been considered one of three possible enactors of linguistic change, together with printers and the speakers themselves”.

Some notions of language correctness in the voices of 19th-century Irish English speakers can be found in the letters that they wrote. The period of massive emigration mentioned above resulted in copious letter writing between the emigrants and their families and friends. Some of those letters are contained in CORIECOR, which was compiled by Kevin McCafferty and the present author with the aim of studying the emergence and development of Irish English

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across time (see [Amador-Moreno 2022, 2024](#)). The letters date from 1731–1940, which spans the period during which Ireland became overwhelmingly English-speaking, as mentioned above. The letters were written by people of diverse social and geographical backgrounds. A high proportion of the letters come from the province of Ulster; and some of the writers represented in the corpus moved up the social ladder in the areas where they settled, as discussed below. The letters were written by people of Irish or Anglo-Irish backgrounds, some Catholic, some Protestant, some educated, some with hardly any education, but all the letters are written in English. The analysis of their linguistic attitudes and linguistic choices, in general, based on third wave historical sociolinguistic concepts such as enregisterment, style-shifting, intra-speaker variation, individual language choices and perception, have yielded interesting results, some of which are summarised below. Individual case studies from CORIECOR have allowed us to explore various types of interactions with the English standard, thus opening a window into how speaker-writers of Irish English experienced differing levels of exposure to the standard model, and to other varieties of English in the New World.

One such case study is the correspondence of James Horner (as discussed in [Ávila-Ledesma & Amador-Moreno 2023](#)), one of the many Irish emigrants who crossed the Atlantic between the late 1700s and early 1800s. Communication between Horner and his family back in Co. (London) Derry provides detailed accounts of his experiences and impressions of the recently adopted country. The letters also show progressive standardisation, which makes them an interesting case for historical sociolinguistic analysis: shifting from vernacular Irish English towards a more standardised type of English to some degree. Contrary to those emigrants who settled in established Irish communities in different parts of North America, Horner moved far from his fellow countrymen and devoted himself to continuously improving his social and professional status (as explained in a letter sent to his parents in 1810). The study poses two main research questions: (i) what impact do geographical and social mobility have in an individual's speech and (ii) how does social status affect linguistic choice? Ávila-Ledesma and Amador-Moreno used quantitative methods in order to construct a comprehensive account of Horner's use of plural verbal *-s*. The findings reported in their study show that social mobility as well as dialect contact seem to have contributed to general standardisation and the subsequent blurring of identity markers in language use. Horner was upwardly mobile, and his language use shows change over the ten years covered in the letters, shifting from vernacular uses of plural verbal *-s* shown in (1) to the standard construction we observe in (2) below:

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- (1) I understand that *Unkle and Aunt McCracken* is in a House of there [their?] own and *has* got a son.
(James Horner, Philadelphia, to Jacob McCracken, Co. (London)Derry, 10 October 1802)
- (2) I hope the rest of my brothers and sisters *are living* well. (James Horner, Maryland, to Thomas Horner, Bovevagh, Co.(London)Derry, 30 October 1807)

A noticeable absence of vernacular constructions can be observed in Horner's later correspondence where those environments that had initially favoured non-concord, are considerably more likely to occur with the standard equivalent. Non-standard constructions like (1) operate consistently in the letters written by Horner during the first four years of correspondence (1801–1804). In 1804, after two years working with a type founder in Philadelphia, he moved to Georgetown (62 miles from Philadelphia), and then to Easton, Maryland, where he went from being a schoolteacher, to being a private teacher in a rich gentleman's home. Finally, in 1810, he set himself up in business, becoming the owner of a store in Vienna, Dorchester County, in the State of Maryland. From 1804 onwards, a clear change can be observed towards a more standard subject-verb agreement, which coincides with the writer's relocation and the beginning of his upwardly mobile lifestyle. In the Horner case study, then, social mobility as well as dialect contact seem to have contributed to general standardisation.

A second case study is John Kerr (1843–1847), whose correspondence is analysed in [Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García \(2023\)](#) by taking a preliminary look at linguistic attitudes and self-perceptions of language use. The study of Kerr's correspondence aimed to (i) ascertain whether Kerr's linguistic evaluation of Irish English shows the impact of contemporary ideologies about the Irish and their dialect, (ii) determine whether the voices of Irish emigrants echo an enregistered repertoire of Irish English features that may have influenced their awareness and perceptions of their own and others' speech, and (iii) evaluate these writer's ideas about language correctness. The focus of the study is on two pronunciation traits that Kerr comments on in the letters: the pronunciation of /r/ and consonant lenition. Kerr, the son of a Protestant farmer, from Newpark, Co. Antrim, in the province of Ulster, was the oldest in his family and the first to emigrate to America in the 1840s. His letters to his uncle James Graham provide us with interesting views on language use from someone who had social aspirations. We know from the letters that Kerr moved around, seeking employment as a tutor or clerk, and at various times lived in places near New Orleans, Pittsburgh, Cincinnati, New

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York, etc. However, we do not know much about his educational background. As a Protestant growing up in Co. Antrim, it is likely that he would have received some education, given that literacy levels at the time were highest in the wealthiest, Protestant dominant north-eastern regions of the island (see [Fernihough & Ó Gráda 2022](#): 1610, 1616). His commentaries on the importance of schooling and education confirm that he placed a lot of value on educational matters, something that seems to have extended to language use, too: explicit comments in the letters on the Irish way of pronouncing suggest that he took American English and Americans, but also Walker's dictionary (published in the United States for the first time in 1803) (see [Section 2](#)), as models for shaping his own perceptions and evaluation of Irish English. Such opinions do in turn offer a valuable glimpse into shared ideologies about and attitudes towards Irish English and the Irish. In a letter written in the 1840s Kerr writes:

- (3) The *brogue* is common everywhere in Ireland, but you are taught to avoid it in reading.
(John Kerr, unknown origin, USA to the Grahams in Newpark, Co. Antrim, 1840s).

Explicit use and discussion of the term *brogue* in Kerr's writing show his own awareness of norms that clearly shaped his self-perceptions about correct language use. His metacommentary of the *brogue*, which he describes in the same letter as "a very rough pronunciation of the letter r and likewise that peculiar sliding of the tongue between the teeth in pronouncing such words as dross, drum, dirt, etc." in fact coincide with Walker's observations on "the jarring pronunciation of the letter R" in Irish English (1791: x). As discussed by [Amador-Moreno & Ruano-García \(2023\)](#), Kerr's evaluation of the dialect not only bears witness to the popularity of Walker's dictionary, and the shaping of ideas of 'correctness' among the Irish themselves, but it also testifies to the identification of specific features that were enregistered as core constituents of the Irish brogue at the time.

5 *Analysing the conceptualisation of the Irish brogue through CORVIZ*

The concept of the *brogue* as applied to Irish pronunciation is, as discussed in [Section 4](#), a sign of the stigma² that was associated with this particular variety

²It could also be a source of pride, something which Boucicault used to good effect in his plays (see [Hickey 2012](#)).

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of English throughout the historical period covered in the CORIECOR corpus (1700s–1900s). While the term *brogue* is by no means exclusively associated with the Irish,³ its occurrence in the letters of Kerr and other writers provides an insight into the perceptions that Irish emigrants and their contemporaries had of their own English, which is the focus of the present section.

CORIECOR is currently part of a web-based solution, ‘CORIECOR visualized. Irish English in writing across time (a longitudinal historical perspective)’ (CORVIZ), which uses a server-side program (written in PHP) to query data and present it to the user in the CORVIZ web browser.⁴ A PHP script handles the dynamic requirements of the site that give access to some of the letters and to some visualisations that have been created to tap into historical sociolinguistic issues (see Amador-Moreno 2024). A search of the term *brogue* through CORVIZ using the ‘Advanced Search’ function: https://corviz.h.uib.no/index_convert.php?convar_function=9 yields 11 results. Once we exclude the uses of *brogue* with its original meaning ‘shoe’,⁵ and as part of a placename, *Finnesbrogue*, *Downpatrick, Co. Down*, we are left with seven valid hits, including the Kerr letter already discussed. Four of the other hits belong to letters written by members of the Smyth family, whose use of various Irish English features are discussed in de Rijke (2016), Amador-Moreno (2019), and Bonness (2024). One of the members of this family is James Alexander Smyth, a Protestant from rural Co. Tyrone, who went to Canada in the late 1800s, and worked his way up from farmhand to principal of a small public school (see de Rijke 2016: 75–78).

Like Horner’s and Kerr’s, Smyth’s is a clear case of upward social mobility (Amador-Moreno 2019: 190). His comments on the *brogue* show his linguistic awareness and the importance that he placed on language “while moving in the higher circles of society in Essex, Ontario” (de Rijke 2016: 81). In a letter from 1904 he comments on the accent of a preacher, Mr. Joseph Hamilton, an Irishman who “has been in this Country for about nine years”:

- (4) Rev. Hamilton was originally from Co Down. He is a fairly aged man, but he might get a call. He has *a fairly good brogue*.
(James A. Smyth, Ontario, to Liza Smyth, Co. Tyrone, 24 May 1904).

³As shown in O’Sullivan et al. (2025), a search through Google N-gram Viewer substantiates an overall association with Scottish English, too.

⁴The CORVIZ project, funded by the Agencia Estatal de Investigación, Spain (Project Reference number PID2019- 106609GB-I00) and hosted at the University of Bergen (<https://corviz.h.uib.no/index.php>) allows us to explore the potential of letter writing to tap into processes of dialect awareness in the past. All letters discussed in this paper can be directly accessed online through the project.

⁵From the Irish Gaelic word *bróg*, pl. *bróga*.

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In an earlier letter from 1900, when asking about his sister Bella's visit back to Ireland he writes:

- (5) I wonder how she likes *the Irish brogue*. If the peoples [sic] voices sound as loud and course [coarse?] to her as they did to me when I went back she will think it funny.
(James A. Smyth, Ontario, to J. J. Smyth, Co. Tyrone, 23 July 1900).

The type of mockery relayed in (5) is also conveyed in another letter written in 1905, where he once more comments on somebody else's Irish accent:

- (6) Oh, by the way I was making some fun [in?] my other letter about Johns' [*Brogue?*] and the appearance of some over there.
(James A. Smyth, Ontario, to J. J. Smyth, Co Tyrone, 30 March 1905).

An interesting aspect of Smyth's letters is that despite his evident linguistic awareness and willingness to share his dialectal perceptions and judgements, his own use of Irish English is in fact rather marked and very consistent throughout his letters, even during his years as a student and throughout his career as a teacher and principal. He uses, for example, embedded inversion (e.g., "I *wonder did he* make a will"), as discussed in [Amador-Moreno \(2019: 182–183\)](#), and is, together with some other members of his family, one of the users of final *sure* (e.g., "I am going home now *sure*") which documents the occurrence and the transportation of this discourse pragmatic marker across the Atlantic. While we have no information about his accent, what is evident from James Alexander Smyth's letters is that he was consistent in his pronunciation of *they* as /ði:/, which is not unusual in Northern Irish English (also in reduced forms [ði] or [ðə]). Smyth's spelling clearly indicates that his pronunciation of *they* as *the* (reproducing the realisation /ði:/) did not disappear during his 35-year settlement in Ontario, as phonetic representation of it is found in his letters throughout this period of his life ([de Rijke 2016: 59–79](#)).⁶

Another member of the Smyth network, James Alexander's sister Eliza Catherine Smyth, is also one of the writers who uses the term *brogue* in a letter from 1894:

- (7) Father showed them the way to play the seven days of the week and *the Brogue* their [there?] was good fun that night in Uncle James.
(Eliza C., Castledamph, Co. Tyrone, to James A. Smyth, Ontario, 1894)

⁶Of 236 letters written by Smyth, 71 contain the vernacular spelling *the*.

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In contrast to James Alexander and some of her other siblings, Eliza stayed in Ireland. Her letters are penned from Castledamph, Co. Tyrone, which makes for an interesting comparison with her brother's letters, given that she did not move and therefore did not experience dialect contact in the context that her brother did. Eliza contributes 54 letters to CORIECOR, written over the course of three decades (1891–1921). Eliza's correspondence includes fewer phonetic representations than grammatical features (see [Bonness 2024](#)), but she shares with her brother the lack of consistency in the spelling of the definite article *the* and the personal pronoun *they*. As noticed by [Bonness \(2024\)](#), her writing displays both the spelling *the* replacing *they* (43) and hypercorrection in the use of the form *they* for *the* (44), which confirms interpretation of this interchangeable spelling made by de Rijke, who, as mentioned above, concludes that the pronunciation of both words as [ði:], lies in the fact that they were homophones ([de Rijke 2016](#): 61–82). It is difficult to determine exactly what Eliza understood by *brogue*, given the brevity of the comment. Her own use of non-standard features might well be significant in her own interpretation of the term as including not just accent but dialect features more broadly. What can be observed in (7), though, is that her reference to the *brogue* is devoid of criticism. Unlike her brother's remark, her comment not only shows dialectal awareness, but it is also rather positive, almost affectionate.

This positive view of the term is also present in the letter of another female writer, Jane White, who in 1857 sends the following lines to her friend Eleanor Wallace, in Newtownards., Co. Down from Goderich, Ontario:

- (8) (...) their uncle Miss Parkes's father has taken charge of the whole family some time since, there are three left, they are smart lively girls with a great quantity of *the Irish brogue* I like it, it sounds musical in my ears.
(Jane White, Goderich, to Eleanor Wallace, Newtownards, 9 January 1857).

Jane White's letters do not contain much dialect, and although her correspondence with her friend Eleanor reveals strong opinions about politics and religion (from her Protestant perspective), her commentary on language use does not indicate any strong views or negative attitudes towards Irish English. Her reference to the three Irish girls' *brogue* in (8) above is clearly of a positive nature, and it simply shows an awareness of language use that is also confirmed within the same letter, when describing the accent of another Irish woman:

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- (9) I met with a Miss Caldwell lately over there, she teaches music to Lucy Weather---- [Weathersald?], she is come out from Ireland some months ago, from Coleraine. She is a fat stout old country girl so [rosy?] and clear coloured innocent and Irish looking it is a long time since I heard *such a strong Northern Irish accent* before.
(Jane White, Goderich, to Eleanor Wallace, Newtownards, 9 January 1857).

Apart from the reference to the Northern Irish accent, (9) above contains an example of *be*-perfect (“she *is come* out from Ireland”) where the past participle is presented as an adjectival form rather than as a past participle (see [Amador-Moreno 2010](#): 41). This type of construction, which is often listed as a feature of Irish English (see [McCafferty 2014, 2015](#)) seems to have come about in the course of the 19th century, as indicated by a survey of its use in CORIECOR ([McCafferty 2019](#)). From the information contained in her correspondence we assume that Jane White, whose father was a politician, was well educated. The fact that a Protestant upper middle-class writer like her uses *be*-perfect in her private correspondence indicates that linguistic constructions like this may not have been stigmatised at the time, or at least not as prominently as other linguistic features that were either avoided by the most educated writers, or subject to commentary from those who were prone to passing remarks on the use of dialectal forms.

The last reference to the *brogue* from the CORVIZ search is in a letter written in 1836 from Baltimore, Maryland, by Thomas Cather. Only three letters from this writer are contained in CORIECOR, and all three of them were written to his family in Limavady, Co. Derry. In one of the letters, addressed to his mother, he writes:

- (10) Judge Porter one day drove us a few miles from Washington to the house of a Colonel Manford, where the widow of Theobald Wolfe Tone resides, and introduced us to her, she is a fine old lady with great veracity of manner, and *a good taste of the brogue* on her tongue - she expressed herself delighted to see the Irishmen so fresh from the sod, and begged us to visit her as often as we could, during our stay.
(Thomas Cather, Baltimore, to ‘My Dear Mother’, Limavady. 19 May? 1836)

Although we do not have much information about Cather, this particular letter addressed to his mother is especially interesting because the owner of the *brogue* that he refers to is no less than the widow of Wolfe Tone, founder of the United

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Irishmen and a leading figure in the fight for Irish independence from British rule. In 1795, Wolfe Tone left Ireland for America to escape arrest and took up residence in Philadelphia (Elliott 2012). Cather's encounter with his widow seems to bear out the sense of identity that was deepened by the experience of exile in Wolfe Tone's home (Brundage 2016). Again, as in examples (7) and (8), the commentary surrounding the use of the Irish *brogue* here seems to be far from critical, while indicative, nevertheless, of metalinguistic awareness.

Even though the occurrences of the term *brogue* discussed here show a mixture of prescriptivist attitudes and simply descriptive observations, the commentary offered by these letter writers shows that certain features associated with Irish English, signalling accent (but also perhaps dialect more broadly) were salient enough to deserve a few lines in their letters. The existence of contemporary works like those previously described in Section 3 also shows that for some of the letter writers the dialect was often attributed to a recognisable social type, and even rejected or censured.

An interesting point that is worthy of notice is that all the letter writers mentioned in this study are from the province of Ulster. We are, therefore, inevitably restricted by the perspective of those Irish emigrants and their immediate circles. As Hickey (2010a) points out, in the appendix to his grammar Sheridan compares the pronunciation of Irish English with southern British English. The Irish English forms listed by Sheridan are those in which "well-educated natives of Ireland differ from those of England" (1781: 146). He is, however, referring here to the Protestant middle and upper class, "given the fact that at the end of the 18th century the attribute 'well-educated' in Ireland applied first and foremost to Protestants" (Hickey 2010a: 261). Given the connection between literacy/educational level and religion mentioned in Section 2, it seems very likely that some of the attitudes and observations that we have discussed here were the result of a deeply rooted belief that somehow echoed Biggar's remark discussed above that "Ulster people need correction". Such a statement certainly seems to tally with the comments made by letter writers John Kerr and James A. Smyth.

6 Conclusions

This chapter set out to discuss the perceptions and attitudes towards Irish English and the notion of the *brogue* during the Late Modern English period in Ireland, as reflected in historical documents such as grammars, dictionaries, and with a focus on private correspondence.

As the chapter argues, historical corpora play a crucial role in confirming language attitudes in the past. A general look at the evidence preserved in Late

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Modern English grammars and pronunciation dictionaries exhibits clear indexical links between a set of linguistic features evaluated as characteristic of Irish English and distinct meanings that were in turn commonly associated with a recognisable Irish English speaker. This association was also established through fictional representations of the Irish character on stage and in novels. As discussed here, the *brogue* was often subject to stereotypical representations in literature and drama, which contributed to broader societal perceptions of Irish speakers. Such portrayals often reinforced negative stereotypes, which in turn impacted how these speakers viewed their own dialects.

As a complement to these types of documented evidence, the analysis of contemporary comments on dialect forms as well as of ordinary speakers' perspectives on language correctness and dialect use offers valuable insights from a historical sociolinguistic perspective. Such insights are often found in private correspondence. By turning to the *Corpus of Irish English Correspondence* (CORIECOR), the chapter has explored the notion of language correctness in the letters of 19th-century Irish emigrants, thus investigating how attitudes towards dialects were influenced by social mobility during the LModE period. The analysis of the personal letters contained in CORIECOR provides valuable insights into the everyday language use and attitudes of ordinary speakers. As has been shown, these letters serve as a rich source of information, revealing how individuals navigated their linguistic identities and the societal expectations surrounding language use. Focusing on the term *brogue*, the study addresses sociolinguistic questions related to dialect contact, migration, and perceptions. Overall, the commentary found in the letters provides firsthand information on how linguistic variation was perceived in the past. The study has sought to draw significant conclusions regarding the perceptions and attitudes towards the *Irish brogue*, revealing the complexities of language attitudes in Ireland and the New World.

The analysis of the term *brogue* through CORVIZ clearly indicates that attitudes towards Irish English were complex and varied among speakers, particularly in the context of emigration. While some individuals expressed a desire to distance themselves from *the brogue*, others embraced it positively, indicating a less tainted relationship with their dialect and identity. This has interesting implications in relation to the 'interactions with the Standard' perspective of the present volume, as it gives us an indication of how some Irish English speakers perceived the language spoken in their new country. Speaker-writers clearly show metalinguistic and dialectal awareness when commenting on *the brogue*. Most writers, as the examples above show, seem to refer to accent (which would be expected, given the dialect contact situation in North America and also in Ulster during the period investigated). In that sense, their observations may be

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based on their own aiming for a levelled pronunciation. The exposure would have made them interact with this levelled (standard?) pronunciation. However, as one reviewer points out, this also seems to be a matter of salience. The evidence available from the letters shows that pronunciation features were obviously more salient to these letter writers than other linguistic features such as the *be*-perfect, as pointed out in Section 5. Thus, it could be assumed that the speaker-writers mostly interacted with what they may have perceived as a standard pronunciation norm but to varying degrees with (less salient) grammatical norms.

Cases like James A. Smyth, John Kerr, and to a certain extent, also James Horner, highlight the impact of migration and subsequent social advancement on dialect perceptions. As Irish emigrants settled in new regions, their dialects changed in some cases (despite the fact that they were cut off from their native linguistic environment), and their attitudes towards their native speech were influenced by their experiences in different linguistic environments. This suggests that migration probably played a more significant role in shaping language attitudes and practices than educational background, and letter writing allowed for certain prejudices to come to the fore. The connection between literacy, education, and religion likely influenced the observations and judgments related to Irish English features, but the role played by dialect contact and social mobility seems to have been prominent in the cases analysed here. However, given that the analysis is primarily based on letter writers originating from the Ulster province, some limitations apply to this study when generalising to Irish English as a whole.

The study, nevertheless, emphasises the importance of historical linguistic analysis in understanding language attitudes. By examining the metacommentary and personal reflections of the speakers (letter writers), researchers can gain deeper insights into the evolution of language use and the social factors influencing it. This is a useful complementary perspective to what we can learn by observing the complaint tradition, and prescriptions in grammars, dictionaries, etc. The individual case studies presented here have allowed us to explore various types of interactions with the English standard (mostly in relation to pronunciation levelling but also contrasting the perception of pronunciation and grammatical features). This has also provided us with a deeper understanding of how speaker-writers of Irish English experienced differing levels of exposure to the standard model(s), and to other varieties of English with which they came into contact. In that sense, the findings discussed in this chapter have sought to contribute to a deeper understanding of the complexities surrounding dialect use and language attitudes in 19th-century Ireland.

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Chapter 9

Manuscript spellings in Early Modern English: Interacting with the printed standard?

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Recent work has shown that sixteenth- and seventeenth-century printing-houses played a part in the standardisation of English spelling. This study compares developments of three graphemic variables in printed texts with results from two corpora of manuscript texts, the Corpora of Early English Correspondence (CEEC-400) and the Electronic Text Edition of Depositions 1560–1760 (ETED). This approach is complicated by deficiencies in the data, but workarounds are possible. The results show that while some spellings were standardised first in print, others followed similar trajectories in print and manuscript concurrently.

1 Introduction

On the landing page of the EEBO-TCP N-gram Browser on the EarlyPrint Lab website,¹ one is immediately faced with a startling graph (Figure 1). The N-gram Browser plots the relative frequencies of the search strings – such as different spellings of the same word – in the corpus over time. The corpus, EEBO-TCP, is part of the *Early English Books Online Text Creation Partnership* project, which contains diplomatic transcriptions of over 60,000 Early Modern English books and pamphlets as full text XML.² What Figure 1 shows is how the spelling of the word LOVE changed from <loue> to <love> in the seventeenth century. Three

¹<https://earlyprint.org/lab/>, Northwestern University and Washington University in St. Louis. EEBO-TCP N-gram Browser by Anupam Basu and Stephen Pentecost.

²See <https://textcreationpartnership.org/tcp-texts/eebo-tcp-early-english-books-online/>.

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things are striking about this graph. First, the speed of the change: it takes place over a mere two decades, from about 1620 to 1640. Second, the categorical nature of the change: some minor variation notwithstanding, the pre-1620 spelling of LOVE in English print was <loue>, and post-1640 it became <love>. And thirdly, the scope of the change: since the dataset consists of EEBO-TCP, Figure 1 in effect shows that the change took place in *all* printed texts in England at the same time.³

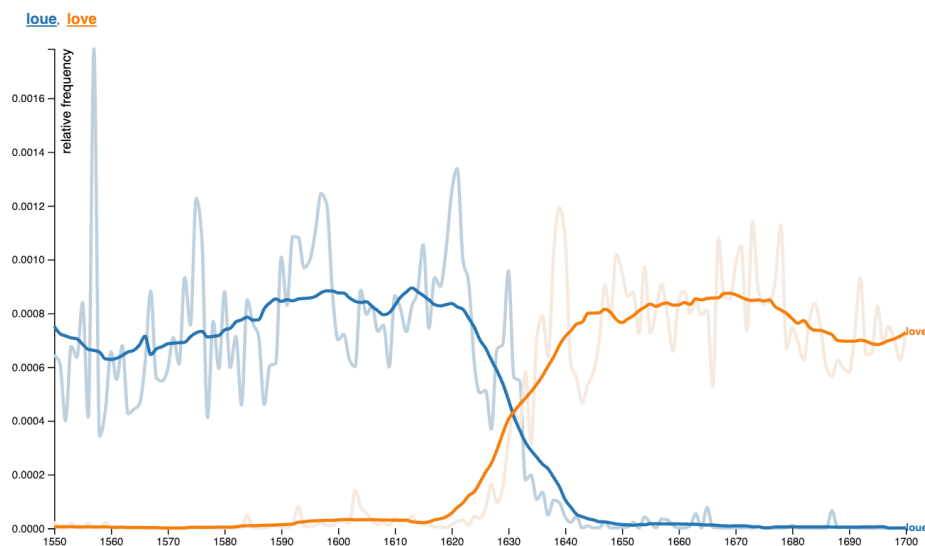


Figure 1: <loue> and <love> in EEBO-TCP N-gram Browser

Research on the standardisation of spelling in Early Modern English has generally acknowledged that printing had a strong impact on the process (Condorelli 2022: 32). Figure 1 indicates that this is likely to have been true. Condorelli (2022) has shown through quantitative surveys of EEBO-TCP data that printers indeed can be credited with (or blamed for) the standardisation of many graphemic variables in Early Modern English – including word-medial <u/v>, seen in Figure 1.

Such claims deserve counterpoint studies in order to see how standard spellings developed in hand-written texts. This article is the first diachronic study to investigate graphemic variables in Early Modern English manuscript texts and compare them to developments in contemporary print, thereby providing a broad overview of interactions between spelling standards in print and in hand-written

³The EEBO-TCP N-gram Browser currently uses a corpus of some 59,000 texts from EEBO-TCP. Data for the period 1620–1640 comes from 3,455 texts.

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texts.⁴ Using two corpora of manuscript texts, the *Electronic Text Edition of Depositions, 1560–1760* (ETED) (Kytö et al. 2011) and the *Corpora of Early English Correspondence* (CEEC-400) (Nevala & Nurmi 2013), I investigate two of the graphemic changes studied by Condorelli (2022) in printed texts; namely word-initial <u/v>-variation and epenthetic <aun>, as well as word-medial <u/v>-variation. My findings both support and contradict those of Condorelli (2022).

This article proceeds as follows. In Section 2, I will first briefly discuss the current understanding of the standardisation of Early Modern English spelling between 1500–1700. In Section 3, I discuss the corpora used in my study, and Section 4 describes my methods. Section 5 contains three case studies: the first of word-initial <u/v>-variation, the second of word-medial <u/v>-variation, and the third of epenthetic <aun>. Section 6 contains the discussion and conclusions. For more information on my data, see the Appendix in Section ??.

2 The standardisation of spelling in Early Modern English print and manuscript

The development of the English spelling system between 1500–1700 is perhaps easiest to demonstrate through examples. In sixteenth-century English, <y> was frequently used where other vowels serve in Present Day English (PDE), as shown in the excerpt from a letter by Henry VIII in 1528, in example (1):

- (1) As tochyng your syster mater, I have causyd Water Welshe to wrytte to my lord myne mynde therin, wherby I trust that Eve shall nott have poure to dyssayve Adam.
(HENRY8_003; Henry VIII to Anne Boleyn, 1528; Stemmler 1988: 128)⁵

Other non-PDE features in Henry VIII's spelling include doubled consonants where we expect single (*wrytte*, *nott*), single consonants where we expect doubled (*mater*), and alternate spellings of 'power' and 'deceive'.

Muriel Bell's spelling ninety years later is closer to PDE and perhaps easier for a modern reader:

- (2) I can not gett leue of my good Nephew to depart vntill his Returne from London but then he haue promissed me to bringe me vnto you:
(PASTONK_010; Muriel Bell to her sister, 1618?; Hughey 1941: 45)

⁴Tyrkkö (2020) is similar to the current study, but surveys only medical texts, and the absence of precise dates for most of his manuscript corpus means it cannot be used to accurately track developments in handwritten texts over time.

⁵All examples in this article are from the CEEC-400.

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Consonant doubling was still common (*gett*, *vntill*, *promissed*), but instead of the <y>-spellings seen in example (1), the main difference to PDE is the presence of <u/v>-variation.. In late medieval and early modern English, <u> and <v> were allographs of each other, their use determined primarily by their position within a word: <v> was preferred word-initially (*vntill*, *vnto*), and <u> word-medially (*leue* ‘leave’, *Returne*, *but*, *haue* ‘have’). This practice was common, but not universal and categorical, as seen by Henry VIII not following it (1).

By the end of the seventeenth century, John Evelyn was using for the most part what became standard spellings (3). The main period-typical spelling feature in Evelyn’s letter is the use of the apostrophe as a visual abbreviation of a past participle.⁶

(3) My Friend,

The desire I had that my Wife should be perfectly recover’d of her late and long Indisposition, hindred my motion from Says-Court til a very fine warme day tempted us abroad;

(EVELYN2_018; John Evelyn to Samuel Pepys, 1695; *de la Bédoyère* 1997: 256)

We can make some rough points about the development of English spelling based on these examples, each of which is typical for its period. First, spelling changed over time. Second, spelling conventions changed over time. Third, given the little overlap of pre-standard spellings between these periods, we can see that spelling change proceeded in stages. And fourth, considering the writers in these examples are social elites and professional writers, spelling variation was ubiquitous, and its presence was not marked.

Much if not most of the scholarship on the standardisation of English spelling has been focussed on trying to explain its causes (for a recent summary, see *Condorelli* 2022: 21–39; see also *Basu* 2016, 2025 and *Wright* 2020). Explanations have been sought in the work of grammarians, orthoepists and lexicographers (*Hernández-Campoy & García-Vidal* 2024), as well as printers (*Tyrkkö* 2020), and many scholars have concluded that standardisation appears to have been the product of many causes working with and against each other (*Condorelli* 2022: 39). It has long been understood that different standards applied in different spheres, of which the primary examples are print versus handwritten texts, and ‘public’ versus ‘private’ handwritten texts (*Osselton* 1984; see also *Salmon* 1999: 42). But the lack of suitable datasets for quantitative studies of manuscript texts

⁶This practice continued into the eighteenth century, see *Sairio* 2009. Evelyn’s use of capitals is period-typical, but capitalisation is a feature of orthography, rather than spelling.

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has meant that we lack a clear picture of what spelling variation in handwritten texts means in terms of trends in the overall development and standardisation of English spelling (see e.g. [Salmon 1999](#)).

The situation is better for printed texts thanks to the EEBO-TCP, which has now been used for quantitative diachronic studies of spelling, and the results have already changed our ways of thinking about the standardisation of English spelling. [Basu \(2016\)](#) finds evidence of two waves, or periods of increased or rapid spelling standardisation, the first roughly in the second half of the sixteenth century, and the second centred around 1650 ([Basu 2016](#): 193–196, esp. Figures 14 and 15). These waves can also be seen in the case studies in [Condorelli \(2022](#): esp. chapters 7–8). Both authors further find that spelling standardisation is not a single linear process ([Condorelli 2022](#): 23–24), but the “result of accumulated and structured variation”, an outcome of “a constantly evolving set of conventions” ([Basu 2016](#): 176). At the granular level, what changed were not the spellings of lexemes, but of graphemes and grapheme clusters ([Basu 2016](#): 180, 183–184; [Basu 2025](#): 92; [Condorelli 2022](#): *passim*).

Basu and Condorelli explicitly argue that drivers of spelling change in Early Modern English are to be sought in printing practices, but most previous studies appear to implicitly assume that Standard English spelling was something that came to be established in print (e.g. [Scholfield 2016](#)) – even if its ultimate causes were not the printers themselves. This stance can be seen for instance in the framing of manuscript spelling practices as “informal” ([Osselton 1984](#)) – which is not to say “dual standards” did not exist, as has been verified by studies of later periods ([Sairio 2009](#)). The problem is that such terminology presupposes the existence of a regularising process of standardisation in print, as opposed to “private spelling” in manuscripts (e.g. [Nevalainen 2012](#): 141–146; [Kaislaniemi et al. 2017](#)), which this appellation suggests did not (and could not?) lead to standardised spellings.

I am perhaps unfairly portraying a situation arising from differing definitions of terms for standardisation processes on the one hand ([Condorelli 2022](#): 21–26; see also [Milroy 2000](#)), and simple lack of access to broad manuscript data on the other. In this paper, I adopt the sense of ‘standard’ used by [Condorelli \(2022](#): 21–38), indicating shared norms rather than prescribed practices. Standard spellings in this sense are not necessarily the ones adopted into what became Standard English, instead such standard spellings could and did emerge and then disappear during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries ([Condorelli 2022](#): 66, Figure 4.2). Indeed, it is important to understand that rather than order emerging from chaos, standardising processes in Early Modern English ([Condorelli 2022](#): 26) commonly involved the favouring of one variant among several existing ones.

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As seen in Figure 1, the standard spelling of LOVE in English print before 1620 was <loue> – no less standard, in this sense, than the post-1640 spelling <love>.

Whether the standard spellings emerging in print became Standard English spellings or not, Figure 1 also shows that their adoption by printing-houses was nearly universal. Yet we know little about if and how changes in print spellings affected the spelling practices of contemporary writers. This article tries to make inroads into these questions by comparing work done on the EEBO corpus with results drawn from two corpora of Early Modern English manuscript texts: the ETED and CEEC.

3 Materials for studying EModE manuscript spelling

3.1 The Electronic Text Edition of Depositions, 1560–1760 (ETED)

The Electronic Text Edition of Depositions, 1560–1760 is a corpus of Early Modern English witness depositions transcribed and compiled from manuscripts by Merja Kytö, Peter Grund and Terry Walker (available on CD-ROM with Kytö et al. 2011). The corpus is fairly small in size at 267,238 words, but its 905 texts were carefully chosen to provide samples from north, south, east and west England, as well as London; depositions were chosen because they can contain representations of direct speech, which the compilers were interested in (Kytö et al. 2011: 5, 44–47). The time span 1560–1760 was based on a previous resource (the *Corpus of English Dialogues 1560–1760*, see Kytö & Walker 2006); this was divided into four subperiods (1560–99, 1600–49, 1650–99, 1700–60), and although the aim was to collect at least 10,000 words from each region per period, the final corpus does not quite achieve this balance (Kytö et al. 2011: 5–6; 323–325). An important motivation for the compilers was to create a corpus that was reliable for philological enquiry, as editions used previously by the compilers were found wanting in many respects (Kytö et al. 2011: 7–10).

Crucially for this study, the texts have been diplomatically transcribed and original spellings have been retained in the corpus. In addition, the regional coverage of ETED, and the 194 different scribal hands it includes, gives it a degree of representativeness (Kytö et al. 2011: 148–151). The corpus extends into the eighteenth century and is thus beyond the scope of the survey of Condorelli (2022), but I felt it necessary to use the whole corpus upon the discovery that some of the changes studied continue into the 1700s in ETED.

Although ETED does contain text from every decade between 1560–1760, its regional coverage is far from constant. When divided into the four subperiods mentioned above, there are no gaps, but when viewed by decade or twenty-year

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period, there are forty-year gaps in every region (if at different periods), and at times only one region is represented in ETED (Kytö et al. 2011: 325, Table 3). For example, the only data for the 1600s–1610s is from South England, and there is no data at all from the South for the periods 1620s–1650s and 1680s–1740s. Given the regional variation in spelling recorded in ETED (Kytö et al. 2011: 158–163), this means that for some twenty-year periods (particularly ones with low word counts), it is likely that regional and/or idiolectal variation is magnified. This issue is discussed at apposite points in Sections 4–Section 6.

3.2 The Corpora of Early English Correspondence (CEEC-400)

The Corpora of Early English Correspondence (CEEC-400) is a family of corpora of Early Modern English personal letters. It contains some 12,000 letters from c. 1400–1800 by c. 1,200 writers, coming to about 5.3 million words. The CEEC-400 was designed for historical sociolinguistics, to study how social factors affect language use. Letters were chosen since the text type is relatively close to the spontaneity of spoken language (e.g. Biber 1995), since plenty of Early Modern English letters were available in accessible form as published editions, and because epistolary correspondence comes with information about the social context of production and reception (including the names of the correspondents, the date and place of writing, and address), information which is needed for sociolinguistic enquiry.

The use of published editions comes with a cost, however. Editions are rarely diplomatic, and editors usually modernise features they expect modern readers to find confusing, such as <u/v>-variation, changing spellings such as *haue* and *vp* to their modern versions *have* and *up*. The CEEC-400 compilers were well aware of this, and the sources of the CEEC-400 were subjected to careful scrutiny as to their editorial reliability. Only editions that appeared to retain original spelling were chosen in the first place, and the CEEC team visited manuscript repositories to spot-check editorial accuracy. Nonetheless, some compromises were inevitable – in particular the modernisation of <u/v>-variation is in fact so common that it is usually adopted silently, without any explicit editorial justification. The implications of using edited sources to study Early Modern English spelling are discussed further in Section 3.3.

Although every effort was made in the compilation of the CEEC-400 to create a balanced and representative corpus, ultimately edition-based corpora are reliant on the existing edited record. While special attention was paid to social coverage, the majority of editions of English historical correspondence consist of the letters of men from the upper echelons of society, and women and social

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groups other than the gentry are underrepresented. Nonetheless, the gender ratios in the CEEC-400 are decent: overall, a quarter of the writers in CEEC-400 are women, although just 21% of the letters are by them. But social ranks lower than the middling sort are only represented by about 3% of the letters in the CEEC-400. However, these deficiencies are also to some extent artefacts of the available data, as women’s letters form a minority in the manuscript record, and letters from the lower social ranks have rarely survived (see [Daybell 2006](#): 32–37).

Table 1: The CEEC-400 family

Subcorpus name	Years	No. letters	No. words
CEEC-1998	c. 1410–1681	5,961	2,597,795
CEEC <i>Extension</i> (CEECE)	1653–1800	4,923	2,219,422
CEEC <i>Supplement</i> (CEECSU)	1402–1663	947	485,524
Total: CEEC-400	1402–1800	c. 12,000	c. 5.3m

Table 1 shows the constituent parts of the CEEC-400: the main CEEC parts are the CEEC-1998, the CEEC *Extension*, and the CEEC *Supplement*. Conceptually, the *Extension* follows the CEEC-1998 chronologically, whereas the *Supplement* brings additional material to the period covered by the CEEC-1998.

For this study, I have drawn on the entire CEEC-400, but restricted my study corpus only to letters written between 1500–1699, to match [Condorelli \(2022\)](#). Further, I created a subset of this study corpus based on editorial and philological principles described in Section 3.3. The bespoke subcorpora of the CEEC-400 used in this study are shown in Table 2 (see Appendix 9.1 for a list of the CEEC-400 collections included in each subcorpus).

Table 2: CEEC-400 subcorpora used in this study

Contents	No. letters	No. words
CEEC-400, 1500–1699	6,439	2,873,328
CEEC-400, 1500–1699, only sources that retain <u/v>-variation	2,229	908,164

3.3 On corpora of manuscript texts and the philological reliability of CEEC-400 sources

There is nothing even remotely resembling EEBO-TCP for manuscript texts. Since corpus compilation is expensive, corpora transcribed directly from EModE manuscripts are restricted in size and scope, often consisting of a single text type. Examples include ETED, the corpus of EModE urban varieties being compiled by the *Emerging Standards* project (Gordon et al. 2020), and the *Málaga Corpus of Early Modern English Scientific Texts* (Calle-Martín et al. 2016). Of these, ETED is quite small in size, the *Emerging Standards* corpus has not been released, and the *Málaga Corpus* neither provides precise dates for its manuscript texts or adequate information on their writers. Printed editions are an alternative source of EModE manuscript texts (as used in CEEC), but very few editions of EModE texts are diplomatic, as discussed in Section 3.2.

It is possible today to create a large corpus of EModE manuscript texts from existing digitised resources using transcription software such as Transkribus (www.transkribus.org) or a Large Language Model such as ChatGPT. Yet even large-scale digitised collections of British manuscripts do not have similar genre coverage to EEBO. Of course, the CEEC is also a single-genre corpus, but what makes it stand out is its size and especially its coverage. If we compare the regional coverage by twenty-year period in the ETED and CEEC, we find that the ETED has data for only 54% of regions-by-period, whereas for the CEEC (1500–1699) the corresponding figure is 95%. This coverage, and the copious and reliable metadata, make the CEEC the best existing corpus of EModE manuscript texts. As discussed in Section 3.1, results from the ETED can potentially be skewed from regional or idiolectal amplification. In contrast, there is enough socioregional coverage in the CEEC for such noise to be dampened – much like the amount of data in EEBO-TCP flattens outliers. However, the philological reliability of the CEEC sources needs to be addressed before using the CEEC to study spelling.

As has been noted, one of the consequences of philological outsourcing (Dollinger 2004) for the CEEC-400 was the understanding that the corpus would not be a reliable source for the study of spelling, and the CEEC team has been careful to stress this fact (Nevala & Nurmi 2013: Section 2.3). In previous research on spelling using the CEEC, we found that while some spellings are likely to have been changed by editors, others are more likely to have been retained reliably, and that it is in fact possible to use the CEEC-400 to study spelling, provided the complications involved are understood (Kaislaniemi et al. 2017). For a better understanding of editorial principles and practices, in 2016–2019 the ERRATAS project (Kaislaniemi et al. 2023) surveyed all the sources of the CEEC-400, look-

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ing at, inter alia, the presence of spelling variation, including <u/v>-variation, and recording it in a database (Kaislaniemi 2023; for more on ERRATAS, see Sairio et al. 2018, Sairio & Kaislaniemi 2025, and Kaislaniemi & Biri n.d.). Among the most important findings of the project was that editorial practices do not cluster: what is done to, for instance, <u/v>-variation, does not correlate with what is done to, for example, punctuation (Sairio et al. 2018: 38–42; Sairio & Kaislaniemi 2025: 628–629). For the current study, the implications of this are that for corpus searches to be as representative and philologically reliable as possible, a different subcorpus (Table 2) needed to be used when looking at a graphemic variant that has usually been editorially changed, namely <u/v>. The same does not hold for spellings that are retained by editors because they are easier for the modern reader to parse, such as epenthetic <aun>.

The creation of a bespoke subcorpus based on the presence of graphemic variables, however, comes with its own trade-offs. The decline of <u/v>-variation over time means that late seventeenth-century letters are likely to have less variation – or none – so that choosing specifically CEEC-400 collections that contain use of the ‘old’ form (e.g. *vp*, *haue*) leads to underrepresentation of the use of the emerging standard form. On the other hand, <u/v>-variation is likely to have been modernised silently by editors even in editions that ostensibly retain spelling variation, thereby effacing the use of the old form. This means that the full CEEC-400 corpus spanning 1500–1699 skews towards standard PDE spellings, while the bespoke subcorpus skews towards the old spellings.

In the end, particularly for the graphemic variant <u/v>, it is impossible to say based on the CEEC texts alone whether the use of a spelling is very rare, or the editor has modernised all but a handful, or whether an Early Modern English letter-writer simply always preferred the emerging standard spelling, or if the edition is completely modernised. The results from my searches in the CEEC-400 for these variables should be understood as evidence of the *presence* of spelling variation: so far, we have not encountered any cases of modern editors changing spellings from PDE standard to obsolete forms. Therefore, the presence of <u/v>-variation in an edition is a representation of the manuscript reality. Although the frequencies may be conditional, overall trends are likely to be accurate, thanks to the composition and size of the CEEC-400, and therefore the data can be relied on for charting the presence and direction of change.

4 Methods used in this study

Condorelli (2022) conducts case studies of several graphemic spellings in English print 1500–1700, grouped into positional spellings (<u/v>- and <i/j>-variation),

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<i/y>-variation, etymological spellings, and vowel diacritic spellings. This study takes the same graphemic alternants from two of these categories: for positional spellings, word-initial <u> and <v> as alternants of each other; for etymological spellings, the epenthetic grapheme cluster <aun>. Inspired by the EEBO-TCP N-gram Browser, my second case study is word-medial <u/v>-variation, which is not looked at by [Condorelli \(2022\)](#).

This study asks two questions:

1. Is there change over time in the use of word-initial and -medial <u/v>-variation and the frequency of epenthetic <aun> in the ETED and CEEC?
2. If trends are visible, how do they compare to those for the same graphemic variables found by [Condorelli \(2022\)](#)?

In order to ensure comparability, it would be optimal to follow the methods used by [Condorelli \(2022\)](#) on corpora of manuscript texts, but an accurate methodological replication is not possible. Condorelli uses a sophisticated model of quantitative analysis, where in particular the identification of spelling variants draws on a separate Early Modern English Vocabulary Database created from a much larger dataset than just his EEBO-TCP study corpus ([Condorelli 2022](#): 86; see 61–123 for a full description of his method). Spelling variants identified in this way are then searched for in his EEBO-TCP study corpus, using Perl scripts. Most of his results are presented as relative frequencies per time period (instances / words × 100), to allow comparability between periods and across graphemes ([Condorelli 2022](#): 104).

The creation of a similar vocabulary database was beyond the scope of this study; instead, spelling variants were determined manually. The plain text corpus files of the CEEC-400 and ETED were searched using the CasualConc application (v.3), and results were processed and counted. Graphs depicting the results were created in MS Excel. The more frequent graphemic variants studied by [Condorelli \(2022\)](#) would have been too laborious to survey in the CEEC with these methods: there are 270,000+ instances of word-initial and -medial <u> and <v> in my <u/v>-reliable CEEC subcorpus. Following previous work ([Kaislaniemi et al. 2017](#)), sample words were used instead: <up*> and <un*> for word-initial <u/v>-variation, and HAVE for word-medial <u/v>-variation. Such sampling is identified in the case studies in Section 5.

As ETED is smaller, I was able to go through all 25,140 instances of word-initial and -medial <u> and <v> in it. The full results are used in Section 6.1, but for the case studies in Sections 5.1 and 5.2, sample words were used to bring the results

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from ETED in line with those from the CEEC. When it came to <aun>, since this is less frequent than <u/v>-variation, it was possible to go through all instances in the two corpora.

Both Condorelli (2022) and this study look at spelling, rather than orthography, which means that majuscule and minuscule letters were counted together (Condorelli 2022: 92, 95). Words and passages in languages other than English were not included (Condorelli 2022: 79–82); these are marked in both ETED (Kytö et al. 2011: 272, 275) and the CEEC-400 (Raumolin-Brunberg & Nevalainen 2007: 158), which made their exclusion simple. Condorelli removed hyphens and counted the resulting words individually (Condorelli 2022: 96). In contrast, I did not count post-hyphen graphemes in the CEEC-400 as word-initial, because hyphens in the source editions are generally editorial insertions, and the original spellings and word divisions are unknown. Alternants other than the variant pairs studied were not counted, for instance, the use of <u> for <w>, in e.g. *uife* ‘wife’.

In the case of specific pairs of spelling variants which can be seen as binaries, such as word-initial <u/v>, percentages can be more indicative of the proportions of use rather than relative frequencies: this method is used in Figures 6, 9 and 10, which show the use of ‘old’ and ‘new’ forms, ergo the proportions of pre-Standard (e.g. *vp*) and emerging Standard (e.g. *up*) spellings. As Condorelli (2022) does not provide raw data, the same method cannot be applied to the figures for EEBO, and therefore such a direct comparison between print and manuscript data is unfortunately not possible; relative frequencies are used specifically in order to enable comparability. Relative frequencies also dampen artificial fluctuations caused by small word counts, an issue particularly pertaining to ETED (cf. Figure 6), which can make it difficult to differentiate between regional or idiolectal practices and overall diachronic developments.

Whether given as relative frequencies or percentages, all results in this study are presented in such a way that they answer the two research questions above. The focus is not on the actual frequencies of each graphemic variable in each corpus, or even the exact proportions of the use of ‘old’ and ‘new’ spelling variants. Instead, the figures show the presence of change in the data on the one hand, and differences between the three datasets – not in the degree of the changes (volume or speed), as much as in their timing and duration. The sample words, too, were chosen specifically because they were most affected by the standardisation of <u/v>-variation (as opposed to words like *but* or *very*, the spellings *bvt* and *uery* being very rare), in order to highlight how these spellings changed over time.

5 Spelling variation in Early Modern English manuscript texts: Three case studies

5.1 Word-initial <u/v>-variation

The first graphemic alternant looked at is word-initial <u> and <v>. Historically, <u> and <v> were allographs in English texts, but rather than being in free variation, their distribution broadly followed positional rules: <v> was favoured word-initially, and <u> word-medially, regardless of phonemic value. Spellings such as *vp* ‘up’ and *haue* ‘have’ were the norm, although even the same text could also include *up* and *have*, and it is common to see spellings such as *rvn* or even *seruavnt* ‘servant’, as in example (4) (emphasis added in all examples):

- (4) **Worshypfull** master, fynally I beseke yow, for the entyre **loue** of all myghty God, to be good master **vnto** me **your** pore **seruavnt** and dayly bedeman, for I **haue** no nother **trust**, helpe, nor socor **but** only God and yow
(BRERETO_019: Gilbert Godbehere to William Brereton, 1530s. [Ives 1976](#): 88)

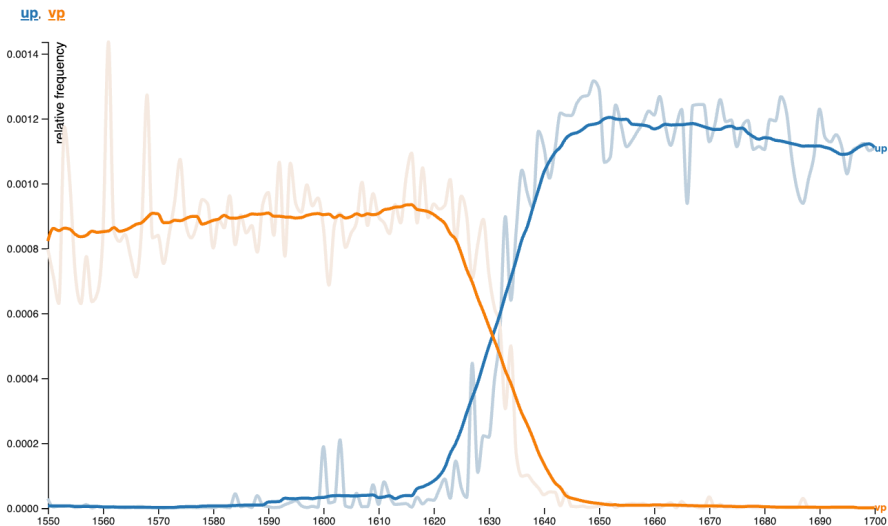


Figure 2: <vp> and <up> in EEBO-TCP N-gram Browser

As was seen in Figure 1, in print word-medial <u> and <v> came to be mapped exclusively to their respective modern standard phonemic values in the first half

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of the seventeenth century. This was also the case for word-initial <u> and <v>, as seen in Figure 2. As the next figures will show, in manuscript texts the change occurred later, and the overall process took longer to complete.

Figure 3 plots the relative frequency of word-initial <v> as an alternant of <u> (both *vp* for *up* and *very* for *uery*) in Condorelli's EEBO-TCP study corpus against those of word-initial <v> in UP* + UN* (i.e., *vp** and *vn**) in the CEEC and ETED. The change appears to be complete in EEBO by the period 1640–59. In contrast, in ETED, the frequency of word-initial vocalic <v> only begins to decline after that period, with the change continuing into the eighteenth century and only reaching completion some 80 years after EEBO. In the CEEC data, the decline is much more protracted, but its end is in the period 1660–79, bridging the change as seen in EEBO and ETED.

(See Appendix 9.2 for the data for all figures, which provide word counts of the corpora used, and the total number of instances of the graphemes in each corpus.)

Turning to the adoption of word-initial vocalic <u>, the three corpora are compared in Figure 4. In EEBO, the change takes place rapidly from the 1600–19 period to the 1640–59 period. It is mirrored in the CEEC, where the rise takes place with a 40-year delay compared to EEBO. Like with the decline of <v>, the adoption of <u> in the ETED data lags EEBO by 60–80 years, with the rise lasting from 1660–79 to 1720–39.

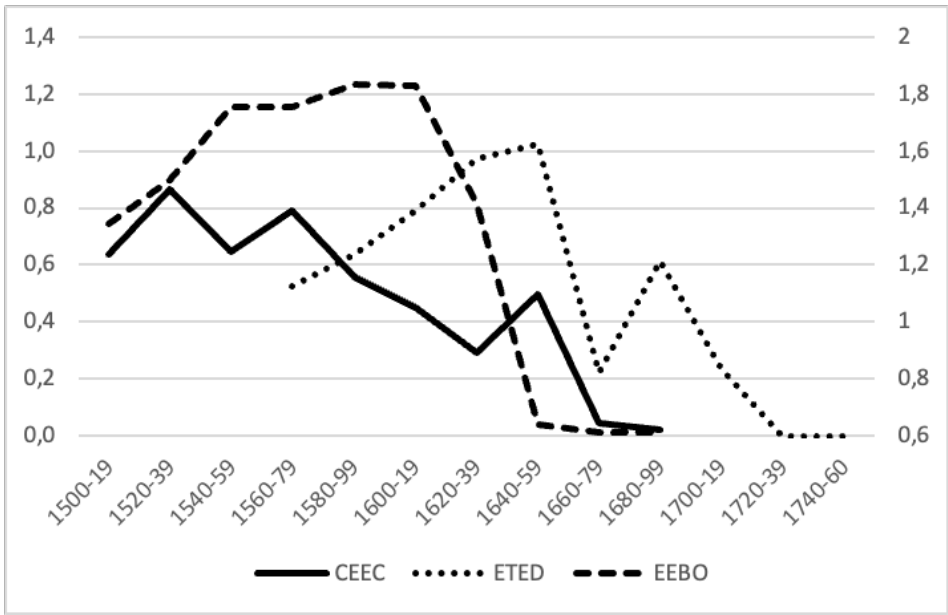
In both Figures 3 and 4, the results from the CEEC for the period 1580–1639 may reflect editorial changes to the sources. A comparison with the ETED data suggests that such an interpretation might be correct for word-initial vocalic <u>, which starts abruptly from zero in EEBO and ETED, but not necessarily in the case of word-initial vocalic <v>. Although the decline of <v> in the CEEC data is not as steep as in EEBO and ETED, the significant fluctuation in the ETED data (an artefact of the data, as discussed in Section 3) shows that there was more variation in manuscripts than in print.

5.2 Word-medial <u/v>-variation

The second case study is of the spelling encountered at the beginning in Figure 1, word-medial <u/v>-variation. Condorelli (2022) does not study this change, but Figure 1 shows us that word-medial <u> and <v> became standardised in EEBO-TCP texts over the period 1620–39. Figure 5 shows the relative frequencies of word-medial <u> and <v> in the word HAVE in the CEEC and ETED.⁷ In the

⁷As noted in Section 4, word-medial <u> and <v> overall are too frequent in the CEEC to be counted by my methods. But see Section 6.2 for ETED.

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Figure 3: Word-initial <v> as an alternant of <u> in EEBO (right Y-axis), and word-initial vocalic <v> (UP* + UN* only) in ETED and CEEC (left Y-axis), relative frequencies

“In Figure 3, the Y-axis for the EEBO data has been shifted to make the comparison with the ETED and CEEC easier. Condorelli’s figures include all words with variant spellings, for which reason the lines for EEBO do not reach zero. For instance, where <vp> as an alternant of <up> becomes obsolete, <very> as an alternant of <uery> becomes the standard form (Condorelli 2022: 83–92, also 127–139). In contrast, all of the spelling variants looked at in the ETED and CEEC – <vp>* and <vn>* – become obsolete, and the corresponding lines in the graph reach zero.

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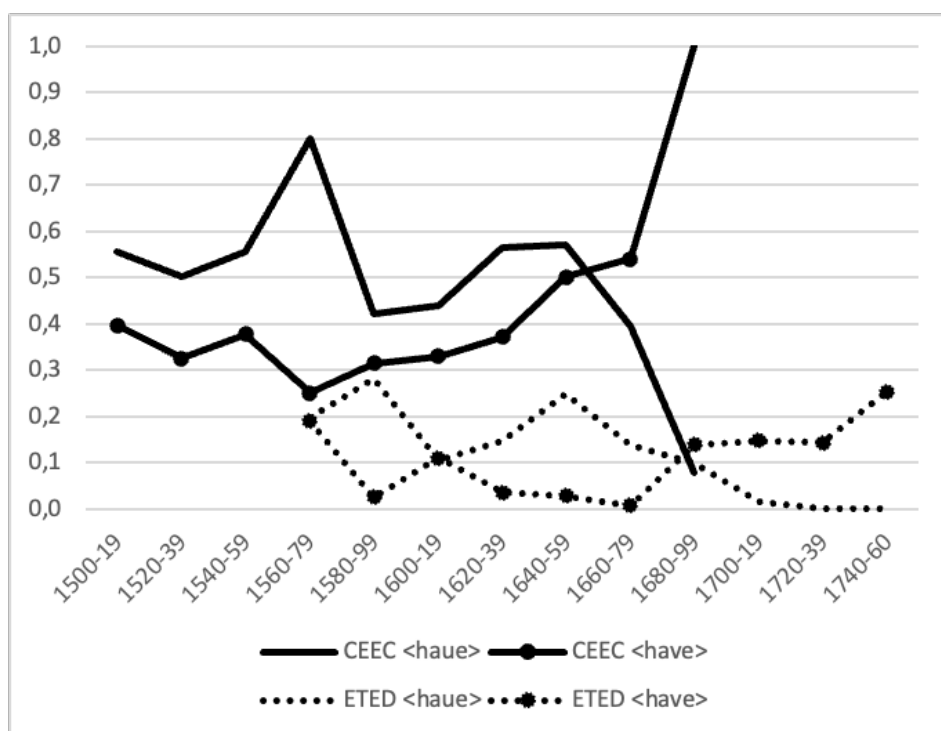


Figure 4: Word-initial <u> as an alternant of <v> in EEBO, and word-initial vocalic <u> (UP* and UN* only) in ETED and CEEC, relative frequencies

CEEC, the ratio of <haue> and <have> remained roughly the same from the early 1500s to the 1650s (the period 1560–79 excepted), with <haue> being about a third more frequent than <have>. Rapid standardisation took place over the last two periods of the seventeenth century, some forty years behind print. In ETED, the frequencies of HAVE are lower, but <haue> dominated – proportionally more than in the CEEC – until the period 1660–1679, and standardisation of the spellings took place from the 1670s to the early 1700s, with a slight lag to the data from the CEEC.

To directly compare the periods and rates of change in the CEEC and ETED, Figure 6 plots the percentages of use of the emerging standard spelling of HAVE (i.e. <have>) in both corpora. The figure shows a twenty-year lag between the standardisation process in the CEEC and in ETED, with the change reaching completion in the CEEC by the end of the seventeenth century, while taking until the early eighteenth century in ETED.

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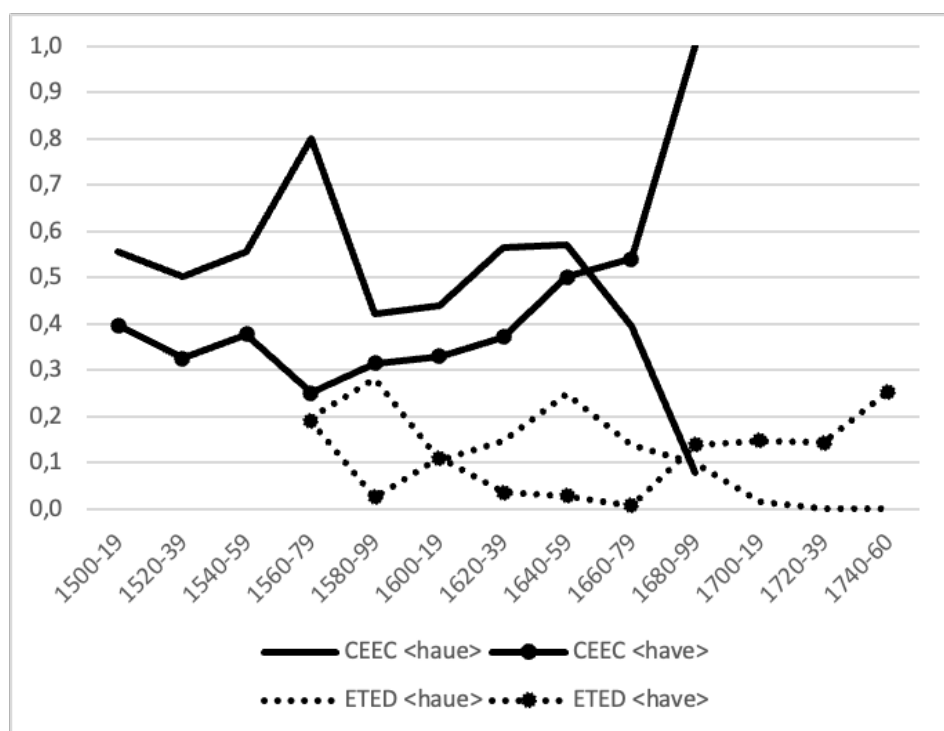


Figure 5: Word-medial <u> and <v> in HAVE in ETED and CEEC, relative frequencies

Two other points in Figure 6 are worth noting. The line for <have>-spellings in CEEC averages around 40% from the beginning of the sixteenth century through the 1630s. As speculated earlier, this may again reflect editorial interference, rather than actual spelling practice. In contrast, the final s-curve for the change in ETED begins near zero, not unlike the trend lines for EEBO in Figure 1. But the high fluctuation for ETED is in fact an artefact of the data, and reflects regional (and scribal) preferences – something mitigated in the CEEC data by better socioregional coverage. Yet regional or not, the presence of sixteenth-century writers in ETED who prefer the eventually emerging standard form <v> long before its domination suggests that my speculations of editorial interference in the CEEC data may be wrong, and that mixed use of word-medial <u> and <v> in Early Modern English manuscript texts may have been the prevailing state until at least the mid-seventeenth century. This conclusion is corroborated by evidence of writers using both old and new spellings in the same sentence, as in

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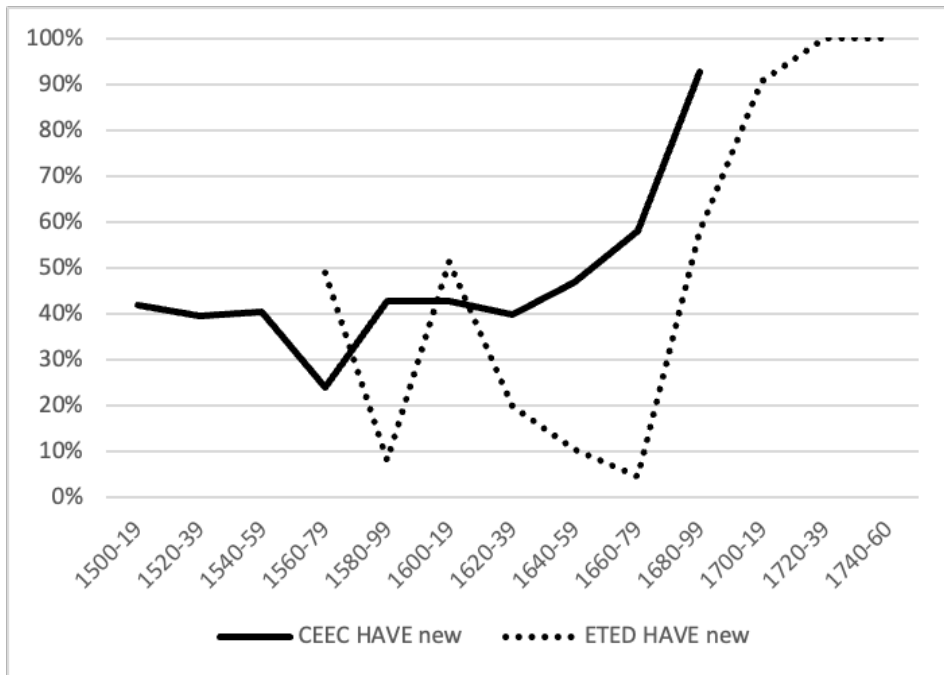


Figure 6: HAVE in ETED and CEEC, new form %

example (5):⁸

- (5) I would not **have** delayed writeing soe long, but that I thought to **haue** writ with Rich. Burnyeats, who should **haue** bene here ere this;
(FLEMING_109; Henry Fleming to his father, 1679; [Magrath 1904](#): 282)

5.3 Epenthetic <aun>

The third and final spelling variant looked at is epenthetic <aun> for <an>, as seen in example (6).

- (6) God euer kepe you from al **daungerous** attempts, and **graunt** you many yeres to liue and raigne.
(ROYAL1_001; Queen Elizabeth I to James VI, 1585; [Bruce 1849](#): 12)

⁸A survey of scribal preferences in <u/v>-variation is beyond this paper, but see [Grund et al. \(2021\)](#).

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The prototypical example of etymological spellings in English is perhaps *doubt(e)*, formed by the insertion of into *doute*, based on Latin *debitum* (e.g. [Salmon 1999](#): 27–28). According to [Condorelli \(2022: 171\)](#), etymologising spellings also include graphemic clusters such as <aun> for <an>, which was borrowed into English from French. The spelling <aun> spread through and beyond Romance and Latinate vocabulary in English during the sixteenth century, only to fade away in the seventeenth ([Condorelli 2022](#): 171–172, 176–177).⁹

In contrast to the previous spelling variants looked at, as seen in Figure 7, the relative frequency of epenthetic <aun> follows a remarkably similar pattern in all three corpora. The spelling <aun> is first to fall to near zero by 1620–39 in printed texts, but the manuscript corpora are not far behind, with both the CEEC and ETED approaching zero by 1640–59.

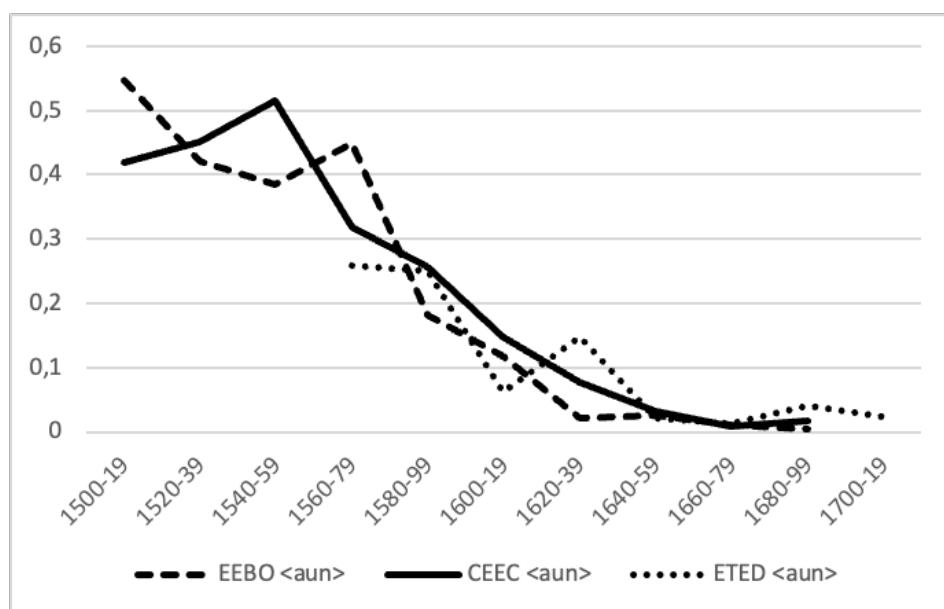


Figure 7: Epenthetic <aun> in EEBO, ETED and CEEC, relative frequencies

Unfortunately, data for the alternant <an> is not provided by [Condorelli \(2022\)](#), and we do not have the corresponding figure of the adoption of this emerging standard spelling in EEBO-TCP (e.g. *commaund* > *command*). However, that

⁹I am grateful to a reviewer for pointing out that <aun> for <an> has longer roots than Condorelli claims, and may be insular in origin. [Upward & Davidson \(2011: 92\)](#) further complicate the history of <aun>-spellings in English.

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<aun> declined in all three corpora over the same period of time is clear from Figure 7.

6 Discussion and conclusions

6.1 Print driving change in manuscripts

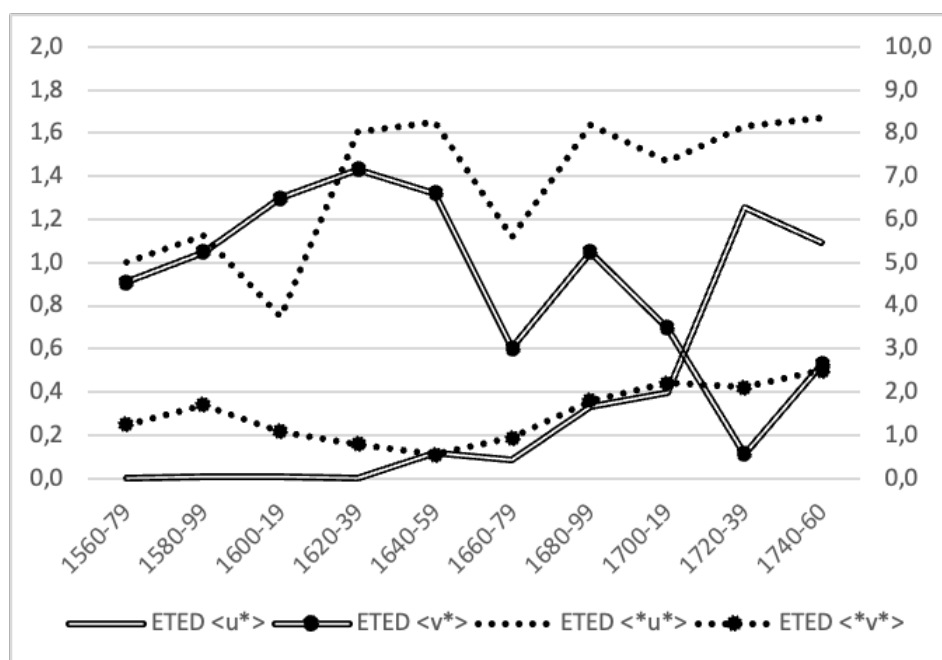
My results from manuscript-based corpora both support and contradict the findings of Condorelli (2022). For word-initial <u/v>-variation, print does appear to have driven the change. This is supported by the speed and comprehensiveness of the change in print (Figure 2), as well as the timing: in letters and depositions, the change took place 20–80 years later (Figures 3 and 4). Perhaps most importantly, however, the rise of word-initial vocalic <u> appears to be an innovation in print, as its use was negligible not only in print prior to 1620, but also in manuscript texts into the middle of the seventeenth century.

For word-medial <u/v>-variation in EEBO, the change appears to have been as rapid and categorical as word-initial <u/v>-variation (Figure 1). In contrast, the use of both spellings was common in manuscript texts throughout the sixteenth century and into the early seventeenth century, so that the standardisation process did not involve the adoption of an innovation, but rather the rearrangement and specification of existing allocations of phonemic values. The timing of the standardisation of word-medial <u/v>-variation in the CEEC and ETED is similar to that for word-initial <u/v>-variation.

Comparing the developments of different graphemic alternants shows that, as both Basu (2025: 92) and Condorelli (2022) note, standardisation did not proceed through individual graphemes across the English lexis, but rather through clusters of graphemes and/or lexemes. This is already intimated by a comparison of word-initial to word-medial <u/v>-variation; a clearer picture emerges when we look at data from *all* of the words that contain <u> or <v>, word-initially or -medially. Figure 8 shows the relative frequencies of all word-initial and word-medial <u> and <v>-spellings in the ETED (as noted in Section 4, there were too many instances of <u> and <v> in the CEEC to survey with the methods used in this paper).

There are three things to note about Figure 8. First, in contrast to the behaviour of HAVE seen in Figure 5, the relative frequencies of word-medial <u> and <v> stay more or less constant in relation to each other, with both numbers rising gently over the 200-year period, and there is no cross-over point. Second, as noted before, word-initial <u> only emerges in the 1640–59 period. And third, unlike for word-medial spellings, there is a crossover for word-initial <u/v>-variation,

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Figure 8: Word-initial <u> and <v> (left Y-axis) and word-medial <u> and <v> (right Y-axis) in ETED, relative frequencies

^aTo make the comparison of the two features easier, the more frequent word-medial <u/v>-variation has been plotted on the right Y-axis at a different scale.

as the frequency of <v> drops and is matched by a steep increase of <u> (as seen in Figure 4).

The strength of the changes seen in Figure 8 can be studied by plotting the ‘new’ spellings (consonant <v>, vocalic <u>) in all words that have word-initial or -medial <u> or <v> in ETED as percentages over time: this is shown in Figure 9. This graph shows how minor word-medial <u/v>-variation is overall in the ETED: what eventually become standard spellings are dominant even as early as the sixteenth century (as seen in example (1)), staying for the most part above 80% and slowly rising to completion from the 1660s. Word-initial <u/v>-variation is slightly more common, the ‘new’ consonantal <v> being used about a quarter to a third of the time, until the frequencies spike in the 1660–79 period, and the proportion of vocalic <u> reaches the modern standard by the 1720s. The early peak, followed by a slight decline, is an artefact of the data, also visible in Figures

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3 and 8.¹⁰

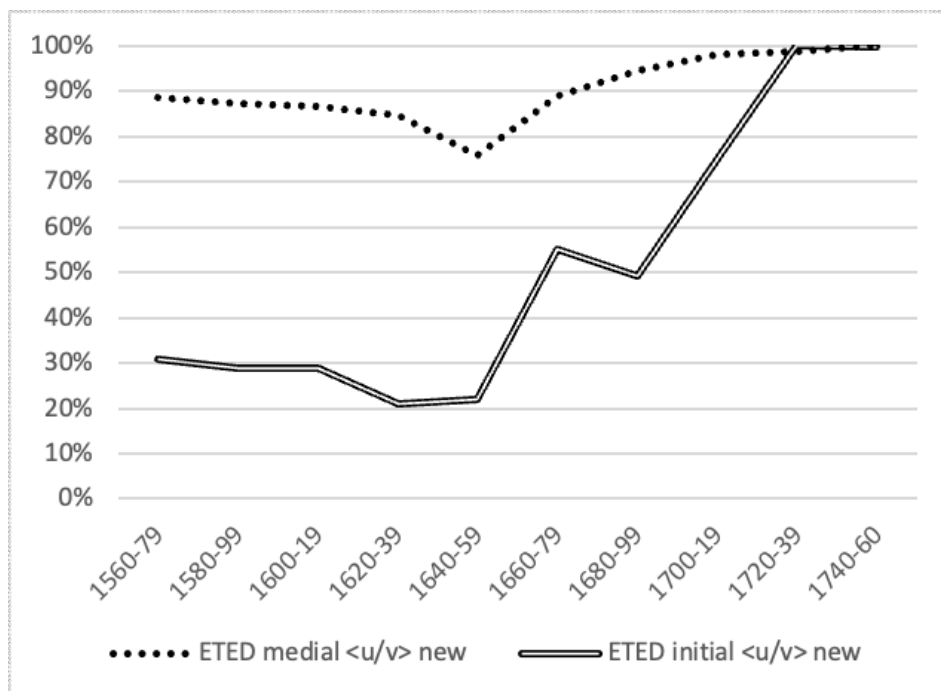


Figure 9: Word-initial and word-medial <u/v>-variation in ETED, new forms %

In other words, the standardisation of word-medial <u/v>-variation in Early Modern English really entails the solidification of practices that had already for the most part followed a phonemic distribution for over a century. Most English words with word-medial <u/v>-alternation remained unaffected, but some words – like HAVE – underwent a dramatic change (and can therefore be used as clear indicators of the ongoing spelling change). The trajectory of their change in turn resembles that of word-initial <u/v>-variation, where the innovation of vocalic <u> became dominant very rapidly.

What about in letters? A comprehensive look at all the words in the CEEC with <u/v>-alternant spellings is beyond this study. But to present one more angle on

¹⁰The cause was referred to in Section 3.1: there is no data from the South of England in ETED for the period 1620s–1740s except for the period 1660s–1670s. Crucially, these two decades have a low word count, the bulk of which consists of data from the South (Kytö et al. 2011: 325). This data includes text from writers in Oxford whose preferences differ from the writers in the previous and next periods in ETED. For a comparison of the spellings preferred in different regions represented in ETED, see Kytö et al. (2011: 160, Table 5.2).

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how letter-writers came to adopt the emerging spelling standards, Figure 10 plots the data seen in Sections 5.1 and 5.2 by birth cohorts of the writers, and gives them as percentages of the ‘old’ and ‘new’ forms. In order to smooth the lines, the writers have been grouped by birth decade into rough generations of 30 years. The result is quite clear: the emerging standards were adopted by people born after 1620 – in other words, by people learning to read and write during and after the process took place in print (Figures 1 and 2; see also Kaislaniemi et al. 2017: 204–205).¹¹ This suggests that print had a direct influence on the development of <u/v>-spelling standardisation in handwritten texts. Whether the new standard was actively taught or if the spellings spread due to their universal adoption in print remains an open question.

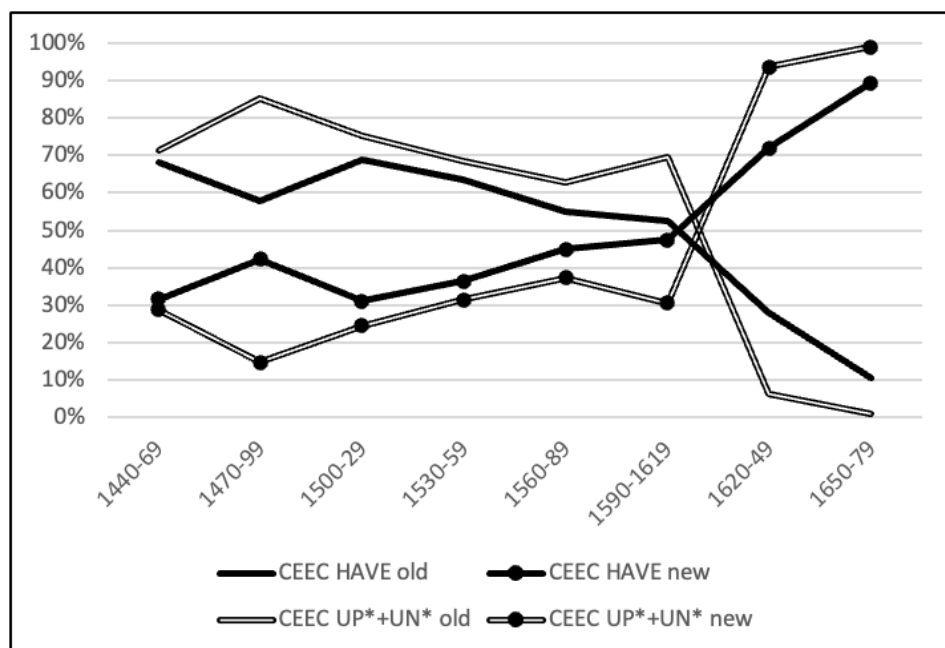


Figure 10: Generational change in CEEC: <u> and <v> alternation in HAVE and UP* + UN* by writers' birth decade, old and new forms %

To sum up: was the standardisation of <u/v>-variation in Early Modern English driven by developments in print? The fact that the changes were also completed in manuscript texts supports this interpretation. The timing of the changes in EEBO, the CEEC and ETED would also appear to confirm this: there is a lag

¹¹When looked at by ten-year-period, the first generation to favour word-initial *vp** and *vn** were born in the 1610s, and those to favor <have> in the 1630s.

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of two generations or more between print and manuscript texts for standard spellings to establish themselves, as previous work has found (Kaislaniemi et al. 2017: 210–211; see also Salmon 1999: 51–52). For word-initial <u/v>-variation, vocalic <u> became dominant by c. 1640 in EEBO, and for UP* and UN*, by c. 1660 in the CEEC, and as late as c.1710 in the ETED. For word-medial <u/v>-variation, the new spellings were dominant by c. 1640 in EEBO, and for HAVE, by c. 1660 in the CEEC, and 1690 in the ETED. In letters, the emerging standard was adopted primarily by younger writers, older writers apparently resisting change. One explanation for spelling standardisation taking longer to effect in depositions is the suggestion that depositions generally favour more conservative spellings (Cusack 1998: 95–96; Kytö et al. 2011: 47–48). But this claim does not appear to hold for all regions covered by ETED and for all spelling variants, as seen in Figure 9. The difference between letters and depositions could also be conceived of as one of text type – even if text categories in print were not found relevant by Condorelli (2022: 129).¹² Further research on the diffusion of spelling changes through various manuscript genres is clearly called for.

6.2 Simultaneous change in print and manuscript

Most of this article is concerned with the standardisation of <u/v>-variation, but the third spelling variant studied was specifically chosen in order to illustrate that not all of the spelling changes studied by Condorelli (2022) can be convincingly traced back to printing-houses. As shown in Section 5.3, the decline of the etymologised graphemic cluster <aun> happened simultaneously in print and manuscript. Condorelli's suggestion that “the disappearance of <aun> may have been motivated by the need to speed up typesetting” (Condorelli 2022: 184) cannot explain the concurrent developments in manuscript texts.

The reasons for this spelling change are unclear. Although previous studies on EModE spelling have often looked to orthoepists as a possible source for changes in spelling (e.g. Salmon 1999), recent work suggests that they do not appear to have had much effect on people's spelling practices (Hernández-Campoy & García-Vidal 2024). It would be interesting to follow up on Terttu Nevalainen's (2020) suggestion that the Book of Common Prayer may have been a great influence on the adoption of standard spellings, and investigate whether it makes use of <aun>.

¹²Perhaps this is due to the London-centredness of early modern English print (Condorelli 2022: 28).

7 Conclusion

This article has been focussed on graphemic developments in EModE manuscript texts, as compared to those found by Condorelli (2022) in print. Condorelli posits that the causes of spelling standardisations in print were pragmatic, and related to printing-house practices (Condorelli 2022: 127–219), but the verification of his conclusions would require much more work by book historians (see e.g. McLeod 1979). In Section 6.1, I suggest that one opportunity for print spellings to have been adopted by writers is when people learned to read and write (see also Nevalainen 2012: 156; Salmon 1999: 32). Another tantalising possible source for some EModE spelling standardisations is foreign languages: perhaps the standardisation of <u/v>-spellings was an international process (Scholfield 2016: 158; Condorelli 2022: 149). We have fleetingly seen that regional and scribal preferences varied in the adoption of standardising spellings in depositions (Sections 5.2 and 6.1): such variation merits further study using these corpora, as well as others (see also Grund et al. 2021).

There is no question that a full understanding of the processes of standardisation of spelling in Early Modern English must take into account developments in manuscripts. Condorelli (2022) and others have shown that some graphemic developments leading to standard forms were driven or initiated by printing practices. However, as this article shows, changes in print could also reflect developments coming into effect simultaneously in all written media, and sometimes quick and/or categorical changes in print actually codified existing practices – which might in fact have been more firmly established in handwritten texts at the time. EEBO is a vast and important resource, but in the early modern period, handwritten texts outnumbered printed texts by orders of magnitude. The challenges for accessing manuscript texts, particularly for quantitative research, are scant excuse for their neglect in studying the history of English spelling. The manuscript-based corpora used in this article have amply shown their worth, while also making very evident their weaknesses. Without a large, philologically reliable corpus of manuscript texts, our picture of Early Modern English spelling will remain incomplete, and we will only have access to the broad strokes of how early modern scribes and letter-writers interacted with the printed standard.

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.1 Collections of the CEEC-400 used in this study

Table 3 lists all the CEEC-400 collections with letters from 1500–1699; Table A2 a subset of the same of collections which reliably retain <u/v>-spelling variation. For a full list of the collections of the CEEC-400 and their sources, see Kaislaniemi2023.

PCEEC and CEECES refer to published sections of the CEEC-400, the *Parsed Corpus of Early English Correspondence* and the *Corpus of Early English Correspondence Extension Sampler*, respectively.

.2 Word counts and numbers of instances for Figures 3–10

Tables 5–9 present the sums of the data used for Figures 3–10: the word counts of the corpora used, and the total numbers of instances of each grapheme.

The word count for ETED is given in Kytö et al. (2011: 324, Table ??). The word counts for EEBO are those of the “study corpus” used by Condorelli (2022: 69–74; word counts by period in Table ??1 on p. 107). Condorelli does not give full tables of data, and the number of instances of the spellings for EEBO in Figures 3–4 are estimated from his figures and discussion of these graphemes (Condorelli2022: 131–136). The number of instances of spellings for EEBO in Fig. 7 is calculated from the relative frequencies he gives for <aun> (Condorelli2022: 176, Table ??1).

7.0.1 Figures 3 and 4

7.0.2 Figures 5 and 6

7.0.3 Figure 7

7.0.4 Figures 8 and 9

ETED, 0.27m words.

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Table 3: All CEEC-400 collections with letters from 1500–1699

ADDISON	ESSEX	HOLLES	PINNEY
ALLEN	EVELYN	HOSKYNS	PLUMPTON 2
ARUNDEL	EVELYN 2	HUTTON	PORY
ARUNDEL 2	FACTORY	JOHNSON	PRIDEAUX
BACON	FERRAR	JONES	PRIDEAUX 2
BACON DOROTHY	FEARINGTON	JONSON	RALEGH
BACON EXTRA	FITZHERBERT	KNYVETT	RALEGH 2
BARRINGTON	FLEMING	KNYVETT 2	RERUM
BASIRE	FLEMING 2	LEYCESTER	ROYAL 1
BAXTER	FLEMING EXTRA	LISLE	ROYAL 2
BENTHAM	FOX	LOWTHER	ROYAL 3
BETTS	GARDINER	MARESCOE	ROYAL 4
BOLTON	GARDINER 2	MARVELL	RUTLAND
BOWREY	GAWDY	MINETTE	SMYTH
BRERETON	GAWDY 2	MORE	STAPYLTON
BROWNE	GAWDY LETTICE	ORIGINAL 1	STIFFKEY
BRYSKETT	GIFFARD	ORIGINAL 2	STOCKWELL
CARY	GIFFARD 2	ORIGINAL 3	STUART
CECIL	GRENE	ORIGINAL 4	THYNNE 2
CHAMBERLAIN	HADDOCK	OSBORNE	TIXALL
CHARLES	HADDOCK 2	OXINDEN	TIXALL 2
CLERK	HAMILTON	OXINDEN EXTRA	VERSTEGAN
CLIFFORD	HARINGTON	PAGET	WANLEY
CONWAY	HARLEY	PARKHURST	WENTWORTH
CORIE	HART	PASTON	WESA
CORNWALLIS	HARVEY	PASTON EXTRA	WHARTON
COSIN	HASTINGS	PASTON KATHERINE	WILLOUGHBY
CROMWELL	HATTON	PEPYS	WILMOT
DERBY	HATTON 2	PEPYS 2	WOOD
DUPPA	HENRY	PEPYS 3	WYATT
EDMONDES	HENRY VIII	PETTY	
ELYOT	HENSLOWE	PETTY 2	

Number of collections: 126

Number of words 1500–1699: 2,873,328

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Table 4: All CEEC-400 collections with letters from 1500–1699 that retain word-initial and/or word-medial <u/v>-variation

Collection name	CEEC subcorpus	Collection name	CEEC subcorpus
BASIRE	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	HENRY VIII	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
BETTS	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	HENSLOWE	CEEC-1998 (part in PCEEC)
BRERETON	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	HOSKYN	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
BRYSKETT	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	HUTTON	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
CARY	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	JONSON	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
CECIL	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	KNYVETT	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
CHARLES	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	KNYVETT 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
CLERK	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	LISLE	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
CORNWALLIS	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	MARVELL	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
CROMWELL	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	MORE	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
DERBY	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	ORIGINAL 1	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
EDMONDES	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	ORIGINAL 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
FERRAR	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	PAGET	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
FFARINGTON	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	PARKHURST	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
FLEMING	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	PASTON	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
FLEMING 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	PASTON EXTRA	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
FOX	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	PASTON KATHERINE	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
GAWDY	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	PLUMPTON 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
GAWDY 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	ROYAL 1	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
GAWDY LETTICE	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	ROYAL 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
GRENE	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	STOCKWELL	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
HAMILTON	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	THYNNE 2	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
HARLEY	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	WENTWORTH	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
HART	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)	WYATT	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)
HARVEY	CEEC-1998 (PCEEC)		

Number of collections: 49

Number of words 1500–1699: 908,164

Table 5: Data for Figures 3 and 4 (word-initial <u/v>: all alternants in EEBO, UP* + UN* only in ETED and CEEC)

Corpus	Word count	No. of instances	
		<u>*	<v>*
EEBO	1.42m	c.6–7,000	c.18–19,000
CEEC	0.91m	2,740	4,371
ETED	0.27m	584	1,430

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Table 6: Data for Figures 5 and 6 (word-medial <u/v>: HAVE in ETED and CEEC)

Corpus	Word count	No. of instances	
		<have>	<haue>
CEEC	0.91m	3,853	4,389
ETED	0.27m	343	356

Table 7: Data for Figure ?? (epenthetic <aun> in EEBO, ETED and CEEC)

Corpus	Word count	No. of instances
EEBO	1.42m	c.3,000
CEEC	2.87m	4,956
ETED, 1560–1719	0.23m	282

7.0.5 Figure 10

CEEC, 0.82m words.

The counts for Figure ?? are smaller than in other figures showing <u/v>-variation data from CEEC because Figure ?? only incorporates data where the letter-writer’s birth decade is known. There are 730 writers in CEEC writing between 1500–1699; the birth year is only known for 377 of them, of whom 169 occur in the <u/v>-reliable subcorpus.

Table 8: Data for Figures 8 and 9 (word-initial and word-medial <u/v>: all alternants in ETED)

	No. of instances	
	Word-initial	Word-medial
<u>	704	17,975
<v>	2,564	3,909
Total	3,268	21,884

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Table 9: Data for Figure ?? (word-initial and -medial <u/v>: HAVE and UP* + UN* in the CEEC)

	No. of instances		
	New form	Old form	% new form
HAVE	3,508 <have>	3,733 <haue>	48.45 %
UP*	930 <up>*	1,294 <vp>*	41.82 %
UN*	1,388 <un>*	2,415 <vn>*	36.50 %

Chapter 10

Literary dialect, dialect literature and folklore

Oliver Currie

Folklore is a rich source for the study Late Modern English non-standard dialects, but an underresearched one compared to literary dialect and dialect literature. This chapter explores variation in the use of Standard English and different English dialects (Derbyshire, Lancashire, Lincolnshire, Shropshire, Suffolk and Yorkshire) in a corpus of late 19th-century (1870–1898) published folktales. A continuum of dialect and standard use is observed ranging from texts wholly in standard, at one extreme, to texts wholly in dialect, at the other, and with mixed standard-dialect texts in between, typically with the narrative in standard and the dialogue partly or wholly in dialect. Underlying this continuum seems to be an association of dialect with dialogue or types of narration which are more inherently dialogue-like, such as first-person narration or quoted narration attributed to dialect-speaking characters. The extent of both inter- and intra-writer variation in the same text type suggests that folklorists/writers could select narration types more or less associated with dialect to vary the amount of dialect in their tales. It is argued that a number of different factors seem to have influenced the extent of dialect use in folktales, including folklorists' sources and methods, their own authorial identity (as standard or dialect writers), their target readership, as well as sociolinguistic and stylistic factors.

1 Introduction

1.1 The language of folklore collection and publication

Folklore is a largely overlooked source in English historical linguistics, yet it can provide a particularly interesting perspective on the use – and avoidance – of

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dialect and non-standard varieties (Widdowson 1987). Since it was deliberately collected from the least educated classes (Ó Giolláin 2022: 83), mostly at a time – in the 19th and early 20th centuries – when they still largely spoke dialect, folklore could be expected a priori to be a particularly favourable domain for dialect. Local tradition and lore, a central component of folklore, was, moreover, also a typical subject matter of dialect literature. Yet, while there are some notable folktale collections in dialect such as Marie Clothilde Balfour’s and Mabel Peacock’s legends and folktales from Lincolnshire (Balfour 1891a,c,b; Peacock 1886), published 19th-century English folktale collections were often predominantly or exclusively in Standard English. The folklorist and dialectologist Sidney Oldall Addy’s statement in the introduction to his collection of *Household Tales* from the counties of Yorkshire, Derbyshire, Nottinghamshire and Lincolnshire – “[a]s nearly as I could manage it, the tales are given in the very words of the narrators. I have hardly attempted to reproduce dialect” (Addy 1895: ix) – encapsulates this fundamental paradox concerning the language of 19th-century English folktale collections. Despite a concern for authenticity, the original language or dialect of folklore was not always preserved.

Addy’s words “I have *hardly* attempted to reproduce dialect” [my emphasis] are ambiguous, as “hardly” could be interpreted as meaning either that he did not even attempt to reproduce any dialect or that he only reproduced very little dialect. Given that some, though only a small minority of Addy’s tales do, in fact, include some limited dialect dialogue or sporadic dialect words and phrases, it seems that the second interpretation is more likely. Nevertheless, Addy’s comment seems to suggest, on the one hand, significant use of dialect by his informants and, on the other hand, a presumption against publishing tales in dialect. Addy does not specify the reasons for not using more dialect; he may have felt that there were self-evident practical and commercial reasons for using Standard English. Dialectal spelling may have been difficult to reproduce consistently for several different dialects, especially for those other than his native one (that of northeast Derbyshire and the Sheffield area). He may also have considered that using dialect would have made the texts less accessible. Yet, Addy was also a dialectologist (Ashton 1997) and, interestingly, in a debate on the “collection of folklore” in the 1902 volume of the journal *Folklore*, he was the only one of six folklorists to explicitly stress the importance of recording folklore in the original dialect. Addy’s words in this debate curiously echo his words in the introduction to his folktale collection quoted above where he opted not to “reproduce dialect”:

In writing a thing down it is best to use the very words ond [sic] dialect, if

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possible, of the narrator, and one should try to avoid translating into conventional or literary form (Addy et al. 1902: 299).

Given the relative abundance in 19th and early 20th-century English literature of LITERARY DIALECT – where *dialect is recreated* in the dialogue of texts otherwise primarily written in standard English to represent non-standard speech – as well as of DIALECT LITERATURE (Shorrocks 1996; Beal 2006; Hodson 2017: 1), it is perhaps even more of a paradox that dialect often has at best only a marginal presence in published folklore texts, including ones which had been orally collected such as Addy's *Household Tales* (Addy 1895) and where much of the source material was likely *already in dialect*.

1.2 Scope and research questions

This chapter explores the factors which may have influenced the use or avoidance of dialect in 19th-century folklore publications, focusing on folk narratives (e.g. folk and fairy tales, legends, anecdotes). The aim of this contribution is not to undertake a comprehensive study of the use (or avoidance) of dialect in English 19th-century folklore collections, but rather a more limited and exploratory corpus study of variation between standard and dialect in different types of publications which include folktales. The focus, therefore, is on publications where there is some use of dialect (ranging from systematic to residual), where there is variation in the use of standard and dialect, or where there is evidence of a change in the use of standard and dialect (for example from oral sources to the first written publication, or from written sources to their republication). This study investigates the following research questions (RQ1-RQ3):

- RQ1. What factors influenced language choice between standard and dialect as well as the way and extent to which dialect is used in published folktales?
- RQ2. Is there an association between the use of dialect and dialogue, that is does dialect tend to be used more frequently in dialogue than narrative or in tales with a more dialogic or conversational style of narration (e.g. first-person narration, narration involving interaction with the listener or quoted narration)?
- RQ3. To what extent can the use of dialect in folktales be described in terms of the literary dialect vs. dialect literature distinction (Shorrocks 1996: 386)?

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The rest of this chapter is structured as follows. The next section (Section 2) discusses the concepts of literary dialect and dialect literature and how they relate to folklore. Section 3 presents the corpus used for the study and the methods to analyse the use of dialect vs. standard. Section 4 then presents the analysis of the patterns of dialect vs. standard use in the corpus, focusing on how much dialect is used in the tales and where (e.g. dialogue vs. narrative), and on how the different folklorists'/writers' use of sources, intended audiences and types of narration impinge on the use of dialect or standard. Section 5 discusses more broadly the different factors – textual, sociolinguistic, stylistic, cultural, scholarly – which seem to have influenced the use of dialect and standard in published folktales and how these factors interacted with each other. Finally, Section 6 presents the conclusions.

2 Folklore and written dialect

2.1 The study of dialect and folklore

This study of the use of dialect in folklore draws on two broad strands of scholarship: sociolinguistic studies of Late Modern English written dialect, on the one hand, and historically focused studies of British folkloristics, on the other. The former have tended to focus on the representation of dialect and non-standard speech in texts, which has been investigated from a range of different perspectives. These viewpoints include the reliability of written texts as source for spoken dialect and the analysis of historic spoken dialects using written texts (Beal 2006; Honeybone & Maguire 2020); sociolinguistic variation between standard and non-standard dialects in written texts (Hakala 2017; Cooper 2025); the enregisterment of non-standard dialects and their indexical social meanings both in written texts and wider society (Beal 2017, Cooper 2020, 2025, García 2020); and the literary function of dialect in written texts (Hodson 2014; Broadhead 2017).

Hodson (2017: 3) stresses the interdisciplinary nature of the study of literary dialect as “stand[ing] on the cusp between several different disciplines, most notably dialectology and literary criticism, but also history of the English language, sociolinguistics, corpus linguistics, stylistics and folklore”, significantly mentioning folklore as one of the relevant disciplines. Folklore texts have also been included as sources for the sociolinguistic study of written dialect such as, for example, in the *Salamanca Corpus* of English dialect texts (Ruano-García et al. 2011; García 2020) as well as in Cooper (2020, 2025). However, sociolinguistic studies of written dialect have generally tended to focus on literary dialect and

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dialect literature texts; insofar as folklore texts have been included as sources for the sociolinguistic study of Late Modern English dialects, they have generally not been studied specifically as folklore texts.

Historically focused studies of British folkloristics have, in turn, discussed the place of dialect in 19th and early 20th-century folklore collection as well the importance of folklore as a source for dialect (Widdowson 1987). Two key factors which influenced whether and how dialect was included in folklore publications were the intellectual focus of contemporary folklore research and the types of sources used. The Folklore Society, which was the most prominent institution for the study of folklore, organising regular meetings and publishing monographs as well as the scholarly journal *Folklore* (Dorson 1968: 266), focused more on the theory of folklore than on its collection in the field. A consequence of this theoretical focus was a rather limited output of published collections of English folklore, which were rather “haphazard and random” in their regional coverage, tended not to “set down literal texts” and “mixed written and oral sources” (Dorson 1968: 320–321). The focus on folklore theory and written sources meant that little in the way of dialect texts tended to be included in such publications. At the same time, however, as Ashton (1997) and Roper (2012: 246–250; Roper 2019) have shown, there were regional folklorists who collected local folklore and studied their local dialects. Some folklorists with interests in their local dialects, such as Sidney Oldall Addy (Ashton 1997) and Mabel Peacock, collected and published regionally at the same time as contributing to the national Folklore Society journal *Folklore*.

Studies of the place of dialect in English 19th-century folkloristics have tended to focus on two areas: dialect scholarship (Ashton 1997; Roper 2012; Roper 2019: 404–406; Townend 2024: 219–231), on the one hand, and the textualization of the vernacular, that is how oral dialect is recorded and represented in written texts (Haase 2002: xviii–xx; James 2013; Teverson 2013: 38–42; Roper 2019: 407–408). The focus and approach are different here, in that the present study uses a corpus to empirically examine folklorists’ use of dialect vs. standard in folktales from an interdisciplinary – sociolinguistic and folkloristics – perspective. The studies of Ashton (1997), Roper (2012, 2019), James (2013), Young (2022) and Townend (2024) are also interdisciplinary – combining dialectology, folkloristics, philology and intellectual history – but focus more on folklorists’ dialect scholarship rather than, as here, on linguistic variation between standard and dialect in published folk narratives.

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2.2 The literary dialect vs. dialect literature distinction

The distinction, introduced by Shorrocks (1996), between LITERARY DIALECT, on the one hand, and DIALECT LITERATURE, on the other, has been central to the analysis of the use of dialect in written texts. Shorrocks' defines the terms as follows:

I shall use *literary dialect* to refer to the representation of non-standard speech in literature that is otherwise written in standard English (for instance some of the dialogue in the works of such writers as Eliot, Dickens and Hardy) and aimed at general readership; (*non-standard*) *dialect literature*, by contrast will refer to works composed wholly (sometimes partly) in a non-standard dialect, and aimed essentially, though, not exclusively, at a non-standard-dialect speaking readership. (Shorrocks 1996: 386) [original emphasis]

Although it has provided an important reference point in the study of written dialect, Shorrocks' binary distinction between literary dialect and dialect literature has been criticised as being too narrow and simple (Hodson 2014: 116–117; Broadhead 2017; Honeybone & Maguire 2020: 10–14). Hodson (2014: 116) argues that the boundary between literary dialect and dialect literature is a “permeable one”, as the audience of a text can change over time, if a text acquires “an audience beyond that they were originally intended for”. Hodson (2014: 116) and Broadhead (2017: 69) further argue that books comprising collections of texts tend to be more problematic to categorise than individual texts, as they may include both texts entirely in dialect originally intended for a dialect-speaking audience and texts wholly in Standard English. Shorrocks' distinction relies on two key criteria – the proportion of the text in dialect and its intended audience – and assumes these criteria coincide in a specific way. Dialect literature texts tend to have more dialect as well as an intended audience of dialect speakers. Texts with literary dialect, on the other hand, are primarily in standard and are intended for a general readership. Broadhead (2017: 69) argues, however, that these two criteria need not coincide in this way, as texts written in dialect by certain writers, such as William Barnes who wrote poetry in the Dorset dialect as well as in Standard English, aimed their work at both a local and general readership. Indeed, I would further argue that certain folklore texts such as Marie Clothilde Balfour's *Legends of the Lincolnshire Cars* (Balfour 1891a,c,b) do not fit neatly into Shorrocks' literary dialect vs. dialect literature distinction either because of this mismatch between the proportion of dialect and intended audience

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criteria. The *Legends of the Lincolnshire Cars* are written entirely in Lincolnshire dialect – though Balfour, their collector, was not a native dialect speaker – and were published in the scholarly journal *Folklore* and aimed primarily at a learned, folklorist readership.

Honeybone & Maguire (2020: 10–11) recognise the importance of Shorrocks' criteria but argue that a “two-way distinction is too simple to encompass all kinds of dialect writing”. They propose reconfiguring the two criteria – “the proportion of text in non-standard spelling” (in their conceptualisation) and the intended audience – as “two clines” in a “two dimensional ‘DIALECT WRITING SPACE’” (Honeybone & Maguire 2020: 11). The proportion of text in non-standard spelling could range from the whole text to only the speech of certain characters, and the intended audience could range from all readers of English to only dialect speakers. In the dialect writing space “literary dialect and dialect literature are not completely distinct categories, but are prototypes of the extremes of difference that is possible given these two clines” (Honeybone & Maguire 2020: 11). Texts can be situated at any point within the dialect writing space, enabling any number of intersections of the two clines. The two dimensions – proportion of text in non-standard and intended audience – are themselves more than one dimensional, though, as they encompass both quantitative clines (more or less non-standard spelling and a larger or smaller intended audience) and qualitative sociolinguistic differentiation (the textual contexts of non-standard spelling and the socio-cultural characterisation of the intended audience).

2.3 Folklore and the literary dialect vs. dialect literature distinction

Since all three textual categories – literary dialect, dialect literature and folklore – overlap, they may be seen as problematic: a publication could be categorised as literary dialect, dialect literature and folklore all at the same time. James Bowker's *Goblin Tales of Lancashire* (Bowker 1883), for example, is folklore in terms of subject matter and presentation: goblin and ghost tales legends associated with different places in Lancashire, together with a discussion of folk superstitions in the notes. Bowker does not, however, provide much information on his sources. While it seems likely that he had oral sources – he speaks in his introduction of “the fairy and folk stories it was my good fortune to *hear* in the county and moorland districts” (Bowker 1883: 25) [my emphasis] – he may have substantially or even completely rewritten them, including the sections in Lancashire dialect, so it is not possible to tell to what extent the dialect is reproduced from oral sources or is Bowker's own recreation (i.e. classic dialect literature).

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Four of Bowker's 26 tales (25 prose and one verse) are predominantly in dialect. All 26 tales as well as the introduction and most of the notes were originally published in the weekly Manchester-based newspaper *Ben Brierley's Journal* 1874–1875, then republished in 1883 in book form by Swan Sonnenschein & Co in their *The Fairy Tales of all Nations* series. Bowker's four predominantly dialect tales would therefore meet the twin criteria for non-standard dialect literature, being dialect in form and aimed (at least when initially published in *Ben Brierley's Journal*) at a predominantly local and dialect-speaking readership. Bowker also composed dialect literature and had a Lancashire dialect poem "Hard Times; or, Th'Weyvur to his Wife" included in Harland's anthology *Ballads and Songs of Lancashire* (Harland 1875: 512–514; Evans & Axon-Waters 2025: 103). At the same time, six other tales in Bowker's collection resemble literary dialect in that they are mostly in Standard English with only part of the dialogue in dialect. Bowker's collection could, further, be argued to show a continuum with Standard English literature (without literary dialect), as there are also five tales in the collection exclusively in Standard English.

The fluid and overlapping nature of the categories literary dialect and dialect literature raises the question to what extent they are helpful terms for understanding written dialect use in late Modern English. Townend's (2024) recent monograph on dialect in Victorian England, which is particularly broad in its scope, encompassing dialect scholarship, philology, literature as well as folklore, does not use the terms literary dialect and dialect literature, but is instead organised around a central theme of dialect philology. Given that writing dialect "commonly involves respelling", that is "abandoning the standard spelling of a word or phrase" (Honeybone & Maguire 2020: 3), Townend argues that dialect writing can be seen as a conscious deviation from Standard English, which in turn presupposes literacy based on Standard English. Townend further argues, like Hodson (2017: 1), that dialect writing went hand in hand with dialect philology:

Most obviously: in addition to other social factors, it is not likely to be a coincidence that dialect compositions came to be more frequently printed, and more widely valued, during the same decades when philological thinking was prominent in Britain. Philology enhanced the general standing of dialect, not only its collection and analysis. Furthermore, all written dialect literature must be in some way artificial, in that its literate composers, even if they are dialect speakers themselves, begin with a pre-knowledge of Standard English as their first written language, and thus they have to devise

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a new system of spelling to represent their dialect: a significant degree of self-conscious linguisticism is involved (Townend 2024: 114).

Philology is certainly pertinent to the study of the use of dialect in folklore here: an interest in folklore was often intertwined with a philological interest in dialects. Some of the folklorists included in the present corpus study were also dialectologists (William E. A. Axon, Sidney Oldall Addy, Richard Blakeborough and Mabel Peacock) or dialect writers (William E. A. Axon, Richard Blakeborough, James Bowker, Mabel Peacock) or indeed all three – folklorists, dialectologists and dialect writers – at the same time (Axon, Blakeborough and Peacock). Some published folklore collections also contained dialect glossaries or grammars and, conversely, some works primarily on dialect included chapters on and examples of folklore (Blakeborough 1898; Peacock 1886; Ashton 1997). In some cases, a specific interest in dialect may have motivated some folklorists (e.g. Marie Clothilde Balfour and Mabel Peacock) to publish their tales in dialect, though an interest in dialect (as in Addy's case) did not necessarily mean publishing folktales in dialect.

Given the fluidity of the concepts literary dialect and dialect literature, and given the fact that certain folktale collections – e.g. Bowker's *Goblin Tales of Lancashire* – could be categorised as both literary dialect and dialect literature at the same time, I do not consider it meaningful to attempt to categorise systematically individual texts or collections of folktales included in the corpus as dialect literature or literary dialect. However, it is pertinent to analyse the corpus texts in terms of the amount of dialect they contain as well as in terms of their likely intended audience. Honeybone and Maguire's dialect writing space provides a more practical and insightful framework, though even using this more comprehensive and flexible model is not always straightforward, as indeed is the case with Bowker's *Goblin Tales of Lancashire*. Nevertheless, I would argue that the interest of the dialect writing space conceptualisation is less in providing a universal categorisation tool than in providing a more nuanced understanding of how the use and extent of dialectal respelling, on the one hand, and intended audience, on the other, interact.

3 Methodology and corpus

3.1 Defining folklore

As a starting point for defining folklore and providing a basis for determining what kind of texts to include in the corpus, I am using the following definition

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of folklore from the second edition of *The Handbook of Folklore* published by the Folklore Society in 1914, which was revised and enlarged by Charlotte Sophia Burne:

THE word Folk-Lore literally, “the learning of the people” was coined in 1846 by the late Mr. W. J. Thoms to replace the earlier expression “popular antiquities.” It has established itself as the generic term under which the traditional Beliefs, Customs, Stories, Songs, and Sayings current among backward peoples, or retained by the uncultured classes of more advanced peoples, are comprehended and included. It comprises early and barbaric beliefs about the world of Nature, animate and inanimate; about human nature and things made by man; about a spirit world and man’s relations with it; about witchcraft, spells, charms, amulets, luck, omens, disease, and death. It further includes customs and rites as to marriage and inheritance, childhood and adult life, and as to festivals, warfare, hunting, fishing, cattle-keeping, etc.; also myths, legends, folk-tales, ballads, songs, proverbs, riddles, and nursery rhymes (Burne 1914: 1)

Although this second edition of *The Handbook of Folklore* was published later than the corpus texts analysed (which date from 1870–1898), Burne’s definition of folklore is essentially consistent with that in George Laurence Gomme’s first edition of the handbook (Gomme 1890: 1–7). Folklore can be understood on multiple levels in Burne’s definition. A first level is that of the text: Burne (1914: 1) categorises “myths, legends, folk-tales, ballads, songs, proverbs, riddles, and nursery rhymes” as folklore text-types or genres. A second level concerns the more intangible manifestations of folklore: beliefs, customs and practices. A third level is the notion of “tradition”, i.e. beliefs, customs, practices as well as texts that are handed down via oral transmission from generation to generation within a community. A fourth level is folklore the discipline, today folkloristics, which defines what is of key interest in the study of folklore. Folklore texts and practices are considered of particular interest as supposed relics of an earlier primitive human culture. Folklore is considered to be “the expression of the psychology of early man” and, accordingly, there is a focus on collecting from “backward peoples” or “the uncultured classes of more advanced peoples”, as they were considered to have best preserved folklore (Burne 1914: 1).

In theory, all the different levels of folklore are interconnected. Thus, a folktale is considered folklore not just because of its genre, but as a text which is traditional and has been orally transmitted. Further, a folktale, most obviously in the case of subgenres such as goblin or ghost stories which are associated

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with superstitions, may reveal something of a community's traditional beliefs and in turn be one of the means of transmitting such beliefs. Finally, folktales are of interest as an object of academic study to the folklorist because tale types or motifs recur across cultures, and cross-cultural comparison may shed light on an ancient cultural inheritance or alternatively on cultural diffusion. However, *prima facie* folklore publications show great variation in terms of their sources (oral vs. written), methods, focus (e.g. scholarly, literary or popular) and likely intended audience, so defining them in terms of all the different levels discussed above can be problematic. In the following two sections, I discuss this variation and its potential significance for the use of dialect or standard in folklore publications using examples from the corpus compiled for this study, while at the same time explaining the rationale for the composition of the corpus.

3.2 Composition of the corpus

Nine different folktale collections are included in the corpus. Table 1 lists the different sources showing (from left to right) the collection (bibliographical citation with pages), the publication type, the English counties from where the tales originate, the genres of the folktales and the number of tales in each collection. Overall, there are ten corpus items, since one collection – Richard Blakeborough's *Wit, Character, Folklore & Customs of the North Riding of Yorkshire* (Blakeborough 1898) – has been split for the purposes of analysis into two sub-collections of different genres and possibly also different source and composition types: comic anecdotes illustrating Yorkshire character (abbreviated as “Blake C” in Tables 2-6) and witchcraft tales (abbreviated as “Blake W”). The tenth corpus item in Table 1, five folktales from Joseph Jacobs' anthologies, are retellings of tales from other collections in the corpus: Anna Walter Thomas's two tales originally published in 1877 and 1878 in *The Ipswich Journal* and then republished by Jacobs in *English Fairy Tales* in 1890, and three tales from Marie Clothilde Balfour's *Legends of the Lincolnshire Cars* first published in the *Folklore* journal and republished by Jacobs in *More English Fairy Tales* in 1894. Jacob's tales were included in the corpus to examine how the use of dialect could change when tales were republished. Jacobs edited out much of the Suffolk dialectal features in Walter Thomas' tales *Tom Tit Tot* and *Cap o'Rushes*, while retaining the colloquial style and non-standard forms.¹ Jacobs also translated Balfour's three tales from Lincolnshire dialect into Standard English.

¹See Teverson (2013: 38–42) for a discussion of the publication history of *Tom Tit Tot* and Haase (2002: xxiii–xxv) for the publication history of *Cap o' Rushes*.

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Table 1: Composition of corpus

Collection	Publication type	Region	Tale genres	N° tales
Axon (1870: 11–20, 44–51, 53–89)	Book – local collection	Lancs.	Local legends	3
Bowker (1883)	Local news-paper (1874–1875); book (1883)	Lancs.	Goblin, ghost legends	25
Walter Thomas (1877, 1878) [AWT]; Gurdon and Clodd (1893: 43–48)	Local news-paper (1877–1878); Folklore Society: county survey (1893)	Suff.	Wonder tales	2
Peacock (1886: 60–108)	Book – local collection	Lincs.	Legends, droll, anecdotes	9
Burne (1883)	County folklore survey	Salop.	Local legends; witchcraft goblin, ghost	47
Balfour (1891a,c,b)	Folklore Society: <i>Folklore</i> journal	Lincs.	Local & goblin, droll	10
Addy (1895: 1–53)	Book – local collection	Yorks., Derbys., Notts., Lincs.	Wonder tales, local legends, religious / superstition	52
Blakeborough (1898: 1–16)	Book – local collection	North Yorks.	Comic anecdotes	15
Blakeborough (1898: 153–209)	Book – local collection	North Yorks.	Witchcraft legends	26
Jacobs (2002: 19–24, 48–51, 213–218, 259–263, 273–278)	National anthologies (1890, 1894): reedition of AWT’s and 3 of Balfour’s tales	Suff., Lincs.	Wonder tales, droll, goblin tales	5
Total n° tales				194

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The aim in compiling the corpus was to include a variety of different publication types with tales from different regions of England and examples of different dialects. The corpus collections include tales collected in or originating from eight different English counties – Lancashire, Yorkshire (the North Riding and Sheffield area), Derbyshire, Nottinghamshire, Lincolnshire, Shropshire and Suffolk – and six different dialects: Lancashire (Axon and Bowker), Yorkshire (Blakeborough), northeast Derbyshire (Addy), Shropshire (Burne) and north Lincolnshire (Peacock and Balfour) and Suffolk (Walter Thomas).

3.3 Intended readerships

The publication type in Table 1 can provide an indication whether the corpus folktale collections were scholarly or more popular publications and what their intended readerships might have been. Only Jacobs in his fairy tale anthologies explicitly states his intended readership, though, as Haase (2002) shows, he seems to do so in deliberately confusing way:

[...] *English Fairy Tales* and *More English Fairy Tales* deliberately throw into question the conventional boundary between folklore and literary culture. Jacobs does this by inviting confusion over his intended audience. While he states clearly in the prefaces to both of these collections that he assembled and rewrote the tales for children, he makes equally distinct, if contradictory, gestures that he also envisions an audience of folklorists (Haase 2002: xvi).

Besides Jacobs' anthologies, five other corpus folktale collections – those of Bowker, Burne, Balfour, Addy and Blakeborough – contain scholarly discussions of folklore in the introduction or notes. Of these, Balfour's and Burne's publications are perhaps more likely to have been aimed at a narrower, more scholarly readership: Balfour's tales as they were published in the scholarly *Folklore* journal, Burne's because they are published in a scholarly format, embedded in discursive prose rather than grouped together as a series of standalone tales. While Addy's collection also devotes more space to the discussion of "traditional remains" (pages 55–151) than his "household tales" (pages 1–52), his folktales could easily be read as standalone tales for entertainment, as they are presented accessibly, grouped together at the beginning of the book. Addy's collection could, thus, have had a wider intended audience, both scholarly and popular. Bowker's goblin tales, while also having contextual notes, seem to have been published in *Ben Brierley's Journal* primarily for entertainment.

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Blakeborough's *Wit, Character, Folklore & Customs of the North Riding of Yorkshire* seems to have been aimed at a local Yorkshire readership specifically interested in Yorkshire dialect and traditions. The addresses in the list of subscribers are predominantly local, and the back matter includes a full-page advertisement for Blakeborough's "public and private humorous recitals of his character sketches in the Yorkshire dialect (as spoken in the North Riding)". At the same time, however, the content seems to have been made accessible to non-Yorkshire readers. Yorkshire dialect only occurs in dialogue, while the narrative and discussion are in Standard English. He states, for example, before telling the story of the reputed witch Dolly Maikin "[f]or the benefit of my readers, I will give the story literally but in standard English" (Blakeborough 1898: 155). Mabel Peacock's *Tales and Rhymes in the Lindsey Folk-Speech*, which are exclusively in Lincolnshire dialect, on the other hand, seem to be more unambiguously aimed at a local readership, as well as potentially readers with a scholarly or amateur interest in folklore and dialect.

4 Dialect vs. standard use in folktale corpus

4.1 Extent of dialect use

To assess how much dialect was used in the corpus texts, their language was categorised into four different degrees of varying standard or dialect use: texts wholly in standard or in standard with the occasional dialect form, mixed standard-dialect texts mostly in standard, mixed standard-dialect texts mostly in dialect and texts wholly in dialect. Table 2 shows the number of tales in each category of degree of standard vs. dialect use for each corpus folktale collection.

Two of the corpus collections – Balfour's and Peacock's Lincolnshire tales – are wholly in dialect. Both Balfour and Peacock seem to have made conscious decisions to use dialect as much as possible: Balfour to transcribe the folktales "exactly as told" to her (Balfour 1891a: 149), and Peacock to provide for "Lincolnshire folk" tales "in their own words about their own ways", the like of which were already available for Lancashire and Yorkshire (Peacock 1886: v).² Axon's three

²Balfour's legends have sparked controversy. The authenticity of the tales has been questioned, largely on the grounds that they were considered to be unusual compared to other folktales (Philip 1992: 156; Roper 2019: 402). Lincolnshire folklorist Ethel Rudkin also criticised Balfour's recording of Lincolnshire dialect as "shocking" (Rudkin 1955: 396). However, Maureen James's comprehensive study of Balfour's Lincolnshire legends in her PhD thesis challenges the rejections of Balfour's tales as inauthentic, noting that the scholars who dismissed them had not studied "the actual historical, social and cultural context in which the *Legends* were gath-

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Table 2: Extent of use of dialect vs. standard (STD) in corpus texts

Collection	Total tales n°	STD only or STD with oc- casional dialect forms	Mixed - more STD	Mixed - more Dialect	Text wholly in Dialect
Axon	3	-	0	1	2
Bowker	25	8	13	4	-
AWT	2	1	-	-	1
Peacock	9	-	-	-	9
Burne	47	33	7	1	6
Balfour	10	-	-	-	10
Addy	52	46	6	-	-
Blake (C)	15	-	11	3	1
Blake (W)	26	8	17	1	-
Jacobs	5	5	-	-	-
Tales n°	194	101	54	10	29

Lancashire tales are also predominantly in dialect: two tales wholly in dialect and the third tale all in dialect except for the speech of one non-dialect-speaking character.

Jacobs and Addy, in contrast to Balfour and Peacock, made conscious decisions to limit dialect use in their collections, which have the least dialect in the corpus. Jacobs deliberately “soften[ed] down overabundant dialect” in his written sources (Jacobs 2002: 189), while Addy “hardly reproduced the dialect” of his informants (Addy 1895: ix). Four of Jacob’s five tales in the corpus selections which have dialect sources have only retained residual dialectal forms, while the fifth tale is exclusively in standard. Of Addy’s 52 tales, 41 are exclusively in Standard English, five have only the odd dialect word, four have dialect quotations (rhymes or a full sentence), one tale has some of the dialogue (the speech of

ered or considered the motives of Balfour” (James 2013: 195). James argues cogently that the tales seem more likely to have genuinely been recorded from oral tradition rather than made up by Balfour herself and also considers “Balfour’s efforts to record the stories in dialect” as “serious, though perhaps misguided” (James 2013: 203–204). Philip actually revised his earlier assessment of Balfour’s tales as falsified in light of James’s PhD thesis (Philip 2022: xviii).

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a local dialect-speaking character) in dialect, and one tale has all the dialogue in dialect. Interestingly, the eleven tales with some dialect were all collected in Addy's native northeast Derbyshire; none of the tales from Nottinghamshire, Lincolnshire or the East Riding of Yorkshire have any traces of dialect. The fact that the dialect is limited to tales from his native area may indicate that Addy only felt comfortable writing his native dialect. It might also reflect his collection methods: he may have collected the tales from his local area from informants he knew and whom he spoke dialect to or who were comfortable speaking dialect to him, while outside his local area he may have solicited tales only in Standard English, or potentially enlisted the help of third parties.

The remaining four corpus folktale collections – of Walter Thomas, Bowker, Burne and Blakeborough – show the most intra-writer variation in the use of standard and dialect as well as the most mixing of standard and dialect in individual tales. Walter Thomas has one tale (*Tom Tit Tot*) in dialect and the other (*Cap o' Rushes*) mostly in standard except with occasional dialect and non-standard forms. In an 1898 letter to the *Times* published some twenty years after the tales were published in *The Ipswich Journal*, Walter Thomas states that the dialect in the tale *Tom Tit Tot* was that of a servant who had narrated the tale to her as a child many years previously, though interestingly the same servant also seems to have been the source of the second tale, which is mostly in standard (Teverson 2013: 40; Haase 2002: xxiii).

The nature of the mixing of standard and dialect is, however, different in Walter Thomas compared to the other authors who show intra-writer variation (Addy, Axon, Blakeborough, Bowker and Burne). In the latter authors, there seems to be a clear distinction between sections in dialect and sections in standard. The sections in dialect have frequent dialectal respelling, while the sections in standard have no dialectal respelling except for the occasional dialectal term or name. In contrast, the variation in the use of dialect between Walter Thomas' tales *Tom Tit Tot* and *Cap o' Rushes* involves a difference in the frequency and density rather than in the presence or absence of non-standard or dialectal forms. Dialectal or non-standard forms occur throughout both tales, in the narrative and dialogue, though are less frequent in *Cap o' Rushes* than in *Tom Tit Tot*. The style of *Cap o' Rushes* and *Tom Tit Tot* is also colloquial throughout – in both the narrative and dialogue – whereas in the mixed dialect-standard tales of Addy, Blakeborough and Bowker, in particular, there is a clear differentiation between narrative in literary Standard English and dialogue (or part of the dialogue) in colloquial dialect.

The case of Walter Thomas' tales highlights a broader dilemma concerning the categorization of written dialect: how much dialectal respelling is necessary

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for a text to be considered dialect? Not only do authors vary in their density of non-standard spelling, but the same text could potentially be perceived differently depending on the reader's perspective. A text such as Walter Thomas' *Cap o' Rushes*, for instance, could be perceived by a reader who is predominantly a speaker of Standard English and unfamiliar with the local dialect as a text in Standard English with occasional non-standard forms. On the other hand, even a small minority of respelled forms could provide a sufficient cue for a reader familiar with the local dialect to recognise a text as dialect and pronounce, when reading aloud, some of the standard spelled forms as non-standard, where these differ phonetically in the local dialect.

Of Burne's 47 tales from Shropshire, 33 are exclusively or almost exclusively in standard (28 standard only, five in standard with the occasional dialect form), seven are mixed with more standard than dialect (six in standard with only the occasional dialect sentence/quotation and one mostly in standard but with more frequent instances of dialect), and six tales are wholly in dialect. While Burne and her colleague Georgina Jackson collected much of their folklore orally and transcribed at least some texts in dialect, the preponderance of standard seems to reflect the scholarly focus and organisation of the work. Burne's focus is describing and analysing folk beliefs rather than providing a collection of folktales. None of her tales are presented as standalone texts but are embedded in discursive prose in chapters on specific folklore topics (e.g. giants, ghosts, witchcraft). While the six tales wholly in dialect and mixed standard-dialect tales are presented in quotation marks as the words of the informants, 16 of the 33 tales wholly or almost wholly in standard are only in summary form. Burne states in her preface to *Shropshire Folk-lore* that she deliberately omitted dialect and "considerably modified" it, even where she tried to give "the actual words of the narrator" (Burne 1883: ix). Unlike Addy, Burne gives her reasons for not reproducing dialect, commenting that "strongly-marked dialect" would be "tiresome" for readers and it would have been difficult for her to reproduce dialects other than her native Staffordshire dialect:

In relating the Legends, I have endeavoured to give them in simple colloquial language, such as a nurse might use to a child, or an old parish clerk to an 'intelligent foreigner.' But in so doing I have usually omitted the dialect. Even where I have tried to give the actual words of the narrator, I have as a rule modified the dialect very considerably. First, because the use of any strongly-marked dialect makes a book tiresome to readers who are not interested in that especial subject, and secondly, because I doubt my own ability to reproduce, with sufficient accuracy, more than an occasional

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word or phrase of any dialect save the softened form of ‘Staffordshire,’ which is spoken around my own old home. (Burne 1883: ix).

Bowker and Blakeborough have more mixed dialect-standard texts than the other corpus collections – 17 out of Bowker’s 25 tales and 32 out of Blakeborough’s 41 tales – though, overall, both collections have more standard than dialect. Bowker has eight tales wholly or almost wholly in standard (five wholly in standard, three in standard with the occasional dialect form), 13 mixed texts mostly in standard (five of which have only the occasional dialect sentence or quotation), but no texts wholly in dialect and only four mixed texts mostly in dialect. Blakeborough has eight tales wholly or predominantly in standard (seven wholly in standard, one in standard with the occasional dialect form), 28 mixed tales mostly in standard (of which seven have only the occasional dialect sentence or quotation), but only one tale wholly in dialect and four mixed tales mostly in dialect. Blakeborough may have had specific textual and stylistic reasons for opting for mixed dialect-standard rather than wholly dialect tales. First, the work is a scholarly and also humorous discursive text where Blakeborough describes the characteristics of Yorkshire folk and folk traditions. Blakeborough’s illustrative narratives – anecdotes and legends – are embedded in this discursive text rather than being presented as standalone tales. Since Standard English, not dialect, is the language of scholarly discursive prose, any Yorkshire-dialect folk narratives would have to appear embedded within a Standard English frame narrative, within a bilingual standard-dialect as opposed to a monolingual dialect-only environment. Moreover, Blakeborough’s discursive Standard English authorial voice extends into the folk narratives themselves, since not only the third-person narrative but also his own speech in dialogue is in standard rather dialect, even when conversing with dialect-speaking informants, as illustrated in Extract 1:

- (1) The dear old lady who was my study for Mrs. Waddleton asked me to paint her a picture—‘*seea ez Ah s’all ’a’e summat ti leeak at ’at ya’ve deean yersel when ya’ve geean,*’ said she. I readily promised to do so, and in due course sent her a little snow scene.

A few days afterwards she saw me passing. ‘*Noo then,*’ she shouted, ‘*cum in wi’ ya. Ah’ve gitten ’t heng’d up, an’, mah wo’d, bud it leeaks grand, dizn’t it?*’ ‘**I am glad you like it,**’ said I, as I gazed at my work of art nestling amongst coloured grasses and peacock feathers; ‘**and very nicely you have arranged everything. But perhaps it would be better if you hung it up the right way up.**’ (Blakeborough 1898: 12) [My emphasis: italic – dialect; bold – Blakeborough’s own speech in Standard English]

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There also seems to be a specific stylistic rationale for the mixing of standard and Yorkshire dialect in the *Wit* section of the work. Much of the humour in this section exploits an us-them contrast between Yorkshire-folk and outsiders – in language and character – and involves the humorous interaction between them. In the anecdotes (e.g. Extracts 1, 2 and 3), Yorkshire people are typically represented as being down to earth, direct and with a quick repartee. Blakeborough relates an anecdote, quoted in Extract 2, about a school inspector from the south of England whose “southern twang” is misunderstood by Yorkshire school children (Moses, pronounced ‘Mouses’ in Blakeborough’s representation, is understood as the plural of ‘mouse’):

- (2) At one school in Wensleydale a South-country inspector, when examining a class on the Bible, put this question, ‘**Neow tell me something about Mouses.**’ ‘*Cats kill ’em,*’ was the prompt reply. (Blakeborough 1898: 15) [My emphasis: bold – Blakeborough’s representation of ‘southern twang’; italic – Yorkshire dialect]

In the lead up to the punchline, Blakeborough describes Yorkshire country-people as bilingual “in their mother tongue” (i.e. Yorkshire dialect) and “ordinary English”, that is Standard English, though knowing “ordinary English” does not mean they can understand “southern twang” (Blakeborough 1898: 15). Blakeborough’s characterisation of Yorkshire people as bilingual in Yorkshire dialect and Standard English may in turn give us an insight into his own bilingual dialect-standard writing. While dialect is used in the work to express Yorkshire identity and character, bilingual writing in dialect and standard – as well as writing about Yorkshire culture predominantly in standard – could also be seen as an expression of Yorkshire identity. As a Yorkshire dialect speaker and dialect writer collecting folklore and stories about his local area – the North Riding of Yorkshire – one might expect Blakeborough to have interacted with his informants in Yorkshire dialect. The bilingual standard-dialect and monolingual standard tales may, therefore, reflect partial translation from dialect into standard.

In Bowker’s case, as noted in Section 2.3, it is difficult to determine to what extent his sources may have influenced his use of standard or dialect, since he provides hardly any information about them and no information at all about how he wrote or edited his tales. An indication that Bowker is likely to have at least partly rewritten his tales is the way he frames them for a wider readership. He typically adds, especially at the beginning of the tales, descriptive passages setting the scene in a very literary Standard English. Such passages, as illustrated by the opening of the tale *The Fairy Funeral* quoted in Extract 3, seem to be aimed

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at the reader of a written text and to reflect Bowker's own authorial voice, so are unlikely to have been part of a tale narrated by an informant.

- (3) There are few spots in Lancashire more likely to have been peopled by fairies than that portion of the highway which runs along the end of Penwortham wood. At all times the locality is very beautiful, but it is especially so in summer, when the thin line of trees on the one side of the road and the rustling wood upon the other cast a welcome shade upon the traveller, who can rest against the old railings, and look down upon a rich expanse of meadow-land and cornfields, bounded in the distance by dim, solemn looking hills, and over the white farm-houses, snugly set in the midst of luxurious vegetation. (Bowker 1883: 83)

Where we do not have detailed information on folklorists' collection, editorial and (re)writing practices – as with Blakeborough, Bowker and Peacock – we can only try to surmise, if at all possible, by analysing the style and language of the texts themselves, how much of their texts may represent the recorded language of informants and how much the (re)created language of the folklorists.

4.2 Third-person narration without dialogue

The fact that we frequently find both standard and dialect in the same folktales raises the question where and how dialect and standard are used in such texts. To investigate this question, and more specifically the third research question (RQ3 in Section 1.2) whether the use of dialect is associated with dialogue, a more detailed analysis was carried out to identify where in each corpus text dialect or standard is used and whether the type of narration seems to influence the use of dialect. Three broad types of narration were distinguished: (1) tales with third-person narration without any dialogue, (2) tales with third-person narration and dialogue and (3) more dialogue-like or conversational narration (e.g. first-person frame narration, wholly first-person narrative and quoted narration). The narration types overlap, since a third-person narrative can have first-person frame narration, be embedded in dialogue or be presented as quoted (attributed to an informant or a character in a tale and put in quotation marks). This section (Section 4.2) analyses dialect vs. standard use in third-person narratives without dialogue, Section 4.3 in third-person narratives with dialogue and Section 4.4 in tales with first-person or dialogic narration.

The overlap between the narration types is reflected in the quantitative analysis of dialect vs. standard use in each section. Burne's tale about "tangled elflocks" in Extract 4, for instance, is narrated in the third person without dialogue

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but is also presented as the quoted words of the informant, which means that the whole tale is in effect in dialogue. This tale is, therefore, included both in Table 3 below, which shows dialect vs. standard use in tales with third-person narration without dialogue and in Tables 5 and 6 (in Section 4.4), which respectively show the numbers of tales with different types of dialogic narration (including quoted narration) and the different types of dialect use in tales with dialogic narration. There is, however, a much greater overlap between Table 4, on the one hand, which shows dialect vs. standard use in tales with (wholly or partly) third-person narration and dialogue, and Tables 5 and 6, on the other, since 29 tales combine third-person and first-person narration types, so are included in all three tables. As a result, the sum of the different types – third person without dialogue (Table 3), third person with dialogue (Table 4), first person/quoted/dialogic narration (Tables 5 and 6) – is greater (223) than the total number of tales in the corpus (194) in Tables 1 and 2.

Only a fifth of the tales in the corpus (38/194) have third-person narration without any dialogue (Table 3), and this type of narration seems to be the least favourable for dialect, with only one tale wholly in dialect compared to 31 tales wholly in standard and five in standard with occasional dialect words or quotations.

Tales from Burne's *Shropshire Folk-lore* make up the majority of the third-person narrative corpus tales without dialogue. As noted in Section 4.1, Burne presents a number of her tales in summary form in her own words in Standard English and these tales also have no dialogue. The only tales with continuous dialect in Burne's collection are presented in quotation marks as the words of informants. Five of Burne's six tales wholly in dialect have both narrative and dialogue, and only one (cited in Extract 4) is third-person narrative without dialogue, but is presented as the quoted words of the informant.

- (4) The tangled 'elf-locks' in horses' manes are still called 'witches' stirrups' among the Cleve Hills, where the following anecdote was heard in 1873: 'A waggoner w'en a went to sup up, used to fine 'is 'orses in a lather. 'E couldna mak out whad wuz the raison. Söo a wentun to a wise-ööman, an' 'er toud 'im to watch, for it wuz the witch as wuz ridin' 'em; söo a watched an' watched, but a sid nuthin, an' the 'orses wun i' the same fettle every night. But at last a sid a bit o' straw a-top on one o' thar necks, an' söo a laid out on it, an' took it, an' sed some charm the ööman' ad touden 'im. An' then a chucked it o' the fire, and the owd witch wuz sid gwine up the chimdy on a bröömstick.' (Burne 1883: 157)

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Table 3: Dialect vs. Standard (STD) use in tales with 3rd person narra-
tion only and no dialogue (3P w/o dialogue)

Collection	Total tales 3P w/o dia- logue	STD only	STD w/ dialect words or quo- tations	Mixed - more STD	Mixed - more Di- alect	Text wholly Dialect
Axon	-	-	-	-	-	-
Bowker	5	3	2	-	-	-
AWT	-	-	-	-	-	-
Peacock	-	-	-	-	-	-
Burne	20	18	1	-	-	1
Balfour	-	-	-	-	-	-
Addy	3	2	1	-	-	-
Blake	-	-	-	-	-	-
(C)						
Blake	10	8	1	-	1	-
(W)						
Jacobs	-	-	-	-	-	-
Tales n°	38	31	5	-	1	1

Extract 4, an orally recorded anecdote from the Clee Hills, which Burnes gives as an example of a folk belief that witches cause tangles in horses’ manes (lo-
cally known as “witch stirrups”), illustrates Burne’s wider practice. Her focus is
on describing and analysing folk beliefs and traditions, rather than on collect-
ing and publishing folktales as works of oral literature. The fact that we find
orally recorded or remembered third-person narrative tales in dialect in Burne
(five with dialogue, one, Extract 6, without dialogue), in Balfour’s tale *A Pottle o’
Brains* (which has dialogue), as well as in Walter Thomas’s tale *Tom Tit Tot* (which
also has dialogue) shows that third-person narration in dialect does seem to have
been part of oral folktale repertoire. Dialect writers, such as Axon, Blakeborough,
Bowker and Peacock, on the other hand, seem to have avoided third-person nar-
rative in dialect or, as argued in Section 4.3 and Section 4.4, seem to have used
strategies to make it more dialogue-like, using a first-person frame narrative or
attributing the narration to a dialect-speaking character.

In Bowker and Blakeborough, there also seems to be a clear preference for stan-
dard in third-person narrative tales without dialogue. Bowker’s five third-person

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narrative tales without dialogue are in standard only (3) or standard with occasional dialect forms (2), whereas – as shown in Table 4 below – only five out of his 20 third-person narrative tales with dialogue are in standard only (3) or standard with sporadic dialect in dialogue (2). Similarly, nine out of ten of Blakeborough’s third-person narrative tales without dialogue are in standard only (8) or standard with occasional dialect forms (1), and only one tale has dialect. The one tale with some dialect, the story of the Guisborough witch Jane Grear (Blakeborough 1898: 177–180), is exceptional in that it has extensive quotations from two dialect poems about the local witch legend in question. In contrast, all of Blakeborough’s 30 third-person narrative tales have some dialect (Table 4). Given that we find extensive (untranslated) dialect in Blakeborough’s work – which seems to have been aimed at a non-Yorkshire readership as well as a Yorkshire one – the question remains why dialect should be so consistently avoided in third-person narration. Similarly, in the case of Bowker, the fact that there are four tales predominantly in dialect suggests that the presence and indeed extensive use of dialect was not considered a problem for his readership, and so the question remains why also he consistently used standard only in third-person narration.

4.3 Third-person narration with dialogue

It was shown in the previous section that only a small minority of tales narrated in the third-person narrative with no dialogue have some dialect (7/38 or 18%), and that the dialect in most of these tales (5/7) is limited to the odd dialect word or quotation. In contrast, most tales with dialogue (82/148 or 55%, the sum of columns “b” to “f” in Table 4) have at least part of the dialogue in dialect – ranging from just one dialect sentence to all the dialogue in dialect – and 21 of these tales also have the narrative in dialect. The extent and distribution of dialect and standard in tales with both third-person narrative and dialogue is shown in Table 4.

Table 4 distinguishes six different categories of dialect use, from the least (column “a”) to the most extensive (column “f”):

- a) 67 tales in standard only or standard with odd dialect forms, including 52 tales exclusively in standard and 14 in standard with occasional dialect or non-standard forms (AWT 1, Bowker 1, Burne 5, Addy 4 and Jacobs 4);³

³As noted in Section 4.1 above, the distribution and frequency of dialectal or non-standard forms differ in Walter Thomas’ (AWT’s) tale *Cap o’ Rushes* compared to the other tales in this category. While non-standard forms are infrequent (typically three or fewer instances) in the other authors’ tales in this column, non-standard forms are relatively more frequent in Walter

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Table 4: Dialect vs. Standard (STD) use in tales with third-person narrative (narr.) and dialogue (DLG)

Collection	Total Tales w/ narr. & DLG	STD with occasional dialect forms (a)	STD with limited dialect in DLG (b)	STD exc. local chars in DLG (c)	STD narr. / Dialect DLG (d)	Dialect exc. non-dialect speakers in DLG (e)	Dialect only (f)
Axon	1	-	-	-	-	1	-
Bowker	20	3	2	6	9	-	-
AWT	2	1	-	-	-	-	1
Peacock	7	-	-	-	-	-	7
Burne	25	15	5	1	1	-	3
Balfour	9	-	-	-	-	-	9
Addy	49	43	3	2	1	-	-
Blake (C)	14	-	-	13	1	-	-
Blake (W)	16	-	4	10	2	-	-
Jacobs	5	5	-	-	-	-	-
Tales n°	148	67	14	32	14	1	20

- b) 14 tales with exclusively standard narrative and only limited dialect in dialogue, including 8 tales where all the dialogue is in dialect but with little dialogue overall and 6 where there is more dialogue but little dialect is used;
- c) 32 tales with standard-only narrative and dialect consistently used for the speech of local and/or lower-class characters;
- d) 14 tales with standard-only narrative and dialect-only dialogue;

Thomas' *Cap o' Rushes* and are found in both the narrative and dialogue, yet they are not used consistently and represent a small minority overall.

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- e) 1 tale, Axon's *The Hartshead Boggart*, with the narrative wholly in dialect and the dialogue all in dialect apart for the speech of one non-dialect-speaking character;
- f) 20 tales with both the narrative and dialogue wholly in dialect, only two of which (one in Peacock and one in Balfour) have third-person narration throughout and 18 of which have a third-person narrative embedded in first-person frame narration.

Overall, there are 61 mixed dialect-standard tales where there is more than just the odd dialect word or form (the total of columns “b” to “e” in Table 4). In these 61 mixed dialect-standard tales, the dialect occurs only in the dialogue and not the narrative, with the exception of just one tale, Axon's *The Hartshead Boggart* (column “e”). There is, however, significant variation in the extent of dialect use in dialogue in these mixed dialect-standard tales. The single most-frequent pattern – column “c” in Table 4 with 32/61 tales (52%) – is to use dialect only for the speech of local and/or lower-class characters. An illustration of the use of dialect for local characters and standard for non-local characters, from one of Blakeborough's comic anecdotes, is given in Extract 5. Here, the non-dialect-speaking character, the new vicar, is even flagged in the narrative as “not a Yorkshireman”. The local churchwarden, who also happens to be of lower rank, in contrast, speaks in Yorkshire dialect.

- (5) The new vicar (not a Yorkshireman) of a country parish decided that his congregation should stand when he and the choir processed from the vestry. “*Tha’ll nut deea ‘t,*” said the churchwarden when the question was mooted; “*t’ au’d fau’k nivver did seea, an’t young uns weean’t.*” The tone in which this was uttered would have been conclusive to any Yorkshireman. “I think I can make them,” said the vicar. “*Mak ‘em!*” with great unction; “*did ya say mak’em? [...]*” (Blakeborough 1898, 3) [my emphasis]

However, the differentiation between dialect and non-dialect speaking is not always based on a local vs. non-local distinction. It was noted in Section 4.1 – with an illustrative example in Extract 1 – that Blakeborough, who was himself a Yorkshireman from the North Riding and a dialect speaker, consistently represents himself as speaking standard to local informants. This may be, as argued in Section 4.1, because Blakeborough is presenting himself in a scholarly role as an authority on Yorkshire traditions, folklore and dialect. Since standard rather than dialect seems to be the language of scholarly discourse – not only for Blakeborough but also for the other dialect writers in the corpus (Axon, Bowker and

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Peacock) – Blakeborough’s authorial voice is expressed in standard only, both in the frame narrative and in the dialogue.

In some of Bowker’s tales, there seems to be a class distinction underlying the use of dialect by some characters and standard by others, all of whom may be local. The protagonist of Bowker’s tale *The King of the Fairies*, for example, is a “worthy named Burton, ‘Owd Dannel Burton” (Bowker 1883: 52), who had become a prosperous farmer, apparently by selling his soul to the devil. Daniel Burton is frequently referred to in the tale from the locals’ perspective using his dialect nickname “Owd Dannel Burton”, though Daniel’s own speech is only in standard. His labourers and neighbours, on the other hand, speak in dialect. Bowker also differentiates linguistically in dialogue between ordinary local folk who speak dialect and supernatural beings who speak only standard. For example, in the tale *The Headless Woman* (or *Beawt Heeod* in dialect), a local man walking home from the pub speaks dialect, while the headless woman, a boggart, speaks to him in standard (Bowker 1883: 131–139). Similarly, in the tale *The Rescue of Moonbeam*, a local fisherman falls asleep in a meadow and witnesses a fairy banquet; while all the fairies in diverse shapes and forms talk in standard, the fisherman and his wife talk in dialect (Bowker 1883: 140–151).

It is also possible that the fourteen tales in (d) above – nine of Bowker’s, one of Burne’s, one of Addy’s and three of Blakeborough’s – where the narrative is consistently in standard and the dialogue in dialect, could also be instances of the use of dialect to represent the speech of local or lower-class characters, but where all the dialogue happens to be spoken by such characters. An illustration of consistent standard in narrative and dialogue in dialect is given in Extract 6, the beginning of Addy’s short tale *The Old One*, where a parson speaks to one of his parishioners, an old woman.

- (6) THERE was once a parson in Derbyshire who was very good in visiting his flock and enquiring after their souls. [...] One day an old woman sent for him and told him that she was very uneasy in her mind. When he got to the house he sat down in the kitchen and said:
- ”Way, does ta go to t’ sacrament?”
- ”Yea,” said the woman.
- “Way, does ta owe anybody ought?” said the parson.
- ”Not a fardin,” the woman replied.
- ”Way, then, what’s i’ matter wi’ thee?” said the parson. (Addy 1895: 38)
- [my emphasis]

In Bowker’s nine tales where the dialogue is consistently in dialect, all the characters with dialogue seem to be local. For example, in *The Enchanted Fisher-*

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man, the protagonists are local fishermen speaking entirely in dialect (Bowker 1883: 104–119). In *The Silver Token*, the tale itself is narrated in dialect to “gaping listeners” by a local woman, Old Nancy, sitting in a farmhouse (Bowker 1883: 129–130). In *The Fairy Funeral*, the dialogue is spoken by two local characters, one of whom is described a “local ‘cow-doctor’” (Bowker 1883: 83–96).

Axon, interestingly, shows a similar association between dialect and local identity but in an inverted pattern: his tales are wholly in dialect, both in the narrative and dialogue, except for the speech of one non-dialect-speaking higher-status character, a rector, in his tale *The Hartshead Boggart* (Axon 1870: 53–59), an illustrative extract from which is given in Extract 8 (with the dialect sections again highlighted in italics).

- (7) *So th’ tawk ended wi’ each thinkin’ as he’d done at th’ first. Bu’ th’ Rector made up his mind ’ at he would convart ’ em to his way uv thinkin’. He said to ’ em, with a good-humoured smile, “I see that you are as positive as ever about this ghost, and what I have said has not changed your opinion one bit.” Mergit said ’ at hoo didna want to set hersel’ up agen th’ Rector, for he owt to know bethur nor her ’ at wur none book-larned, bu’ hoo’d seen it wi’ her own een, that hoo hed.* (Axon 1870: 57) [my emphasis]

However, dialect is not always used consistently for all the local or lower-class characters in some tales. For example, in Bowker’s tale *The Spectral Cat* (Bowker 1883: 63–72), which relates how the foundations of a new church being built in a field keep on mysteriously disappearing overnight, there is a variety of characters, some of whom, judging by Bowker’s other tales, might be expected to speak standard and others dialect. The priest, Father Ambrose, speaks standard like the minister in another of Bowker’s mixed dialect-standard tales *The Christmas-Eve Vigil*, though other characters who might be expected to speak dialect, such as Adam the miller, the mason, a “sturdy young fellow”, a “grey-haired old farmer” and a “rustic running down the road” speak only standard. The dialect dialogue in *The Spectral Cat* is limited to a labourer as well as to two men who are sent to keep watch over the church foundations. The two men doze off at their first attempt at keeping watch after “partak[ing] of a homely but plentiful supper” washed down with alcohol. On their second attempt at keeping watch, though, they discover a huge supernatural cat demolishing and making off with the church’s stone foundations. The use of dialect, thus, seems to be limited to specific episodes in the tale for comic and dramatic effect, especially the comic dialect dialogue between the two watchmen first as they doze off, then as they wake up embarrassed by their failure to keep watch, and finally their shocked and earthy reaction to the sight of the spectral cat.

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Extracts 1-7 above as well as the quantitative data in Tables 3-4 reveal two broad patterns in the use of dialect in the corpus tales narrated primarily in the third person. First, dialect use tends to be concentrated in dialogue and avoided in third-person narrative. Second, within the dialogue, there is sometimes sociolinguistic differentiation between characters, with dialect typically used for local and lower-class characters. The association of dialect with dialogue can thus be seen as sociolinguistic as well as textual and stylistic, since it seems to reflect an underlying social and cultural association of dialect both with orality and local identity. Dialect thus tends to be limited to the representation of speech in dialogue, while being excluded from literary narrative or learned discursive prose. Yet, while there are common underlying patterns in the use of dialect, there is significant inter and intra-writer variation in the extent of dialect use in texts which are comparable in genre and subject matter. We can observe a continuum in the extent of dialect use: at one extreme, there may be only the odd dialect phrase or sentence in dialogue in a text otherwise wholly in standard and at the other extreme, the whole tale may be in dialect, often, as is shown in the following section, because the tale is narrated in dialogue by a local dialect-speaking protagonist or because the author narrates the tale in the first person in a dialogic manner. In between these two extremes we find variation both in the extent of dialogue in individual tales and in the extent of dialect within the dialogue.

4.4 First-person and dialogic narration

In just over two thirds of the tales with dialect (63/93), the dialect occurs only in dialogue, while less than a third of the tales with dialect have dialect in the narrative (30/93). Only one of these 30 tales wholly or mostly in dialect, in Burne (1883: 157), has third-person narrative only and no dialogue, while the other 29 have both narrative and dialogue and occur mostly in collections where all the tales are wholly in dialect (Balfour – 10 tales, Peacock – 9 tales) or almost wholly in dialect (Axon – 3 tales). The narration style of a large majority of the tales wholly or predominantly in dialect – 27 out of 30 – can be argued to be more dialogue-like than that of the tales wholly or predominantly in standard. Three principal techniques are used to make a narration more dialogue-like:

- a) quoted narration, where a narrative is attributed to an informant or character and presented in quotation marks;
- b) first-person frame narration, where a predominantly third-person narrative is framed in the first person by the folklorist/writer or by a character;

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- c) first-person protagonist narration, where the narrator narrates the tale in the first-person and is also a protagonist of the tale.

These three techniques can be combined with each other as well as with third-person narration. For example, Bowker's tale *The Enchanted Fisherman* combines third-person narration with quoted first-person frame narration (Bowker 1883: 104–119). First, there is a long (two-and-a-half-page) introduction setting the scene in third-person omniscient narration without dialogue in Standard English, then a character nicknamed “Owd England” (“Old England”), one of a group of men sitting in a pub, narrates a tale wholly in Lancashire dialect, which takes up the following three and half pages. Owd England's tale is a predominantly third-person narrative with dialogue, but it is introduced and framed in the first person and also presented in quotation marks. After Owd England's dialect tale, the third-person omniscient narrative, interspersed with some dialogue and quoted rhymes, resumes wholly in Standard English for just over nine pages until the end of the tale. Owd England's dialect tale within a tale is dialogic not only because it is told in dialogue, but also in its narration style, since it is framed in the first person. It can be argued that first-person narration is inherently more dialogic than third-person narration because it presupposes a more direct and conversation-like interaction between the narrator and listener. This is the case, for example, with Peacock's Lincolnshire dialect tale *The Lass 'at Seed Her Awn Graave Dug* (“The Lass who Saw her Own Grave Dug”), a third-person narrative with first-person frame narration, though, unlike Bowker's *The Enchanted Fisherman*, it is not a quoted narrative. The tale's opening lines are given in Extract 8; it begins with a first-person question directly asking the listener in the narrative, “gran'muther” (“grandmother”), “Did I ever tell you about our Bessie...?” (my translation).

- (8) Did I niver tell ye about oor Bessie, gran'muther, 'at seed her awn graave dug, poor lass? It's a queer taale that, an' ivry wo'd on it's trew. She was a real pretty lass, wi' flaxen hair an' blew ees, an' ther' was a man, call'd Fox, 'at was straange an' fond on her. Well, he maade a deal on her, an' when he'd gotten his awn wark dun, he'd tidy hissen up a bit, an' then he'd walk ower to her feyther's hooose, an' help her to milk coos, sarve pigs, an' such-like. (Peacock 1886: 72)

The tale also ends with a first-person comment on the story – “as trew as I stan' here” (‘as true as I stand here’) – which completes the first-person framing. In Balfour's orally recorded Lincolnshire dialect tales *The Green Mist* and *Yallery*

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Brown, both first-person narrative tales where the narrator is also a protagonist, the first-person narrator addresses the listener in the second person not only at the beginning but also throughout the tales, using interjections such as “*a can’t tell’ee more ’n ma gran’ther said*” (‘I can’t tell you more than my grandfather said’), “*stra’ange an’ true a’ tell thee*” (‘strange and true, I’ll tell you’), “*Oh! a’ll tell thee ’bout ’em efter’ds*” (‘Oh, I’ll tell you about them afterwards’) (Balfour 1891b: 262, 265).

In total there are 37 tales in the corpus with a dialogic style of narration. Table 5 shows the number of tales in each collection with different types of dialogic narration. To allow for different combinations of the three principal techniques – quoted narration, first-person frame narration and first-person protagonist narration – five different categories of dialogic narration are distinguished in total. Only two tales – one in Axon and one in Burne – have quoted third-person narration (column “Quoted 3P narrative”). All but one – 34 – of the remaining tales have a form of first-person narration, while just one tale – Blakeborough’s comic anecdote about socialism included in the column “1P or dialogic narrative” (Blakeborough 1898: 7) – has only dialogue and no narrative. First-person frame narration is much more frequent than first-person protagonist narration. There are 26 tales with first-person frame narration, 17 of which are not quoted narratives (column “1P frame narration of 3P narrative”) and nine of which are also quoted narratives (column “Quoted 1P frame narration of 3P narrative”). In contrast, there are only eight tales with first-person protagonist narration, three of which are not quoted (the tales of Peacock and Balfour in the column “1P or dialogic narrative”) and five of which are quoted (the tales of Bowker and Burne in the column “Quoted 1P narrative”).

The 16 tales with quoted narration are concentrated in four collections: Axon (3), Bowker (5), Burne (7) and Blakeborough (1). In Burne and Blakeborough, the tales are embedded in scholarly discursive prose, and quotation is used to mark a boundary between the authorial voice of the folklorist and the words of the informant. Burne often summarises, paraphrases or translates the words of informants, though when she does give the words of the informants, she quotes the whole narrative, which sometimes also includes dialogue. Blakeborough, in contrast, tends to quote only dialogue and gives the narrative linking the bits of dialogue in his own authorial voice in Standard English. In Axon and Bowker, the quoted narratives – in all-dialect dialogue – are embedded in literary frame narratives. Axon’s *Black Knight of Ashton* has a single literary frame narrative, in which the three tales, narrated by characters in dialect, are embedded. There are also shorter chunks of dialect interspersed within the Standard English frame narrative, so the tales are in effect instances of extended dialogue with narration.

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Table 5: Tales with first person (1P) or dialogic narration

Collection	Total all types of 1P / dialogic narra- tion	Quoted 3P nar- rative	1P frame narra- tion of 3P nar- rative	Quoted 1P frame narra- tion of 3P nar- rative	1P or dialogic narra- tive	Quoted 1P nar- rative
Axon	3	1	-	2	-	-
Bowker	5	-	-	1	-	4
AWT	-	-	-	-	-	-
Peacock	9	-	7	-	2	-
Burne	7	1	-	5	-	1
Balfour	9	-	8	-	1	-
Addy	-	-	-	-	-	-
Blake	1	-	-	-	1	-
(C)						
Blake	1	-	-	1	-	-
(W)						
Jacobs	2	-	2	-	-	-
Tales n°	37	2	17	9	4	5

In Bowker’s *Goblin Tales of Lancashire*, the quoted dialect narration occurs embedded in a third-person Standard English narrative in five separate tales, one of which is *The Enchanted Fisherman* discussed above. The quoted dialect narratives in Axon and Bowker also contain dialogue. In both Axon and Bowker, quoted narrative, which for all but one of Axon’s tales is also first-person, seems to be a literary device which enables whole tales or extensive parts of tales to be told in dialect, as the quoted narrative is attributed to a dialect-speaking character.

Table 6 shows the extent of dialect use in tales with first person (1P) or dialogic narration, indicating the number of tales in each corpus collection with different degrees of dialect vs. standard use. Four degrees of dialect vs. standard use have been categorised (cf. Table 1 above): (1) standard (STD) only, (2) mixed with more standard, (3) mixed with more dialect (4) dialect only in both narrative and dialogue. Overall, Table 6 suggests a clear association between the use

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Table 6: Dialect vs. Standard use in tales with first person (1P) or dialogic narration (narr.)

Collection	Total / dialogic narration	1P only	Standard only	Mixed – more Standard	Mixed – more Dialect	Dialect only
Axon	3		-	-	1	2
Bowker	5		-	1	4	-
AWT	-		-	-	-	-
Peacock	9		-	-	-	9
Burne	7		1	-	-	6
Balfour	9		-	-	-	9
Addy	-		-	-	-	-
Blake (C)	1		-	-	-	1
Blake (W)	1		-	-	1	-
Jacobs	2		2	-	-	-
Tales n°	37		3	1	6	27

of dialect and first-person or dialogic narration: only three of the 37 tales with first-person or dialogic narration are wholly in standard and one mostly in standard, while the remaining 33 tales are either wholly (27) or mostly in dialect (6). The seven mixed dialect-standard tales include one in Axon, five in Bowker and one in Blakeborough. Axon’s tale, *The Hartshead Boggart* quoted in Extract 8 and discussed in Section 4.3, has quoted first-person frame narrative and is all in dialect except for the speech of a non-dialect speaker. Bowker’s five tales as well as Blakeborough’s tale have third-person frame narrative in standard and first-person dialect narrative in the dialogue. In addition, there is also one case of a comic anecdote in Blakeborough which is wholly in the form of dialogue, and which is the only tale in the corpus sample for Blakeborough wholly in dialect.

4.5 An association between the use of dialect and first-person narration?

The use of first-person narration seems to be associated with dialect use in two respects. First, we find first-person narration primarily in collections with dialect tales. While nearly all of the tales (21/22) in the dialect-only or predominantly dialect collections of Axon, Balfour and Peacock have first-person narration, there are no examples of first-person narration in Addy, which is the main collection

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(almost wholly) in Standard English. The evidence of Jacobs' collection, which is wholly in Standard apart from the residual dialect words, is less meaningful here, since all his tales in the corpus sample are retold from other sources. Of the two tales in the corpus which Jacobs retold from Balfour and which had first-person narration in the original, he kept first-person narration in one (*The Buried Moon*) and changed it to third-person narration in the other (*Yallery Brown*). Second, as shown in Table 6, the tales with first-person narration also tend to be predominantly in dialect. This is not a trivial observation, simply a corollary of the fact that first-person narration in the corpus primarily occurs in the collections which are already predominantly in dialect. The only tales (four in number) which are predominantly in dialect in Bowker's collection are also those with first-person narration in dialogue, which at the same time takes up most of the text. Moreover, dialect tends not to occur in narration except in first-person narration; this observation applies both to the use of dialect for narration in Bowker's collection, which overall has more standard than dialect and no tales exclusively in dialect, and to Axon's, Peacock's and Balfour's collections which are wholly or predominantly in dialect.

The association between dialect use and first-person narration may be a specific case of a broader (actual and perceived) association of dialect use with dialogue or orality, which affected not only mixed-language writing where dialect was confined to dialogue in texts otherwise primarily in Standard English (literary dialect), but also dialect literature, where texts were predominantly or wholly in dialect. Townend (2024: 114) notes a similar association between dialect and dialogue as well as first-person narration in Ben Brierley's dialect literature. He observes that Brierley's "early fictions" are similar to novels and stories with literary dialect in that "dialect is normally confined to the speech of characters with the narrator using Standard English". He further observes that Brierley's most famous dialect literature works, the *Ab-o'th-Yate* tales

are narrated in the first person, and thus written wholly in Lancashire dialect; and it is this use of dialect for narration as well as dialogue that marks the biggest formal difference between northern dialect writing and the more national traditions represented by Gaskell and Elliot. (Townend 2024: 114)

While literary fairy tales have written models, dialect folklore and dialect literature have oral models, that is oral conversation in the case of prose and song in the case of poetry. Written dialect narration may thus have been perceived as more natural or credible when framed as conversation, whether by incorporating linguistic and stylistic features characteristic of conversation such as first-person

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narration and explicit interaction with the listener, or by presenting the whole narration as quoted and in the words of a dialect speaker.

5 Discussion: factors influencing the use of dialect vs. standard

5.1 Patterns of inter and intra-writer variation

A number of factors were identified in the previous section as potentially impinging on the use – or avoidance – of dialect in the corpus of late 19th-century published English folktales. These factors include the mode of narration (e.g. first vs. third person), an association of dialect with dialogue, an association of dialect with local identity and often also lower social classes, the folklorists' sources and methods, the publications' intended audience(s) as well as literary and stylistic considerations. The aim of this section is to discuss how these different factors interact and to answer the research questions set out in Section 1.2 above.

Folktales are a particularly interesting text type, as they seem to have been a culturally and linguistically contested domain between standard and dialect. Whether and to what extent folktales were perceived as a Standard English (or dialect) context seems to vary depending on the folklorist. The linguistically contested nature of the folktale as a text type is borne out, above all, by the intra- as well as inter-writer variation evinced in the corpus. We find marked inter-writer variation between folklorists such as William E. A. Axon, Marie Clotilde Balfour and Mabel Peacock, at one extreme, whose tales are entirely or almost entirely in dialect and, at the other extreme, folklorists such as Joseph Jacobs and Sidney Oldall Addy, whose tales are entirely or predominantly in Standard English. Between these two extremes, there are the more mixed dialect-standard collections of Richard Blakeborough, James Bowker, Ann Walter Thomas and Charlotte Burne, which show the greatest intra-writer variation. In these more mixed dialect-standard collections we find intra-writer variation both between and within individual tales. For example, there are only two tales narrated by Ann Walter Thomas in the corpus: *Cap o'Rushes* is mostly in Standard English with occasional dialectal or non-standard forms, while *Tom Tit Tot* is wholly in Suffolk dialect. 28 of Burne's 47 tales (60%) are in standard only, but 6 are wholly in Shropshire dialect and there are a further 13 tales with varying degrees of dialect use, ranging from the odd word or sentence to longer chunks of dialogue in dialect. Blakeborough and Bowker's collections are the most linguistically mixed. 31 of Blakeborough's 41 tales in the corpus are mixed standard-dialect, compared

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to nine tales wholly or almost wholly in standard and one wholly in Yorkshire dialect. 17 of Bowker's 25 prose tales are mixed dialect-standard, four of these with more (Lancashire) dialect than standard, while the remaining eight tales are either exclusively in standard only or in standard with only the odd dialect form.

Axon, Blakeborough and Bowker, who show the greatest intra-writer variation, seem to have selected and adapted their narration styles as a means of varying the amount of dialect they use. Axon's *The Black Knight of Ashton* (Axon 1870), for example, is described on the title page as "an account of a visit to Ashton-under-Lyne to witness the annual riding of the Black Lad with some tales and songs by way". The work comprises a frame narrative in Standard English presenting Axon's account of his visit, but there is also interspersed dialogue in dialect. Three longer tales – the "tales...by the way" – are told in dialogue by a local dialect speaker and are wholly in dialect apart from the speech of one non-dialect speaker in one tale. Embedding tales in dialogue attributed to a dialect speaker provides a means for Axon to tell them wholly or almost wholly in dialect.

There seem to be four broad patterns underlying the inter- and intra-writer variation in the use of dialect vs. standard in the corpus:

- 1) Discursive prose is consistently in Standard English in all the corpus folk-tale collections. Scholarly discursive prose is, thus, a Standard English context, where dialect appears only in the form of quotations, sometimes as longer quoted dialect tales, more often as isolated words and phrases.
- 2) Dialect is used more frequently in dialogue than in narrative and where dialect is used in mixed-language tales, it tends to be used only in dialogue, with standard typically used for third-person narration outside dialogue.
- 3) Dialect dialogue is often used only for local dialect-speaking characters, while standard is used for non-local and, in the case of Bowker's tales, also for supernatural protagonists.
- 4) Where dialect is used in narrative, the narrative tends to be more dialogue-like in nature: within dialogue attributed to a dialect speaker and/or in first-person frame or protagonist narration.

These four patterns have a common denominator: an association of dialect with orality, reflecting the use of dialect to represent the speech of local dialect speakers or "folk-speech", to use the contemporary term (Jackson 1879: xxi–xxii;

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Burne 1883; Peacock 1886). The use of written dialect often indexes aspects of local identity, such as local folk traditions and culture as well as local character and humour, which are in turn associated with dialect speakers.

5.2 The social indexical meaning(s) of dialect

The use of written dialect in the corpus to represent “folk speech” and index local identity is consistent with the findings of sociolinguistic studies of literary dialect (Beal 2006; Hakala 2017) and dialect literature (Beal 2017; Cooper 2025; García 2020). Such sociolinguistic studies have generally used an indexicality and enregisterment framework to elucidate the social meaning of dialect and how it is represented and used in written texts. Johnstone et al. (2006: 80–84) combine Silverstein’s concept of “indexical order” (Silverstein 2003) and Labov’s (1972: 178–180) tripartite distinction between different levels of salience of sociolinguistic variables (indicator vs. marker vs. stereotype), thus distinguishing three different orders of indexicality.

The first order of indexicality, corresponding to Labov’s indicators, involves “a correlation between a form and a sociodemographic identity or pragmatic function that an outsider could observe” (Johnstone et al. 2006: 81). Johnstone et al. argue that “(b)ecause the form-social category connection only begins to be meaningful when someone notices it, first-order indexicality is potential indexicality” (Johnstone et al. 2006: 82). Second and third-order indexicality, in contrast, involve correlations between linguistic forms and social categories which are salient to the speakers themselves. In second-order indexicality, corresponding to Labov’s markers, “speakers start to notice and attribute meaning to regional variants and shift styles in their own speech” to express a social meaning (Johnstone et al. 2006: 82). A linguistic feature can, further, acquire third-order indexical meaning when it becomes associated with “reflexive performances of local identities, in the context of widely circulating discourse about the connection between local identity and local speech” (Johnstone et al. 2006: 84). Third-order indexicality corresponds to Labov’s stereotypes, and, indeed, Johnstone et al. argue that only a subset of features of a local dialect, which come to be perceived as particularly representative of it, acquire third-order indexical meaning. Forms with second-order and third-order indexical meaning can be considered to have undergone enregisterment, which Agha (2003: 231) defines as “processes through which a linguistic repertoire becomes differentiable within a language as a socially recognized register of forms”. In other words, a feature is enregistered when “it has become associated with a style of speech and can be used to create a context for that style” (Johnstone et al. 2006: 82).

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Written dialect could be considered to have a second or third-order indexicality, since dialectal respelling involves the conscious alteration of standard spelling to represent non-standard and/or local speech (Honeybone & Maguire 2020: 3; Townend 2024: 114). The use of written dialect in folktales could, thus, index local identity more broadly – to indicate that given folk traditions are from a specific place and to highlight their authenticity – as well as to index specific social values that have come to be associated with local people. For example, in his study of both 19th-century written and present-day spoken Yorkshire dialect, Cooper (2025: 49) notes that the use of enregistered Yorkshire dialect features “also indexed a range of additional social values including ‘plain speaking’, ‘authenticity’, ‘independence’, ‘sense of humour’, ‘geniality’ and ‘hospitable’”.

In the present folktale corpus, as in Cooper’s more comprehensive book-length study of 19th-century Yorkshire dialect (Cooper 2025), both metalinguistic comments and patterns of intra-writer variation and style shifting can provide evidence of the use of written dialect to index local identity. Peacock’s opening words in her preface – “Yorkshire and Lancashire people write in their own words about their own ways, and why should not Lincolnshire folks do so also?” (Peacock 1886: v) – suggests that Peacock’s consistent use of Lincolnshire dialect in all the tales in her collection was motivated by local pride and a desire to produce a work of local Lincolnshire culture in her local Lincolnshire dialect. In the mixed dialect-standard tales of Addy, Axon, Bowker and Blakeborough, the use of dialect in dialogue for the speech of local dialect-speaking characters but not non-local characters, discussed in Section 4.3, also suggest the use of dialect *inter alia* to index local identity. In addition, dialect is used to index social values associated with local identity similar to those enumerated in Cooper (2025: 49), such as plain speaking, authenticity and above all sense of humour. Moreover, as argued in Section 4.3, the tales in Addy, Blakeborough and Bowker where all the dialogue is in dialect may also be cases of the use of dialect to index local identity, since all the characters happen to be local dialect speakers. The same applies to Axon’s wholly dialect tales, which are narrated in dialogue by a local dialect speaker.

More broadly, then, the predominant pattern of inter- and intra-writer variation observed in the corpus – a tendency to use standard in third-person narrative and limit dialect to dialogue or dialogue-like narration – may reflect not only an association of dialect with orality but also the use of dialect to index local identity. This raises the question to what extent it is possible to analyse the inter- and intra-writer variation in the folktale corpus in sociolinguistic terms as indexing local identity and associated social values, and, indeed, whether all the variation can be explained in this way. However, even if we were able to analyse all the

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instances of the use of dialect in the corpus as indexing local identity, we cannot explain the full extent of inter- and intra-writer variation in the use of dialect vs. standard solely in such terms. In their subject matter – which relates to local folk traditions and culture – as well as in terms of their sources – orally collected from local speakers who are likely to have spoken dialect – the folktales are, in most cases, inherently associated with local identity. The tales could, therefore, have been told wholly in dialect, as is the case with all of Balfour’s and Peacock’s tales and two of Axon’s three tales, yet we find marked variation in the extent of dialect use in the corpus ranging from its complete avoidance, at one extreme to its consistent use, at the other, with various patterns of mixing of dialect and standard in between.

5.3 Competing motivations for use of standard vs. dialect

Dialect does not seem to have been an exclusive means of representing local identity, and, at the same time, individual writers evincing intra-writer variation in the use of dialect vs. standard such as Axon, Blakeborough and Bowker also seem to have had competing authorial identities as both dialect writers and writers in standard. Seven of the nine corpus folklorists – Addy, Axon, Blakeborough, Bowker, Burne, Peacock and Walter Thomas – published folklore at least in part from their own native areas and seem to have been motivated by local pride as well as by a scholarly interest in folklore. In Peacock’s case, this local pride meant publishing her Lincolnshire tales exclusively in Lincolnshire dialect. Blakeborough, though a Yorkshire dialect scholar, writer and performer, published his tales mostly bilingually, with the narrative in Standard English and much of dialogue in Yorkshire dialect. A comment in one of this comic tales – “the Yorkshire country-people and their bairns are bilingual”, i.e. in “their mother tongue and ordinary English” (Blakeborough 1898: 15) – suggests that Standard English is thus also part of Yorkshire identity and is used to express Blakeborough’s own authorial voice in both the frame narrative and dialogue. At the same time, the use of Standard English alongside Yorkshire dialect is central to conveying Yorkshire humour, where, for example, direct and plain-speaking Yorkshire folk using dialect are contrasted with non-Yorkshire folk speaking standard.

The corpus folklorists Addy, Balfour, Burne, Peacock and Jacobs were all connected through the national Folklore Society and published articles in the society’s journal *Folklore*, though they differed considerably in their attitude to dialect as well as in the extent to which they included it in their published folktales. Addy, Balfour, Burne and Jacobs all explicitly acknowledge the presence of

dialect in their sources. Addy and Burne also highlight in different ways the importance of dialect to the folklorist: Burne states that residents with knowledge of the local dialect “have a great advantage over visitors in collecting proverbs” (Burne 1914: 286), while Addy states that collectors should “use the very words and [sic] dialect, if possible, of the narrator, and one should try to avoid translating into conventional or literary form” (Addy et al. 1902: 299). However, only Balfour and Peacock consistently published their collections in dialect. There seem to have been conflicting factors which influenced the use of dialect or standard in the same text type (folktales) and by practitioners of the same discipline (folklore). For Balfour and Peacock, there were overriding reasons for using dialect. Balfour seems to have perceived the dialect as an integral part of the folklore she collected and to have considered the publication of the dialect as essential for preserving the folklore’s authenticity. For Burne and Jacobs, on the other hand, an assumed preference of their target audiences for reading in standard rather than dialect seems to have overridden any need to preserve the formal authenticity of the folklore.

6 Conclusion: a literary dialect–dialect literature–folklore continuum

The study has shown that there is a continuum in dialect and standard use in the corpus folktales, ranging from texts wholly in standard, at one extreme, to texts wholly in dialect, at the other, and with mixed standard-dialect texts in between, typically with the narrative in standard and the dialogue partly or wholly in dialect. Underlying this continuum seems to be an association of dialect with dialogue or types of narration which are more inherently dialogue-like, such as first-person narration or quoted narration attributed to dialect-speaking characters. The extent of both inter- and intra-writer variation in the same text type suggests that folklorists/writers could select narration types more or less associated with dialect to vary the amount of dialect in their tales. The patterns of dialect use in the folktales would thus seem to resemble both dialect literature (tales wholly in dialect) and literary dialect (tales primarily in standard with dialect used to represent non-standard speech).

Such a continuum in dialect use is consistent with Honeybone & Maguire’s (2020: 11) observation that dialect literature and literary dialect are not discrete categories but the extreme ends of two clines: the degree of dialect use (or “proportion of non-standard spelling”), on the one hand, and the size and nature of

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the intended audience (ranging from local dialect-speakers to a general readership), on the other. Honeybone and Maguire’s graphical reconceptualization of the literary dialect vs. dialect literature dichotomy as a two-dimensional dialect writing space with the “intended audience” along the x-axis “proportion of dialectal respelling” along the y-axis better captures not only the continuum in variation in the use of dialect vs. standard, but also the fluidity between different genres and text types, since dialect literature, literary dialect and folklore all blur into each other. However, the two-dimensional dialect writing space cannot fully capture the more complex textual transmission of folk narratives, which typically are not created in a single definitive form at a single point in time, but may be reperformed, reworked and reedited multiple times, undergoing linguistic transformation in the process, from oral (re)performance to written collection, publication and republication. The most striking examples in the corpus of the linguistic transformation of folktales are Jacobs’ translations into Standard English of Walter Thomas’ Suffolk dialect tale *Tom Tit Tot* and of three of Balfour’s Lincolnshire dialect tales. More generally, though, the nature of the folklorists’ sources (written or oral), how the folklorists obtained or elicited them (in standard or dialect) and how they recorded, edited and presented them has a bearing on the language of published folktales. So, to capture the dynamic nature of folklore texts we would need to add a third dimension – the source(s) and transmission of a text – to the dialect writing space.

While folklore forms a continuum with dialect literature and literary dialect, it also differs from both in a crucial respect. The marked inter and intra-writer variation in the use of dialect observed in the corpus folktales – in texts of broadly the same genre – highlights how published folklore texts could be a linguistically and culturally contested domain. On the one hand, folktales could be published wholly or mostly in dialect, especially when collected from dialect-speaking informants, or, on the other hand, they could be published wholly or mostly in standard, especially when (re)written in a genre – the literary fairy tale – or re-framed in a medium – scholarly discourse – associated with standard and aimed at a primarily standard-speaking readership.

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